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DISCLAIMER

Before reading any further, be aware that this book is set in a different age which had different values and morals. In attempting to recapture the sense of that age, I have presented in detail situations and scenes as I believe they may have happened.

In those days, as I have tried to show, sex, violence and human sacrifice frequently constituted acts of worship of the Mother Goddess. The sex, violence and sacrifice presented in this book are not gratuitous but are essential to the story.

If you think you might find this disturbing, please put this book down now.

Note on Time and Units

The ancients did not use our calendar, let alone our system of "epochs" - BC and AD. As far as I am aware, no such system existed in the timeframe of this book. More than that, in the first three sections of this book, all of the characters lived in a world with an infinite time horizon - a worldview in which each year was fundamentally a repetition of the previous year, and one in which the cycles of life were much more important than the passing of history.

Although the Romans later devised an epoch system AUC (from the founding of the City) which was dated to the presumed founding of Rome, it was not in use during the timeframe of this book.

At a smaller scale, I do not believe that the ancients of this book could count effectively, and have tried to use units which they would have been able to comprehend, both in time and space. Likewise, when counting people, I have assumed that their method would be to subdivide large groups into a manageable number (say, at most five or ten) of smaller groups, each of which would, again, be of a manageable size. In the first three sections of the book, you should not think of the entire population of the village being more than a thousand total individuals at any time.

For the benefit of modern readers, each of the four sections of this book (and some chapters, especifally in the fourth section) carries with it a tagline giving a modern day place and modern date. These are simply to help the reader imagine where and when the action is taking place and to put in within a familiar frame of reference. The characters in the book will not have had the same associations with these places and dates as the modern reader.

For those interested in more fully understanding the detailed assumptions I have made, there are appendices at the end of this book.

Mykenai, Greece

3317 BCE

1. New Year's Eve

She started to move her feet through the ritual steps of invocation. As she did so, she heard the drummers behind her start their steady beat, both tracking her movements and driving them forward.

In front of her the circle of men started to move from her left to her right, all taking part in the dance, trying to be perfect in the prescribed moves, wanting to be *the one*. The one: the *chosen* one, the one who, more than all others, would partake with her in tonight's ritual under the new moon.

In the background, she was aware of the insistent drumming, automatically directed her movements through the steps she had practiced so many times since childhood: forward, back, left, right and back again, the whole of her body swaying in time with those movements. To her left and right, she knew the other priestesses were doing the same, making the same preparations, in their own, lesser way to be part of the ritual that would usher in the new year and see Her reborn for the year ahead.

In the front of her mind, she examined the men as they passed opposite her in minute detail. Not just the surface appearance they had put on tonight - hair waxed back and bodies oiled - but the attention they had paid to the minute details of the steps and movement of the dance. Only the most perfect performance could reach the heights needed to bring Her back.

As the men danced, they became aroused. Again, she studied their penises, stiffening, becoming erect and ready for the task ahead. They could not move forward until all twelve men were fully aroused and ready to be taken. She was looking not just for the man who most showed the inspiration of Tammuz but also the one who could satisfy her lust. Only in the perfect offering would She come down and bless them, send blessings in the year ahead: corn in plenty, new livestock, new children (preferably girls), rain and sunshine in perfect quantity, and good hunting. All of this was conditional on her choice here, and carrying out the ritual perfectly.

The music turned and skipped. Overhead, she could see the stars blazing away, the configuration of the Bull introducing the holy month of rebirth; and tonight was the very night when the Moon Goddess hid her face from the Bull and went down into the underworld with the Sun Goddess. Behind her, the flames of the bonfire crackled and spat, flickering orange light onto the faces of the men opposite her, making them appear ruddy and raw. The heat of the flames flared her back, pressing her ever onwards to the peak moment that must soon come.

That One! Yes, as he danced past, not noticing her, lost in the ritual steps, she could sense his presence, his readiness to become one with the divine first through her, and then through the Door. Only then could he become more than a man, more even than a woman - become, in fact, one with the Divine. Only then would the Goddess be recalled to bless this community for the coming year.

He moved on, but even if she were not to recognize him - indeed, did not already know him by name - she would recognize his movements; see the precision again that marked him out for the others. And see by his erection that the spirit of the Goddess truly moved him; truly wanted to be the One. The only one that would mate with Her High Priestess and then go on to join Her throughout all eternity.

He came around again; the circle moving faster now, the insistence and tempo of the drumming picking up, and raising them further and further. She reached out and pointed at him; selecting him; demanding him. Once more the circle would turn, but now she had made her selection the drumming changed tempo, slowed; changed rhythm, became irregular. Everybody knew their place and knew who had been selected. For those that had not been *the one* there was still the lesser compensation: twelve couples would unite this night to bring blessings to the community. Only one would go on to have the highest consummation, but all would remember this night forever. Especially for the coming cycle of the moon when other consummation was taboo.

As he came around again, she stepped forward, perfectly in time with the prescribed movements. The rhythm changed again, moving into the approach. He came towards her, arms outstretched and reaching for her breasts - the givers of life to the young and aborning. She placed her hands on his shoulders and took charge. Around her, without looking, she knew eleven other couples acted in unison with her. To do this wrong would be sacrilege.

She stepped wide and entered the birthing position, pushing him down. He slid his feet along the ground, underneath her, remaining stable and upright through strength and practice. Once his bottom was on the ground she pushed him down and came to rest on his chest. Reaching behind her with her left hand, she massaged his penis for eight beats, then lifted it and placed it inside her, sliding down on it as she had done so many times before. The rhythm changed again, the tempo slowing. Around the circle, twelve women raised and lowered their bodies over their chosen men, both parties caught in the moment. The tempo started to pick up and she kept in time with it: faster, now faster. She could feel herself reaching the supreme moment, then: there it was. She shrieked and fell forward on him. Almost comatose, she felt his juices explode inside her. Perfect! It had been perfect. She had chosen the right man.

As if on cue, the drumming stopped. The only sounds now were the crackle of the bonfire and the heavy breathing of twenty-four men and women slumped on the floor.

Slowly, languorously, they came back around as the villagers looked on as the next, most important step of the ritual took place.

The drum started again as she stood up, releasing his now flaccid penis to flop back against his body. Around her, the other eleven women arose and took up their tools. Stepping back, she picked up the sacred flint knife with which the ceremony would reach its climax. As the women gathered around her, taking their long-established places, she reached down to grasp the member which had performed so well. Only one way existed to dedicate that perfect performance to the Goddess, and, as he watched on in spiritual calm, she lifted it again with her left hand as she had minutes before, then, reaching down with her right, removed it in one swift motion. As the organ came away, she tossed it onto the fire as a message to the Goddess.

Around her, the other women swung their axes and in no time his body was in pieces. Each woman carried one piece and tossed it into the fire, sprinkling the blood on the ground to nourish it. The flames guttered and spat, then took on the task of consuming the body and presenting it to the Goddess.

Now it was time for the Goddess to speak to them. As she lay back on the ground, she lifted her knees and spread her legs wide for Her representative to come to them. Her assistant brought forward the basket with the Goddess' representative on earth in it. She lifted the lid on the basket and the snake slithered out toward her. She watched it, not in fear, but in expectation and exultation. It paused, lifted its head and looked around. Around her, now, silence had come down like a blanket. Other than the hissing of the snake, the only sound was the crackling of the fire.

The snake settled down again and slithered the remaining few feet between her legs, then lifted itself up again and placed its head in her vulva and bit her. The moment she felt it and reacted, her assistant picked the snake up by its tail and placed it back in the basket.

She felt the Goddess' ichor flowing through her, causing her heart to pump even more rapidly. She felt the familiar disorientation as the Goddess slowly claimed control over her. Her vision started to blur, and then she felt herself transported from the fire as she slowly ceded control to the Goddess. And then the Goddess spoke through her, spoke the words that introduced her return for the New Year.

A Year of Growth,
A Year of Change,
A Year of Birth,
A Year of Death.

This Year shall welcome many fruits
This Year shall welcome new guests
This Year shall show My glory
And This Year shall render Me praise

Yes, thought the High Priestess, the Goddess has returned and will favour us this year.

In the darkness, outside the circle of those who had danced, the other women of the village who wanted fulfillment now chose men they fancied and took their pleasure with them as they wanted. Others watched or stretched out, fulfilled and reassured by what they had seen and heard.

2. In the Fields

"I do love this time of year," said Pip, leaning on his hoe for a few moments. "The weather, the promise of spring, the simple rhythm of hoeing. This is the life, I always say."

Polo stopped his own hoeing and looked up at him. "I know what you mean. After those months of shivering in the huts with almost nothing to do, it's good to get out and be busy. And it's great when the sun shows her face earlier every day and for longer. And really good that her sisters are back up before her. It's going to be a good year, I can feel it in my bones."

"Says the man who said the winter was going to be mild," chuckled Pip, starting to hoe up the weeds between the barley shoots again. "There were times there where I thought I was going to freeze to death in that hut with only the four of us to keep each other warm."

They continued to hoe for a little while in companionable silence, basking in the warmth of the early spring sunshine. They heard the noise of footsteps running towards them from the village and turned to look. A girl was running towards them from the village. She slowed down as she approached.

"Hullo, Sprig," called Polo. "What message do you bring from the Ladies?" He waited a few moments while Sprig recovered her breath.

"Tamarisk reports that a lion has been seen to the south; all men are commanded to help her immediately." Having left her message, Sprig ran off to the next pair of men in the field to pass on the same message. Immediately, Polo and Pip took their hoes and ran off to find Tamarisk.

Twelve men had gathered around Tamarisk, who was standing on the rock which served as an observation platform to the south of the village, by the time Pip and Polo arrived. Tamarisk turned to address them all. "We saw a lion stalking to the south here," and pointed her arm in that direction. "Obviously her intentions have not been revealed to us, but we have to assume she and her cubs are hungry and that we look like good food to her."

She looked around the assembled men. "We must disabuse her of this notion."

Quickly, she organised the men. They might only be men, and dispensable, but nevertheless she wanted to keep as many of them alive as possible. And, most importantly, the lion had to be turned away - or killed - before she dared to attack the settlement. So much depended on the lion.

Four of the men she sent to the right, four to the left. The other six she sent heading directly towards the lion. As others arrived she would deploy them as need dictated.

Polo and Pip ended up leading the central group heading straight at the lion. Tamarisk had confidence in their ability and experience. While they were not so old as to have started losing their strength, they were old and wise by the standards of the village. They probably could not remember the number of fierce animals they had faced off in their lives. Those sent round the edges, meanwhile, had less experience, and while they might come into the fight, were really there to watch and learn from the sidelines.

By now, the big cat had settled down into the long grass. Pip took this as a good sign. When lions were serious about killing prey, they tended to hunt in packs - as he and Polo were now. One animal - however fierce - was never a match for a group. Pip and Polo had ducked down the moment they had left Tamarisk and, along with the other four men from the village were hurrying forward in a crouch. They were not realistically attempting to catch the lion by surprise - she had to know they were there - but the best possible result was to put the lion to flight. And, Pip knew from experience, she was more likely to flee if the noise, light and people appeared suddenly from the grass. She might attack, but even so, it would be a reaction rather than a planned attack.

Pip raised his hand to signal a halt. The other five men with him paused in mid-stride. He held out his left hand and jerked it. Dirk and Buddy started moving again, but now circling to the left. With his hoe, he gestured to the right and Finn and Goldie ran that way. Pip gave them a few moments to get into position, then looked Polo in the eyes and yelled "Charge".

Polo bounced up, waving his hoe for all he was worth and sprang forward. As he had looked in Pip's eyes, he had seen the fear there: a fear that mirrored his own. As often as they had done this - and Pip and Polo had led numerous such charges over the past two seasons - they had yet to take so much as a scratch. But there was something atavistically primitive about going up against a wild animal. They would lie about it afterwards to the women they wanted to impress with their merit, claim that they were as calm as the evening breeze, but the fact was from the moment they had started moving towards the lion, their hearts had been racing.

"Waaawaaawaawaa," Polo yelled, charging forward. He couldn't see the lion yet, but he trusted Pip's eyesight and judgment about where the lion was: jump too early and they gave the lion too long to consider its options. Too late, and the lion could spring on them before they were set. Against the lion's strength, weight, teeth and claws all they had were some feeble hoes - and their wits, courage and experience.

From the sides, they heard the other four charge forward, also braying at the top of their lungs. By offering a wide front to the lion, the intention was to get it to turn and run back to the south - away from the village. If any of the men failed to be intimidating enough, it could easily see a weak link and attack that way - and that way lay disaster.

There it was! Pip had become concerned he had misjudged the position of the lion and leaped too early. But no, it was where he had thought it was, but concealed by both the grass and a small bush. The lion, of course, used its sense of smell much more than its sense of sight for stalking prey. Pointing his hoe forward to indicate that he had a bead of the lion, he shouted louder and ran faster - mainly to scare the lion but also to give an outlet to his fear.

The lion pricked her ears up and looked at them. Her head, then her body, came up and she looked at them, baring her teeth. This was the decision time: if they faltered, she would decide that they were prey and attack; if they dominated the situation, she would run. Pip threw his head back and started to sing: there was nothing like singing to cover your own fear as you crossed those final yards into glory or oblivion.

The lion blinked first, turned and trotted off. Not out of fear; merely thwarted. There would be easier game elsewhere.

"It was nothing," boasted Wayne, later in the day. "We shook our rakes at it, and it ran off. Lions are supposed to be dangerous, but I don't see it."

Sprig was impressed. She had not seen the lion, but she remembered times when other lions had killed some of the men of the village. Wayne must be very brave to have not felt any fear.

"Don't pay him no mind, dearie," said Hyacinth, her mother. "Men like to think they are important because they scare the occasional lion. But none of that matters. How would they live without food from our fields? Where would they sleep if we did not give them shelter? What would they drink from if Auntie Chrys didn't make the pots? And where would they be buried? Really, apart from that, what are men good for?"

Wayne dropped his eyes, abashed. He had forgotten the Lady was here, focused as he was on the girl, a couple of seasons younger than him, with whom he had enjoyed playing while they grew up. Now he was counted a man, with a full load of work in the fields as well as his occasional duties chasing lions or fighting other villagers. She was still a girl although, to look at her, she would come of age at some point in the coming season. The goddess willing, of course. Always, everything with the permission of the goddess.

To cover his embarrassment, Wayne turned back to the task in hand - raking away any stones from around the barley sprouts. He was never quite sure where the stones came from; more seemed to appear every day - but that too was probably the work of the Goddess. Although why such a benign, caring and loving deity would give them stones baffled him. But that was another thing that was in the hands of the Ladies - he was never likely to come into contact with the Goddess himself. Unless he was chosen in one of the dances at one of the ceremonies, it was unlikely that his life would ever reach a higher pinnacle than maybe one day become the lion Chaser.

It looked easy: it was all very well for Pip and Polo to say that there was skill and nuance involved. And all very well for Tamarisk to say that you worked your way up, observing and learning as a Fielder before you could become a Surrounder and then, possibly, if you didn't die first, a Chaser.

He bent down and picked up the stones they had extracted and put them in his bucket. It was nearly half full now; Hyacinth would not let him go back to the village until it was full - unless it became dark first, of course. Even now, the days were quite short and it was an effort to finish all the work in the fields before the Sun set, leaving the sky to her younger sisters.

Hyancinth had wandered off to do one of those "administrative" tasks that the Ladies did - not real work, for sure, not like picking up these stones. He glanced up to see Sprig. He gave her a quick grin and was pleased to see that she returned him a shy smile. He was sure she liked him. He felt a faint swelling and reminded himself she was still a girl - and too young to do that, even if she did feel that way about him. No, best not to think that way and get on with moving these stones. He picked up his rake again and moved on to the next patch. Sprig followed him.

"A little faster," said Chrysanthemum, holding the wet clay firmly, but not too tightly, as it rotated under her hands. She made it look easy but anyone who had tried it knew what a difficult challenge it could be. Hank had attempted to mould a pot on a couple of occasions when Chrysanthemum had wanted to discipline him - and had done nothing except get the clay everywhere. He obediently moved his hands a little faster - turning the wheel as evenly as he could with all his years of experience. Even this task - designated as sufficiently unskilled for even a man to carry it out - still required considerably more skill than hoeing up weeds in the fields.

As the wheel started to turn more quickly, Chrysanthemum shaped the delicate neck of the flask. The gentle curvature had to not only be functional, but pleasing to the Goddess. Without that, no joy could come to those who drank from this vessel. It was often here that even the most perfect piece of pottery would fall down and be scrapped. As senior potter, it was her job to make sure the work of the others was up to scratch: and she could hardly criticise others if she did not do a perfect job herself. Yes! That was coming together nicely.

Across the room, Anthurium was applying glaze to a pot that Chrysanthemum had finished this morning when the panic with the lion was over. While Hank was too old to be rushing off to fight lions - or people - the disturbance was still enough to distract everyone in the village from what they should have been doing. Fortunately, no damage had come to the pot with the interruption. While a less delicate job than actually casting the pot, glazing was a specialist task. By her side, her daughter Petal was watching and learning. Sometimes, she would practise herself on shards of discarded pots, although her formal apprenticeship would not start until she became a woman in her own right.

3. Thargelia

Pip was up before dawn.

In itself, this was not surprising, as he was given charge of the early morning watch. But today was special, and he knew it. When he had been woken up from his sleep in the middle of the night, the moon was just rising to the east. When the moon showed half her face like this, coming up at the dead center of the night, while her elder sister was still asleep, everybody knew the month was a quarter through. And this month - the first month of the entire year, the first month that the younger sisters were back awake in the morning sky - just over there, in fact, rising in the east, hurrying to be up before their big sister - would be the festival of the first fruits.

There was no question they were ready. The barley was standing in fields, waiting to be plucked. The fig trees were hanging with fruit, possibly not quite ripe but the Sisters never seemed to agree amongst themselves exactly when it was in the year, so who was he to say whether it was too early for the offerings? The almond trees would be ready - they always were. He'd been hoeing around the beans a little while back - before the season started, anyway - and the leaves there had looked good; although you never could tell with beans.

To the east, he saw the sky beginning to brighten; as it did, he watched the stars slowly retreat from the sky, just as they did every morning. Hiding their faces in worship as Sister Eldest took to the stage. Only Second Sister sometimes had the temerity to hold on to her place in the sky during the day when Sister Eldest was out and about. And only sometimes.

Sprig was asleep at his feet; as a messenger, she wasn't needed until there was a message to run. Until now, as it happened tonight, so she was free to sleep until he needed her. Gently, he nudged her with his foot. As a mere girl, she was his social equal, and this was acceptable. He would obviously have shown proper reverence to a Lady asleep at his feet. Sprig came awake instantly and silently. To do otherwise would quite possibly endanger everyone in the village - depending on why she was being woken of course.

"Run to Bougainvillaea and tell her that She is arising from Her slumbers. And that her sister has crossed the midline this morning. Today is the appointed day. Bougainvillaea must organise us for the Thargelia." Immediately on her feet, Sprig started running for Bougainvillaea's hut.

Bougainvllaea was awake, of course. Sprig had expected as much when she had been sent: whenever she had been sent to alert her in the past, she had always been awake. Now, as then, she slowed from her run before she reached the porch of the leader's hut and approached slowly, eyes downcast. When she arrived, she bowed meekly from the waist and waited to be addressed.

"Sprig, isn't it?" Bougainvillaea asked at last. "No doubt Pip has sent you to alert me to the Thargelia. I'm sure he knew I would know, but it is good of him to stick to protocol nevertheless. Go in and notify the other Ladies. They will wish to collect themselves before She fully rises this morning. Turning to her two assistants, she said, "Come, let us go and prepare ourselves to greet Her as she rises on this most special morning." Slowly, she walked down the steps from the porch and led the way to the Megara.

Forgotten, ignored, Sprig spent a few moments looking after them, wishing that she was like them; hoping that, one day, she might be like them. Then she turned and went to the other huts. Everybody in the village had to be roused for this day of all days; but she would start with the leading Ladies, for they should be first is acknowledging Her, and then in giving the gifts that had come from Her in that endless cycle that was life-in-death.

Bougainvillaea stood with arms raised as the Sun's face breached the horizon. Today, the sky was clear and the Sun shone Her face down on all the villagers as they gathered in the Megara. A good sign, Bougainvillaea told herself, that She would choose to show herself in all her glory on this day of praise. She started to intone the ritual prayer of greeting:

We greet you, O Sun,
Visible face of Her we adore,

Giving to us all things
And asking us for nothing
As we receive, so we shall share
With those of your persons
With whom we share this life

Today is the day of collection
In which we gather our bounty
We share with all who live
And hold nothing back.
Today is the first day of the season
Today is the glimmering of life
For which we give your praise.

When she had finished, she held her hands out to the sun, and then began again, all the Ladies behind her joining her in worshipping the Sun as it cleared the horizon. For moments more they stood there, entranced by the glory of what was happening, and what was about to happen.

When the Sun was about two fingers' width above the horizon, Bougainvillaea clapped her hands together and led the way down the steps from the Megara and out into the fields. She walked through the barley and, when she found some particularly ripe and delicious-looking ears, she plucked them. Turning to Chrysanthemum, she placed them in the platter she had made especially for this day. The holy platter. The platter of offering. The platter itself was part of the offering - the first thing Chrysanthemum had made since the turning of the seasons. And the beauty of its decoration, and the arrangement of the fruits on it, was all part of the offering. The offering must be perfect, for in what other way could these mere villagers express their undying gratitude for all that they would receive this year? Could they really consider themselves worthy of all this plenty if they did not do their utmost to prepare the ultimate offering for the Goddess?

In the orchard, she reached up and picked the ripest fruits. Like Pip, she could never understand why all the different manifestations of the Goddess seemed to be ready at different times. But the Sisters in the Sky could not be denied - everybody knew that this was the time to make the offering and if the sprites in the fig trees were a little behind this year - and they were - then she would just pluck the best, juiciest and ripest figs to share. Bougainvillaea was confident She would understand. She, in her infinite wisdom, would accept that the villagers had tried, had not stinted in their efforts, or held back in any way. She would know that Bougainvillaea had walked through the orchard every day this year, observing the growth of the fruit and what would be ready.

From the orchard she led the procession to the field of beans. Each year, one field was sown with beans while the others held the essential barley. The Goddess had ordained it so, and had punished villages in the past who had forsaken this rule. Neither barley nor beans grew when the rule was broken: a clear punishment for wayward children. The beans were the most difficult fruit to select: being underground, you could only go on the health of the leaves on the surface. She had enlisted the help of Tamarisk over the past few days to select the seemingly healthiest specimens. Tamarisk was an expert when it came to beans.

She signalled Tamarisk forward now. In her hand, Tamarisk held the sacred shovel, the special shovel which was obligatory on these holy occasions. Tensing slightly, for the occasion was important beyond words, Tamarisk placed the shovel at the root of the bush Bougainvillaea indicated - the one that they had identified a few days before.

She drove the shovel into the soil in a single, fluid motion. The soil broke easily and she pulled it back out. Stepping to her right, she drove it down again. Again, and again she made the ritual movements until the plant had been broken away from the soil on all the cardinal points. Now Bougainvillaea herself came forward and communed with the plant. "As I was pulled from my mother, so I pull you from your mother, the earth." With a swift tug, she pulled on the stem of the plant and it came away, soil draining from it as she lifted it into the air.

As she brushed the excess soil away, she could see that Tamarisk had, indeed, chosen brilliantly: these beans were shining brilliantly in the early morning sun. She continued to brush away the excess soil, then called Poinsettia forward with a ewer filled with water. Holding the beans away from her, but with the stem over the hole from which they came, she intoned, "as we take from you, Our Mother, so we return unto you that which we will not eat," and, with that, Poinsettia carefully washed the beans and the mixture of soil and water fell back into the hole, leaving behind a clean bean bush.

Magnolia stepped forward, bearing a new, clean towel she had finished weaving on the eve of New Year's Day. She held the towel under the bean bush and started to dry the beans. As she did so, water and soil ran off the beans and discoloured the fabric. When she was done, Bougainvillaea held a gleaming bush. She passed it to Tamarisk, and then, carefully, gently, started removing the beans from the bottom and placing them on the platter in an arrangement she had been thinking about for days - without knowing exactly how many beans she would have to make the arrangement.

From here, they walked out to the west. Here were the almond trees, uncontrolled but growing here for centuries. Truly a gift of the Goddess. As the procession reached the trees, they stopped and Bougainvillaea reached up and selected the first ripe nuts of the season to add to the platter. Her arrangement complete, she turned to the people and said, "All have seen us gather the fruits to offer to the Goddess. Our offering is collected; it is the first of the fruits of this season; we are proud of our offering. Now, those who are chosen shall continue; the lesser shall return to the village to spend the day in fasting and meditation that the Goddess may look down at us and see the respect we have for her."

With this, most of the Ladies and all of the men and children turned and went back to the village. When they were gone, Bougainvillaea looked at the four Ladies who remained with her. The chosen. The leaders. Between the five of them were held all the secrets of life: of barley, of trees, of beans, of pottery, of weaving. None were closer to the Goddess. In turn, they passed the secrets on to their daughters and to others in the community. These were not *intentional* secrets, but rather, it took years to assimilate the care required in each of the crafts.

With the others gone, they carried on westwards, out towards where they knew the Sun would set and hide Her face from them. Where everything went at the end of its time: the Sun, her sister the Moon and her lesser sisters all made the same transit, day by day, from their rising in the East to their setting in the West. In the same way, Bougainvillaea knew, the souls of man travelled from the origins in the East Wind to their setting out here, in the cisterns of the western wilderness.

They walked carefully, in the prescribed formation, with the platter - and Chrysanthemum - protected in the middle of a diamond with the other four taking the cardinal points. There was no hurry to this celebration; the Goddess knew that a whole year had gone into the preparation for this moment: after all, had she not done most of the work? In her form as the Sun, she had shone on the crops; as the Clouds, she had sent rain; as the Rivers she had sent water when there was no rain. Everywhere they turned, the Goddess was there, helping them, providing them with what they needed. So no, there was no hurry. Just respect. Respect for the Goddess and for all her manifestations.

They reached the designated spot, in amongst the cisterns. Chrysanthemum placed the platter on the ground, bowed low before it, and the five women retreated twenty paces back to the east to watch and see how their offering would be received by the Goddess. Favourably, they all hoped. Slowly, from behind them and to their left, the Goddess' face climbed higher into the sky.

It was mid-afternoon by the time the first snake came up out of the cisterns to look around. This was a propitious sign: neither so quickly that the Goddess was angry at their tardiness in offering to her, nor taking so long as to show disdain for their offering. She crawled slowly across the dry, broken ground and then went once around the platter before lifting her head to look at what she had been offered.

As she moved her head, a gentle sibilant hissing could be heard. Slowly, she reached forward and opened her mouth, probing a fig with her tongue. Then, hesitancy dismissed, she jerked her head forward rapidly and swallowed the fig in a single motion. They could almost see it as it flowed along her body. Again, the gentle hiss, a hiss of pleasure as she continued to examine the platter in front of her.

As they watched, others came slithering up from the cisterns and approached the platter. Once one had accepted the offering, others followed suit. Within minutes, a dozen or more snakes were slithering over the platter, consuming the offering until it was all gone. The hissing of the snakes expressed pleasure, not disappointment, and Bougainvillaea was pleased that her offering had been accepted by the Goddess' representatives on earth.

This would be a good year. She was sure of it.

4. Sprig

"Mother, I'm bleeding."

As Sprig ran up to her, Hyancinth was momentarily confused. The girl didn't seem hurt, didn't seem distressed in any way; in fact, she seemed joyous. Then she saw where the red stain was on her dress and ran to hug her. In some sense, Sprig was no longer her daughter. In two senses, since, as a woman, Sprig would take on a woman's name and leave behind her girl name.

But then Hyancinth's discipline overrode her personal pleasure at the occurrence. A girl becoming a woman, while a cause for personal joy, was a major event in the life of the village, to be recognised, cherished and verified. Almost as much as the first fruits, the transition from girl to woman was an event in the life of the community which showed the Goddess still smiled on this people. "We must go to Bougainvillaea that she may recognise you in the face of the Goddess."

At this, the joy left Sprig's face. Who was she to go and disturb the peace of the great leader? Yes, she was sent to her with messages of great importance, but to disturb her for an issue of her own? That was different. Her mother read her thoughts, written plainly on the girl's face. Not a girl any more. "Sprig was a child. You are no longer Sprig. As a woman, you have standing in this community. WIth effort, with application, who knows how far you might rise?"

Bougainvillaea looked the new woman sternly in the face. She knew the mother - Chrysanthemum's sister, of course - fairly well. She did her work well, and was a good field supervisor, but would never rise higher than that. Sprig she recognized and knew by name - as she did all the women and girls in the village; many of the men, too, come to that. Only babies - half of whom never made it through a whole turning of the seasons - were beneath her attention. Except her own, of course. Back when she had been gifted with them, one in every season. Another thing that had changed, turned like the seasons.

She had examined her, of course. No doubt that this was a woman in front of her now. There were steps that must be taken immediately; others would flow with the seasons: first ritual, first impregnation, first child. Only then would she unquestionably be a woman among her peers, and only then would she be considered for the stages beyond merely being a woman in the community. Without a child, where was her standing? How could she be truly invested without knowing that there were progeny to inherit from her work in this life? Sometimes, she felt the need to indoctrinate fledgling women herself; but this one seemed less important: she would probably not even rise to the mediocre levels her mother had achieved. Bougainvillaea knew that she herself would not live to see what became of this girl-cum-woman; in a moment of irritation, she made a snap decision.

"Pastinaca!" she called, and the woman came out from the hut behind them. "Take this newly minted woman and her mother to the fallow field, and show her what is necessary. Make sure she understands all that is involved in being a woman and make sure she is ready by the Waning Festival."

Pastinaca bowed and turned away, signalling to mother and daughter that they should follow her out to the field that this year was being rested in service of the Goddess. In this field was the blood split. The blood of men sent to the Goddess, and the blood of women freely given when they were not impregnated by the river or the wind.

They followed her in silence, walking hand in hand to the field which Sprig would enter and somebody else - a woman with a different name and a different future - would leave.

"Remove your dress and lie down," Pastinaca instructed the woman who had been known as Sprig. "I don't know how much you and your mother have prepared for this moment, but your life has just begun. As a nut is not the tree, as the seed is not the barley, so the girl Sprig was not the woman you have become. Only now, does your life truly begin." She lifted the pitcher of water she had brought with her, and, instructing the girl to open her legs wide, poured the water over her, giving the life-nourishing blood and water back to the ground.

"This is the field of unseeded women. Every month, if you have not accepted the seed of the river or the wind, you will bleed as you are now. When you feel the bleeding start, you will come here and share the blood with the soil. When it is day, you will lie like this in the fields, sharing of your bounty with the field. When it is night, you will retreat to the hut in the middle of the field with the other women in the field. When your bleeding is over, you may return to the village.

"This is not a punishment. In her wisdom, the Goddess has chosen that some women will be fertile and have children; other women, unblessed with children, will offer their fertility to the fields. In years to come, the crops will grow in this field and will thank you. Know that all this is part of the cycle of life. In time, as you give back to the Goddess through these fields, she will reward you with children of the river or the wind. When your time comes, you will see that this is no more a punishment than that is.

"But, as this is your first time, it is your right to have another woman of your choice to stay with you and guide you through what will become commonplace to you over the course of your life. Your mother may stay, if you wish, or you can ask for another. And while you are here, we want you to meditate on two things: the gifts that you have received today; and what name you would choose for the woman you have become."

Sprig looked up at her. "I thank you most kindly for your wise instruction, Pastinaca. I would have my mother by my side at this time, as she has been for my sisters before me. While I am sure the others will miss her, I am also sure that they can cope for these few days by themselves."

"In that case, I will leave you to your meditations and discussions. As a Woman, you are expected at the festivals of Women, the first of which will be a few days after you return from here. At the waning festival, it will be expected that you dance with a man. You have seen the ritual before, but now it would be a good time to discuss with your mother any aspects of that ritual which seem unclear to you."

And she left them alone.

The waxing festival took place at sunrise; the waning festival correspondingly took place at sunset. In each case, the half moon was directly overhead at the start of the festival. As always, the villagers had collected wood for a fire and, on this occasion, Sprout, as one of the Keepers of the Flame, was responsible for bringing a flaming branch from the Sacred and Eternal Fire to light it. Bougainvillaea knew that the flame was not as eternal as was claimed; indeed, within her lifetime she remembered having had to go on searches for a wild fire to collect to relight the Sacred Flame. For Sacred it certainly was - whenever it had gone out, it had heralded disaster: not to mention that it had led directly to disasters of a more minor sort. Without fire, food could not be cooked; huts could not be warmed; pottery could not be fired. No, fire was as essential to life as was water, barley or figs. As much as for illumniation, the fire was lit at the great festivals to celebrate the fact that the Goddess had shared the gift of fire with them. And a gift it remained, to be nourished, cherished and preserved; or else to be lost and removed, possibly next time for ever.

Bougainvillaea stepped forward from the circle of villagers into the firelight and, as was her right, began to dance, swaying with the rhythms that were in her head. As she did, some of the women picked up her motions on the hollow drums that they had. The beat became more insistent and started to dictate - rather than follow - the dance. Then other women came in on the flutes. The music picked up and swirled around itself. As the dance continued, Bougainvillaea pointed to other women and called them out into the circle. They, too, began dancing and swirling around the fire in time to the music. The music swelled and grew, and now men joined in as well, slapping their thighs and stamping their feet, getting themselves ready for what they knew was coming - and might, or might not, involve them.

As the moon slowly drifted across the sky, all the women were eventually called to the dance. As the musicians were called, they abandoned their instruments and joined in the swaying and gyrating. Now the music was coming from bodies - stamping, slapping, singing.

Suddenly Bougainvillaea let out an ear-splitting shriek and threw her head back. Everything stopped and the field went silent except for the crackling of the fire. The crackling continued until Bougainvillaea broke it with another shriek:

"Clematis. Clematis, come here!"

Clematis moved from her where she had been dancing to Bougainvillaea's right and stood in front of her, facing her. Bougainvillaea started to move again, beginning the same sinuous dance. Clematis watched her, followed her movements, copied her. In unison they danced together; then the others slowly joined in, all the women moving and singing in a circle around the fire. Outside the circle of women, the men were now on their feet, dancing, moving, circling in the opposite direction around the fire and the women.

"Choose!" hissed Bougainvillaea.

The moment was upon her. In some sense, she felt that she had been preparing for this moment for years: but certainly she had been readying herself for it, alone in the fields for the past quarter moon, thinking about how, who, when, what it would be like. And now was the time. The time of choosing. Except her choice had already been made. And there he was. As the circles moved, she reached out her hand to point. Wayne danced past and she pointed to the man who came after him: Shep.

As she pointed, Wayne started to take the first step forward towards her and then realised his mistake. Embarrassed, he retreated, but not before his mistake had been noticed. Meanwhile, Shep hesitantly stepped forward; contrariwise, he had never expected to be chosen for this task: certainly, nobody had ever chosen him before, and he was usually one of the last chosen by anybody - if he was chosen at all.

In time with each other now, they both stepped forwards out of their circles towards each other, going through the prescribed motions of approach and engagement. She reached out and touched him, pulling his right arm toward her. He responded by pulling her toward him. As they closed, they embraced, still moving with the flow of the music and the hundreds of others in the dance. In some sense the focus was now on them, but in another sense everybody was part of a giant organism slowly doing its thing. Like one of the giants snakes in the cisterns, the whole of the dance oscillated and jithered. Shep and Clematis - the head now of this giant organism - came closer and wrapped their arms around each other, embracing and pulling each other tight. She moved her right hand down his back, over his buttocks, then round and between his legs. He was ready; she knew that already, but this was the signal. As it was her first time, it was up to him to take control and make sure it went well; but even so, he could not be expected to take lead and decide when she was ready to start. But now she had let him know she was ready and expected him to take it from here.

He dropped his hands from behind her back under her buttocks and lifted her up. She moved her arms and wrapped them around his neck, pulling herself to him and thrusting one of her breasts - the nourishers of life - into his mouth. He opened wide, accepting it and sucking hard on it. As he did so, she felt a thrill of pleasure run through her body and flung her head back, letting out a senuous moan. By now, she was unaware of the dance, just aware of the primitive feelings in her body and the body next to her, entwined with hers.

He released her breast, slowly lowered her. She slid smoothly along his body, both of them wet from sweating in the firelight. Then she felt his penis between her legs, pushing, demanding entry, then - ow! - he was pushing further, inside her and ...

The rhythms of this dance, which she had learned from as young as she could remember, made perfect sense to her now. What had been a mystery for all those years became as clear as crystal. As did the reactions of all those other women she had seen do this over those years. Oh yes, oh yes, oh indeed, Shep! You are welcome in my canal of blood and birth; I am happy to share the gift of life with you. She started to drift and then - wow! - she all but passed out; only Shep holding her tightly kept her from falling to the ground.

5. Harvest

Clematis swung the scythe from left to right.

She wasn't perfect at it, but it was a skill she had limited practice with. Reaping, was, after all, men's work. It wasn't at all intellectually demanding; it was just a repetitive task that required strength and coordination. Most men at least had those skills. But this looked like it would be a bumper harvest and that meant all hands to the scythe - not the senior women, of course; and those who were looking forward to giving birth to their own life too were excused. But while there was still this much standing barley, exposed in the fields and at risk of being destroyed by the occasional storm, or of being eaten by pests in the fields, everyone who could be spared was hard at work from before dawn until the sun was down. Hard, hot work in the fields swinging a scythe, with very little rest. The Goddess had ordained these weeks as weeks of work: once the harvest was in, and all the barley had been threshed, there would be time to give thanks, celebrate and relax. But for now, the Goddess demanded work.

The villagers worked in a long line, from north to south, working their way across the fields in the natural way, from east to west. The same way the Sun travelled across the sky. The way the Moon traversed the night. The way the stars spun around them. Life moved from east to west, and thus the barley was harvested from east to west.

She dropped the latest bundle of stalks she had reaped behind her. The older children - as she knew from her many seasons doing it herself - would collect the stalks that the reapers dropped and bundle them up, tying strings of flax around them. Some of the older boys were then giving the task of carrying the bundles to the Megara where they would be stored until there were enough women free to do the threshing. Threshing! A mystery which she had seen performed for many years but which she would attempt for herself for the first time this year. Now there was a skill that was beyond even the most intelligent of men.

As she swung her scythe again, she looked at the man to her left, Pip. He was an expert at reaping, years of experience went into that smooth, effortless swing and the rhythm of collecting and dropping the stalks. Every time, he grasped the stalks with his left hand, swung with his right - in perfect time with his whole body, the hips providing most of the power - and then in a single motion pulled on the stalks and dropped them before him, before taking a step forward. In contrast, she shuffled to get in the right position, took an age to grasp some stalks and then swung unevenly near, if not at, their base. She then had to turn to drop them behind her. It was hardly surprising that she kept falling behind. But when she did, one of the men to either side of her, Pip on the left or Dirk on the right, would lean across and do a few handfuls further ahead for her while she cleaned up the patch immediately in front. And then she would scurry forward a few steps to find her proper position in the line. It wasn't just her, of course, a number of the younger folk - spread out up and down the line - were in much the same position. Hopefully they would all be better by the time the moon turned again. There was certainly no lack of oppotunity to practise!

"New scythe here," somebody shouted to her left. She, of course, just had a wooden scythe - sharpened as much as it could be given that wood hardly took an edge. But the more experienced reapers had the few, valuable bronze scythes. She didn't really know where they came from: somewhere to the south, she thought, or maybe more to the east, there were villages which knew the mystery of making bronze, just as Chrysanthemum understood the mystery of turning river mud into pots, plates and other useful items. A few women in the village knew enough to keep the blades sharp, and even to mend them when they broke, but making anything from bronze - let alone the making of bronze itself (what was it made from? also mud?) was a complete mystery to all the women in the village.

One of the children brought forward another bronze scythe to exchange, and hurried off back to the village huts to hand the blunt scythe to one of the women responsible for cleaning, sharpening and reforging bronze. Such women were obviously excused the raw labour of harvesting the barley - it was much more important to ensure a steady supply of sharp bronze scythes.

She looked up at the sun: it had hardly moved since she had last looked. Would this backbreaking work never end?

As they came down to the final areas of barley, the pattern changed: those working faster moved to the outside and started to encircle the remaining barley. Everyone was more experienced now, and with that experience came an increase in tempo and rhythm, and the work started to be done faster. Even so, some workers were still stronger, more experienced - faster - than others. As time moved along, they spread out to the wings and started to work along the edges and around the far side. As the slower reapers moved into the centre - where Clematis found herself, now without Pip covering for her - the line spread out and around the remaining field of barley and the reapers worked towards each other.

When the encirclement was complete, finishing the reaping started to become a competition - who could cut the most of the remaining barley? And as the circle closed in on itself, those who could not compete - like Clematis - found themselves literally left behind, without a space in the circle to swing a scythe. And inevitably, as time drew on, only the most expert reapers - who all had the bronze scythes to further aid their efficacy - were left in the reaping line.

But the others did not retreat back to the village yet. Another of the Goddess' gifts would soon reveal itself to the weaker reapers and the children who were increasingly relieved of their duties bundling and carrying barley to the safety of the Megara.

For now, though, they were able to stand back and have a rest; for most, the first real rest they had had during the daytime in the past two weeks. And as they did so, they were able to appreciate the skill and effort being put into the reaping by those still left in the game. And to choose favourites and to cheer them on.

"Pip! Pip! Come on, Pip!" yelled Clematis, appreciating his efforts - and skill - even more now from a distance than she had been while standing next to him. In her eyes, he truly was among the best of them out there. All around her, others were screaming for their champions as they battled it out to be the last few standing. Inevitably, in a contest like this - of strength and dexterity - it was now mainly men still in the fray.

"There! There!" came a screech cutting through the partisan cheering. A young woman, onlyslightly older than Clematis, was pointing low behind the line of reapers. And it was immediately obvious what she was pointing at. A small hare, obviously frightened, had jumped out of the ever shrinking field of barley and was desperately trying to escape. The woman who had first pointed out the hare ran forward and dived, trying to catch it. A desperate move at best, the hare just jinked left and dodged the lunge. But for one hare, there were just too many villagers, equipped with scythes. The fourth blow struck the hare a solid blow to the head and felled it. One of the children ran forward and quickly finished it with a flint knife.

No sooner had that excitement ebbed away than another screech went up as a vole came running through the line of reapers. Again the villagers mobbed it, quickly dealing a killer blow. As the reapers kept reaping, more and more animals emerged from the ever diminishing field into which they had been concentrated over the past two weeks. Quickly the number of animals making a dash for it meant that some of them overwhelmed the villagers and escaped. But by the end of the day, the Goddess had provided them with enough meat to feast on that night.

Clematis took her designated place in a circle on the floor of the Megara next to her mother. While reaping was rough work best suited for men, they were redundant in this skilful labour. Instead, they were delegated to the role of children, bringing sheaves of barley to the various groups around the floor. Each woman had a threshing pot to catch the seeds and a threshing grate - a small wooden grill on which was placed a small amount of barley. The sheaves were placed in the middle of the circle, and, as she needed them each woman took some of the barley, broke it onto her grate and then started the threshing motion: a combination of tossing, shaking, grinding and rotating which - so Clematis had been told - would end up with all the grains in the pot and a pile of waste on the grate, which was dumped back on the floor to be swept up at the end of the day. As with the reaping, there was a competitive aspect to this - the bigger the pile of waste at the end of the day, the more successful the circle. And if nothing else, there were serious bragging rights for the year to come to be a member of the most successful threshing circle.

Clematis knew she had a lot to live up to - for the last two seasons, her mother and her friends had been the winners in the threshing competition. By joining this circle this year, as a complete novice, was a responsibility she felt keenly. And as much as her mother had explained how threshing was done, she knew that until she did it herself, she would never truly understand. After all, if it were easy, they would let the men do it.

Her first attempt was a disaster. As she tried to toss it up and catch it again, it ended up going everywhere - the floor, her mother, the sheaves of barley waiting to be threshed. Her mother looked at her and laughed.

"Nobody said it was easy," she consoled. "It's a very tricky skill, that combination of strength, dexterity and gentleness. You need to be more gentle. And use your wrists to *flick*, don't *throw*."

Clematis gathered some more raw barley and tried again. She tried to be more gentle, but this time, the barley didn't even leave her grate. "Flick, flick," her mother chided. "It's not going to jump up by itself. You have to give it some oomph, just not too much. Watch!" And she effortlessly did six complex motions with her hands that sent the raw barley up in the air, then separated the seeds from the husk, dropping the seeds into the pot; she repeated the same process six or seven more times until no more seeds fell into the pot. She then tipped the rest of the husks out onto the floor.

Clematis tried again. This time, the barley went up into the air and came back down onto the grate. An improvement to be sure, but no seeds came loose. She tried again. And again. Still no seeds feel through into the pot.

"Better, much better," her mother encouraged. "That's the toss sorted. You are getting the barley up and back down again. But when it comes down, the grate needs to be moving from side to side to shell the seeds. You are just throwing it up and down. You could do that with a plate. And you'll notice you're not using a plate."

"Hyacinth is right," one of the other women in the circle added. "It's not an easy skill, but you need to toss the barley up straight and then catch it on the grate while it's moving. But not too much - or it will go everywhere."

She tried again, throwing the barley up in the air, and moving her grate to the side as it came back down. This time she ended up with something in her pot - but mainly whole barley kernels that hadn't been threshed.

"It's a much finer motion than that, love," her mother's friend confided. "If you jerk your hand like that the grate won't be anywhere near where the kernels come down. You need a small, fast, late motion."

She tried again. And failed again. This was not easy.

Two days later, she had filled her first pot with barley seeds. The other women in the circle had filled countless pots. And from somewhere, more pots and more sheaves of barley kept appearing, a never-ending torment of more failure. From behind her, a man appeared and whisked away her full pot, replacing it with a new, empty pot.

"The first pot you fill takes the longest," her mother told her. "It will go quicker and quicker as you perfect your technique."

"Will I ever be as good as you?" she asked. "You are all so accomplished."

"Oh yes," Hyacinth reassured her. "I can remember saying exactly the same thing to *my* mother. She was so proficient at threshing, so elegant while doing it. And almost not paying attention while she talked to her friends in a circle just like this one. But eventually I got the hang of it."

Clematis crushed another handful of kernels onto her grate and tossed them up in the air. Some came back down in the right place, some went here, some went there, and a little seed fell through into her jar.

"Watch the seeds, luvvie," said one of the other women. "Don't watch your hands, and whatever you do, don't watch the grate. You need to know where they are and what they are doing by instinct. But the corn is doing its own thing. You need to watch it up into the air and back down again. And when it's about to land - flick!" She demonstrated by doing the whole thing - including an eye roll - in exaggerated slow motion. "If you want to perfect your technique quickly, what you need to do is perfect where you put your attention. Your grandmother may have been able to do all of this while barely paying attention, but I can assure you the moment I stop watching what the kernels are doing is the moment they start doing their own thing."

Another week went by and it was almost the end of the month by the time the threshing was done. The Lady in charge of accounts confirmed that it was, indeed, a bumper crop; possibly the biggest in living memory. While Clematis had been a drag on her mother and her friends, they had nevertheless been competitive for the most corn threshed. At the end of the day, the bragging rights had gone to another circle, but Clematis had learned a lot and was sure that next year their circle would be back on top. Next year! Next year, she would be ready.

But now it was time for the festival. The Haloa - the Festival of the Harvest - had always been one of her favourites, even though as a child she had been excluded from most of the ritual. Somehow, there seemed a freshness here at the beginning of the year; with all the hard work of the harvesting complete, and (this year at least) a supply of food guaranteed for the year ahead; with the sun shining down and promising more warmth and daylight as the year grew into its full splendour; what was not to like?

And this year, as one of the village's women, she would get to take part in the whole of the ritual.

On the morning of the last day of the month, she rose just before dawn as the watch sounded the morning trumpet. There was, of course, no moon to guide the watch in tracking the passing of the night: they watched the stars and waited for the purpling gleams of the morning sunrise. All the villagers walked to the east to greet the Sun in her majestic appearing, to express their gratitude for her part in their plenty. As the Sun rose, Bougainvillaea spoke the ritual words of greeting and added their heartfelt thanks,

> *To you, O Sun,*
> *To you we give thanks*
> *For your light, your warmth,*
> *For the nourishment you give to our plants.*

When the Sun was fully up the men were dismissed. They were sent forth, away from the village and the cisterns; sent into the forests and wilderness around the village; they and the male children were to spend the day and the night in hunting, practising hunting and passing on the secrets of hunting. Meanwhile the women would offer the Goddess her rewards from the bounty she had provided.

Bougainvillaea led the women back to the Megara, where tables had been set up overnight. Around each table gathered groups of women and girls. Near the tables were some of the pots of barley, along with oil that had been kept from the previous harvest. At each table, they collected some barley seeds and mixed it with the oil. They pressed the mixture together to make a paste. Once they had made the paste, they used a flat stone to press the paste into a cake. They repeated this over and over until the cakes were firm and flat.

Cakes complete, the young girls were now also dismissed, leaving only the women behind for the most sacred part of the ritual. Once again, the women collected barley seeds and mixed them with the oil. Again, they crushed this together and pressed them not flat, but into shapes. Into, specifically, two complementary shapes. One set of women formed a phallic tower, while the others shaped a vulva. Together, these were the representation of sex in this ceremony - as men were excluded, and the actual performance of the sexual act was prohibited until the Haloa was complete - this was how the sexual act, the act of sympathetic magic by which men helped induce the birth of children, was incorporated into this ritual.

The cakes and symbols were placed on platters out in the heat of the Sun. For such an important ritual, no other preparation was allowed. To heat them with fire would be to pollute them. The cakes dried over the course of the afternoon as the women sat in the glare of the Sun, giving thanks for the harvest and praising the Goddess.

As the Sun reached four fingers from the end of her traversal, as She hung in the western sky, Bougainvillaea signalled, and the women gathered up their platters and set out into the West, following the setting Sun as she guided them to the land of the Goddess, the cisterns of the dead and the caverns of her representatives on earth.

As the reached the cisterns, the tip of the Sun touched the rim of the earth and Bougainvillaea lifted up her platter in respect. The other women followed suit.

> *To you, O Sun,*
> *As you set in the West,*
> *We praise you and thank you,*

And give you your due.

Starting with Bougainvillaea, each of the women in turn carried forward a platter and placed it on the edge of one of the cisterns. As they did so, they bowed to the snakes they knew lived inside and would welcome the gift. Then, in turn, each retreated to form a line behind those still waiting to offer their gifts, chanting and praisig the Goddess. The Goddess who had given them so much bounty. The Goddess to whom they now returned a small portion that was her due.

When all the gifts had been offered, the women bowed one last time in one long line, turned, and retreated to the village.

But the celebrations were not over yet. Back in the Megara, Bougainvillaea called for champions.

"There will be three events. The winner of each event will be honoured with position for the year to come, and the opportunity for rank in the future. The events are: sprinting, wrestling and potting."

Quickly the contestants made themselves known. From much practice, Clematis thought she stood a chance in the sprint; she knew she was too small, light and weak to be a contender in the wrestling bouts; and, though she had carried buckets since she was a child, had no illusions that she could even compete with her mother at the heavier weights used in this competition.

Quickly, the first heat of the sprints was organised. Ten women raced across the floor and the winner was quickly determined. Clematis was part of the third heat. Already, she sensed that she was not going to be competitive - the runners in the first two heats were so quick!

She started quickly as Bougainvillaea called the mark, and held onto the lead for the first twenty paces or so across the floor, but a couple of places to her left, Jasmine came cruising past her as if she wasn't even trying. By the end of the fifty paces of the course at the other side of the Megara, she was probably fourth or fifth. Jasmine was the clear winner.

With all six heats complete, there were six winners who started the final. On the mark, two of them moved off easily, but within thirty paces, Jasmine had tracked them down and won the overall race, and the laurel necklace, without difficulty. Clematis felt better for seeing how easily even these experienced runners were beaten by the clearly excellent Jasmine. Next Year, she thought to herself again, Next Year I will be better. I will be older, stronger, faster. Maybe I will even be as good as Jasmine.

The wrestling was organised into pairs. Twenty or so pairs started the competition, and, as each pair was decided, the losers returned to sit with their friends and the winners paired off again until it came down to just two women who had beaten all their opponents. Kittentail and Lavender eyed each other respectfully. Both just over twenty seasons old, they were in their prime as wrestlers. Both had had a number of children, but were not at the moment obviously pregnant. Both had well developed physiques and strong arm and leg muscles. In truth, they both recognised, there was little to choose between them and the issue would probably come down to luck.

Kittentail leapt forward, hoping to catch Lavender unaware, but Lavender stepped back with her right foot and blocked with her left. Kittentail countered by grappling Lavender with her right hand across her buttocks and attempting to push her to the floor. Lavender resisted the thrust and used her right hand around Kittentail's neck and tried to tug her off balance, shifting her left leg forward and under Kittentail's crotch to dislodge her grip. Kittentail gave way and fell back, but more out of deliberate intent than under duress: as Lavender followed she used her left arm to continue Lavender's momentum and push her down to the ground.

But Lavender had, in turn, prepared a feint: as she fell, she went down on one knee and, using the arm she still had around Kittentail's neck, pulled her over her outstretched thigh and into a braced position. Thrusting upwards and over, she managed to turn Kittentail and push her down onto the floor with her own weight on top.

"To Lavender," announced Magnolia, who was one of the judges, and judging this bout. "Congratulations to Lavender, best wrestler this season."

"Congratulations," echoed Kittentail, levering herself up from the ground. "That was clever. Until next year!" And, smiling, she took the laurel from Bougainvillaea and placed it around Lavender's neck.

"On to the potting," said Bougainvillaea and Clematis received the biggest shock of the night as her own mother stepped forward as one of the contestants. The potting competition was more of endurance than speed, although the question was of distance rather than time, so the winner was often the fastest as well as the one who lasted the longest. In all, six women had come forward, and now took their positions on a track that was created around the outside of the Megara; the other women now moved to the centre which had been the scene for the first two events.

Clematis gasped as two women each carried one of the big pots used for the storage of grain, filled it with water and carefully lifted it into the air. As Bougainvillaea called the mark, each of the contestants bent and ducked under her pot. As she stood up, she transferred the enormous weight onto her head, neck and back. Once steady, the two assistants released the pot and the woman started walking.

One lap, two laps, three ... Clematis could hardly imagine what it was like to have such a heavy pot on her head and could not imagine being in this competition. Meanwhile, her mother seemed to be breezing around the three hundred paces of the Megara without a care in the world; as if she were just out for an afternoon stroll in the summertime. To be fair, most of the other women seemed to be just as comfortable with the task.

Suddenly, one of the women wobbled and started to lose her balance. A gaggle of the watching women hurried forward and steadied the pot, letting it gently slip to the floor so that neither was the woman hurt or the pot damaged; amazingly, Clematis saw, hardly any of the water was spilled either. But, of course, the woman was eliminated. She had done ten laps, and was by no means last, but it wasn't about speed: it was about going the distance.

Twelve, fourteen, eighteen ... the laps kept on going and none of the other women looked like dropping out, until, suddenly, one of them took a misstep and another nearly crashed into her. More women from the audience leapt to the task of rescuing women, pots and water; but in doing so, inhibited a third woman, who in turn had to drop out.

Now only Hyacinth and another woman Clematis did not really know were left in the event. Another six laps went by and both women started to look as if they were starting to wear thin. But they were carrying an enormous amount of water, and had already gone further than to the river and back! Finally, the other woman stopped and called, "Congratulations, Hyacinth! You win again."

Quickly, women came to relieve both contestants of their pots and to congratulate them on their efforts. When Hyacinth came back to join Clematis, she was wearing a laurel necklace.

"Mother, that was amazing. I mean, I knew you had won things in the past, but ..."

Hyacinth just hugged her daughter.

Cronos

His thrust went wide.

It was tricky fighting in the uneven light of the volcano at sunset. But this was the time custom dictated for the ritual, when both God and man walked the earth. He realised his mind had wandered and snapped his focus back to the moment when his opponent's bronze blade glimmered in the red and purple light.

Technically, it wasn't a duel to the death: no property rights had been transgressed; neither had interfered with the other's women. But in some senses it was worse. To lose here would, in effect, to be to lose the life he had always known. To lose here would be an outcast. And worse, to be shown inadequate in the face of the Gods. Not to mention his father.

Regrouping his concentration again, he went on the attack. He drove a hard line down, across, straight. Boroon blocked each in turn, then twisted. Cronos saw an opening and dived for it; too late, he saw the trap as Boroon opened his guard and delivered a counterthrust, cutting open the unprotected flesh on his upper arm.

"Good, good!" barked their father. "Yes, yes, indeed the Gods have told us the answer. You are my true son, Boroon, and you will inherit this tribe from me. Cronos, the Gods have decreed that your destiny is to be your own. But tomorrow is enough for that. For now, let us celebrate! I declare a feast." He turned to face the volcano and addressed it: "Come, oh Gods, come and join us. We offer you the fat of the beasts in your element. Come and join us, feast with us on this savoury flesh. Come, celebrate with us the dividing of the tribe!"

For almost a year now, the tribe had been struggling with its size. Tirzaan, the leader - and father to both Cronos and Boroon, although by different mothers, as if that mattered - had been astonishingly successful in growing his tribe. He had been good in war; by conquering other tribes he had claimed their women for his own and taken their goats. By breeding frequently - and successfully - he had had many fine sons. The daughters he had managed to sell to other tribes with whom he chose not to fight. And all the time he had been expert at breeding his flock of goats.

But success this magnificent came at a price. Fortunately, tradition told him how to deal with it.

The main problem, of course, was finding enough food. As a nomad, he could go wherever he wanted and stay until all the food had been eaten. He could pluck almost limitless fish from the rivers by which they camped; he could drink milk from his goats, and from time to time, could even kill a goat to feast on. But it took a large area to camp, the goats always wanted more grass or scrub, and the women had to wander a long way to find fruits and vegetables in the surrounding forests.

Besides that, of course, there were all the other problems that came from dragging such a large group around with you: the constant bickering between rival factions; the arguments about women; the occasional fights that broke out between highly charged individuals. And, as the group became bigger, so it naturally started to split along the faultlines of friends and families.

"When the tribe is too big, find the two most powerful leaders," his father had advised him shortly after dealing with the same problem and making Tirzaan his chosen heir. "Take them to the Gods and get them to fight it out. If one of them dies, sobeit, but at the end the winner is your heir. The loser is outcast; let them start a new tribe to raise up more seed in your name, but they must leave. Don't stint in letting them take goods with them - the idea is to lose men, women and goats. The tribe will naturally split down the middle: those that love the loser and are afraid of the winner will leave; the majority will want to stay because they know and trust your leadership.

"And then, obviously, you must have a feast to show your gratitude to the Gods for delivering their verdict. Don't stint on that either. Never stint on your worship of the Gods. It always pays to have them as friends. Particularly at a time when they could choose to leave you and go with the Outcast."

And so the feast they threw was huge. Each of Tirzaan's grown sons - and a leader of a family in their own right - contributed a goat to the feast. Soon nine goats were on spits over nine fires, their blood trickling into the fire. Each of the fires had been lit from the heat or flames of the volcano - the Gods attending in person and making their contribution.

When the meat was sizzling and ready, Tirzaan ordered his sons to make the offering to the Gods. Each of them cut the heads and removed the entrails, and cast them sparkling into the fire. They also chose some of the juiciest strips of flesh - full of fat and grease, essential for keeping warm in these cold temperatures - and threw them alongside in the fire. The spirits of the Gods flared up and consumed the fat as it was thrown in, the flames rising high to meet the juices.

Only when the Gods had feasted did Tirzaan once again give a command to his sons: "Now, my sons, bring me your choicest flesh that I may feast." Each of them quickly, but not hurriedly, selected the finest portions remaining on their animals and sliced it off and carried it to him. Quickly, he gobbled the food as it was given him before it grew cold. Ah, but it was delicious. He realized he was going to miss Cronos. Whatever his other faults - and he had many, most particularly disobedience - he was an expert chef. The meat was tender, but runny with juices. Lovely and hot but not to the point of burning him. How the boy did it, he did not know.

Come to that, how many of his boys would still be with him tomorrow? He looked around him at his nine sons. Boroon obviously; likewise not Cronos. Of the other seven, probably four would choose to stay. He had no doubt that Kilionan would go with Cronos: the two had been inseparable since they were young children; born within months of each other some twenty years ago, Kilionan had been Cronos' sidekick his entire life.

Probably Ard-noon would leave as well. He had generally been the peacemaker as strife had flared in the past year or so, but anyone who could use the word "peace" and "Cronos" in the same sentence must have a level of love for the man that even Tirzaan - his father - could not manage.

He looked at the others again. Yes, that would be the split. Three would leave and six would stay. That would probably see him out during his lifetime; and then the tribe would probably split again on his funeral day when his mortal remains would be offered to the Gods.

His thoughts turned to that future once again. On that day, would they judge that his life had been sufficiently worthy to be given the honour of joining them? And, if so, how many of his sons would worship him that day? After all, immortality was the one thing that made all this mortal struggle worthwhile. Without the aspiration to reach the Gods, was life really worth it?

In the morning, he was up early. Here in the mountains, sunrise was always a questionable thing. The sky became brighter, but you were lucky if you saw the sun at any point in the day, let alone as it rose between the mountains. But more importantly that that, he wanted to be able to see the light of the volcano one last time, to commune with the Gods and, while still in their presence, beg their guidance in what was to come. If all went well, the division would be easy; it it didn't ... the thought trailed off.

He wondered if he would need to send his herald to find his sons and bring them to him; but he did not. By the time he had finished his silent communion with the Gods of the Volcano, he turned to find all nine of them arrayed before him and, much as he had expected, already divided into two groups. To his left, ready to depart, the trio of Cronos, Kilionan and Ard-noon. To the right, his six other sons grouped around Boroon. He nodded once. It was as he had expected, what he would have ordained. But the choice was not in his hands, but the hands of the Gods.

"Cronos, Kilionan, Ard-noon. Today is the day of parting; the day in which it is your honour and obligation to leave your father and set off into the unknown. You have the right to take all your property with you: your goats, your tents, your swords, your women. All that is not yours you will leave behind. And yet, as your father, it is my pleasure to offer you a boon: is there anything belonging to me that you would ask for youselves? That which belongs to your brothers you may not ask."

Cronos stepped forward and bowed low in homage to the man who would ever remain his father but whose suzerainty he would leave this day. "We take a hard road, father, since we must not only depart from you, but also depart from these lands, for, were we to stay, you and I would come to contention and to blows." Indeed we would, thought Tirzaan, a fight you know you could not win: aside from the numbers, last night proved you not to be Boroon's equal.

"I spent last night in communion with the Gods, since this is a holy place. And they sent me a sign: I saw it, as did my brothers," he indicated Kilionan and Ard-noon. "Having discussed the sign at length and asked for the guidance of our Fathers, I have come to the conclusion that it can only mean one thing." He turned to his right and added, "the Gods wish us to travel south through the mountains."

Tirzaan was shocked. The Cronos he knew was vapid and quick to anger; always ready to take the easy, not the hard path. One of many reasons he preferred Boroon as his heir: and one of the reasons the Boroon had *become* his heir last night. The way south was all but unknown.

"It is my belief that the slave Fidaah was born somewhere to the south, possibly even south of the mountains and came into your possession through a series of accidents that I have always considered bizarre. But last night, as I sat praying, I considered. Father, it is possible that the Gods sent him to us in order to help me in this very moment?"

Tirzaan looked at him blankly. Of all the directions he had thought this conversation might take, this was not one he had even considered. Clearly, Cronos had been thinking things through all night - or else one of his brothers had given him good advice. Fidaah was nothing special as a slave, and, as far as he knew, had no particular attachment to any of the others in the tribe. In terms of what it would cost Tirzaan, it was almost nothing. But he could see the value to Cronos if he really did intend to try to force a passage through the mountains. He decided to stall for time while he thought through the ramifications.

"Does he, in fact, know anything useful that would be of assistance to you? Does he know a route south into the mythical warm lands there where the sun shines all year? Do you think he still knows tribes down that way who can guide you or help you? Can you, even with your brothers and this guide hope to force a way through whoever is in your way?"

Cronos shrugged, a large gesture from this giant of a man with big shoulders. Had last night's contest been one of physical strength rather than skill with bronze, Tirzaan had little doubt that the outcome would have favoured this man.

A silence developed and lengthened. Eventually Cronos relented and offered what little he knew. "I have heard him tell stories to the children around the fire of a cold evening. I don't know how much is story, how much myth and how much is memory. But that he knows of the lands from which he claims to come I have no doubt. He may be a help to me, or he may be useless. I cannot see how, even as an extra mouth to me, he would be a hindrance."

Tirzaan nodded, thoughtfully. All good points. In the long run, it mattered little, and the conversation had gone on long enough that it constituted all he would ask for. Tirzaan had worried he would ask for things of real value - goats or swords. Or maybe something of trade value - there were some daughters in camp he could have taken for their trade value to other tribes as he travelled. He nodded his head once, in finality.

"Good enough. Summon the slave Fidaah. He shall go with Cronos and his two brothers. Let all be set in motion for the parting. Cronos, Kilionan, Ard-noon: in the presence of our Gods, I release you from my family. You are no longer my sons. You are free to find your own path. And yet, the path of three equals is a tricky thing that leads to bloodshed, so I hereby declare as my last act that in choosing to go with Cronos, who would have been heir had he won last night, you put yourself under his authority as you have been under mine until such times as you shall agree to another Dividing. All of that shall be in your hands."

As he finished, Fidaah was brought into the assembly from the compound of the slaves. "Fidaah, know that I have given you to my son Cronos. You are now his property as formerly you were mine and his fate you share. He plans to go to the south and would take you as his guide. Your life and death are in his hands. I suggest you guide him to the best of your ability."

Much of the year had passed in the mountains. The three brothers, their slave guide, their gaggle of women and slaves, along with their herds of goats had been battling through the mountains. From time to time they had encountered other parties in valleys and passes and, cautiously, made contact with them. As yet, bloodshed had been avoided. Human bloodshed, that is. On every occasion a goat had been sacrificed to invoke the Gods and to provide meat for a feast.

As a guide, Fidaah had been a complete waste of space. He didn't even know north from south, couldn't guide himself by sun or stars (if and when they ever chose to come out), couldn't tell a pass from a valley, had no idea about following trails or telling if there were other groups around. But nevertheless, Cronos judged, he had been worth his weight in gold.

The thing was, Fidaah might not know the first thing about navigation, geography or tracking, but he had not forgotten any of the languages he had learned as a child. Early in their travels, most of the groups that they met spoke a language familiar to Cronos - pretty much a dialect of the language he spoke himself. He could have handled negotations with those tribes by himself, and certainly with the help of his brothers. But as they had made their way first up into the mountains, and then, as best he could tell, back down again, the tribes started to speak ever more exotic tongues. And to Cronos' surprise, Fidaah knew all of them, even when Cronos couldn't even make out the sentence structures, never mind the individual words. For himself, he was reduced to the seemingly universal system of body language, hand gestures and signs to convey simple meanings. When he had introduced himself and distanced himself from any violent intentions, he motioned Fidaah forward who, bowing lowing as was expected of an inferior, started to converse with the leaders opposite. Sometimes, the tribes they met would also have an interpreter: such individuals invariably turned out to have a history as exotic as Fidaah's.

Santazin signalled a halt.

Given the uselessness of Fidaah as a guide, Cronos had scouted around for alternatives. Santazin, one of his slaves and hunters of long standing, turned out to have a natural talent in these mountains. Most usefully, he was hypersensitive to other living creatures: human or animal. And, at this moment, it would seem he had noticed the proximity of another tribe. Cronos closed his eyes and attempted to focus his other senses. But, try as he might, he could not duplicate Santanin's efforts. He could not hear, smell or feel anything out of the ordinary. He opened his eyes again to see Santazin beckoning him forward. He carefully and silently picked his way forward, then followed as Santazin started climbing up a nearby outcrop. When they reached the top, Cronos was astounded by the view.

Spread out below them was a valley. How they would get down there, Cronos had no clue. But it was huge and deep, with a river running right through it and forming a lake in the middle. And there, he could see as Santazin pointed it out, there was a tribe camped near the river, with tents and goats spread around. As he looked closer he realised something else: this camp had more *permanent* structures in it: as well as tents, tree trunks had been felled and used to build structures that he presumed people could live in. He had heard - from Fidaah among others - of these more permanent structures: *houses* was the word Fidaah had used from his youth; but to see them was a different thing again. He was entranced.

"Notice the trunks in the river," whispered Santazin beside him. There was no chance that the sound of their voices would carry that distance down below - Cronos was still unsure what Santazin had picked up on to be aware of their presence himself - but both of them felt an awe that caused them to feel the need to whisper. Cronos followed where Santazin was pointing and was confused. A set of trunks were laying ramshackle across the river. Cronos struggled to see the point. Were they halfway through moving them from one side to the other? But they had these "houses" on both sides of the river and up to the shore of the lake. And there were forests on both sides. What was the point? But clearly Santazin had grasped it.

"They make a ... across the river," he said, struggling for the word and holding his hands up and together to show what he meant. Cronos looked at the river and back at his slave's hands but still struggled to grasp the what or the why. Then Santazin pointed back down at the river where a woman was getting up near the trunks and walking towards them - and then onto them. She kept walking, stepping from one trunk to another and - across the river! These people, whoever they were, had managed to build their own artificial ford across the river in the middle of their camp site. Cronos had never seen anything like it. No, he corrected himself: he had never even **heard** of such a thing. If they could do this, what else could they do?

"But why ... why would they do that?" he struggled to say. None of this made sense. Not only was this unprecedented, it said something even more strongly than the houses did. His brain simply could not process what it was being shown.

"They have found a way not to move," Santazin struggled to form the words. They simply did not have the concepts in their language for people who chose - who *had* the choice - to stay in one place. Everybody moved: there simply wasn't enough land to stay in one place. The goats would eat in out in no time. Although, these people seemed to have less goats that you might expect for the number of people. And the land didn't look eaten out.

"How?" Cronos asked, wide-eyed, trying to make sense of it all.

Santazin could only shrug. He had seen what he had seen and described it to the best of his ability with the limited experience and vocabulary at his disposal. But he was not a great thinker, just a slave with a talent for navigation and tracking. In his view, it was Cronos' job to make sense of it and to work their way through this situation. He just sat and watched.

In all, they sat and watched for seven days. In that time, they saw many things that made absolutely no sense to them. People came and went, they dragged sticks through the fields, they carried water from the river and then just poured it out on the fields. These people were strange beyond belief.

While Santazin and Cronos watched, Kilionan had led a group of trackers around the canyon rim and found a route down following the river. For five days they had tracked the route and then come back in just two. As far as they could tell, none of the people down below ever came up into the hills. They seemed to live down there *permanently*, never going anywhere. Kilionan came up to Cronos to tell him what he had discovered.

"So, what should we do? Can we fight them? Or should we try to talk to them, maybe do a trade with them?" Cronos asked. "Or should we just go around them?"

"I don't know. So much of what they do is a mystery. Do they worship other Gods? Do they have other magics? How can they live on so little land? And this thing you say of taking water out of the river to pour on the ground? Why do they do that? Is it to show respect to their Gods?"

Cronos shook his head. The only thing he was sure of was the portent that had brought him this far. He knew the Gods had told him to make his way south for some reason. This was south, further south than he even had known existed. He was certainly out of range of his father. Was this where he was supposed to come? But then, how could he live here? Certainly, he could see that these villagers lived here somehow, but their mode of lifestyle was obscure to him. Could he defeat them? If he did, could he work the same magic that they did, or would their Gods reject him? And while all this was happening, he was eating his way out of the land around the canyon's rim. He would need to move tomorrow, or the day after at the latest. And by then he needed to have made a decision: go down into the valley below, or go around them.

As they came out of the river canyon into the valley, Cronos marshalled his men with the armed veterans at the front and the others holding the animals and women to the rear. He wasn't sure if there was going to be a fight, although he had decided by now that he didn't *want* a fight: if there was going to be a fight, it would not be of his choosing; but if there was a fight, he was determined to win it.

With his veterans at the front, he brought Fidaah. If he had any hope of avoiding a fight, it would be through a combination of a show of strength with a reasonable conversation. And if he was going to have any hope of a conversation, he needed someone who could speak the language. That might or might not be Fidaah, but he was their best hope. Before they had come down into the valley, Cronos had asked him if he knew anything of what was going on down here, and Fidaah only had a few words that might describe it: "field", "village" and "bridge". But it was all too long ago and he could not explain, other than to confirm that yes, he had once lived just in one place where women had made plants grow where they wanted them to and that water was very important, so it had been by a river. More than that, he could no longer remember.

As they walked around the lake and came closer to the "village", Cronos had his trumpeter play the challenge. He didn't imagine these people would have the same trumpet calls, but he wanted to alert them to his approach and give them time to prepare. If they chose battle, he would have lost the element of surprise, but while watching them, they had not seemed particularly martial. He imagined that they would choose peace.

Slowly a group emerged from the village and came toward them. It was a group of six, only three of whom were armed, and even then only with flint axes. If it came to a fight, these six would be dead before they had finished exchanging insults. But then the truly odd thing dawned on him - the other three, the unarmed three, were all women. And the women were in the lead. The women *were in charge*? Cronos could not really believe what he was seeing.

Fidaah turned to Cronos and said, "I cannot really understand what they are saying. Some words, maybe, but the language is different again to anything I have ever heard."

But it was clear that they did not have violence in mind. They were curious: clearly, they did not have many visitors in this isolated valley. Where had they come from? That, at least, seemed to be the main question on the natives' mind. How to describe it? Was it worth describing?

They settled in to try again.

Cronos' temper snapped.

It was a lot of things, but mainly it came down to the fact that this old man opposite him seemed to think that the most important person here was the *woman* to his right, and not the *man* standing in front of him. He would have long conversations with her, and then she would try and say something and Cronos just felt ... *disrespected*.

"What is wrong with you?" he yelled in the old man's face and then, yanking his sword from his belt, cut the man's throat before he could even react. His pupils were still dilating as he fell to the ground, blood pumping from his neck.

Before he could turn around, his brothers had followed his example and all three of the men opposite them were lying in the dirt, dead or dying. Which left the women. The women who had been shown too much respect by their menfolk. Cronos knew how to deal with uppity women.

Reversing his sword, he slashed it across the woman's garment and it floated free and dropped away to the earth. A second stroke removed her loincloth. She stood transfixed, obviously unable to process what had happened, although it seemed impossible that she had not been treated this way before. Dropping his bronze sword, Cronos removed his own loincloth and exposed his other sword. Then he simply pushed the woman to the ground, fell on top of her and started thrusting inside her. At once, she started screaming and pummelling his giant chest with her tiny fists. Oh, she had a temper, this one! He would enjoy taming her. He continued to rut her, trying to make it as painful for her as possible, to demean her, to expose her powerlessness, to reduce the standing she would have had in the dead man's eyes, but nothing about this woman's spirit gave way. She might have been beaten physically, but she was still determined to outlast him: he could see that much in her eyes.

As he climbed off her, she spat at him and kicked him in the testicles. She started to roll to get away, but, lost in a red mist as he was, he still easily picked up his sword and drove it straight through her belly, pinning her to the ground. He laughed at her as she squealed and squirmed and the life ran out of her.

He looked around, saw his brothers were still raping the other two women. "Kill them when you're done," he ordered.

Kilionan heard the order but decided not to wait. It was more fun to choke them to death while you were still on top. He knew this from experience. He held her around the throat and stopped her breathing while he kept pounding away at her. When he finally ejaculated, it was into the dead husk of a woman.

By the time they reached the village, all the other people and most of the animals had gone. Cronos had no idea where. He dispatched Santazin to try and find them, but it was a hopeless task. All he could really say was that they hadn't all gone to the same place together by the same route. This had possibly happened before and they had a plan for dealing with intruders. Perhaps the trumpet blast had been a mistake.

Cronos looked for a sign.

Two nights later, it was dark but it was clear. He had a clear view of the sky, and, while there were no volcanoes around to give him a sense of closeness to the Gods, he felt that they had left the sky clear so that they could send him a sign.

It had not been a good two days. What the magic was that these people worked was beyond him. There was nothing obvious to eat here in this valley, although there was a small amount of fruit to be found in the trees. They had subsisted the past two days by killing some of the goats the people had left behind and the supply of fish in the river. The fish presumably would not run out, but the goats would. And either way, there wasn't an obvious supply of grazing in the valley for their own goats.

If this was the "south" to which the Gods had intended him to come, it confused him. Once again, he regretted his loss of temper that ended in the death of the people that might have been able to explain the magic and the spells and the offerings to him. Were there different Gods here in this land who worked in different ways and wanted different things? He could not tell. He needed a sign: either to confirm that the Gods he had known his entire life came with him here, or else to tell him how to adapt to life here.

Suddenly, he saw the shooting stars he had seen before, many moons ago after losing the duel with Boroon. They started to his right in the north, and went clearly to the south. Well, that answered that. This was not the destination and he would need to press on with his journey. But how? Should he follow the track of the river, or should he climb back into the mountains? What was he looking for?

Rushing out of the sky from behind him came another shooting star: closer by far to him than any he had seen before. It tore through the sky in a blaze of fire, almost like a miniature volcano. That this was a sign from the Gods could not be doubted for a minute. He watched it as it fell, illuminating the river below and the canyon the river issued through before splashing down *in* the river.

That was a sign that could not be doubted. He was to build boats here from the tree trunks which had already been felled and follow the river to the south. No doubt about it.

6. Pharmakos

The sun was baking hot.

Directly overhead, as it always was at this time of year, it was scorching. No time to be outside, thought Clematis as she swept the paths around her hut. But tomorrow, Bougainvillaea had declared, was going to be the day of atonement and expulsion: and everything must be perfect.

Since the harvest had been completed, the stubble in the barley fields had been burnt at nightfall in praise of the Goddess, and other crops had been harvested on an almost daily basis. At the same time, the regular life of the village - making pottery and weaving - had returned to normal after the hiatus of harvest.

And now, as the year turned from waxing to waning, and the cycle of life prepared to begin again, it was time for the village to make peace with the year behind and likewise prepare for what was to come. In the cycle of the life in the village, the day of atonement was, in its own way, as important as New Year, Harvest or any of the other festivals. It marked a transition, a turning point in the life of the village and it fulfilled one of their key obligations to the Goddess.

The hut was clean and perfect; her mother would not have allowed it to be any other way. She still lived here with her mother and younger siblings, and would continue to do so until she had children of her own. At that time, she might take over another hut, if there was one free at the time, or have to build a new one if the village were growing. The last few years had seen excellent harvests and no pestilence, so the young had survived, the old had not died as they might have, and the village was as full as she could remember it. Several new huts had been built over the past couple of years as girls she had grown up with had matured and had children, starting their own families.

She looked around her: everything she could see looked perfect, and she knew in her heart that they were prepared. Nobody would find fault with their hut or surrounding areas. And today - or rather tomorrow - was a day to achieve perfection.

Before sunrise, all the villagers were grouped to the east of the village, watching for the sunrise. At this time of the year, the sky was normally clear and today was no exception. The sky flared purple and orange, then red and yellow and then, with great majesty, the Sun showed her face over the eastern horizon. Bougainvillaea greeted her with the traditional words on this day:

> *On this day, as we greet you,*
> *Know that you see our village in its most perfect state,*
> *Nothing you see today will cause offence*
> *And we will drive out all evil from before you.*

All the villagers stood there, mute, with their arms raised until the Sun had cleared the horizon. Then Bougainvillaea turned to the assembled villagers and called: "Pip! Finn! The Goddess has chosen you. Come with me. Villagers! Go to your houses. Prepare for the atonement and the expulsion.

The two men called walked forward and stood behind Bougainvillaea. All of the others went to their own huts where they would spend the day in meditation and preparation until they were called to atone.

When the dust settled, Bougainvillaea started walking towards the nearest hut.

Hyacinth was the first to be ready.

She went to the counter where the leeks had been prepared and passed them out to her daughters and the two sons still young enough to live at home. All six of them now held a leek in their right hand, in preparation for the visit that was about to come.

Bougainvillaea put her head through the door and asked the ritual permission for entry through a door. Hyacinth responded with the appropriate, polite response of confirmation. Leaving her attendants outside, she stepped into the hut and looked around. She had had no doubt that everything would be perfect here; Hyacinth was like that and had brought all of her daughters up well. In truth, Hyacinth was reaching an age where she deserved to be given a more important role in the community.

"All that I can see is clean and fresh; I see no impurities here," she intoned the ritual phrase of approbation. "But there is one thing lacking. We do not know what Spirits may lurk in dark corners or in our souls. The only remedy is to beat them out." With that, she turned and went outside.

Immediately she had left, bedlam erupted inside the hut, with each of the family members laying about them with their leeks, beating each other and yelling "Out! Out! Out!". They ran around the hut making a racket and invoking the spirit of cleanliness. "Get out! All unclean Spirits! We have cleaned our hut and you are not welcome in a land of cleanliness!"

After running around the hut several times and thoroughly beating each other, they rushed out in the harsh noonday Sun. Immediately they saw Pip and Finn, they started to beat them with their leeks. They stood patiently under the punishment, now well used to it after walking around half the village and receiving the same treatment everywhere they went. They knew that the Goddess was watching and that their future - both in this life and as the cycle turned - would depend more on this moment of privilege than any other.

Clematis watched as the Sun started to descend in the sky from her position near the middle of the procession. Once she and her family had driven all of the evil spirits from their hut into the two Pharmakoi, they had watched as the procession moved on to the next hut and then had joined the rear of the procession. As the winding procession travelled from hut to hut, they had followed in their place, singing the hyms of the Goddess, of atonement and cleanliness.

Pip and Finn had been repeatedly beaten and accepted their lot, their fate soon to be determined for this life and the next turn of the cycle. If they had done really well in this life, they might even have the good fortune to return as women in the next life.

Now the villagers went forward once more to beat the final sins both out of themselves and the Pharmakoi. Where before the violence had been contained within some form of restraint, now all the villagers piled in, beating the two men bloody until they fell to the ground. As each villager reached the end of their strength, they threw the leeks at, near or in one of the cisterns and retreated back towards the village, where the huddled watching the final sunset.

As sunset came, so did the snakes, issuing out from the cisterns, attracted both by the offerings of leeks and the smell of the human blood. They slithered over to find the two offerings on the ground, bleeding and writhing in pain but still alive.

One of the snakes sat up and sniffed the air, its long, forked tongue stretched out to capture the faintest of scents. Yes, this was a human victim, still alive but abandoned by its friends. It lunged forward, biting the man in the neck, then retreating.

As the venom spread through the man, his writhing increased, moving from agony into dementia. As he writhed, he called out. His voice was strained and rough, his words broken and indistinct, but never meaningless.

"Beware... men. Men with bronze sticks. Coming. Let me go! Let me go! They come, they burn." He suddenly sat up and pointed a finger at Bougainvillaea: "Beware! They are strong! They challenge the Goddess and all who believe in her." And then, as if the effort of speaking had finally worn him out, he collapsed again on the ground and stopped breathing.

Finn was more measured in his death throes. "The world ... changes. I cannot see what happens. It is a blur. But the world will never be the same."

Bougainvillaea was shocked. Never before had she heard such prophecies from the victims sent before them to commune with the Goddess. They had fulfilled their duties to the Goddess in exemplary fashion. The harvest had been abundant. What could possibly change ... and what could Pip possibly have meant about *men* being behind the change? And challenging the Goddess? Who would dare? Who *could* dare? What would it even look like to challenge the Goddess? She had no answers, no answers at all.

7. Battle

Shep rushed in from the west and into the Megara in front of Bougainvillaea.

She acknowledged his arrival and inclined her head to signal to him that he was welcome to speak. He drew in a few deep breaths, recovering from the efforts of running from the outer reaches of the settlement where he had been posted as a sentry today.

"From the southwest, a large cloud of dust. We think a group of warriors are coming to attack us."

Bougainvillaea considered this. It had certainly come to the time of year when groups could be tempted into attacks and raids, but the harvest had been excellent; usually such attacks came when the benefits of stealing from others outweighed the risks associated with it. If indeed this was such a raid, people would be dead by the end of the day. Mostly men, admittedly, possibly even just useless mouths in the winter ahead, but even so, Bougainvillaea had a maternalistic feeling for them.

On the other hand, mobilizing for an attack would disrupt all the activities of the village for the day; which, if the boy was in error, would be a terrible waste. At least it was not harvest time, but then nobody would be foolish enough to mount a raid instead of bringing in the harvest.

Shep might still be young, but she was confident that he had seen what he had seen and knew what it meant. A raiding party was almost undoubtedly coming up from the southwest and would be here before noon. If they were not prepared to meet it, the raiders would be able to enter the village unopposed and make off with anything they fancied - grain, tools, even the villagers. No, they must prepare and go out and meet the enemy beyond the outer reaches of the settlement.

"Shep, summon the leaders of the defenders. Go to the barracks of the men and summon all of them to the southwest boundary. Spread the word through the fields for all men to take their tools and gather at the southwest boundary."

Immediately, Shep ran off to raise the alert.

The Sun had risen nearly to full by the time that the majority of the defenders had gathered at the designated meeting point. It wasn't a point, as such, but an area in vaguely the right direction to meet the outsiders. When the first men or leaders appeared, they drifted towards each other, and that then became "the designated meeting place". As others arrived, they drifted to the same location where they could see the others already gathering. When the leaders arrived, they started to take stock of the situation and had directed various men to forward scouting positions and had tried to organise the rest of the men into some kind of formation so that they were more likely to scare off the enemy than injure each other.

Men were good at fighting. Sometimes Virbunum thought that it might be the only thing they were really good at. Often they did it amongst themselves for no apparent reason. But then, when you wanted them to fight, to protect the village, and tried to organise them in such a way that they actually defended the village, they would suddenly just start doing whatever they wanted, rather than focusing on the task in hand.

By now, the scouts were sending in frequent messages and it was clear that the enemy were coming up in a vague column pretty much directly at them. There appeared to be only four or five women leading them, so probably a smaller force than Viburnum had at her disposal (she had ten lieutenants to call on, and each of them should be able to corral three to four hands worth of men[1]). If they were well deployed, and managed to hold their formation and nerve, they should be able to hold their own against this lesser force. Considering all her options, she called her lieutenants to her and, drawing in the sand, outlined her array of battle.

[1] One hand being able to count up to five, so four hands would be twenty; thus the total force would be up to 200.

She had decided to opt for the classic left-centre-right formation, and stack three units to each of the left and right to hold a "corridor". In the centre, she placed the other four units, further back towards the village in a square formation. She expected the oncoming attackers would come down and engage with the front two units and, once these were engaged, the two units behind could come around and join the fray. If her intelligence as to the enemy's numbers were correct, that would be about an even fight; when it reached its zenith, she would signal to the troops to left and right to leap up from their positions and crush the enemy. If all went well the enemy would recognize that they were outnumbered and run away. For form's sake, she would order her men to chase them for a few furlongs, but then let them escape. There was no merit in injuring more men - on either side - once the issue had been decided and the village protected.

Plans conveyed, she checked that all of the women understood what was expected of them, and they went and collected their relevant units of men and took them to the positions and everybody bent down, crouched down, lay down, hid or otherwise concealed themselves while the forward scouts continued to relay information about the oncoming units. When they were close enough - and still on the same course - Virbunum gave silent instructions that they should retreat back behind the defending soldiers. These men now formed the front line of the defence.

Soon, the singing cadence of the advancing enemy could be heard over the noise of their jogging footsteps. In weather like this, it never paid to run too fast, but a loping jog, combined with an appropriate song, could eat up miles with seemingly no effort - something that all the men (and the women who supervised them) had long since mastered. At a walking pace, it could take days to travel between large villages; at a jog, the job could be done (in both directions) in a single day.

Tamarisk had the front left unit of the central square. She was hiding in a gully near one of the cisterns. She, too, could hear the oncoming soldiers and could feel her heart beating faster. Soon, they would once again be in combat. Last time, one of her men had been killed and two others had been wounded. Hopefully, it would not be like that this time! She looked forward, expectantly, but could see nothing yet. On the other hand, the singing and stamping feet were getting closer every minute.

There they were! As if by magic, there was suddenly a line of men across her line of sight, stretching from off to her left to beyond her right. The men to her right would be Amaryllis' problem; those to her left would be initially unengaged, but she had to hope that the unit behind her would take them on before they had the opportunity to surround her unit, outnumbering and overwhelming them.

She watched carefully, now. The moment of engagement was the single most important decision that she had to make in the battle. Engage too soon and the element of surprise was lost; leave it too late and her men would still be trying to get into position while the other side would be sweeping at them with their scythes and prodding at them with the pruning-hooks. Not yet, not yet, but soon ...

"Ready, now!" she called quietly to the twenty men around her. "Be ready!"

The enemy kept coming. She couldn't tell if they knew she was there, in their path; if so, they were yet to give any sign by either pausing or charging.

"Now," she shouted. "Get them!"

Leaping up, the twenty men around her entered the fray, launching themselves towards the ten or so men opposite them in them line. Within seconds, scythes and pruning-hooks were flying and making contact with enemy weapons and bodies. Incredibly effective when used against plants, the weapons were much less effective against bodies, and many a *crack* would evince groans or shouts of pains, but would not obviously immobilise an opponent.

The other three central units were now up and involved in the melee, and the four commanders had fallen back behind the scrimmage, both to have a better view and to give directions as appropriate. As Virbunum had expected, the numbers now were roughly equal, although the enemy seemed to have a slight advantage, mainly grouped in the centre, but not enough to truly break through and outnumber any of their groups of men.

"Right, keep right!" Tamarisk shouted. As the pressure grew in the centre, the right-hand side of her unit was being forced to the left. If that carried on, the enemy would be able to push through and have spare men to come around the back. If *that* happened, the battle could be lost before Virbunum called in the reinforcements.

Suddenly, she heard the trumpet call. Three strong notes, one after another, called the wings into the battle. Now she knew it was just a dozen or two heartbeats before those extra warriors would be swinging into the battle. The scene in front of her intensified as the enemy tried to force their way through the middle between her unit and Amaryllis'. Then suddenly...

There was a crash as the outside units came sweeping in and across the line from behind the enemy. The almost doubling of home troops caused a sudden reversal in the pressure on the line and in a moment, everything became disorganised chaos. What had been almost a unit-against-unit, line-against-line battle suddenly became every man for himself, and there was the danger of the village's men attacking their friends. Tamarisk called to them to identify themselves.

"Mykenai! Mykenai!" they shouted; and every man from the village was simultaneously shouting and listening for the name. None of them attacked anyone else shouting the name of their village. In the uproar, the enemy turned towards their homes and fled.

"Chase them!" shouted Tamarisk; and Amaryllis; and the other commanders. "Chase them back where they came from!"

All the villagers set off, chasing the enemy, howling their battle slogans and waving their weapons. But the enemy were generally faster. Whenever they were being caught, they would throw away their weapons, and anything else they were carrying, just in order to go faster.

A few minutes later, Virbunum ordered the long blast sounded on the trumpet that indicated that the chase should come to an end. The men stopped, and Tamarisk and the other commanders were able to catch up to them.

"Mykenai! Tamarisk! To Me!" called Tamarisk, as the other commanders did the same. Slowly, panting for breath, all of her soldiers gathered about her. She quickly cast about, and identified all the members of her unit as still present, alive, and, so it would seem, largely uninjured. They continued to look out over the wilderness at the enemy as they continued to retreat.

"Good work, all of you," she congratulated them. "We will wait here for another finger of the Sun, but I do not think they will return; they know we were too good for them. Then we will return, collecting such things as they left behind. They will make good spoils to Bougainvillaea to remind us of this day."

As they stood there, the same dust cloud that had heralded the arrival of the enemy in the morning showed them shuffling off into the desert.

The enemy had not been so lucky as Tamarisk's unit. In total, they had left behind six of their number, four dead and two injured sufficiently badly that they were unable to retreat with the others. On their return to the village, the men tipped the dead into the cisterns as an offering to the Goddess who had no doubt been active in helping them this day. The two injured men, along with one of the village men who had suffered a broken leg, were taking back to the village, along with a handful of scythes and pruning-hooks that had been collected from the battlefield. All of the spoils were taken to the Megara and a trophy was built before Bougainvillaea was summoned.

"Praise the Goddess!" she exclaimed. "We have been very fortunate to be delivered from this enemy today." She turned to the captives: "Tell me, where are you from, and why did you attack us?"

"We are from Ogdoi-li, and we attacked because the Goddess sent a sign saying that she was displeased with you."

"And why is the Goddess displeased with us?"

"I am just a lowly man, I do not have the ear of the Goddess. I just know what I was told yesterday: that we would attack you because the Goddess in her displeasure had ordered it."

Bougainvillaea nodded sagely. Yes, probably that is all this man knew. If she had been going to find anything more out, she would have needed to capture one of the women in charge. But that would have been very tricky. But at least they had come through relatively unscathed, and had some fine new tools. She just needed to get them back in working order.

8. Thesmophoria

The night felt pitch black under the stars.

Polo was leading this fifth hunt of the Thesmophoria. The previous four had all been successful, and the boars had been collected in the stock yard just outside the village. Polo had not been involved with those, but had spent the past two days tracking down this boar. Unlike fending off predators such as lions, or hunting animals for food, bringing in animals for sacrifice required the animals to be surrounded and captured alive, either by getting close enough and putting a rope on them, or managing to stun them for long enough to rope them. It was then a question of managing to lead them back in spite of their bucking and running. Often, more than one rope would be needed to constrain the boar, and all the men on the hunt would be exhausted by the time the boar had finally been shepherded into its cell.

A fluff of moonlight came through the wispy cloud, briefly illuminating the forest ahead of them. There was no sign of the boar, obviously; it was still another hour's jog through the forest to where Polo had been marking its passage on the last couple of nights. But it helped him to see that they were on the right trail, still.

Behind him, staggered out over a furlong or more were the thirty men he had been assigned for this task. He had described to all of them where he had tracked the boar and, in any case, most of them had been this way once or twice in the past four days capturing one of the previous boars. And he wasn't sure he wanted a hunter helping him who was so bad at tracking he couldn't follow a man jogging twenty paces in front of him.

Polo adjusted the rope around his shoulders as he ran. His, of course, was the lead rope, the first - and hopefully only - one they would use to subdue and capture the boar. As a precaution, four of his men also carried ropes. Those carrying the ropes were the five "leaders" of this expedition, and each had five men under his command. Hunting at night was the one activity in which, by age-old tradition, men were trusted to look after themselves and did not need any women to supervise them. Polo had no idea why this should be, but apparently the Goddess had ordained it so.

As they moved further to the north, the landscape changed from rocky and barren to more hilly and forested. It was wetter here too, leading to little brooks that, from time to time, they had to cross. Ultimately, all of these flowed into The River, which then flowed down and past the eastern side of the village. Polo - along with most of the men from the village - was familiar with this route and this forest, since it supplied many of the things that could not be found in the village itself: wood and game being the most common two. Frequently, parties of men would come up here to bring back lesser or greater quantities of wood and, at times of festival such as now, when wild boar were needed, hunting parties would be dispatched to recover them from the woods.

As he crossed one of the brooks, he stopped jogging and started walking. For starters, it was hard to keep on jogging as the terrain became hillier and more uneven; equally, he was somewhat out of breath and needed to be in peak physical condition when he came into contact with the boar; but most importantly, he was close enough now that he wanted to start looking for trails and signs.

He knew where he had seen it on the past couple of nights and felt he knew its routine. Around dusk, in common with many of the other animals, it had spent time by the side of the small lake in a hollow a little further up the hillside. It had then retreated and gone about three furlongs until it had snuffled its way into a thicket which, it presumed, meant it was safe from attack overnight. It was, of course, safe from all its normal predators, who worked alone and could not invade or destroy the thicket. Against a group of organised and well-armed men, on the other hand, it might as well have stayed by the lake all night, drinking.

He crested the small rise and worked his way down the trail towards the lake. He hoped to pick up the scent and the trail here and follow it back - along the path he had seen it take - to the thicket. A stone's throw from the nearest part of the lake he paused; sitting down and remaining still, he watched carefully to see small animals and birds coming and going from the lake. Needless to say, putting any of these to flight could easily give away his position and identity as a predator and scare the boar into flight.

The five men directly under his command came and silently gathered behind him. If they were silent, how did he know they were there? he wondered, and then dismissed the thought as irrelevant. It didn't matter if the animals in the forest knew that they were there, as long as they weren't *frightened* by the fact that they were there. It wasn't other animals that animals ran away from; they were surrounded by them: it was danger. And the main sign of danger was *noise*. When there was a commotion something unusual was happening, and that was probably bad.

He could neither hear nor sense the other four groups gathering back between him and the top of the rise. But he had no doubt that they were there, or that, looking down with a touch of moonlight reflected off the lake, they could see the parties in front of them. But, even if they weren't, it was too late to do anything about it now; if they were needed, the commotion he and his men would cause struggling by themselves would be big enough to attract them to the right spot.

He slowly got up and led his men down to the lake and slowly around it. Loping close to the ground, he sniffed at the trails of the various animals and stared at the various prints in the mud by the lake shore. *There!* he could see the unmistakable prints of a boar, moving around where it had come to drink at nightfall. And - there! - were the tracks it left as it started off to find its thicket. Moving ever slower, he followed those now up the hillside, away from the lake.

Behind him, he could feel the men fanning out. As he came closer, they would need to surround the thicket. They were fanning out now to be in position. At the moment, everything was going to plan.

He looked ahead, trying to make a thicket appear out of thin air, but it would not. He had not gone wrong - he could still see the hoof prints in the clay soil in front of him. One pace, another; yet still the thicket did not appear. It certainly could not have disappeared since yeaterday. He could feel his pulse steadily increasing.

There it was! The thicket suddenly resolved itself out of the darkness ahead, taking form from the liquid darkness. He took another four steps, then stopped and signalled by raising his arm in the air and then pointing. The men behind him did not stop, but simply kept going and surrounded the thicket.

He removed the rope from around his shoulders and carefully laid it on the ground in front of him. He undid the knot that had held it together, then found the noose and made sure that it was tied correctly. The hemp felt warm and soft in his hands. He grasped it carefully - he did not want to let it go accidentally - but ensuring that when he was ready it would float free and not be trapped.

Across from him he heard what sounded like the repeated warble of a woodjay. In fact, he was sure, it was Wayne mimicking the sound closely enough so as not to alert the boar, but distinctly enough that Polo recognised it for what it was: Wayne, the most important of his colleagues in this endeavour, was in place. Hopefully the others were also: he had not heard the honking noise of a goose to indicate disagreement. He waited, listening carefully for any noise coming from the thicket. He couldn't hear anything, but he didn't really expect to. The boar would either be resting or watchful - either way, he would expect it to be close to silent.

It was his turn to signal. Pursing his lips together, he gave forth the cry of a gull, looking for its home in the night. On this signal, Wayne was supposed to stand and simply walk into the thicket. He couldn't see, hear, smell or sense whether this was happening but, again, there was no responding signal to indicate that Wayne was unable to follow the plan.

Suddenly, ahead of him, he could hear a scuffling and the noise of brambles splitting. He heard the boar squeal - presumably as Wayne stuck him with a pruning-hook - and then the forest came alive with sound as every bird any animal within earshot recognised the noise for what it was - danger. They ran, flew or scurried away from the noise as best they can. Polo ducked as a large bird nearly flew through him. But from the thicket, the sounds of struggle continued: as yet, the boar felt that resistance was better than flight.

From behind Wayne came the sudden crashing of cymbals as two of the team tried to startle the boar into flight. Faced with both the noise of the cymbals and the direct assault by Wayne, they expected the boar to turn and flee. But still it kept on, convinced that the thicket was its best chance of survival.

The situation was starting to get desperate: if and when the boar did decide to flee, it would not be a gentle trot to safer pastures but a full-throttle charge, barging through anything it found in its way. Polo, holding a single rope by himself, was unlikely to be able to resist that - possibly would not even survive it.

With a giant tearing noise, Polo sensed the boar tear free from the thicket - or possibly tear the thicket free from the ground - and charge directly towards him. Steadying himself, he focused on holding the rope in the throwing position.

Stepping quickly to his right, he stretched his left arm out so that the loop in the rope hardly moved, and then he neatly dropped it over the boar's neck as he passed. He let the boar pull up the slack and then felt the tension in the rope pick up as the boar continued its charge. He took two steps, then wrapped the body of the rope around a tree and fell to the ground.

The boar's neck snapped back as the rope tensed. Denied its freedom once again, it turned and raged. Although it was caught on the rope, Polo knew that this was now the critical moment in the struggle. One man, however strong or experienced, could not win a test of strength against a boar. Polo's advantage at the moment was solely down to the single coil of rope that he had run around the tree. An advantage that would completely disappear if the boar just walked back to the tree and unlooped itself.

There was a crashing through the underbrush and suddenly Buddy was there with another rope. As he arrived, he tossed it around the boar's neck and pulled. Within moments, he too had run a coil of rope around a tree trunk and succesfully tied it off.

From behind him, he sensed movement and Wayne appeared, pruning hook levelled in his right hand. With a quick jab, he lunged it into the head of the boar, just behind the ear. Within seconds, the boar was on the ground, stunned.

They had the boar. Now they just needed to get it home.

"It is the season of Death," intoned Bougainvillaea at the stockade the following evening as the sun set.

As we see the death of the Sun every day,
As we see the death of the Moon every month,
So every year we see the death of the Sisters,
And with them, the death of the grain.

Into the earth it will be buried,
To grow strong with the Goddess in the underworld,
And to return to us in the New Year
As the Sun turns and the Sisters return to us.

For indeed, after the Sun went down, the Sisters soon followed. In just a few more days, they would not be seen at all until the next year began. And so, it was time for the festival of death, burial and sleep. For this, the Goddess demanded that five boars should show the way: today they would be killed and buried. Once the ploughing was done, they would be brought back up again, as the seed was planted in the soil and they hoped to raise the crops next year. Or as the wind and the river planted seeds inside a woman's body, which would come out again, several moons later, in the form of new life. The ways of the Goddess were ever the same: a cycle of life and death: every day, every month, every year, every lifetime, throughout all the ages.

Bougainvillaea nodded to Poinsettia to lead the first boar forward. With a rope around its neck, the animal, docile now after five nights of captivity, came forward on Poinsettia's command. They led it foward to the edge of one of the cisterns of the dead. As they reached the rim of the cistern, Bougainvillaea reached out her hands and called to the Goddess:

Oh, Goddess!
Even though it is also the time for your Death, hear us!
We who worship you, offer you this nourishment
May itprovide for you over the course of the months to come while you are at rest.
Know that wharever you do not use,
Will we take and feed to the fields that they too
May be nourished in this Time of Death.

Pulling her hands back, she took the long bronze knife of offering and calmly slit the boar's throat from one side to the other. In moments, the boar collapsed and then kicked out in its death throes. When it had ceased moving, Bougainvillaea and Poinsettia reached down and pushed it over the edge. It landed with a distinct thud, following by a rustling and a slithering as the snakes below moved to suck up the blood before it drained into the dry earth.

Four more to go, thought Poinsettia.

Ploughing, thought Clematis, is a job to which men are less ideally suited.

They had the strength, and given how difficult it was to trawl a wooden stick - even one that had a flint or bronze tip - through the dry, barren earth, it was not surprising that they were given most of the work to do. But they weren't capable of going more than a dozen paces in a straight line. And if there weren't someone there to pull them up on it, the furrows would go all over the place. And that would never do. The seeds would then be planted too close together; it would be impossible to walk between the rows; it would be harder to tell sprouting plants from weeds; it would be a disaster. How could these men simply *not* see that?

Clematis had stopped having her monthly bleeding already and, so the elders of the village told her, she had all the other signs, too. Inside herself, she felt no different, but soon after the harvest next year, she would be giving birth to a baby - a daughter, she hoped - and a granddaughter for Hyacinth. And so the family might continue. Of course, if it was a son, that was one of those things and she was sure that she would love it as you do all living things but, well, it just wasn't the same, was it?

"No, stop," she called out. "That's drifting to the left again." Walking forward, she used her own hoe to push the soil that had ridged up on either side of the furrow back down into it, trampled it back down, and then once again drew a straight line for five or six paces from the end of the completed furrow. "OK," she said, trying to keep the exasperation out of her voice, "let's try this again." *And see if you can manage to not muck it up for a moment or two*, she thought to herself.

Wayne picked up his hoe and smiled at her. He had a pretty smile, at least for a boy of his age, and she dutifully smiled back. Anything to try and keep these men happy. Now that she was pregnant, she was eligbile to start working her way up the hierarchy among the women. The bottom rung was to be a woman who had proved herself fertile - an infertile woman was no more use than a man: how could they have a stake in the community if they would never be able to pass that on? What would keep them from just living for themselves?

This was, of course, the most menial assignment that was available. Supervising the ploughing and reaping were low-profile jobs that called for dozens of women to supervise all the men to try and complete the job in the shortest possible time. The more senior women were needed to handle the actual burying of the seeds which, of course, was always done at night - the time of death. With all their other responsibilities as well - pots did not stop being needed just because it was ploughing time - the supervising of the men who, Clematis felt, wouldn't really need supervising at all if they were even moderately competent, inevitably fell to the most junior qualifying women. Women for whom it *mattered* that there would be a harvest next year. Women with a demonstrable stake in the outcome. Women with children.

For a few paces, all seemed to go well. Wayne walked backwards along the line she had scratched in the earth, repeatedly digging his hoe into the ground and pulling it towards him. But before long, Clematis could see that he, too, was drifting from the straight line that was required.

"Stop!" she called again. Wayne looked at her with what she could only describe as a smirk.

"What now?" he asked.

"You've drifted to the right this time."

"I thought you didn't want me going to the left," countered Wayne. Somewhere amongst the men there was a low chuckle. *See how she deals with this*, they seemed to be saying.

"I don't," she replied sternly. "Or the right. The lines need to be shaft-straight, or the seeds won't grow." She moved forward to clean up again. As she did so, she heard one of the men mumbling under his breath:

"I could show you how straight my shaft is, if you'd like." She decided it was best to ignore such comments. There was work to be done. She didn't want to take all day dealing with discipline issues. And she didn't want the senior sisters to think she couldn't handle it. Yes, from time to time men needed to be whipped. But most of the time it was just a question of making sure you insisted on them doing the job the way it needed to be done.

Over and over again, admittedly. She sighed and told the men to try again.

As the night fell, Bougainvillaea led her senior sisters out to the newly ploughed fields, carrying the sealed jars of seed. With the appropriate ritual words, Poinsettia removed the stopper from the first jar and put in the dipper to remove the seeds.

As the river and the wind place seeds in us, so we place our seed in you, O Earth!
At this time of Death, we put you to sleep in your grave,
That as the Sun turns and the Goddess wakes again,
You will sprout and come back to us in life and in bounty.

With that, she poured a line of seed into the prepared furrow. Behind her, Hyacinth and Tamarisk completed the burial by using their hoes to fill in the soil from the side of the furrow, covering the seed in its darkness. Then they moved on to the next five paces of furrow and repeat the procedure.

Planting seed may not be as back-breaking as digging the furrow, but even so, it is a time-consuming task. The women were at it all night, planting seed, burying seed and incanting the appropriate words. But as they looked up at the Moon, approaching full now, they knew that this was the last night for planting, because tomorrow would see the Thesmophoria begin.

Clematis had hoped to be chosen, but had not.

The five young women chosen were all a little older than her, and had all had their first child. While not actually a requirement, it probably helped that they had also done well in the various sets of games that had been held during the year and come to the attention of the senior ladies in the village.

Technically, this was not a competition but a ritual. But every year there was a sense of competition among the five women as they climbed down into the pits to recover the bodies of the boars that had been thrown there the previous month. Each woman who had been chosen had then recruited a team of five friends to help with the task of manipulating the ropes.

Camelia double-checked that her rope was securely fastened to the tree trunk near the top of the cistern she was planning on climbing down into, tugging it as hard as she could. She then paced out the distance to the rim and leaned over. Way down below her, she could see the carcass of the boar, rotting in the heat of the cistern and still covered with snakes. She turned and checked that the other girls she had brought with her had all their noise-makers with them: drums, flutes, rocks. The noise would be key to her survival - literally.

She looked back over to see Bougainvillaea and Poinsettia saying the ritual words to open the festival, and then commanded the young women to "go over the edge". Immediately, the girls started bashing their instruments and making a deafening noise. Under cover of that, Camelia threw her rope over and down into the cistern. It fell perfecly, just a couple of paces from the body of the boar.

Climbing down rapidly, hand over hand as her legs, wound tightly around the rope, slid down, she was near the floor very quickly. Pausing for a moment, she picked out her strategy: seeing where the snakes were and avoiding them, she fell the remaining distance to the ground.

Picking up the end of the rope, she wound it under and around the body of the boar and pulled it tight, all the while keeping an eagle eye out for any of the snakes that might come and attack her. In no time, she had the boar safely trussed and she turned her face upward to signal her rope-women that the boar was ready to go. Immediately, they started pulling on the rope and pulling it up.

Of course, the snakes were not best pleased that their offering was being taken away again. A number of them hissed and raised their bodies from their floor. Camelia pulled the bag which she had brought down with her from her back. From within it, she pulled a number of barley cakes, each of which was in the shape of a boar, and had within it both blood and meat from a real animal, collected at the moment they had been sacrificed. She placed these on the rocks near to the snakes. Although it was not a competition, and there were no judges, everyone knew, and everyone spoke about, and most of the bragging rights consisted of, how closely you went to the snakes to offer them these treats; and whether you offered them to the most active snakes. For most women, this ritual was at best a once in a lifetime experience, so very few stinted at the risk of coming too close to a snake. Camelia certainly didn't.

Her five trophies placed directly in front of the most menacing snakes, Camelia was done and ready to leave. She looked up to see the boar hanging directly over her and almost at the lip of the cistern. Above that, she could see two of the women trying to pull it out over the edge. Behind them, she could hear the raucous din of the noise-girls continuing unabated; the noise was deafening but seemed to have little influence on the snakes.

She started to do the performative dance that was demanded of the women in this situation. It was said to distract the snakes and confuse them. They considered a stationary woman in the cistern as a target, but a woman doing a dance was something else: confusing. They would wait and evaluate before attacking her; by which time, it would be hoped the rope would be back down here and she could escape.

The dance itself was old as time and was said to be based on the snakes' own movements. All of the women chosen for this task today had spent some portion of the last few weeks learning it and preparing to perform this ritual that might simply be the difference between life and death.

Suddenly, with a crack, the rope came flying down to land within two paces of her. Effortlessly adapting the steps to her dance, she leapt into the air and caught hold of the rope two cubits up in the air. Using an efficient hand-over-hand technique - with her legs again supporting her weight - she quickly shimmied up the rope to the lip of the cistern where, by putting her feet against the edge of the lip, she was able to push her body away from the cistern wall and simply climb up using the rope to support her weight.

And she was up! Turning back to the cistern, she bowed to the snakes she revered as representatives of the Goddess on earth still below, and then turned to look around. Three of the five boars were at the top of the cisterns, but she was the only hunter back up. As she looked around, all of the members of her team applauded her and cheered her success.

It wasn't a competition, but ...

Carnation never made it back out of the pit. Although she had successfully roped her boar, and her team had pulled it up, she had not been able to avoid the attentions of the snakes and had been fatally bitten. The price of failing to appease the snakes was to become their possession. Bougainvillaea and Poinsettia went to the edge of the cistern and looked down. Below, Carnation was lying on the floor of the cistern, writhing in pain, just paces away from the rope which she would never reach. Behind them, the girls had stopped making their noise, respectful now in the face of death.

Poinsettia looked down into the cistern at the girl writhing and murmuring at the bottom. "It is a shame," she commented. "We will never know what message the Goddess put in her mouth."

Under cover of darkness, the women gathered to mix straw and blood. Blood and meat from the boars were mashed up and mixed with straw from the previous year's harvest. As they did this, and lay it out on the floor of the Megara, they were seeing how this is the reversal of that. At harvest, they break apart the stem from the life; at burial, they have to put the two back together. As the night progressed, the pile of fertilized straw grew, until finally all the blood and meat from the boars' carcasses had been used up.

The morning after was the morning of burial.

The seeds, of course, had already been buried in the furrows. But now was the day of mourning, and the day of covering, when the seeds would be hidden from the view of the Sun until the time of resurrection should come.

On a day of death, there was no singing. On a day of death, there could be no eating. On a day of death, there was no joy.

One by one, the women took as much of the prepared straw from the Megara as they could, and took it into the fields. They spread it out across the furrows, covering and burying the seeds. Then they sat down on the blankets of straw they had made and prayed silently to the Goddess. On every occasion, in every location, they prayed for her to see their devotion and to give increase to their work.

And then they stood up again, and moved, slowly and in mourning, back to the Megara to collect more straw, to take to another field ...

Clematis took her final armload of straw from the diminishing pile on the floor of the Megara out into the far field as the Sun slowly descended in the west. She placed it on the ground and sat on it. For the first time in the day, as she faced the Sun and prayed, she felt the connection. As she was harbouring life inside her, so the ground was harbouring life. It was not visible to anybody; indeed, they had spent the whole day covering it up in the same way that her body covered up the life growing within her, but it was the same thing.

The ground was not dead, the way she always felt it was at this time of year, but alive. Alive, and growing. Alive and full of potential, soon to be revealed!

Just like her daughter, growing in her womb.

9. The Rape

Clematis smiled at the weak joke.

The winter was generally a time of rest, but there were always jobs to be done in the fields. Today, Clematis had oversight of a party of five men responsible for clearing out the channels and weeds around the dormant plants in one of the barley fields. It was dull, back-breaking work in which the men basically worked on their hands and knees, grubbing through the moulting straw to find stray weeds and pull them out, while at the same time clearing out the irrigation ditches. Elsewhere, other parties were responsible for carrying water from the river to the header tanks that fed the irrigation ditches. Women, of course, carried the large pottery jars on their heads, but the men were generally responsible for the more laborious - if less skilled - task of filling them at the river and getting them up onto the women's heads.

The men, of course, were always lazy. It was almost like a game with them - how close could they come to actually being punished before they gave way and did as they were told. And Clematis, being still young had yet to develop the skills and talents of management that the older women put into practice on a daily basis. She would learn, she had no doubt about that, but in the meantime she was struggling to control these men today and to get the work done at the speed that she - and she knew the women above her - expected.

Wayne had been assigned to her again. In some ways, she liked his company, but he seemed to sense that and seemed to think that their "relationship" - a thing that really existed only in his mind - meant that she would let him slack off. Uh, no.

The wicker basket they were filling with weeds was nearly full. She felt that this should have happened some time ago - maybe a finger or two of the sun - and was impatiently trying to hurry them along. Nothing she could say or do really cut through though.

"We could have a break," Wayne said. "You and I could spend a few minutes together, then I reckon we would work harder after that. Motivational, you might call it."

"We're behind as it is," she countered. "If you want to have a break, you need to earn it."

"Basket's full, needs emptying," one of the others injected. "Why don't you go dump it Wayne, you're young and could do with the exercise."

"Sure," said Wayne. Then, to Clematis, "Do you want to come? We could have some fun together, the two of us?"

She looked at him crookedly. "No," she said. "My job here is to supervise the actual work. You run off and empty that basket now. Good boy."

He stood up, picked the basket up and loped off to the edge of the field where all the detritus was dumped ready to be burnt at the end of the day.

"You don't get it, do you?" Jarn, one of the others, said to her.

"Get what?" she asked haughtily, feeling herself inadequate for not delivering the results she knew her mother would have managed.

"He likes you. He just wants you to treat him nicely," Jarn said. "And all you do is put him down like he's beneath your dignity."

Clematis looked at Jarn, genuinely confused. Both of them were *men*, so yes, they were beneath her dignity. She was a *woman* now, and soon to be a *mother*. What possible connection could she be expected to have with them?

Jarn huffed and looked away. There was no use telling these young'uns. Just because they had rank thrust on them, didn't mean they knew squat about how to get the best out of men doing these fundamentally unrewarding jobs. Great. Just threaten to beat them, or report them, or put them on the list for a sacrifice. Highly motivational. Keep on like that and most men here would be queuing up to die. The only real thing worth living for were the half-moon celebrations, and half the time these stuck-up women didn't even pick you. Even though there were more women than men. Even if he didn't really share Wayne's frustration, he could understand it. In a way this *girl* couldn't. She might be old enough to be counted a woman, but she wouldn't be a woman in his eyes until she started behaving like one.

Wayne came loping back with the basket. The moment he put it down, the other men dumped the weeds they had been collecting in his absence in it. He turned and smiled to Clematis.

"I did my best to be quick. Didn't want you missing me," he chuckled.

Something inside Clematis froze, but thinking of what Jarn had just said to her, she decided not to go with the angry retort but to try and be encouraging. To be, what had Jarn said, *nice*?

"Well, it's good to see you back," and she actually smiled at him.

"Thanks," he replied, smiled and got back to work.

Maybe there's something to this, she thought.

Later in the day, Wayne jogged back with another empty basket. Everyone seemed to be happier, and the work was going more quickly. Clematis seemed to think she was getting the hang of it.

"Glad to see me?" he asked, cheekily.

"Never more so," she said and smiled as he placed the basket on the ground to be filled again.

"Care to show me?" he challenged and, instead of getting back to work, took two steps towards her.

She froze. Earlier in the day she would have slapped him down and they would have been in no doubt about their relative stations. But as the afternoon had gone on, the atmosphere had become more convivial. Suddenly, she didn't even feel in control. What was going to happen here?

In the absence of a clear indication to desist, he took the remaining two steps to her, wrapped one arm around her back, pulled her close to him and then put his hand under her dress and pulled off her lioncloth.

If she had been frozen before, she became petrified: almost literally a rock.

Forcing his own loincloth to one side, he pulled out his penis, already erect from an afternoon of gazing at her and daydreaming about just this: her, unresponsive but compliant, giving herself to his advances.

She melted and her legs gave out, leaving her to fall backwards, away from him. He mistook that for encouragement and followed her down onto the hard ground and entered her. He thrust deeply and rapidly while moving his hands all over her body - her face, her breasts, her buttocks - and pulling her dress off leaving her completely naked.

"Ooh, I knew you'd enjoy that," he crowed as she lay there motionless underneath him. Then, thrusting ever more deeply, he ejaculated inside her and rolled off. "Oh, that was good. You're good," he congratulated himself. "Just give me a couple of minutes to get my strength back and I'll be back to work. You can't expect me to do everything at once."

The other men carried on working, but smirked to themselves. Maybe this was going to be a good gig working with this girl, if she was up for it.

Suddenly there was a huge screech. They all jumped. Then Clematis jumped up as if hit by lightning and bolted off across the field towards the village.

Jarn shook his head. "Not good," he muttered. "Not good."

Hyacinth repeated the story her daughter had told her to Bougainvillaea, who seemed puzzled.

"Did you have any idea he might commit such a crime against the Goddess?" she asked.

"Me? No. I always thought he was quite a nice little boy. Nothing special, and rather lazy, whenever I've had him on a work detail, but this? No. I would have warned Clematis if I had."

"Sobeit," said Bougainvillaea, turning to Tamarisk. "Send a runner to the field to fetch that group. I will hear what they have to say, but I think we will need to prepare an atonement for sunset."

"There is no justification at all for what you did, Wayne," concluded Bougainvillaea. "By the testimony of all present, it is clear that you lost control of your station and violated the laws of the Goddess. The only remedy is atonement. As for the four of you, I have no idea what you were thinking, but will assume that you were taken by surprise - as all of us would be - and simply could not react in time."

She indicated to Poinsettia to take over. Along with her happier tasks, the carrying out of atonements was a responsibility that fell to Poinsettia, chosen by the Goddess as her intermediary. She bowed to Bougainvillea and led a procession out of the Megara, westwards to the land of the cisterns.

As the others stood around, Poinsettia slit the garmets Wayne was wearing from him and tossed them into the cistern.

"Know that by your actions, you have defiled this village and the Goddess who guards it," she intoned. "The only atonement the Goddess accepts is the blood of the criminal - your blood. For the crime of rape, the Goddess insists on the blood that committed the crime - the blood of your penis." So saying, she grasped it with her left hand, and swung the the knife with her right to fully castrate him, then threw the removed member over the edge into the cistern.

As he stood there bleeding out, Bougainvillaea signalled to Clematis, she-who-had-been-violated. Clematis took two steps forward and, reaching out, pushed him firmly in the back. He sank to his knees and then, still pumping blood, fell head-over-heels into the pit.

They could hear the snakes hissing.

10. Anthesteria

Bougainvillaea led the villagers out to the cisterns.

The cisterns of the dead. And of the resurrection. For as surely as death followed life, life would one day follow death. All the villagers knew this, for did they not see it acted out around them every day of the year? It was the cycle of the Sun, of the Moon, of the seasons, of the crops. It was the cycle of life: from birth to infancy to maturity to old age and death, leading back to more new life.

And as life started in the east - the Sun, the Moon and the stars all rose in the east, after all - so all life ended in the west. And out here, in the west, was where they buried their dead. Buried in giant cisterns where they could commune with the representatives of the Goddess on earth, the snakes.

And once a year, when all was death, they who were living came out to see the dead and, if they could, release them for one day from their death, for this was the Anthesteria - the time of life-in-death, the day when even the Goddess slept in the underworld. Only the Moon fully sparkled in life; the seeds had been buried and would not been seen again until the year turned again, after the Moon had completed its cycle.

And so here they were. At the cisterns. At the end of the day, as the Sun settled in to sleep, and behind them the Moon rose. But for the next few hours, death was supreme.

"Hear me, O Goddess," chanted Bougainvillaea as she reached the first of the burial cisterns.

> *Hear me, O Goddess, who art ever with us, even in your day of death.*
> *Know that even as we mourn your burial,*
> *So we release those who have been buried before us,*
> *Knowing that one day those who come after us*
> *Will allow us our one day of release*
> *To be back in the world above.*

She motioned to the four priestesses around her and they moved into position and, grasping the handles on the lid of the cistern, lifted it from the pot below and moved it to one side. Bougainvillaea leant over the open cistern and called down into the space below.

Greetings, O Spirits.
Know that it is now the beginning of the Anthesteria.
You are welcome to wander among us, and tomorrow we will feed you.
But you may not take any who chew the buckthorn with you.

It is your choice.
You may come up and be with us, or you may stay down below.
You spirits are free to stay or to roam
For the next three days as you will.

The greeting completed, she led the procession on to the next cistern.

It was a sombre procession that came back into the village around the middle of the night.

It was impossible to see the spirits that chose to came up from the cisterns to join the procession of the living, but there was a clamminess to the air that accompanied them. By the time all the cisterns had been opened and the dead welcomed up, the procession felt encased in chilly fog. But the air was clear, and the night sky gleamed with the full moon and stars.

The women dispersed to their various houses. By the ritual of the Anthesteria, none of them closed their doors behind them, and all of them had bowls of buckthorn on their tables. Both for themselves and to share with any of the spirits that might choose to come and join them. Most of them would sit up now and be awake for the entirety of the the festival - they were just simply too afraid of what might happen if they were to drift off to sleep.

Hyancinth led her family in a recitation of one of the old verses commonly repeated for this day:

Let us remember those who went before us;
Those who knew the world before us;
They led their lives in cycles long ago;
They came before us and left before us;
They lived the cycles so that we might follow;

The Sun turned in their lives;
The Moon went around;
They were born, they lived and they died
In the cycle of life.

All of the women in the house took part in the brooding verses, trying as much as possible to keep themselves from thinking about the reality of death - the reality that death stalked among them this night.

The word was passed that the Moon was going down and the Sun was about to rise.

In keeping with the low-key nature of this festival, no trumpets or bells sounded; the message almost passed by osmosis. At this point, Hyacinth went and fetched the bucket of pitch they had prepared the week before and the brushes. Each of the women took a brush and they went to the front door, where they went to work "painting" the door frame with pitch.

"Know that we welcome you into our house today, O Spirits!" chanted Hyacinth.

For today is the Anthesteria,
And on this day we know you walk around among us.
But know also that this is our house,
And that by this anointing on of pitch,
We make it clear that life may not be taken out of the house.
You may come and go as you please,
But you may not take any of us with you.

The daubing done, the women took some of the bowls of buckthorn with them and went out to the east of the village to greet the Sun.

As the Sun rose above the horizon, Bougainvillaea greeted it on behalf of the villagers and the spirits of the dead.

Welcome to our village, O Sun!
Know that this day, we mourn our Goddess who is dead,
But live in harmony with our Spirits who are amongst us.
You are most welcome on this day of Death,

And we hope that you will shine on the living and the dead.

When the ceremony was over, they all returned to their houses.

The day passed slowly. And mainly in silence.

From time to time, one of the women would say something, either one of the chants associated with the day, or a recollection of one of the women that had gone before them. They spoke when they were moved to do so, but other that that were generally silent, lost in contemplation and concerned that they did not draw too much attention from the spirits.

And eventually the end of the day drew near.

As the day came to a close, Hyancinth gathered up the pots that had been prepared, and shared them among the women of the house. Then, being sure to cover themselves in mourning garments, they took the feast and joined a procession which formed back out to the cisterns to the west of the village.

Here Bougainvillaea led the villagers in laying out the feast for the spirits. A feast that was supposed both to attract the spirits back to the graveyard and also to placate them with the offerings that they had made.

Hyacinth took a pastry from one of the bowls and ate it sparingly. Clematis absently took one as well and munched on it while looking around her. The air looked clear but again, it felt clammy. Even if the spirits could not be seen, they could be felt. Clematis felt the spirit of her grandmother weighing down on her. Hyacinth's mother had been dead for six or seven seasons now, but Clematis felt her presence every year during the festival.

When the feast was over, the women returned to the village and their houses.

By the morning, the festival was considered over.

The problem with chasing away spirits that you couldn't see was that you couldn't see them, and didn't know if you'd succeeded. The hope, of course, was always that the feast would have drawn the spirits back to the cisterns where they needed to be, but, just to be safe, before dawn, it was time for the chase.

Today, it did not need to be signalled quietly. Quite the contrary.

With a blaring blast of sound, the trumpets announced that the day was breaking, and that it was time for all the villagers to begin the chase. Taking whatever was to hand, they starting making as much noise as possible.

Hyacinth picked up a ceramic pot and a wooden stirrer. Clematis picked up a wooden platter and a bronze shaft. The other women in the house reached for their own items. Hyacinth led the others out of the door, beating her pot with the stirrer and trying to make as much noise as she possibly could.

Begone!
Out of our doors, O Spirits!
It is no longer the Anthesteria!
It is no longer the Anthesteria!

Back in your tombs!
The time of walking with the living is over!
Out of our doors, O Spirits!
Back in your tombs!

Hyacinth's cries were echoed by Clematis and the other women and were overlaid and repeated by all the women throughout the village as they ran from house to house, waking and scaring the Spirits, and then driving them back through the fields to the cisterns.

When they arrived, Bougainvillaea and the priestesses went to each tomb in turn, and spoke the ritual words of reburial into each cistern.

Thank you for coming to guest with us,
Thank you for the lives that you led,
Now it is time to prepare for the next year

And time for you to return to the dead.

And with that, the priestesses covered the cistern and moved on to the next.

It was no longer the Anthesteria.

11. Cronos

Shep ran in from the northern edge of the village, near the forests.

"An army comes ... from the north," he gasped as he reached the Megara and was acknowledged by Bougainvillaea and the other women there.

"How big?" asked Bougainvillaea, confused both by the message and the direction. No villages were to be found to the north; just the forest, and, beyond that, the mountain ridges. Beyond the mountains, they said, there was water.

Like all the other villagers, Shep could count to five using the fingers of his right hand, and sometimes up to ten if he used both hands. Armies were counted by the number of women leaders they brought, sometimes with banners.

But this army was not like that.

"It is different," he said, and attempted to qualify. Probably they needed to send one of the women who was experienced in such things. He was just a runner really - able to take the message from the borders of the village to the leaders quickly. "There are more than five men coming. But they have no leaders. It seems to be just men. And they look different. They are not men like our men."

"They have no *women*?" asked Bougainvillaea, simply failing to comprehend what she was being told.

"We think they have some women with them, and some animals. But they are at the back. The men seem to be deciding things."

Bougainvillaea and Virbunum exchanged glances, confused. But Virbunum knew that dealing with this was her responsibility and she quickly took charge.

"Summon the army and tell them to meet at the northern edge of our lands, where the trail to the forest begins. When they are assembled, they will move forward to the observation point. I will meet them there." And Shep ran off to do as he was told.

Virbunum turned to Bougainvillaea and confided, "the signs this year have confused us. There is a possibility that this is something we have never seen before. Men taking the lead from women would be ... unprecedented."

Bougainvillaea nodded sagely, "I cannot understand how they hope to succeed without women to direct them; and yet, surely they would not appear as an army if they were just a band of surplus men from some other village that could not afford to support so many useless mouths through the winter.

"And this talk of animals confuses me too. Animals are following the men? Or have they taken them captive somehow? How is that possible? Do they have some enchanters with them who can control the spirits of men and of animals and enchant them?"

"There is only one way to find out more and that is to go and observe them. I will not have long. It would be better if we had a full cycle of the moon to observe them, but we do not. It is possible that having come this far, they will not come to our village but go elsewhere but ... I am not sanguine. I feel that this event has been foretold in the stars."

And she turned and left.

Was this it? Or was this just an advance party?

Shep, for all his inadequacy in describing this - she searched for a word - *group*, he had not been wrong in any particular. It was certainly small - she estimated about four hands of men, total - and, as Shep had said, there were no women leading it. At the back, again, as Shep had said, there was a party of women and some kind of animals - maybe the goats that you could find in the mountains - tagging along behind. But these women were clearly not in charge of this party. That would be that man there.

Bigger than most men she had seen, barrel-chested, and with a flame-red beard. He had a loincloth around his waist, but other than that, he was naked. Around his loincloth, he had some kind of ornamented belt, and hanging from that he had some kind of weapon - bronze, certainly - about the size of a club, but thinner. She was not sure what it was, but it was presumably the weapon of the leader.

Except, as she looked more closely, all of the men in this party had the same arrangement: lioncloth, ornamented belt, and bronze club. Yes, she had to presume that these were weapons and that, somehow, some group of men had developed the intelligence to move from place to place - and presumably fight - on their own.

She was tempted to just try a frontal battle. The numbers were so in her favour that she didn't even understand how they would be able to stand against her numbers; probably they would run away in the face of determined resistance.

But caution tugged at her. There was so much here she didn't understand; so much that could be hidden. Was this, in fact, just a feint, a decoy, intended to lull them into false confidence? And then bring up the reserve party to batter them when they were fully engaged? Could that even be done?

Nothing in her experience had fully prepared her for this moment.

She decided to go with the tried and tested. Four units would form the centre and should easily outnumber this rabble. Then she had ten units left and could send five to each side. She certainly had the numbers but couldn't help feeling that what she was missing was much more important than that.

The enemy kept on coming, apparently oblivious to the presence of an army in front of them. They were just ambling, not obviously ready to do battle or scouting ahead for any signs of danger.

As Tamarisk gave the signal, Polo jumped up and charged towards the oncoming group. He brandished his bronze-edged scythe at the man opposite who was yet to draw his weapon. As he swung, the man simply ... disappeared. Polo, committed to the swing, overbalanced and had to adjust his feet to regain balance. And there was the man again, with his bronze club in his hand, ready to swing, in front of him.

Except he didn't swing the club.

Rather, more like he would wield a pruning-hook, the man thrust the club into his chest, where it went - straight through. Polo looked down at himself in wonder, as blood poured out of the wound. A few heartbeats later, he collapsed to the ground and the man opposite him used his foot to contemptuously push Polo to the ground, dead.

Tamarisk saw the same thing happen across the line as they advanced. What should have been a melee, leading to the enemy being surrounded and disarmed due to their limited numbers, was becoming a massacre of the men under her command. Even as the second wave went in, she could see that they held no advantage in terms of surprise, tactics or numbers. Whatever the weapons were that the enemy wielded, they must carry some magic from the Goddess. They killed on contact, and the men carrying them were simply more adept, more adroit, at moving in combat. Even outnumbered, they were simply winning. In all her years, Tamarisk had never seen this many men literally killed in a field of battle. It was just too hard to kill a man.

As she watched, another hand of men fell to the ground. She wrung her own hands, indecisive. Should she send in the reinforcements, hoping that being surrounded would make the difference? Or should she concede now, while she had the strongest negotiating position? After all, if the enemy clearly demonstrated that they could win a comprehensive victory, she would have nothing to negotiate *with*.

She made the fateful decision.

She indicated to the trumpeter to play the sounds for "reform" that would bring the wings back to the rear, where they could offer a defence in depth. And then she sounded the "disengage" that would cause the men engaged in fighting to pull pack. Not that there really were any men actively engaged in fighting; there were those who were dying, and those who had not yet attempted to engage the enemy.

She waited while all the forces at her disposal formed up behind her in their units with the women in command ahead of them. When all was in order, she took the ritual steps forward and bowed to her opponent - or, at least, the man she was assuming was here leading this unnatural force.

She spread her hands wide to include all the forces behind her and indicate that what she said was said to include them all: this was not merely *her* surrender but the surrender of the whole village. Assuming, of course, a peaceful resolution could be had.

She fixed her expression into the neutral shape needed to frame the negotiations of a lost village. She had done this before, but never after such an uncompromising loss. She had never lost this many men before in either a loss or a victory. But now she must acknowledge the loss and extract what she could from it.

She rose up again, arms still stretched wide, and spoke the formal words of submission.

"We accept that you are the stronger party," she said.

She waited, expecting him to acknowledge in turn that he would be magnanimous in victory, but he just stood there, eyeing her with a cruel expression in his eyes: did he want to keep on killing? What would be the benefit of that?

She tried again.

"We accept that you are the stronger party."

Again, no response. She was tempted to give orders to her lieutenants to attack again. If this man wanted to fight, then they could fight. If he wasn't going to accept her surrender and negotiate, it was unclear what he would accept. And if he was so obstreperous as to not accept anything, they would end up fighting: that was inevitable. But surely he could see that in that case, both sides would lose.

She tried to pretend that he had acknowledged her submission and moved on to the next line in the formula.

"We offer you to come and join us in our feast. Let us sit, and share barley with each other and with the Goddess, and let us discuss our differences in the world. And then, full and replete with the necessities of life, let us exchange gifts and part as friends."

Exchanging gifts being code for "what is the least you will accept to go away and leave us alone", thought Tamarisk, not for the first time. Although she could not figure what it would be like to be friends with these stony-faced murderers, she thought. They do seem to really relish the violence. Will they parley? Or will they attack, even against superior numbers?

He stood there, looking at her, intently.

She had no idea what to do.

Through the red mist, Cronos realised he was unopposed.

He stood back, shaking slightly with the battle rage he always felt at times like this. He had killed three or four men already, but now the others had backed off. He shook his head slightly. Were they admitting defeat? Were they regrouping? He and his men were still massively outnumbered. Should he retreat while given the opportunity? Was it a trick?

None of it made sense.

As he watched and wondered, more and more men - with occasional women dotted throughout the force - came from the sides and from behind him to join the ranks of those opposing him. Surely if all of these had joined the fight, they would have won? Man for man, he acknowledged he was superior, but ultimately the numbers would have told. Particularly if they had come at him from behind.

One woman stepped forward from the line. Was she an offering? Were they accepting that they could have won, but would rather not take the losses and would rather bribe him with women and goats? If so, where were the rest? Or was this a token?

She bowed down before him and stretched her arms wide. When she rose up again, she had a strange expression. Not violent, but not submissive either. Whatever she was, she was not an offering.

"Ma-hey-ga-li ga-li-po-da ga-ne-ne," she said, or something like that.

He signalled his men to follow.

Whatever this woman was doing, she clearly didn't want to fight any more. But was she leading him into a trap? But what trap could they have laid that was a better position that the one in which they had started?

They were certainly retreating in disciplined formation. He considered attacking again as they followed, but, at the moment, what was the point? They'd certainly had the better of the earlier fight, but in war there were never any guarantees, and presumably they would finally let him meet the leader of their tribe, their King, whatever, and he would be able to negotiate the right to share this land with these people. After all, it seemed the Gods had been very clear they wanted him to come here. Why would that be if they let him down at the last step?

After a while, he could set yet more people ahead. Most of these were women, which made sense since the fighting force had been mainly men. This would presumably be the campsite where they had left the women when they went off to fight, although he didn't see anywhere for people to live. As they came closer, he could see that there were bowls on the ground, and people arranging all kinds of expensive pottery. Even his father did not have this many pots! For sure, these people were rich - and yet did not have the strength to defend their wealth against any intruder. How, again, was that possible?

The men dispersed away, around the back of the women and the food. The women who had been with them turned and faced him, and again, the woman who he presumed must be standing in for the leader bowed to him and waved her arms wide and muttered something he still had no hope of understanding.

But a feast he understood. He stepped forward and said, "you welcome us to a guest-feast. I see the bowls and finery you have laid out. We will share of our plenty." And, signalling to one of the boys at the back of the column, he said, "we offer a goat in the name of the great God." The boy brought forward a goat and placed the lead in his hand.

Quickly, women came forward and prepared the fire pit and the spit. They opened the holy jar and pushed in a stick, which caught alight. They lit the fire and then, with great ceremony, he slit the throat of the goat, allowing the blood to fall on the ground.

"With this blood, I sanctify this meeting place. Here we share in guest rights and acknowledge that we work together in good faith to good ends. Then let the duel decide for all."

When the goat had bled out, the women quickly dressed it and mounted it on the spit.

"Dionysus, the wine!"

They had little enough wine left; unlike water, which ran in streams, the wine was made somewhere and then traded throughout the mountains. More than once in the past couple of years of travelling, he had encountered other parties who had some to trade, or occasionally, to surrender in the face of death. But many more times, they had drunk the wine that they had, and ever its quantity went down. But, limited as their supplies were, this was definitely an occasion to celebrate.

Another woman had come to join the first. They had talked to each other for a long while, but neither of them had tried talking to him since they had settled down here. Was this one the wife of the chief? Why were all the men hanging back and letting these women do the talking for them? Where was the chief of this tribe?

Oh well, probably everything would become clear as the feast went on. Maybe the men did not want the shame of sharing the guest feast when they had lost in battle.

The meat had roasted nicely, their hosts were waiting patiently with their bowls of fruits, and now Cronos offered the wine. The woman who seemed to be in charge accepted a little and drank it, and tried to keep her face straight, but clearly did not like it. But the gesture was enough. If she didn't want it, that meant more for him and his men. He would, of course, pour out a cup for each of the leaders. Anything less would be an insult. But he expected to have a good night. Even before the ritual offerings began.

One of the women came over and gave him a bowl. It had some kind of seeds in it; he hadn't see anything quite like that before, but they seemed to have no end of them. He signalled one of the boys, who took some of the meat from the goat over to the woman leader. She acknowledged his gift and ate it.

Whatever the seeds were that they had given him, they were certainly filling and nutritious. They did a good job of soaking up the grease from the goat. This was a good combination. He should get one of his women to find out what the plant looked like from which they collected them.

He took another drink of wine and watched the women. They were enjoying their seeds, and partaking of the goat in suitable quantities. But none of them showed any interest in the wine.

"Dionysus," he called. "Do you think these people have never had wine? They seem to drink enough water, but no wine."

"Probably not," replied Dionysus. "I once spent a season in a valley where they made it from small fruits, although I don't know how. And I've met a lot of people who've never heard of it. Sad for them," he added, smiling lopsidely.

Bougainvillaea felt her head hurting.

Leaving aside that they had no words in common, nothing he said or did seemed to fit with any experience she had had of negotiation. For starters, she had never negotiated with a *man* before: the very thought that one had the temerity - not to mention ability - to do so confused her. It clearly wasn't that the women of their tribe had all died: they were here, and relegated to the back somewhere along with these strange animals they had brought with them, one of which they had just slaughtered as if they had hunted it.

And she could not read him. Maybe that was just because he was a man, but, as the feast had gone on, he had become louder and more belligerent. But now the feast was over. And presumably this was the time to negotiate. She stood up in order to address him:

"We do not know from where you come or how the Goddess brought you here, but we would see you peaceably settled and not at war with you. But how do we communicate?"

He stood up too and garbled something she did not understand. Then he waved his arm around in the air before pointing at her and garbled some more. Then, when she did not respond, he pulled his loincloth to one side, exposing his partially erect penis and pointed to it. Then started stroking it.

She was baffled. Did he mean to ejaculate on the floor in the middle of where they had had the holy feast? Or was he asking her if she would like to have sex with him? Neither seemed at all likely, but then nothing he said or did seemed to make any sense. He jabbered again. She stared at him blankly, trying to make any of it make any sense at all.

Suddenly, without warning, he leapt forward, grabbed her right wrist and turned her, thrusting her face down on her knees towards the floor. Before she could grasp what was happening, he had removed her loincloth and cast it to one side. A weight like a boulder crashed onto her back, forcing her to the ground. And then, with a violent tearing, she felt his penis thrust inside her. "Owww..."

What the hell was happening?

The feast was over, and Cronos was pleasantly drunk.

None of these women had drunk any of their wine: they had been happy enough to have their share of his goat, though, so they weren't completely distrusting.

Now, he just needed to figure out where the leader of this tribe was hiding and get him to come out and challenge him to a duel. Once he was dead, he could have this woman and everybody would agree that he was now the ruler of this tribe and, in lieu of goats, he would accept the village with these strange fruits as his dowry.

The woman he presumed must be the wife of the chief stood up and harangued him. Her words hadn't made any sense when he was sober, and he didn't think that would change now. His pleasant drunk was starting to morph into an angry, frustrated drunk and the last thing he wanted right now was to be lectured by some woman. He stood up too.

"Look, woman, I don't know where your husband is, the chief of your tribe, whatever. But if he doesn't come out right now and battle me for the rights to you and this land, I'm just going to take it for myself. You can't stop me, can you?"

She looked at him, blankly. As if that would make him change him mind.

"Your husband, woman! The one who sticks this in you." And he pulled aside his loincloth, revealing his penis, already becoming erect at the thought of both killing her husband and then having her here, in the middle of everyone, demonstrating his prowess in the face of the people, her dead husband and all the Gods.

She still didn't get it. Uppity bitch. Finally, he lost patience.

"Well, if he's just going to hide away, he loses his rights. Come here, and I'll fuck you anyway, and then I will be your master if he can't be bothered to fight for you."

He gave her a moment to come to her senses, but she did not: she just stood there, staring at him like some kind of halfwit. In a well-practised battle move, he stepped forward, pulled on her wrist and twisted her to the ground. Whipping off her loincloth, he knelt down behind her and entered her.

Nobody tried to stop him.

Mykenai, Greece

2145 BCE

1. New Year's Day

The two fighters clashed bronze swords.

Cronos and Rhea sat together in the Megara watching the games. Only one of these contestants could be the ultimate victor, and that came down to Rhea's choice. Of course, in this, as in so many things, she considered, and often deferred to, Cronos' advice. But at the end of the day, she was the Queen and he was simply the only man with whom she would have sex for the year. A year that was rapidly coming to an end.

"Note his use of the feet," Cronos whispered to her, leaning in close to experience as much of her as possible in his remaining time. He gestured to the fighter on their right. "He half-commits, then retreats before fully committing. He is very light on his feet. If he can make the combat last long enough, he will win."

"And the other does not?" Rhea asked.

"No," replied Cronos. "Watch; there! He hesitates, and then over-commits. If he does that at the wrong moment, he will open up his entire body." The men exchanged two more blows and then, as if directed by Cronos' critique, the man to their left exposed his ribs and a gash rapidly opened up across them. Unlikely to be fatal in the games, where it could be quickly treated, it was a resounding victory to the other. As one was dragged away, the other came to Rhea to be rewarded with a laurel crown - the symbol of all the winners in this event.

The herald sounded the trumpet and called out, "Let the candidates for the foot race present themselves." Eight men, including the clearly winded victor of the combat which had just taken place moved forward to the starting line on the right of the Megara. These eight had already won their individual rounds of single combat, and taken part in the wrestling event, where they had performed creditably.

As they formed up on the start line, Rhea watched intently. Winning was not, by itself, enough. The grace and balance of the runners counted for much, as did the ease with which they could cover the relatively short distance of the Megara. In real life, soldiers were required to run many furlongs without a break; a single furlong across the Megara should be accomplished in their stride.

Rhea signalled and the herald sounded the trumpet. As the note finished, all eight men sprinted across the floor until they crossed the finish line on their left.

"A fairly easy decision, I'd say," Cronos whispered to his wife, the Queen.

She smiled at him. As so often since he had become King, they saw things exactly the same way.

As the Sun went down, the stars started to emerge in the sky.

There would, of course, be no moon tonight, and the sisters of the Pleiades would only be showing their faces for a short while before following the Sun into his grave. That was how New Year was.

The men of the village had prepared the big bonfire during the day, and now the young girls brought a brand lit from the sacred flame to set fire to it. As they did so, it crackled and burst into life.

Rhea watched the sky turn and the sisters set in the west, following their brother the Sun. And now, the New Year underway, it was time for the ritual as old as time. She signalled to the priestesses and they followed her to the perimeter of the fire, and began the dance. Meanwhile, the wives stayed back, seated with their husbands.

Surrounding the fire, the men started to beat the drums, and women started to play the trumpets and flutes. Rhea felt her body begin to move to the timing of the music and tried to find that point of communion with the Goddess, mourning now for the loss of her brother/husband.

Around her, the other priestesses were doing the same thing: worshipping the Goddess with their supple movements at the same time as trying to reach the ecstatic state of communion.

"Waaaahhhh!" To her left she heard one of the priestesses reach the point of ecstasy, then point into the crowd at one of the men there. Called forward to worship, he left his wife and came to the priestess. Immediately, he joined in the dance opposite her, timing his movements to hers, a reflection of her purity and devotion to the Goddess.

"Wooooo..." And to her right, she heard another priestess reach the threshold and call a man forward. She redoubled her efforts to reach the threshold, dancing every faster, losing herself in the rhythm of the music. The wine she had drunk before the festival began was starting to take hold as well, leaving her ever more disconnected from the here and now and lost in the cycle of life and death with the Goddess.

As she slowly slipped from conscious thought through unconscious action into ecstasy, she became connected with all around her, and was aware of the increasing number of priestesses who had moved from dancing, through ecstasy, to sexual intercourse with their partners. All around her, the dance was becoming slower but more entwined, as the male and the female joined together in one human bond.

"Uwwww..." She slipped fully into the trance and as she did so, called her husband forward. This was his moment, in some sense, even more than it was hers. In the same way that the moment of the sunset belonged more to the Sun than it did to Her sister's eternal cycles.

"Come to me, my darling ..." she whispered, almost under her breath.

And then he was there, in front of her.

So big, so muscular, so strong. A perfect representation of the brother/husband, the ideal. And he moved with such grace, such suppleness. Somehow it almost seemed like a shame. But that was the nature of the cycle, and the Goddess had ordained it so at the beginning of time.

He danced opposite her, copying her movements: first consciously, then unconsciously. As he followed her into the unconscious ecstasy of the dance, he came closer and then reached out and put his hands on her. Now they were not just in step, but entwined. She continued the dance as he first pulled her towards him, then lifted her up. She put her arms around him and placed her head on his broad shoulder. He lowered her slightly, and then, still dancing, he entered her.

The fire burned. The music played. All around her, the other priestesses were doing exactly the same thing she was doing, all of them at different stages of completion. As they finished, they fell to the floor, replete, unmoving. In the circle around the dancers, the others watched on, some playing instruments, some clapping their hands and stamping their feet. The ritual was not over until all the priestesses had been satisfied.

Suddenly, she felt him spasming inside her as he ejaculated. As he let her go, she pulled away from him, back towards the fire and pointed an accusatory finger at him. "Who is this man?" she demanded.

From the surrounding circle, a man leapt forward to protect her, a bronze sword shining brightly in his hand. With a single thrust, he stabbed Cronos in the back, then pulled the sword back out. When Cronos had fallen to the ground, he slashed at his neck, and removed the head, handing it to Rhea. She held it by the hair, looking at it disdainfully, and then threw it into the fire.

"Cronos is dead! The old year is done!" cried the man who had killed Cronos, throwing away the sword.

Rhea moved closer to him and wrapped her arms around him. As he lifted her up and began pleasuring her, she shouted as loudly as she could manage, "Cronos is alive! Long live Cronos! The New Year is with us!"

The music kept playing.

2. A Day in the Fields

"Strike high, then thrust!"

Cronos was working the men through the basic drill of fighting men. Every day, some of the men would take part while others worked in the fields. He had a core of men whose first responsibility was to always be ready to fight: four or five hands' worth. But the others came and worked out with the soldiers once or twice a month, except during the harvest season. It was probably a good compromise - there was a lot of other work that needed to be done to keep the community alive - but Cronos was invariably frustrated by the lack of skill that these part-timers showed. And it often seemed that they had forgotten everything that they had been taught the last time they had been here.

"No, no, no, if you expose yourself like that, you are just asking to be skewered," he yelled at a particularly idiotic young man who seemed to think that this was a day off in the hayfields, rather than a serious activity that could one day be the difference between life and death. Specifically *his* life or death.

Today, there was no risk of being skewered. The bronze swords were too valuable, too fragile and two sharp to be used for day-to-day training. Instead, they used wooden training swords to beat at each other. It wasn't the same of course - the wood was nothing like as heavy as bronze, and the swords didn't have the same balance - but it was better than not having any bronze swords to hand when they actually needed to fight.

"Come here. Let's go through this slowly," he said, pointing to the young idiot. "Now, stand opposite me. Like this. That's right. Now don't plant your feet as if you are going to stand there all day; fighting is all about motion. You need to be ready to pick your feet up and move them backwards and forwards. You need to be ready to dodge a thrust and put all your weight behind your own thrust. Stand on your toes!"

Cronos took up his guard position and waited for the man to copy him, which he did - slowly and lugubriously. Cronos snapped his sword out and hit the man on the arm before pulling his sword back.

"Hey! I wasn't ready!" he complained.

"Be sure to mention that to any enemy soldiers you might meet," hit back Cronos. "You never know, it might work. Try again. And be ready!" Suddenly, he lost his temper and jumped forward, slapping the idiot's sword to one side and, stepping inside his guard, shouldered him in the face, knocking him to the floor. Cronos flicked his sword out and left it across his neck. "Dead," he pronounced. "Leave the sword there, get up and go back to work. You are no use to me."

Enarete leaned back on her hoe.

The barley was growing nicely and she was sure that it would be a good harvest, but clearing out the weeds from this field was backbreaking work. But somebody had to do it. She had been here all morning, just working her way along this row of barley, often on her hands and knees, scrabbling out the extraneous plants that should not be there.

And then she noticed the blight.

When she had been down amongst the weeds, it had not been obvious, but now it was. On the leaves and the burgeoning stalks of the barley, a discolouration was there. She pulled at some of it and sniffed it. Without doubt, that was barley blight. If she didn't do something quickly, that could soon take over and kill the whole crop. Dropping her hoe, she moved up and down the furrow, looking closely at the state of the barley she passed. The blight was quite widespread, but certainly not taking over the entire field as yet.

Feeling that she had assessed it to the best of her ability, she ran to find Rhea.

Macareus slumped into the river.

It had been a hard drill session. Even without Cronos losing his temper with one of the part-timers - and then taking it out on the rest of them for the rest of the session at arms - the combination of the heat and the effort involved in the gymnastic portion of the drill was enough to reduce them to quivering wrecks. *With* Cronos in a bad mood, it just became insufferable. They had had to carry four huge rocks (each) along the running course, and then he made them go around a second time because of some perceived failing by one of them. By the time Macareus finally reached the river, Cronos was going back looking for the stragglers who had - literally - fallen by the wayside.

Bathing in the river was generally the best part of the day's drill. Apart from the ability to relax and wipe off the dirt and sweat of the day's activity, there were often women down here doing the village's washing that they could watch and talk to. But not today. For some reason, there were no other people down at the river. Since he would be one of the first to know if the village was under attack, he assumed it had to be something else - but what?

Rhea took the flaming brand from the girl's outstretched hand.

Some of the barley from each end of the blighted patch had now been scythed away to create a firebreak at each end, and all of the surrounding earth had been doused in water to prevent the fire spreading across the ground. If Enarete felt it had been backbreaking work doing the hoeing, the combination of scything and bringing all that water from the river - even with most of the villagers dropping their other tasks to help - had left her completely exhausted.

With a few pots of water still around them, in case the fire should spread unexpectedly, Rhea addressed the Goddess to acknowledge the actions she was taking.

Oh Goddess, we know not what we have done to be
blighted like this,
But we use your holy flame and destroy the enemy,
We clean out that which is corrupt in our fields
And will look to do the same in our hearts.

And with that, she touched the flame to the blight and stood back. Within seconds, the barley had become a tower of flames as the fire leapt from stalk to stalk. While the Sun crept down in the sky, the fire burnt and destroyed blight and barley both. Eventually the flames died down and the barley was reduced to smouldering ash. While not the disaster that it could have been if it had been allowed to spread unchecked through the field, the black smudge was a reminder of how fragile was the cereal on which they all depended.

They stamped on the ash to make sure it was all burnt out and then trudged back to the Megara. Days like today were not the sort of thing to celebrate - more to survive.

The work never seemed to come to an end.

Even the "full-time" soldiers were expected to carry jars of water back from the river to the village to put in the irrigation channels at the end of the day. Cronos called it "character-building exercise" but the truth was that even as a full-time soldier, there were aspects of village life which still called upon you. And it was certainly better than having to spend the whole day in the fields, hoeing, weeding and making sure the cereals were watered; or even working in the craft sheds making pots or weaving cloth from flax.

But today, for some reason, the pots were not where they usually were, so Macareus and the other soldiers had to first walk up to the irrigation pond to find them, before carrying them back to the river just to fill them. He walked stiffly up the hill and through the field.

And noticed the smell of burning. Some of the field had been burnt - intentionally? - during the day. He was sure that if this had been carried out by some other tribe, he would have been alerted and they would have been called to fight them off. But that at least explained why the pots were not where they should be - they were here, having been used to put the fire out.

Macareus picked up two of the pots and walked back down to the river. Stepping into the river, he lowered each of the pots in turn, and filled them as full as he could manage. He passed each of them in turn to one of his colleagues, and in exchange received more pots to fill. When all the pots had been filled, the men picked them up and carried them, once more, back up to the fields.

At the irrigation pond, Macareus put down his pot and tipped the water into the reservoir. When the pot was empty, he took it and stacked it with the others waiting to be carried back down to the river.

Cronos lay down next to Rhea on the straw bedding.

"What a day!" he said. "Do you think we have done something to offend the Goddess?"

"I cannot think what," she replied. "But if we have, we must root it out as thoroughly as we did the blight today. But tell me, are you concerned about discipline at a wider level, or is it just one man? One man I can keep in the fields; he wasn't a full-timer, was he?"

"Goodness, no! He would never make the grade. You know as well as I do how stiff the competition is to become one of the Goddess' own! But no, my concern is not really about one man, it is about the readiness of the village as a whole to resist an attack - particularly a surprise attack. You remember the battle three years ago? I was just a soldier then, of course, but we could very easily have lost. I feel we are not as prepared as we need to be.

"And I can't help feeling that the blight today was a sign. Serious as it could have been in its own right - and I do realise that - the important thing is to make sure you that you take prompt action and root it out completely. And I feel that is the message that the Goddess is sending us today - we need to root out indolence in the community and make sure that we are ready for any attacks. Do you agree?"

"I don't know," she demurred. "I think we should ask the Goddess herself to give us a clear sign."

"A sacrifice?" he asked.

"Tomorrow," she replied, and moved closer to him.

Theano walked among the goats.

For a sacrifice like this, only the best of all the goats would do. It must, of course, be healthy, fit and without blemish. To sacrifice an inferior goat could bring down the wrath of the Goddess on all of them. And as the woman in charge of the offering, it was Theano's responsibility to make sure that the goat was perfect. On top of all that, it needed to be perfect *today*. Theano knew all the goats of course - knew them nearly as well as the children that tended them on a daily basis - but she needed to sense which of them was ready, *today*, to go and meet the Goddess and take a message from the villagers.

And bring a response back.

That one! Without question or doubt, she hooked her crook over the small goat Edsel, and led it away. It knew her of course, and knew that she would give it some special malted barley that she carried with her everywhere. What it didn't know was that today was going to be different - and that in a little while it would be burning on the altar.

Cronos laid down the big flint double-headed axe. He picked up the last pieces of wood he had just finished splitting and put them on the pile behind the altar.

Behind him, Theano was approaching with the goat. To his right, Rhea stood with the flint dagger drawn, ready to slice the goat's neck.

When Theano arrived, Cronos turned and picked the goat up, placing it on the altar. Rhea took two steps towards him, reached out, and slashed its throat.

Goddess, if we have sinned, tell us how!
Goddess, if we must change, show us how!
Goddess, if there is aught we do not know, tell us now!
Goddess, lead us in thy paths.

Theano watched the struggles of the goat intently and then, as it ceased moving, signalled to Cronos to place it on the fire. When all was arranged, one of the girls came forward with a fiery brand and passed it to Theano.

"Goddess, accept our gift."

"The Goddess agrees with Cronos. She is afraid."

The others looked at Theano in shock. The *Goddess* was afraid? Of what? How was that possible?

Rhea, to whom the responsibility for the village ultimately fell, asked the question for all of them: "what can frighten the Goddess?"

Theano shook her head in confusion. "I don't know. But she sent the signs, and they were very clear. The Goddess fears that we will be weak, we will not prevail, and we will be destroyed. And she is concerned that along with us, she herself will perish."

Cronos shook his head dolefully. "I never thought. If I had known, I would never ..."

Rhea cut across him, "no, it is good that we asked. Now we know that our fears are not of our own making, but that even the Goddess herself shares them. I do not know what we can do differently, but we must work diligently to make sure that we are ready for any attacks from outside."

"And be prepared for any other emergencies," amplified Theano. "I think the blight might not just be a warning about our enemies, but also to keep alert to the vagaries of weather and soil."

"We are assailed on all sides," lamented Cronos. "How will we even know in which direction to look for the next crisis?"

"The Goddess will guide us," reassured Theano.

3. Thargelia

Cronos and Rhea led the villagers out to the east to greet the dawn. Rhea led the chorus of the priestesses in welcoming the Sun on this day:

We greet you, O Sun,
Visible face of Her we adore,
Giving to us all things
And asking us for nothing
As we receive, so we shall share
With those of your persons
With whom we share this life

Today is the day of collection
In which we gather our bounty
We share with all who live
And hold nothing back.
Today is the first day of the season
Today is the glimmering of life
For which we give your praise.

The freshly made platter of offering was handed to Theano, who then followed Cronos and Rhea in the procession through the lands of the village. For this festival, for reasons obscure to the villagers, no goats were offered to the Goddess. But she was offered fruit from the trees, especially the figs that were starting to ripen, and others that were ready. From the barley fields, they plucked and shelled ears of barley and added them to the platter. From there, they went to collect beans, just starting to be ready for plucking, and then the procession moved west, collecting almonds from the trees there. With all the fruits gathered, Rhea and Theano stopped to arrange the platter for the presentation.

Platter ready, Rhea bowed to her husband and dismissed him.

"Husband mine, know that in the presence of the Goddess, I will be safe and protected. In her arms, I will be comforted. No needs that I have will she not meet and, loth as I am to be separated from you, she has ordained that only women should come into her presence to make this offering." So saying, she bowed to him again.

In return, he bowed to her and said the formal words of release.

"Wife mine, keeper of the village, I know that with the Goddess you will find all your needs met. I cannot stray where she wishes me not to be, so, for the good of the village, I leave you here."

And, so saying, he bowed again and returned to the village. In his wake, all the men followed him.

Rhea reached the first of the cisterns to the west of the village just as the Sun climbed to its zenith.

She placed the platter on the ground and, together with her chief priestesses, retreated a few paces and sat to observe how the Goddess would receive their offering. The other women, who had remained in the procession, had stopped a furlong or so back from the cisterns: included, but not included. And most importantly, not at risk should the Goddess express her extreme displeasure with the ultimate sanction: death.

Rhea sat, and waited for the Goddess' response.

The Sun was closing on the horizon when the first snake emerged, tentatively, from the cistern.

The wait had been long and nerve-wracking. Particularly in light of the signs they had already received that month, for the Goddess to reject the offering of the Thargelia could devastate the harvest in the eyes of all of them. Why would the Goddess do that? Did she want to destroy them and, by her own implication, herself? Was there a bigger game at play here that they simply could not understand?

The snake hissed aggressively. And slowly, suspiciously, slithered over to the platter. It raised itself up, and slowly sniffed the air. Then it moved closer and sniffed the offering. It moved around the platter, and sniffed in two or three more locations before suddenly becoming erect and clearly on guard.

Another snake came out of the cistern. It too seemed on edge and slithered over to and then around the platter. Whatever had alarmed the first seemed to have spooked the second also.

Suddenly, an eagle swooped out of the sky and landed directly on the platter, overturning it. The eagle spread out its wings and batted them in the face of the first snake, which retreated, dazed. The second - now to the bird's left, instantly snapped forward, attempting to strike the eagle. But with surprising reflexes, the eagle hopped back, batting its wings again. Both snakes now retreated back into the cistern, leaving the eagle in charge of the field.

"Why didn't you do something?" demanded Cronos, when Rhea told him about it.

"Do something? Like what?" she countered.

Cronos was frustrated. As a man, he was excluded from these rituals which involved communion with the Goddess, but even he could see what had happened here.

"Scare it. Chase it off. Kill it," he retorted. "The Goddess tells you, *specifically*, that she is afraid that there is going to be an interloper who comes and attacks her and then, there she is, coming out for the offering you made her, and *you let her be attacked*. She *specifically* said that we needed to be ready to intervene on her behalf, both to protect the village and her herself. *And you did nothing?*"

He stopped, exasperated.

He could feel their whole world, possibly their whole way of life, closing in on him and he didn't like it. The defence of his village was his responsibility, and he had but the one year to do it. When he had just been a soldier, striving for excellence, he had not realised what a responsibility it was to be Cronos. He had seen men he admired, taking on the role for their year in turn and had seen the glory, the power, the authority. But not the responsibility.

And now, through circumstances outside his control, he felt he had failed in that responsibility.

4. Initiation

Metapontus and Arne were admitted to the Megara.

Cronos and Rhea were seated, dealing with the everyday administrative business of the village. When they had finished dealing with the previous item, Metapontus and Arne approached and bowed low.

"My daughter has come of age," declared Metapontus, not entirely without pride, for today his daughter had taken the first step towards being a full member of the community.

"And which path do you wish her to take?" enquired Cronos. "Do you have a husband picked out for her, or do you wish her to be a priestess?"

The single biggest decision in a woman's life: to be attached to one man, and to have the simplicity, consistency and, some said, security of a nuclear family; or, by rejecting that, to be free to serve the Goddess completely; and, in time, to have the possibility of real rank in the community and to have her children grow up among the servants of the Goddess.

For each girl becoming a woman, it was an individual choice, but a choice so important that only her parents, with the maturity and wisdom that comes from a long life, could hope to make it correctly. And, even then, they were well advised to consult with others, especially the leaders in the community.

"There is a young man we think might be a good choice," said Metapontus, "who is not unknown to you. As yet he does not have a wife, but we think he would like one. And our Amphissa might be a good choice."

One of the issues, of course, was simply numeric: the attrition rate among males, particularly younger males once they had reached maturity, was significantly higher than it was for females, even taking into account the risk of death in childbirth. Once a man was married, he and his wife formed a family. While he could still partake in ritual intercourse at the frequent feasts, he could not marry again. So while for many, the life of a priestess was a choice, for others it simply came down to: is there a man available to marry? And one that will live for long enough to make the marriage worthwhile? And one that is worth marrying? For, once chosen, the path to marriage was irrevocable: both man and woman were committed for the rest of their lives, regardless what happened to their partner.

"Macareus," Cronos guessed. Metapontus nodded. In some senses, it wasn't even a guess: Macareus was a promising and handy young man, not married, and reaching that age where he had demonstrated sufficient skill with a blade that he was more, rather than less, likely to survive in any combat.

"Have you considered waiting?" Rhea interjected. Because, while it was a binary choice, it was also possible to wait: a woman could wait many years before deciding that a husband was the right choice for her, living the life of a priestess and having children along the way. On the upside, that proved her fertility in the eyes of the Goddess; on the other hand, many men were jealous and did not want a wife who came with three or four children who were not his. What was the point of marriage, anyway, if not that a man knew that the children in his house were *his* children, formed from his sexual union with *his* wife.

"Yes, but not seriously," responded Metapontus. "Unlike our other daughters, she is very much that sort of girl. She likes the simple life and does not aspire to communion with the Goddess. And Macareus is a good man, who we are sure will look after her. He often shares his meals with us and sits with us at the festivals. I am sure there is attraction there, and I am sure that it is mutual. Obviously, she must wait the ritual period, but after that, if he confirms he will have her, I would have her married to Macareus."

"I feel the same way, " said Arne. "She is so like me in so many ways. Rhea, you may remember that I decided to wait and see how the life of a priestess felt, but it was not one for me, even though I grew up in that environment. I wanted the security of a good man to wrap my arms around at night rather than the ecstasy of the Goddess. And I have never looked back on that decision."

The benefit of waiting, of course, for the daughter, was that, by becoming a priestess even temporarily, she gained autonomy and the ability to choose her own husband - should she wish to do so.

"Very good," said Rhea. "Let Macareus be summoned."

Macareus put down the heavy rocks he had been lifting.

"Cronos wants me in the Megara? Not on the drill field?" he clarified with the messenger.

"Yes, sir," the boy confirmed. "I was sent to summon you to audience with the King and Queen in the Megara. You are to go there immediately." He didn't need to say it was important: a summons to appear in the Megara was always important.

Cronos walked over to the cupboard by his bunk in the barracks and pulled out his "quality" garment. Slipping it on over his head and bare chest he indicated to the boy that he would follow him.

His mind was racing. Had he failed in some task and was to be punished? Or was he to be given a promotion to a leader of a hand? Or was there some special mission at hand? They couldn't be under attack, he was sure. That summons would not be to the Megara, but to the battle site. And would have been sounded on the trumpet. He hoped he hadn't failed in anything, but his conscience was clear. He didn't *think* he had done anything wrong.

He followed the boy up the two steps and into the Megara, where he found Cronos and Rhea giving audience to a friend of his - Metapontus - and his wife, Arne. He almost greeted them before remembering his station and who had summoned him. He bowed low to Cronos and Rhea.

"Your majesties," he intoned. "How may I serve the village?"

"This is not a question of service," replied Cronos, "but of your future."

"Metapontus and Arne have a daughter, Amphissa," said Rhea, "whom I believe you already know. She has today demonstrated through the shedding of blood that she is ready to take her place as a full member of our society. Her parents think that she would be better served through marriage than as a priestess, and their choice of husband falls on you. What do you say?"

Macareus was gobsmacked. Of all the things he had considered since the boy had summoned him to this meeting, this one had never crossed his mind. Marriage? Responsibility? Living with just one woman rather than the common life of a soldier in the barracks? He struggled to see any of the upsides. Most men did marry, though, having a desire to leave children behind them. In some sense the barracks was a revolving door of young men arriving, growing up, and then moving out to start to marry and start families. He had just never thought about taking that step for himself.

Not that he knew how many children he had, of course, among the priestesses. He performed his duties diligently - and enjoyably - whenever he was chosen in the rituals by a priestess. But that was just a few minutes' service to the Goddess. He had seen Metapontus over the years, tied down by his family commitments and responsibility to his children - a much tighter responsibility than Macareus felt for the priestesses' children held in common by the village.

Cronos saw the emotions playing across the face of his underling - and friend. "You do not need to decide today, my friend. For today she belongs to the Goddess, then to me, and then she will serve with the priestesses until the moon sets on her ritual period. When the moon sets that night, you can claim her, or she can become a priestess."

When Amphissa returned from "the women's hut" out in the fallow field, she was brought to Cronos in the hut he shared with Rhea. Rhea was tactfully and understandably absent. Although Amphissa was aware of the mechanics of what was going to happen from attending the rituals, this would obviously be her first time.

Cronos started by trying to engage her in general conversation, although the girl seemed very shy and withdrawn. He tried a different tack.

"I believe you know that your parents would like you to marry to one of my full-time soldiers, Macareus. Is that what you think you would like, the life of a married woman; or would you prefer to be a priestess to the Goddess?"

She looked at him, surprised. Was the great leader of the community really interested in the affairs of a couple of young people of no consequence in the community? What answer did he want?

"I don't know," she stammered, hesitantly. "If that is what they think is best for me, I'm sure they're right. And yes, I like Macareus. He comes to our hut quite often and seems very nice."

Cronos nodded. Nothing this girl had said or done so far had impressed him; probably life as the wife of a soldier would be the best for her. She didn't seem to have what it took for the much more competitive life of a priestess with the associated responsibilities.

He decided to cut to the chase: she didn't seem to be relaxing at all; quite the opposite. "You know why you're here," he confirmed with her. She nodded. "Shall we just get on with it?" he asked.

"You're the King," she replied. "Whatever you say."

So it was going to be like that, was it? You're the King; I'll do what you say; impress me with your abilities and technique. So be it.

"Well, come and lie down here," he soothed, "and take those garments off." As he said that, he removed his own loincloth and threw it to one side. Then he lay down beside her, and used his hands to soothe her. She relaxed a little, then tensed again. He gave up on all the subtle approaches, climbed on top of her, used his right hand to prepare the way and pushed inside her. She uttered a little "ow" of pain as he entered her and the blood spilt on the straw of the bedding, then flopped back to let him do what he wanted with her.

It was over quickly.

Over the course of the next few days, she came to his hut a number of times, each time building her understanding and confidence. When the festival of the last quarter of the moon came around, she was ready and took her part with the priestesses and did an acceptable job. Cronos was surprised that she did not choose Macareus to be her partner. Did that mean that she didn't want to marry him? Or that, if she did want to marry him, she wanted to experience someone else while she was still able to?

The month wore down and as they prepared for the festival of the turning of the month, Macareus came to see Cronos and Rhea formally at the time of meeting and petitions. After being introduced and bowing low to the couple, he declared his intentions.

"If it is still possible, I would like to take the young woman Amphissa to be my wife."

"Very good, very good," enthused Cronos. "And I am sure she will make you a good wife. You know that it is the festival of the new Moon tonight; she will be with the priestesses. When she calls you, she will call you to be her husband."

"Indeed," said Rhea. "I will talk to her and make sure she is aware of the ritual."

The fire was burning brightly, and the priestesses were dancing. In the audience, instruments were being played. As ever, Rhea was leading the dance and called Cronos to serve her. When they had finished, Rhea rose up again and pointed to Amphissa, strategically placed to her right for this very moment. As she did so, Amphissa left the circle of dancing women and went out into the crowd, pulling Macareus back with her. But, instead of just initiating sex with him, she knelt on the earth at his feet.

The music stopped.

Apart from the noise of the burning fire, you could have heard a bracelet drop. The silence and stillness was almost palpable.

Oh, Goddess most dear
Never would I renounce thee
But in this way I will not serve thee again

For unto this man I would cleave
Until I come to join you below.

And, at that moment Macareus reached under her arms, and lifted her up.

The music started again and the ritual continued as it had ever done. Macareus and Amphissa were now married for life.

5. Haloa

At the time of harvest, it was all hands to the scythe, even if you were nominally a full-time warrior.

Macareus actually enjoyed this work: if nothing else, it made a pleasant change from the daily grind of strength training and working out with weapons. While he enjoyed the sparring - particularly against strong opponents such as Cronos - at the end of the day he was always left with something of the feeling that he had not achieved anything tangible. Particularly when he went home to Amphissa and she told him all the things that she had achieved in her day.

No, reaping barley was satisfying work. As the day went on you could see where you had been, and the swathe that you had cut through the field. And know that all the barley that wasn't there any more was being threshed right now in the Megara - he was sure Amphilla would be doing her part - and would provide food for all the villagers for the next year.

The rhythms were very similar to sword fighting as well - except you didn't need to worry about the man next to you *trying* to lop your arm off with his scythe. Step with the left foot, clutch the stalks with the left hand, swing with the right, turn and drop the stalks behind you, then step up with the right foot before starting again. Over the course of the day, you walked from one end of the field to the other and possibly back again. Meanwhile, boys and girls collected the cut stalks you dropped and took them off for threshing.

He stopped for a moment to inspect the blade on his scythe. Much like his bronze sword, it was capable of slicing through anything when it was sharp, but once it lost its edge it became little better than a wooden training sword. Some of the youngsters did, in fact, use wooden scythes during the harvest - for their own protection as much as anything - but a bronze scythe was much more effective: until it went blunt. As he gingerly ran his fingers along it, he could sense what he had already felt while swinging it: it was starting to go blunt.

"New scythe, please!" he called, and stood up, pleasantly relieved to have the opportunity to get out of the continuous crouch. Soon, a child ran up, proferring him a new, bronze-headed scythe with a long oak handle. He took it with his left hand then, with his right, passed the child the used, blunt, scythe, making sure the child didn't injure herself with the blade - still quite sharp enough to do her a serious injury if she weren't careful. Once she had left, he took a deep breath and returned to the job at hand: move left foot ...

The girl delivered the scythe to Beolus in the forge.

"Put it there, with the others," he instructed her, pointing to a stack of five other scythes leaning up against a wall.

He returned to the scythe he was working on. Like everyone else in the village, the time of harvest was a time when he worked all the time, with a continuous level of pressure. There were always scythes coming in, needing sharpening or even repair, and he had to turn them around and get them ready to be used again. This one was blunt all along the blade and had a couple of chips in it. His first job was to try and smooth those chips out - ideally without having to reforge the entire blade. That was an option he tried to reserve for the blades that had hit a rock and literally shattered: when a blade came to him in two or three pieces, there really wasn't any option except to melt down the bronze and start again.

Once again, he found himself wondering where the bronze came from. From time to time, travellers would come through the area with new bronze implements that they had "acquired", usually in the north, but usually in trade from other travellers who likewise knew little of where they came from. He imagined that the bronze must ultimately come from somewhere but did it grow on some plant? Or was it the trunk of some tree? Or was it found in the ground? He had no idea.

He had learnt the magic secrets of working with bronze from his mentor when he had been an apprentice. Secrets that he was now passing on to the apprentices in his forge. How the bronze could not stand heat, but would first glow red, then melt, as you made it hotter and hotter. His forge was kept beautifully warm in the winter - and stifingly hot in the summer - by a big brick fireplace which consumed a lot of wood when it was running. For which reason, it wasn't kept running all the time: he would wait until he had a number of items that needed to be forged before stoking the fire and doing that work.

During harvest, he hardly ever lit the furnace. The most important thing was to keep the reapers in the fields equipped with scythes. And the quickest way to do that was to turn around the simple jobs - resharpening blades and, when necessary, as with this one, removing the chips before sharpening it.

He took another stroke with his flint scraper. A few flakes of bronze came off, while others moved around, evening up the edges of the nick. It was important to always stroke the right way, filling in the gap rather than opening it up.

Many strokes later, he was happy with the outcome. The blade was not perfect, but it was a fairly even line. He put down the scraper and picked up his whetstone. Drawing it along the length of the blade, it left a beautiful edge. Again and again he repeated the stroke. Then he turned the blade over and worked on the other side. Time after time, he stroked the edge and turned the blade this way and that.

Finally, when he was satisfied, he ran his fingers carefully over the edge. Yes, that was sharp enough to do a day's work in the fields. He stood up and leant it against the wall with the scythes ready to go out and be used again, then picked up the next one needing sharpening. In the time he had been working on the last one, two more scythes had been delivered. Oh, well, harvest was always a busy time of year.

Amphilla was nearly in tears.

Her mother had often told her how hard threshing was, and while she had always believed her, she had felt that it surely couldn't be *that* hard; but now that she was actually trying it herself for the first time, she realised how very, very hard it was.

She was sitting in the Megara with all the other women, and specifically between her mother Arne and Arne's sister Desmontes. They had years of experience doing this and were clearly expert. She had been doing it for a week and had seemingly gained no skill at all. Some women, she knew, never did get good at it although the pressure to get the work done meant that only a very few - usually those who had a great deal of skill at something else, which she did not - could be spared from the effort.

She placed more barley on her grate and tossed it, moving the grate to catch it and spinning it to try and separate grain from husk. To no avail. The raw grain just sat there on her grate as if she had done nothing at all. At least, most of it did. Some of it had drifted off onto the floor of the Megara somewhere.

"This is not for me," she cried.

"Keep at it," chided her mother. "I think they're nearly done. Tomorrow will be the day of contest. You'll enjoy that."

"Yes, I will," she replied, cheering slightly. "But then I'll spend the next year fretting over whether I will be able to do better at this next year."

"Fret not," said her mother. "A year is a long time for the Goddess. Anything might have happened by then."

Cronos and Rhea led a procession of villagers out into the field. A stand of barley remained in the middle of the field and today was the day of contest: the male reapers competed for the title of best reaper, and the women and children were to chase down the corn spirits as they emerged from the remaining barley. The individual - or team - with the most animals captured would take home the corn spirit prize.

Cronos led the men and picked up a scythe and inspected its edge. Beolus had been working all yesterday and through much of the night to make sure that all the scythes were in perfect condition. Even so, Cronos didn't want to take any chances. But this scythe was perfect. He ran his finger along the blade - so smooth, so sharp!

Macareus came up next to him and picked up another scythe, which, although it looked fine, seemed slightly off to his touch. Rejecting it he picked up the next: yes, this was perfect! He followed Cronos to the edge of the standing barley and moved to his right.

"Just like in the battle line, boss," he said to Cronos. "I'll be at your right hand, making sure you can be at your best."

"Already given up, eh, Macareus?" asked Cronos. "Or do you think you can out-reap me today?"

Macareus smiled: "I can only do my best, boss. Let the children do the counting."

And with that, they were off: step, clutch, swing, turn, drop, step and repeat. Through a boiling sunny morning, and a boiling sunny afternoon, all the men of the village kept at it. As time went on, some were forced to drop out as the field of barley became ever smaller and the number of men who could swing a scythe at it at the same time fell. Cronos and Macareus were still scything away: step, clutch, swing, turn, drop, step ...

Amphilla saw the hare before her mother did.

She shrieked and pointed to her right, where it had appeared through the line of reapers and was making a dash for the safety of the hedgerow. She took three steps and leapt, arms outstretched, to try and catch it. She managed to get one hand on it, and slow its progress: long enough for her mother to come around and deal it a killer blow with her mallet.

After the frustration of the days of threshing, she was exhilarated to be outside, all the more so to be able to chase the corn spirits. And to catch the first one she saw, that was fantastic!

As she felt the inner surge of joy, from the corner of her eye she saw movement. By instinct, without thinking, she dived to her left and managed to put both hands on a vole escaping from the barley field. A few heartbeats later, her mother had applied the mallet and it went limp in her hands.

"Two already!" Arne exclaimed. "That's as many as I've ever caught in an entire harvest. I think we may set a record this year."

Amphilla couldn't help beaming with pride.

At the end of the day Rhea, with all the barley finally reaped and threshed, announced the winners.

"Among the men, there were some excellent reaping performances; I am pleased to say that my husband, your King, Cronos did an excellent job. But by common consent among the judges, the prize goes to Macareus, who worked diligently all day and narrowly edged him, reaping the most corn today."

There was general applause; Macareus was popular among all the villagers. Cronos went up to him and engulfed him in a bear hug. "Well done, Macareus," he exclaimed. "You certainly deserved it."

"With regard to the corn spirits, there can be no doubt as to this year's winners. With an unbelievable total of five spirits collected, the winners are Arne, Amphilla and Desmontes. They have designated Amphilla to carry the offering to the Goddess tomorrow."

"Gather round women," declared Rhea, "for it is time to make the cakes of offering. Men, you are to keep to your tasks and drills tomorrow, but you are not to intrude on the offering of the Haloa, for that is reserved unto women."

The men dismissed, the women gathered in groups in the Megara, making a paste from the barley, and then shaping the paste into offerings of penises and vulvas. The cakes were left to dry overnight.

In the morning, the women formed up in the Megara and Amphilla joined the senior priestesses in picking up a plate of the offering. She carried it in front of her all the way to the cisterns on the western edge of the village, where the snakes awaited the offering of the first of the harvest - an essential before the rest of the village could profit from the harvest.

They bowed in reverence to the Goddess and to her earthly representatives, leaving the platters by the cisterns and retreated to the village. They did not see the snakes come out and devour the offerings. This time, the omens were good for the village.

Zeus

Zeus lunged, his intent to kill.

What had started as a drunken argument had rapidly escalated into a battle to the death. The rest of the company, who had been watching and laughing as the argument spiralled hilariously out of control were now rapt and alert as they recognised the death struggle for what it was.

Cadmus blocked the lunge and threw back a riposte. He knew he was outmatched in this duel and, had he been sober enough, would have found a way out of it. Not that he would have been able to avoid it forever. Zeus believed - incorrectly, but not without reason - that he had had sex with Hera, and Zeus was very jealous of his wife; even if he himself was anything but faithful.

Zeus blocked the thrust and hacked down towards Cadmus' head. Cadmus ducked and slid to the side, moving out of Zeus' swing and then turning and batting the sword away. He took two steps back and drew a few quick breaths. "We could ..." he began, but Zeus charged at him and swung again. Ducking, he turned away. There was no getting out of this now, so he needed to fully commit to the fight. Rapidly sobering up, he realised that even sober, he would probably lose to a drunk Zeus. Zeus was big, and powerful, and fast. And, he had to admit, spent a lot longer practising with his sword than Cadmus was ever prepared to do.

He quickly gasped a couple of breaths, then leapt to his left, swinging his sword as he did so. Zeus took it on his blade and then twisted inside his guard. With his left elbow, he smacked Cadmus across the face and jumped back.

Stunned, Cadmus took a moment to clear his head. A moment that could have been fatal, except, he now realised, Zeus was playing with him, like a cat with a mouse. His head ringing, he raised his sword and faced Zeus again. Zeus lifted his sword above his head and swung down. Just in time, Cadmus put his blade up and blocked the blow. But Zeus was strong: Cadmus' blade first shivered, then snapped. He was left with just half a cubit of blade in his hand.

Zeus laughed, long and loud. "Are you ready to die, Cadmus?" he asked. With the flat of his blade, he smacked Cadmus across the head, knocking him to the ground. What was left of Cadmus' sword fell from his hand moments before Zeus swung his sword through his arm, chopping it in half. Cadmus screamed in pain.

Zeus came and stood over him, still laughing at the sight, waiting for the scream to end. Cadmus looked up at him, eyes wide and showing the whites with pain. He felt he had one more thing to do in this life, in the handful of heartbeats before his inevitable death. "I swear, Hera was never unfaithful to you with me."

Zeus plunged his sword into Cadmus' neck, sending a fountain of blood up into the air.

"That was fun," he declared. "Anyone else fancy a fight?"

Nobody would even meet his gaze.

Zeus led the ox up the hill.

Augur had prepared the altar and chopped the wood for the fire. He had also prepared the stick with which he would start the fire. It was sharpened at one end and placed in a plank with a hole cut from it, and covered in small chippings of wood called tinder. It was a lot of effort to light a fire this way, but in the absence of lava provided by a volcano - or a chance fire in a forest - it was the only reliable way to start a fire from scratch, which is what was demanded for this ritual.

Celeus stepped forward as Zeus came near the altar, and with a single blow, struck the ox on the forehead with a mallet, stunning it and causing it to slump to the ground. The three men picked the ox up and placed it on the altar. Augur drew his knife and slit its throat, catching the blood in a bowl in his other hand.

Zeus moved forward to where the fire stick was and started rotating it back and forth between his hands until a spark lit the tinder Augur had arranged around it. As the tinder caught, Zeus removed the fire stick from the hole and moved the block onto the chopped wood for the fire. Slowly it started to smoulder and then burn. As it did so, Celeus came and poured the bowl of blood onto the wood - the first offering to the Gods of the Sky.

Meanwhile Augur took his knife and started to slit the belly of the beast. Quickly, he extracted the liver and the heart and put them on a platter. The rest of the entrails of the beast he let slither out and carried them to the burgeoning fire. Where the fat landed, it immediately sizzled and burnt, sticking to the pile of wood. The rest of the slippery mess fell about the stack of wood, flashing and gleaming in the burning light.

Augur used his knife to slice up the liver and examined in closely. Then he did the same with the heart. When he had finished, he took them over to the fire and, using his knife to keep his hand out of the fire, carefully placed them on the burning pile.

Zeus took an axe and cut off the ox's head. This he added to the steadily growing pile of ox parts on the pile of firewood. The flames were now licking greedily around the various parts of flesh, blackening and consuming them.

Once the Gods were appeased, four men stepped forward, bringing the spit with them. They set up the stands to the spit either side of the fire pile and then skewered the ox through with the spit. They carried that over to the fire and placed it on the stands. In short order, the ox was starting to cook and the air was filled with the smell of burning and roasting flesh. Somewhere, somebody had broached a cask of beer and started pouring it into cups and handing them around. Before long, all the men of the tribe were happily merry and singing songs while waiting for the meat to roast.

Zeus walked up to Augur. "What news?" he asked. "What do the Gods say we should do?"

Augur shook his head confused. Others always seemed to think that the Gods communicated in the same way that people did; but they didn't. Messages from the Gods were not just cryptic, they were sent in ways that most men could not even understand. The signs of the heart and liver had been unusual, but he felt confident in his interpretation nevertheless.

"They say that we must be obedient," he replied. "And we must follow the sign," he added, a confused look crossing his face.

"The sign?" asked Zeus. "What sign?"

"I don't know," replied Augur. "Except that I feel in my bones we will be shown it soon, possibly tonight. And I feel sure that the sign will be unequivocal in its message. Wait up with me this night; I know you long for your tent and the warmth of Hera's body, but trust me: this night something will happen and we should be ready for it."

Zeus nodded, externally calm but internally seething. Why did everyone seem to think that he was under Hera's thumb? Yes, she was an exciting, attractive woman, and the mother of his children, but she was just a pastime: she never came between him and his duty.

Slowly, the ox roasted and before long Celeus and the others were slicing meat from the carcass with their swords and handing it out to the men gathered around the fire. Zeus and Augur were off to one side, watching the sky. Celeus brought them some meat and sat down with them.

"Are you searching for a sign?" he asked. "Do you know what or where?"

"No," replied Augur. "I only know that we must be attentive for a sign."

The three of them sat, watching the sky, trying to cover all directions when suddenly the ground starting to move beneath them. All three of them jumped up, awestruck. This was definitely a sign. A sign that the Gods walked among them. A sign that many men lived many years and never had. Having leapt to their feet in shock and surprise, all three now knelt down, prostrating themselves before the power that none of them could resist or imagine.

On the horizon, they saw a burst of flame appear. A volcano! One of the Gods was walking among them and demanded their worship on that far hill. Zeus looked at the other two men with him and knew that all three of them were thinking the same thing: this was not just a sign, this was a clear sign that the Gods were among them and demanding their audience. To the south. In the morning, they would set off, travelling south.

The ground shook again, violently. From the hill to their left, rocks came loose and rolled down towards them. In the morning the would go south.

If they lived that long.

Zeus and Augur climbed up the side of the volcano to where they could walk past the lava flow. Here was where the Gods would speak to them, if they were reverent and brave. They had left the rest of the tribe down below, fearful and fretting over the awesome power of their Gods, of which this was just the most recent manifestation. If they failed to return after two days, the tribe would choose a new leader and a new plan: either to follow in their footsteps or to acknowledge that the Gods had not wanted mere mortals to trespass on the sacred mountain.

The ground continued to rumble under their feet. No matter how many times he saw the flows of lava down mountainsides, Zeus continued to be in awe. The power of a river of fire; the heat thrown off; the destruction they could cause - simply melting rocks that he would have spent hours trying to smash with a hammer; and then the way that at the end the lava just gave up and *became* a rock - by some means that was completely opaque to him. It was all simply fascinating. He could have stayed here forever, absorbed in the mysteries of the Gods.

Except it wasn't healthy.

Everyone knew that the Gods did not welcome humans trespassing on their territory. Apart from the obvious death that came from the lava flows, many had died from some kind of ecstasy after having been exposed to the Gods for too long, struggled to breathe and died.

He was here on a mission and he knew it. For too long now, his tribe had struggled to find a space to call their own in these lands. Other tribes had come, and all the tribes had grown too numerous. Every year, it was harder to find water away from the major rivers, and the grasslands were increasingly being eaten away by the flocks and herds. The pressure of the nomadic lifestyle was causing an ever-increasing number of battles and wars between tribes competing for the same scarce resources. But what were they to do?

Zeus and Augur stood, watching the lava flow down the mountain, melting the rocks that were obstacles to its flow. Zeus understood that in some way the message was for him to do the same thing: remove the obstacles in his way. But he could not see how.

Suddenly, slightly up the hill and to their left, a patch of lava exploded upwards in a ball of steam. As it did so, a new tributary opened up across the mountainside, with a rush of lava down the mountainside. As it plunged down the hill, the red river suddenly hit a pool of water and exploded in an eruption of steam. Zeus stared, once again awestruck by the sight. To be here was truly to be in the presence of the God. He pulled his eyes away, forced himself to look at Augur, in order to check that the man alongside him, whose job it was to interpret the signs of the Gods, had seen the same thing that he, the leader of the tribe, had seen. And what he saw in Augur's face stunned him. It was a mixture of shock, reverence and ... *understanding*.

"Truly, Indra has spoken to us tonight," said Augur. "For all the times that I have said that the Gods speak to us with forked tongues and refuse to make their message plain, today is the exception. There can be no doubt that Indra has come down from his mountain and shown us what we must do."

"What?" asked Zeus, his eyes gleaming from excitement and reflecting the blazing light of the lava. "What do the Gods tell us we must do."

"We are trapped in this valley," explained Augur. "We cannot find space to live because of the others around us upon whom we war. But this valley is not the whole world. If we climb up," he pointed up and around to the mountains that surrounded them, "then we can find a way through. We can go that way," now pointing the way the lava had split off, roughly south although a little west. "And Indra will show us the way. There will be mountains, there will be rivers, there will be seas. And there will be a land flowing in milk and riches. When we arrive in that land, we will be masters of our destiny.

"The Gods have shown us that not all of us will make it. The journey will be long and hard, and there will be many obstacles. But for those who arrive, it will be a land of plenty. I may not make it; many may not make it, but the Gods say, and I cannot doubt them, that you, Zeus, will make it and will be long remembered in that land as the very agent of the Gods, coming down out of the mountain to take the world."

Zeus blinked. He could hardly believe it.

6. Pharmakos

Cronos and Rhea looked at every hut closely.

For the day of atonement, everything must be absolutely perfect; anything less than perfection would show insult to the Goddess. Moreover, at the same time they needed to select the Pharmakoi. Two pharmakoi needed to be chosen to offload any remaining guilt - anything not only unintentional but overlooked. One atoned for the sins of the men, carrying them away; the other atoned for the sins of the women. Both were, of course, men themselves: the Goddess demanded the sacrifice of men to atone for the community.

As they walked into Amphissa'a hut, and saw Amphissa and her husband standling there, the Goddess called to Rhea as clearly as she had ever done in her life. *It pleases me to have this one* came the voice and immediately Rhea responded, pointing straight at Macareus and intoning the ritual words as she had so many times before: "Macareus, the Goddess calls you to serve her as a Pharmakos".

Cronos was rocked. Here was a man he trusted and leant upon; a man who had been married just this season; and a man, who, he thought, might one day be Cronos in his turn. But a man who, even if he survived the experience would be outcast from this village. Cronos turned to remonstrate with Rhea - but then saw the look on her face: she did not wish this for herself; it was the word of the Goddess speaking through her.

While Macareus was stunned, he knew the ritual, he knew his place, and he knew that unlkely as he was to be chosen, it was still a possibility. He had prepared, as all the men in the village prepared and was content with his lot. If nothing else, this was an opportunity to serve the Goddess - and the community - giving his livelihood and his life in order that the village might atone for their sins with the Goddess.

He knelt before Rhea to accept the commission she gave him. He bent his head while she hit him with the ceremonial leek, completing his appointment. Later, he knew, that same leek would be used to give him a thorough beating. Without so much as a glance at his wife, he arose and led the way out of the door.

The moment they had gone, Amphissa broke down and cried. Collapsing to the floor, she knelt until all the tears had wracked out of her. She still wasn't sure if she was carrying his child, but she thought so - but would never have the opportunity to tell him so. Even if Macareus was not dead yet - and might not even die during the ritual - he was no longer her husband; he belonged to the Goddess now. He might as well be dead. And her life, too, lay in tatters, child or no child.

By the time the procession returned to her hut, a few fingers of sun later, she had composed herself and tidied up the mess she had caused in her misery. The beaters, led by Cronos and some of his standing army, came in and screamed and shouted, chasing her - and any hidden spirits - outside into the open air. As she ran outside, screaming herself, she saw Macareus leading the procession. Now formally attired as a Pharmakos, he had the blank expression suited to one who thought nothing, felt nothing and accepted everything. As she joined the back of the procession, the two Pharamkoi led them forward through the village, collecting ever more villagers on their way out of the village, taking all the spirits and evils with them.

It was not enough, never enough, to assume that the spirits would follow them. Everywhere they went, it was essential to screech, yell and make as much noise as possible, scaring any spirits away from the village. And the worst was yet to come. To ensure that all the spirits left, that all the evil was removed from the village, it was essential to beat the Pharmakoi. Her first time attending the Pharmakos as an adult and she would have to beat the man whom she had come to love as her own husband over the last few cycles of the moon. And then cast him off into the wilderness to survive by himself as best he could. How could the Goddess be so cruel?

It was a test, she realized. A test of her strength and fidelity. She must remain strong for the whole village; remain strong even as she knew Macareus would remain strong.

Eventually the procession led out of the village and into the wilderness to the west. The two Pharmakoi stopped, turned and knelt on the ground. Now was the time of the beating: they knew what was coming and were prepared. Macareus looked straight ahead of him, his eyes focused on the far distance, maintaining the strength and purity he knew was the price of carrying his burden to the Goddess. To take all the evil spirits out of the village that the villagers could live in peace and prosperity was a service beyond his highest aspirations. With only one compatriot, he was protecting the village for the next year; a greater service even than he had signed up for when he had joined the army. Possibly greater even than the service of being chosen as Cronos.

The beating began.

As the blows rained down, he held his composure, suppressing his instinct and training to retaliate. He took the blows and endured, holding himself stiff in the kneeling position for as long as he could, trying to distance himself from the injuries to his body - just as he had practised so often during the army drills. And trying to stare into the distance, knowing that those delivering the blows would be known to him: Cronos, his fellow soldiers, his father, his wife. At the thought of Amphissa, he nearly broke and lost concentration. Quickly, he re-focused his mind on the here and now, focusing on the sensation of being beaten, over and over, by all the villagers wielding nothing more than leeks.

But, ineffectual as each blow might be, in total they started to add up. He felt, rather than heard, the body of his fellow Pharmakos collapse to the ground next to him. The beating continued, of course. The beating would continue until Rhea was convinced all the evil spirits had been driven out.

Eventually, he lost consciousness.

When he woke again, he found himself beaten and bloody. Dazed, he looked around him to regain his bearings. By this time, all the other villagers had left; his only companion was his fellow Pharmakos - dead, as far as he could see. The ritual was supposed to be one of expulsion rather than death, but it was always possible to go too far, he supposed.

Moving his head slowly, he saw the platter in front of him; that was all the food that was provided for them for as long as they should continue to live. And there, slithering over it - he recoiled in shock, setting off searing pains through his head, and throughout his body; a mistake. There, slithering over the sum total of food for the rest of his life was a *snake*. A snake that, now it was aware of another sentient being in the neighbourhood, reared back and looked him in the eyes, poised to strike.

It was only then that he realised what had happened to Euphorygus, his fellow Pharamakos. He had survived the beating, only to be left out here as food for *a snake*. The snake - *one of* the snakes, he corrected himself, as he noticed more slithering over the area - had bitten him and killed him.

He knew that any sudden motion would make him a target. But not to move would leave him a potential victim of the snakes. Did Cronos and Rhea know that this would be his fate? Specifically, since Cronos only lived for a year, did *Rhea* know when she chose him that she was, in fact, condeming him to die. Not that it made much difference, he supposed: he had definitely be condemned to a death sentence; the only difference was whether it was here, now, or if he could defer it by using his wits for a number of days or weeks.

The snake watching him settled down and slid back to its meal. Its meal, now, because there is no way that Macareus would attempt to challenge it for the food: to do so would invite certain and sudden death. Probably, difficult as it was to contemplate, his best strategy would be to lie here until full dark by when, hopefully, the snakes would have all left the area.

Mercifully, he lost consciousness again.

In the dark of the night, he could hardly see anything.

He listened intently, trying to pick out the noises that would indicate the presence of snakes. Hearing nothing, he clambered up to his feet. Staggering, he started to move westwards. To move to the east would take him back to the village. Apart from the harm he would do to the villagers, they would undoubtedly kill him on sight. The only safe move was to head westwards into the unknown.

Slowly he staggered onwards, narrowly avoiding falling into one of the cisterns. Everything out here now was a danger and a risk. He had nowhere to stay, nothing to eat; his only source of water would be any river or pond he could find; his only food anything he could kill.

He was now an outcast from the village - the only life he had every known.

7. Cattle Raid

"I'm concerned that our cattle stocks are getting low," Cronos said.

Rhea looked at him intently. "It's true that we have lost more this year than we would have liked," she conceded.

"And they have not bred as well as could have been expected. I don't know why, but I suspect that some of the bulls are not getting the job done."

"Unlike you," she grinned, patting her stomach where her pregnancy was now clearly showing.

Cronos smiled back at her: "It is a shame I will not live to see her born."

"It will not be the first time I will celebrate the New Year ritual carrying Cronos' child."

Cronos brought her back to the topic at hand; the one which had been occupying his mind now for the last half moon cycle. "If the bulls do not quicken the cows, and we do not increase the size of our herds, some will starve before the next harvest."

"The Goddess will provide, Cronos, she always does."

Cronos stared at her. While her faith in the Goddess was absolute, and could not be questioned, he knew the facts to be different. The Goddess did *not* always provide; in some years the food ran low - or even out - and in the absence of cattle to kill, villagers would starve. The harvest this year had been good, but not great. Now was the time to act, he knew it. Another couple of months and the breeding time would be past. Then it would be too late to act. A dozen head of cattle - two or three bulls and the rest cows - might make all the difference to how many lived or died this winter.

"We need more cattle," he asserted. "Let me convince you," pulling her close to him.

The moon was nearly full. Ideal for a cattle raid like this.

Cronos had led his armed men to within a mile or two of the target village during the afternoon, then, as the sun was setting, he had led them into this gulch, hiding from the sentries and patrols he assumed would be protecting the village. Not to do so would be foolish. Overhead, the moon was rising to the east, almost a hand up in the sky now. To the west, the sky was still bright with the fading sunset.

He looked around him at the men crouching in the gully. They were all ready for action, although hopefully there would not be any action until the moon was at its highest. Men, even the best and most alert, were never as alert in the depths of the night; they would be convinced that they were wasting their time, and that nobody would raid here, now, in the middle of the night. Their thoughts would wonder, either to the warm, comfortable bed that they could be sharing with a loved one, or else to thoughts of what tomorrow might bring. His men had no such distractions: they knew that the raid would be launched in a few hours when they were ready and the conditions were favourable.

Of course, they still needed to be prepared for any surprises. The village might have patrols out, any of which might come across them hiding here. If that happened, their mission would be foiled - the element of surprise would have gone - but they would still be required to fight, but in order to defend themselves, not for the more noble purpose of stealing cattle.

Assuming all went well, they would have to make off with the cattle, taking a roundabout route to hide their true destination - after all, it would do them no good if these villagers came tomorrow night to take their cattle back - and that was best done under the light of the failing moon, say, giving themselves a quarter of the night to get away before sunrise and the village would mount an effective pursuit. By then, they wanted to be far gone. Other than that, though, the later the attack came the more likely they were to find guards tired and bored with nighttime duty.

After it had gone fully dark, Cronos had led a hand of men forward into an advance position where they could see the guards and the cattle pen. The pen was outside the village proper, but was still guarded by the villagers. Cronos could see two guards inside the pen, and figured that there would be a couple more in the village near the pen. Ideally, he would have already had a couple of men dismantling the fence, preparing the way for when they were trying to steal the cattle, but that wouldn't be possible under the noses of the guards. On top of which, killing or disabling the guards would be almost impossible without alerting the guards in the village. Unless they both happened to nod off for a while, this was going to be tricky.

Cronos stole back to the gulch to brief the others.

Suddenly, a racket emerged from the darkness in front of him. As he lurched forward, he could see the outline of a couple of men he did not recognise, thrusting spears into the gulch. Around them, his own men boiled up to engage them in combat. Of all the bad luck! A village patrol had happened upon them by what must be absolute chance. Darting forward, he pulled out his sword and swung it across the back of the legs of one of the men, cutting his tendons and felling him instantly. Immediately after, he saw the other pulled down into the gulch by two of his men and disarmed. Quickly, both men were killed, fortuitously quietly.

But the fight had not gone unnoticed.

"Ho! Patrol!" came the shout from somewhere in the direction of the village. There was no answer, of course: both men in the patrol were dead. But unquestionably, the guards would be alert now, and know that somebody - or possibly something - was out here threatening their village. The raid could not happen now; or at least, could not happen with the element of surprise that was so key to success. In a sense, the roles were reversed, since, outnumbered as they were, they would not be able to fight a defensive action if the village mustered all their forces and sent them out here.

What to do? What to do? Although he had been on raids before, he had never been Cronos before - never had the responsibility to *decide*. The plan had been a good one.

Turning around, he bent down in a crouch and hurried back to the forward position. His men spotted him as soon as he spotted them - they had heard both the commotion and the challenge, but had remained where they were until he came to give them further instructions. In a few heartbeats, he was on his knees next to them, indicating with his hands that the only option he saw was retreat. And they should come with him.

Stealing off into the quiet night, they left two dead guards behind them. And a dozen prize cattle that might be the difference between life and death this winter.

8. Thesmophoria

Cronos was still put out by the failure of his cattle raid the previous month.

"We could have used some of those cattle as our offering to the Goddess," he grumbled as he rose out of bed. "It is not easy tracking down wild boar in the forest."

"If it were easy, the Goddess would not need to demand it, would she?" countered Rhea, reasonably, she felt, but increasingly irked by Cronos. She was starting to feel that the New Year - with its new start, and most importantly, new Cronos - could not come soon enough.

"But what if we are not ready? Tonight is the night, is it not?"

"You must have more trust in the men of this village," she responded. "If the Goddess wills us to be ready, we will be ready. If she has already turned her face from us, then we must expiate that sin, or suffer worse consequences."

Cronos turned away from her, his feelings clearly written all over his face. He did not have the faith in the goodness of the Goddess his wife exuded. Maybe it was something to do with being a woman - or maybe to do with being a woman born into a position of power. As his daughter would be, after his death.

Putting on his tunic and sandals, Cronos huffed off to see if they had managed to bring in the fifth boar needed for the ceremony.

Shortly after he arrived at the specially constructed holding pen, Jacceus came in from the forest with his hand of soldiers: a little bloody and battered, but leading a boar by the ropes they had taken with them.

"He is a brave one, that," Jacceus said to Cronos. "He will do the Goddess much honour in his death."

"He fought you long and hard, by the look of it," Cronos replied. "Was it a hard struggle?"

"It was," confirmed Jacceus and launched into a long narrative of the hunt. They had initially attempted to capture another boar, but that one had died rather than be captured; only while he was in his death throes was this other bull stampeded to flight. "Carenus and Oeoragus were trampled immediately he burst from the thicket," Jacceus explained. "But Carenus managed to hold on and wound him and wind him." He pointed to the boar's flank. "He inflicted all these wounds even as he was being trampled. I think he'd already lost the use of his legs by then."

Cronos whistled. The past few months had been difficult, to say the least, and much of it reflected on him and his leadership - and none of it well. Two more of his men lost. The village could ill-afford this rate of attrition.

He watched as the boar was placed in the pen, lost in thought. Then he realized there were other things demanding his attention, and turned south towards the fields where the ploughing was in progress. Hopefully that, at least, was nearly done.

If Amphissa had ever carried Macareus' child, the Goddess had taken it away again. It felt like a dream - a brief interlude in her life between girlhood and widowhood - and now she was returned to the Goddess. And as such, she was eligible to take part in the rituals of the Thesmophoria, something she had assumed she had missed out on because of her path into marriage. If she had given birth to a child with Macareus - especially if it had been an always hoped-for girl-child - she would have been committed to the path of a married woman, no matter that her husband had been taken from her untimely. But now, she had a second chance.

The fields had been ploughed; the seed had been planted; the boars had been slain and cast into the pits. Now all that remained was the ritual of recovering the boars - to bring them back from death into life, thus symbolizing the resurrection that they wanted from the seed that had been buried: in the spring, it should sprout back into the world of life.

It was a ritual, not a competition. How many times had she been told that over the past weeks as she prepared for this important role in the life of the community. Five women would be lowered down over the side, and five boars needed to come back up. Then, and only then, could the five women try to come back up themselves.

All in the face of a den of snakes who would literally see their food supply being removed from them.

As the Goddess' agents on earth, the snakes must be treated reverentially. It was not simply a case of evading them, and certainly not one of killing them. Rather, they must be *negotiated* with. Each of the women climbing into the pit would take with her an offering in place of the boar she was removing. And she had to hope that the snakes would accept the offering.

For that reason, much love and devotion had gone into the preparation of the offering cakes over the past few days. They had to be perfect: succulent, tasty and comprising all the elements that delighted the Goddess in the form of the snakes. Blood, most important, the rich smell of it causing a tang and a snap in the air: a substitute for the fresh blood of the boars. Much of it was grain, both an offering in its own right but a reminder to the Goddess of just how important grain was to the village and how they would be soon lying the grain to rest in the soil over the course of the winter to spring back anew in the spring, ready for harvesting. And mixed in were bodily fluids from the woman herself, identifying this as her specific offering, thus gaining her the privilege of access on the cavern floor.

Amphissa took hold of the rope and moved to the canyon edge. When all five women were ready, Rhea signalled and all the other women at the edge of the cavern starting beating their instruments and making the loudest noise they could manage. As the noise started, the snakes instinctively fled from the boars, and the five women jumped into the cavern, holding on to their ropes and shinning down the side of the cavern as quickly as they could.

In just a few heartbeats, Amphissa was on the cistern floor. It was not a race, but she was pleased to see that she was the first one down. Looking around, she spotted the boar nearest her - the one that she needed to bring up - and checked to see if there were any snakes around. Seeing none, she ran forward, her rope in one hand and the canvas bag with her cake in the other. Reaching over the boar, she placed the canvas bag on the ground and opened it up to expose the cake. Hopefully, any snakes which returned would go for the fresher scent of the cake rather than the more putrid stench coming up from the boar.

As quickly as she could, she tied the rope around the feet of the boar, making sure that even in her haste the knots were all tied tightly. It would be a disaster if the boar were to come loose and fall. Aside from the extra time it would take, it could damage the boar and even possibly land on her. When she was done, she shouted, waved and tugged on the rope to pass the message that the boar was ready for lifting. Almost immediately, the rope became tense and the boar started to lift into the sky.

Not that it was a race, but hers was the first boar off the ground.

Before long, the boar disappeared over the cistern rim, and then seconds later the rope was falling back down. She reached out and took it, then leaped up, climbing against the cistern wall as quickly as she could. Her feet slipped twice, but then she was up and over the rim.

She was up first. Not, of course, that it was a race.

9. Rape

Cronos yelled.

"That is no way to use a sword, even a wooden one." Carrin backed away and looked at Cronos resentfully. As only a part time soldier, he always felt inadequate in these drills, and frequently unfairly criticized. How was he supposed to be as good as the full-timers, who spent all day, every day practising?

"You need to keep the blade under control at all times," Cronos clarified at a more reasonable volume. "If you don't have a strong grip, then your opponent will just bash it out of your hand. Come here!"

Carrin walked over to him, his sword held in what he rather hoped was the "ready" position. "Let's go; hit me!" yelled Cronos. Carrin raised his sword and swung with all his strength. The next thing he knew, he was on the floor. Cronos kicked him and he rolled over. Cronos put his foot on his chest and smashed the wooden sword out of his hand.

"What use are you to the defence of the village like that?" he demanded and walked away.

Unsure what was expected of him, Carrin stood up and went over to collect his sword. Picking it up, he walked back to where the other men were still drilling and took his place in the line of "defenders". Within a few strokes, he had been disarmed again, his wooden sword flying through the air. As he turned to collect it, he saw Cronos grimacing at him again.

This was going to be a long day.

When he was dismissed with the other part-timers around noon, he walked down to the river to wash his sweat off. He was frustrated, angry and feeling hard done to. He had never asked to be part of the "army" and knew he wasn't any good at it. Why couldn't he be left in the fields, hoeing and carrying things for the others? Why this insistence that surely every man wanted to whack other men with a sword?

When he reached the river, he was alone. Most of the men had gone straight back to the village; meanwhile, he had avoided the company of the other two men who had come down to the river, deliberately walking towards the bend where some of the women were often to be found doing the laundry in the river. He thought he might be able to work some of his frustrations out by helping them.

When he arrived, Amphissa was there, trying to beat a *chlamys* dry with a couple of rocks.

"Hey," he said as he walked up towards her. "How are you getting on with that laundry in the hot sun?"

"Well," she replied, smiling up at him. "The heat certainly makes the clothes dry more quickly, but it's making me sweat into the one I'm wearing."

"You could always take it off and wash it now," he joked to her, smiling.

"I suppose I could, but probably best not," she said. "I feel like I'm almost there; a few more fingers of the sun and I should be finished."

He looked at where she was up to and offered to help: "I may not have as much skill as you, and I may not be able to use a sword, but I should be able to beat that with a rock for a few fingers." That, at least raised a smile and a small giggle.

"My husband was good with a sword, until he got himself killed," she confided. "I don't know if you knew him?"

"Macareus, right? I can't say I knew him well; like you say, he was good with a sword and was in the army full-time. I do know he used to beat me bloody when we did the army drills. But then, that doesn't tell you much. Everyone beats me bloody. I hate it." As he spoke, he continued to pound the clothes with the smooth rocks, the intensity of the pounding growing as he let his rage and frustration boil over. Why *did* everyone seem to think that being able to wave a sword around was so important in life? It really wasn't. And even if you were good at it, you could end up dead, leaving a gorgeous woman like this behind.

"Did you have any children?" he asked, knowing that in reality he should know this. He didn't know either of them well, but it wasn't like the village was huge. But, in reality, he was just making conversation while he worked. Why did he care if they had had children? It was unlikely he would ever have any himself; what woman would be foolish enough to tie her future prospects to his dismal standing in the community? And what did he need children for? He would never amass enough wealth in this life to pass anything on. He played with the village children from time to time; that was enough - he didn't need his own.

"No," she responded, a little downcast. She still hadn't decided whether she felt freer back belonging to the Goddess, particularly after the ritual of the Thesmophoria, or whether she would rather have wandered the village with the ultimate status symbol - a baby girl - tied to her back. It would have been hard to have managed on her own, but by the time it had become a toddler it could have played with the other children while she did her jobs around the village.

Carrin put down the rock and held up the garment he had been pounding while they had talked. Most of the water had been beaten out of it, and it was lying flat, all the puffiness ground out. He passed it to Amphissa, who tested it and nodded approval.

"It will dry completely if we leave it in the sun for a few fingers," she said, smiling at him. "Thank you for your help. You may not be any good with a sword, but you are good at pounding rocks."

Something snapped in Carrin, even before he realised it. "I may not be good with a sword in my hand, but there is nothing wrong with my own sword!" he rasped, pulling aside his loincloth to reveal his large erection.

She looked at him, frozen like a boar in the hunt. What was he trying to say? Was this some kind of competition where he was asking her to judge between him and her dead husband? It wasn't even like she hadn't seen dozens of erect penises over the years at the frequent festivals. Even her father's was probably better than his, though. She tried to be conciliatory.

"I'm sure there isn't," she began, "but I'm not sure that it's all that important." She looked at him dubiously, and that was all it took to push him over the edge. Leaping towards her, he pushed her backwards, and mounted her. Holding her down with his left hand, he whipped her loincloth away with his right and entered her with force and violence. She screamed but could do nothing to free herself from his huge weight. For what seemed like an eternity, he thrust inside her until she felt his wetness come inside her. From her own body, she received no messages of pleasure or even physical reaction. This was nothing like what she had experienced with Macareus; not even the neutral experience she had had with Cronos her first time. This was an attack, pure and simple.

As soon as he released his pressure on her, she pushed him to one side and ran back to the safety of the village, leaving the washing to dry in the sun.

Cronos pointed to the runner on duty, a girl of twelve summers.

"Fetch Carrin. I don't care where he is, don't come back until you've found him, or can be sure he has left the village. If you can't find him yourself, go and find a tracker to hunt him down. I'd rather he was brought here alive, but if he resists the commands of the Goddess, that is enough evidence for me - he must be guilty and may be killed. In that case, bring me his body."

He turned back to the woman in front of him. Amphissa. Widow of Macareus. To think that such a woman, the wife of such a man, should be assaulted, abused, abased by such as Carrin. *Carrin!* He couldn't so much as wield a practice sword, let alone fight with it! What was he thinking to enter a "trial of strength" with a woman. The one way in which they were inferior. Inferior, it would seem, even to a specimen as pathetic as Carrin. He struggled to control his temper.

"I am sorry that this has happened to you, Amphissa. I am so sorry for all the tragedies that have come to pass this year. This man is a nothing and I will deal with him like the flea that he is." Signalling to the other runner present in the lodge, he sent for the ritual swords.

A few fingers later, the first runner returned, followed by Carrin, looking downcast. The moment the runner had reached him, the enormity - and the stupidity - of what he had done had dawned on him. And the inevitable consequence.

"Look at me!" hissed Cronos. As he looked up, Cronos saw deep into his soul, and the range of possible futures resolved to just one. "I can see from your face that you know why you are here and that, in turn, tells me that you did what you are accused of and that you are guility. The Goddess has spoken and only has one judgment for assautling a woman of this community. You must fight her champion for supremacy. Only by winning can you indicate the Goddess' approval of your actions, and then you will be Cronos. Take up your sword."

Carrin looked at the two swords on the table dully. He was given the privilege of choice, but there was no value in that to him - how did he even know what to look for in a sword? He simply picked up the one that was closer to him and attempted to get into the ready position.

Before he had even raised the sword, Cronos had leapt forward, snatched up the other sword, bashed the sword out of his hand and, reversing his stroke, removed his head at the neck in a single, mighty blow. As his head went flying, the sword shattered. Cronos threw the haft down on the floor and knelt before Amphissa.

"My word, as the champion of the Goddess. He who did this has been judged and found wanting. He is no more. The law of the Goddess prevails, that is the privilege of hre priestesses to mate with whom they will, and not to be demeaned."

The others all shouted their assent. "Praise be the Goddess."

10. Diasia

As the sun set, the women watching the stars rise saw the sisters appear. As they did, they sent a runner immediately to Rhea. She would know what it meant and what to do.

"It is the time of purification and placation," she declared. "When this moon settles, this year will have come to an end, and the new year will be upon us. When the year has but half a moon left, we will celebrate the Diasia. All those with jobs to do, should start to do them now."

Cronos led the hunting party that night. He knew that in less than a moon he would be joining the other spirits in the nether world and would desire that same connection with the living world. He, too, would want to be fed and placated and, he was sure, would be angry at those who withheld their largesse - or even stinted in their tasks. And, he swore to himself under his breath, he would have his revenge on those who did not feed him.

They hid in a thicket, patiently waiting for the boar to come and drink from the pond. As leader, Cronos had the most dangerous task: approaching the boar and attaching the first rope to its neck. Once done, the boar would not be able to escape since the other end of the rope was already tied around a tree, but there was nothing stopping the boar turning and attacking him. In general, a boar's first instinct was to flee, and often it was only that instinct that kept the hunters alive. The boar could not be killed - ideally, should not even be injured - since both its blood, its vitality, and its flesh were part of the offering to the spirts to be placated at the Diasia.

From their right, they heard a rustling as something moved through the bushes. In the dim light of the lessening moon, they could pick out motion, but not a clear outline of an animal. But drawing on all his experience, Cronos *knew* that this was a boar. And would be the first one he would take tonight. Combining all his senses, he stared out into the dark and "saw" the boar as it moved through the rustling bushes and reached the edge of the pond. Even before it had finished moving, he had tapped his colleagues on their shoulders and slipped noiselessly from his hiding place down the pathway he had reconnoitred earlier in the day. Noiselessly, he crept up on the boar and within heartbeats was alongside the shoulder of the beast. He counted five heartbeats to allow his colleagues to get into position, then reached forward and guided the loop of rope over the boar's head and down on its neck before pulling tightly, releasing the remaining rope and running back from whence he had come.

So skilfully had Cronos trapped the boar that by the time he stopped, a safe distance away, that the boar had not moved, but just stood there quietly sniffing the air, sure that it was threatened but still trying to identify the source of the threat and which way it should run. The tickling on its neck irritated it, and it trashed its head in an attempt to clear the brush away. When that didn't work, it started to realise there was something attached to it, and struggled harder to get away. Only then did it truly understand that it was under attack; roaring its bellow, it started to charge - unsure of the location of its attacker, it struck straight forward, directly into the pond and sank in the mud up to its belly. Within seconds, it was immobilized and thrashing for its life.

The hunters came back to the pond and looked at the boar thrashing itself towards its death.

"If it can't get itself out, can we? It is so strong."

"True," responded Cronos, "but do not forget that it is pushing against the mud, which gives no resistance. But we have the ropes to pull it out. When it has thrashed all its energy and rage away, we will be able to pull it out. When you can, attach your ropes and be ready to pull. Tie yours around the belly of the beast; that will give us good leverage. Truly the Goddess shows her favour on us; this boar shows his strength while at the same time wasting it trying to thash its way out of an impossible situation. When he is worn out, we will pull him free."

Looking around, Cronos saw a nearby tree.

"I am going to climb that tree with my rope and make sure his head is kept above water. It would not do to let him drown while pulling him out."

And with that, Cronos claimed the slack of his rope and started to climb.

After dark, they lit the bonfire.

Before long, it was roaring upwards, the branches crackling and settling onto the larger trunks beneath. Slowly but steadily, these caught too and started to glow a dull orange. On one side of the fire stood Cronos and a temporary enclosure which had been built to house the boars. As ritual demanded, as the intermediary between the living and the spirits that had gone before, Cronos stood on the fleece which marked him out as the messenger: in a place between worlds; if not a spirit himself, he was detached from the world of the living and separated from its concerns by a token of death.

On the other side of the raging fire stood Rhea, likewise separated from the world of the living by a ritual fleece. She stood naked, exposing all that she was to the spirits so that they might know her, recognise her and judge her on this day of purification and placation. For if the spirits were not placated today, who knew what harms they might visit on her village. Better then, that they should choose to take her in compensation for their failure than wreak vengeance on the whole village. That was what it meant to stand surety for the placating of the spirits.

"Oh spirits, know that we summon you today. Today is the annual day of the Diasia, the day in which we feed you and right your wrongs. You cannot live up here with us, for your time is past. But we know, on this darkest day of the year, that life will come again. As the moon turns this time, the seeds will sprout and grow ready for the harvest. And we know that, in the same way, we who live here today will one day be spirits like you, dependent on the charity of our children for sustenance at this dark time of year. And one day, you spirits will return to life to keep the chain unbroken.

"We have lived this year in accordance with the commands of the Goddess. You need not fear for us, nor need you fear that we will fail in our duty to you. Come, take our offerings! Be warm! Feel the glow that we send to you! Come near! Eat, and be filled! Today is the day of the Diasia and we will feed you!"

And with that, she lowered her head and stretched out her arms. "Now," she whispered fiercely and above the roar of the fire, "now, Cronos. Let the feast begin!"

Expertly, the handlers pulled the first boar forward. As it stepped onto the fleece of offering, Cronos reached forward and hit it with the ritual hammer. As it slumped, he reached forward and slit its throat with the flint knife kept for this ceremony. Quickly, before too much of the blood could escape, the handlers picked it up and tossed it onto the fire. Within moments, the fire started to consume it, the smell of roasting flesh filled the air.

"Come!" should Rhea from across the fire. "Come and eat! We offer you fresh boar captured in this phase of the moon, just for you! Come, O spirits! Come and dine!"

As the fire consumed the boar, Cronos and his handlers repeated the process. By the time they had finished, four boars had been offered for the placation of spirits. Then all the villagers, led by Cronos and Rhea, stood and watched as the fire burned down and consumed all of the boars. Nothing was left to be eaten by the villagers.

But that was the way it had to be. The Diasia was for the benefit of the spirits, not the villagers. As long as they were placated, nothing else mattered.

11. Zeus

Cronos reviewed his battle dispositions.

The word had come to him at sunrise that an "unusual" army had been seen on the horizon. Before the messenger had finished his message, he was up and girding himself for war. He snapped off instructions to gather all the men of the village to prepare for battle and to meet the threat at the designated ready point. Then he immediately hurried off to reconnoitre the situation. He had not needed to check his instructions would be carried out: he had known they would be.

Now, all the men of the village where here, grouped by hands. Their officers were in place. The village was not particularly easy to defend, but this place offered him the opportunity to spread out his men and engage an enemy, who would usually be expected to have smaller numbers. His usual tactic was to surround them - and obliterate them. Of course, usually most of them ran away rather than stay to be obliterated.

Standing on a nearby rock, Cronos looked out at where the oncoming army lay, moving slowly towards them. Was this really an army? He understood the messenger's confusion now. It was more like an entire village on the move. Certainly, they mass contained some warriors: he could see swords and spears among them. But there were women - not particularly unusual, but many of these were carrying babies with them - and animals mixed in amongst them. Was this really an army? Or was this a village on the move? He had not heard news of any catastrophes that had destroyed nearby villages; but then, often the first news they would hear would come with those who were affected by it. It was rare news that merited sending a special messenger between villages.

As he watched, the mass of humanity stopped and started to close in on themselves. The warriors picked up flasks from women or from animals and drank - a good idea to keep up fluids before a long day of battle in the hot sun. His men would do much the same in a moment or two before attacking. Having drunk, the men started to group together and come towards the villagers again, readying swords and spears as they came.

About a furlong away, the men stopped and formed into rows. One man, presumably the leader, stepped forward and harangued them:

"Ask-ken-hai Zeus, ah-ken! Ask-ken-hai Zeus, ah-ken!" he bellowed. His men raised up a mighty shout and waved their weapons in the air.

"Final drink and then advance," yelled Cronos. He moved into the lead, brandishing his sword. Men moved around him, taking their places for the advance that would turn into an attack. He had disciplined them well, but even so, no man looked forward to dying and he knew from experience that the forces would close slowly and timidly; only once the first blows had been struck would the two armies start a general engagement. Cronos knew that his job was to be the one to make that happen; the one to lead the army and start the battle by engaging with whoever was at the forefront of the enemy forces.

The enemy leader continued to wave his spear and bawl unintelligibly. Cronos had no idea who he was, but if his language was anything to go by, he was not from anywhere around here. He started to advance, waving his sword at the man.

Suddenly the man charged at him, running at what must be close to full speed. Insanity! How could he manage a steady stance when running? Surely he had a death wish.

When he closed within twenty paces, he reared back and *hurled* his spear, straight into Cronos' chest. Pierced through, Cronos fell to the ground, mortally wounded. Around him, order turned into chaos as other men, mainly officers, were likewise impaled by the spears. Here and there, men charged forwards, engaging the invaders, but to no avail. Before the sun had even raised up a finger, the battle was over. Those brave enough to engage were dead, and the rest either on their knees, begging for mercy or in full flight back to the village.

Zeus had arrived, and the village would never be the same.

The village was in uproar.

As soon as some of the men had come rushing back, telling of the death of Cronos and the enemy who threw spears and spoke gibberish they had never heard before, the panic had started. As men talked over each other, babbling and panicking, relating strange details of the behaviour, the word had spread, shouted from one end of the village to the other. As more and more of the men had come back, confirming and expanding the story, and making it clear that the army truly had been routed, a deeper sense of doom had settled on the village. Nobody quite knew what to do: should they all run away? Where could they run to? If the army could not stand up to these invaders, what could the remnants of the village do?

The situation was unprecedented. From time to time in ages past, one or another Cronos had admitted defeat after a battle; the victorious enemy had then sat down and negotiated. A certain number of goats, or a certain amount of wheat had been demanded and rendered; sometimes even some of the villagers had been handed over as slaves. But never in the memory of or legend known by any of the villagers had Cronos been killed, or the army utterly routed. It simply wasn't *possible*.

Except, of course, on this occasion it had happened.

Rhea entered the Megara and softly called for quiet. Immediately the senior women in the village stopped talking and turned to face her.

"There is no doubt that a terrible tragedy has befallen us. The Goddess has turned her face away from us; I do not know why. But, nonetheless, we must stay calm. These foreigners are here, and they are clearly stronger than us. The Goddess clearly intends to use them to chastise us for our errors; so we must accept that. If she chooses to use them to kill us, so be it; but we must show Her that we trust in her wisdom.

"Now, gather together our people, and let us go to the edge of the village. There we will kneel in reverence to the Goddess, showing Her that Her people show her respect when times are bad, even as we do when times are good.

"Now move."

Zeus called XXX over to him.

The boy had not lived up to his early promise knowing the languages of the south lands that they had passed through. He had struggled to communicate with many of the peoples with whom they had come into contact. Probably more people had died than strictly necessary because of that but, Zeus reflected, only two of those had been *his* men. If villagers wanted to die rather than submit, that was, at the end of the day, their choice.

He had also taken captives on his travels. These *did* know some of the local languages; but, sadly, Zeus could not communicate with them. XXX could, however, and so now, as Zeus called him forward, he brought Lomaria with him. He hadn't even bothered to negotiate with the men who had confronted him: they came armed and girded for a battle, so a battle he gave them. But now that they had run away, he was prepared to negotiate.

As before, it seemed that while men around here were willing to fight, they wanted to leave the negotiation to the women. Lomaria had said that was because in this part of the world women ruled, but that was obviously ridiculous. How could women rule when they couldn't even stop a man having sex with them whenever he wanted to? What kind of rule was it that wasn't based on strength and a willingness to fight, even to kill?

All of the village had turned out for him, it seemed. All neatly arrayed, kneeling on the ground in front of him, heads bowed to the floor. The kind of reverence he liked. He straightened up the sword in his belt and issued his commands.

"XXX, take Lamaria and go and find out which of these women is in charge. Tell her to come her and talk to me."

Rhea looked up at the three men who approached.

The big one on the right was clearly a warrior, and had to be the leader of this group. Big and muscled, he had a bronze sword tucked in his belt, still bloody from the earlier battle. The other two did not look like warriors. Smaller, and somewhat diffident, they shuffled after the big man as if trying to hide in his shadow.

The big man opened his mouth and sounds came out. Not words, but gibberish. She understood what the returning warriors had meant now: this man was not from anywhere in the world that they knew, nor had the heard of it from any travellers who passed through these parts. Diatribe finished, the second man started talking. Some of his sounds seemed familiar, almost as if he were speaking but indistinctly. Unlike the big man, he did not look at her, or anyone else in her party; he seemed to be talking just to the third man of their group. Who started talking the moment the second man had finished.

"The Mighty Zeus says, 'I am Zeus. By right of combat, I claim this village and all the people in it. Now is the time I despise, the time of talking. Tell me one reason why I should not stop this useless talking and just kill the lot of you.'"

The moment he started talking, Rhea flicked her eyes back to Zeus, trying to imagine him actually saying these words. His original speech had been powerful and direct, full of confidence and assurance. These two translators had none of his confidence. But they had none of his strength. She put the words together with the man and knew that he could do whatever he wanted: if he wanted to kill them all, he certainly could.

She stared at him while trying to choose the right words, the words that might stand a chance of being translated correctly. Words that might keep some or all of her people alive.

"You have beaten us in battle. The village is yours. I recognise you as Cronos, and invite you to rule with me."

Zeus waited impatiently while the woman babbled in her 'language' and then while first Lomaria then XXX translated her words for him.

"And she says that you must now be something called Cronos - maybe she means King? - and says you can rule as long as you let her rule too."

"She says what? Tell her of course I will rule, what possible reason could she have for thinking that I would share that with her? She gives me what I already have if I want it."

Again, he waited, now playing with the handle of his sword while the long, long process of communicating with this woman took place. He watched her like a hawk as she listened, then deliberated, then spoke. He admired her lack of fear. And yet, he felt, she would be better to be afraid. She was unlikely to live as long as the Sun did today.

"She says that the ruler must be a woman in order to communicate with someone she calls the "goddess" - again, another title, I think - and that any man can only share in her rule."

Zeus looked at him in astonishment and rage. So enraged, in fact, that he had started to draw his sword to kill him before he realized that the man was just a translator. The woman in front of him was the originator of the comment.

"I care not about this goddess of hers. Did he protect her village on this day? I think not. I spit on him and on her and on all of this village. Tell her there is only one thing I need a woman for, but I do not need to give up my power in order to have her. Tell her I will have her and then give her to all of my men to have after me if she doesn't do better than that."

He waited while the pair of them talked to each other, obviously struggling to figure out what to report to the woman. Probably wondering if they should repeat his threats or just stick to facts. The fact that the woman bowed her head and looked down at the ground again suggested that she had, at the very least, grasped the fact that she was being threatened.

"She says that she does not understand your contempt for her goddess but hopes that you will not suffer the fate of the condemned for your contempt. She says that of course you can rape her, and of course you can kill her, but she asks what the benefit would be.

"And then, and then ... she asked if you would sacrifice her. Take her life, kill her that the village may live. You can settle here, and your men can marry the women here, and settle here. And the village can continue to live. It would be an offence to her 'goddess' if you were to destroy the village."

Zeus looked around. As with other communities he had passed through, and as Lamaria had told him, the communities here had special magic that could make food appear out of the ground. Lamaria himself did not know the rituals, but he did know that the deepest secrets of the rituals were all held by women. It was the women of the village who were important. And who could be cowed.

But who needed men? Particularly weak men, who didn't know how to fight, and allowed *women* to rule over them. Zeus didn't. Although he admired the courage of this one.

"Tell this woman she is now my junior wife. Pass the word to kill all the men. And any boys that you don't like the look of. And then, tonight, we celebrate. Make a grand bonfire and offering to the gods. All the men can choose the women they like the look of, and claim them. But no fighting! There are plenty to go around."

Mykenai, Greece

1345 BCE

1. New Year

The two men stood watching the sky.

Zeus and Helios stood side by side, with their polished bronze swords tucked into their waistbands. The whole village had cleaned and tidied for the past week in readiness to welcome in the New Year. Assuming it came. Tonight, they were sure, would be the night, assuming that the Moon did not show her face tonight before the Sun showed his face above the horizon. Slowly to the East, the sky brightened, obscuring the Seven Sisters - who had risen only a little while before - from view.

"O, Sun, we greet you!" chanted Helios as the disc slowly rose above the horizon. "O, Sun, who brings us a New Year of hope!"

When they had finished greeting the Sun, this first day of the New Year, they walked back to the village.

"Today is the day of challenge," said Zeus.

"Do you think anyone will be foolish enough to challenge you?" asked Helios. "I can't think that anyone has the strength to take you on in single combat."

"Perhaps not, but somebody has to challenge me, and I have to let them win," Zeus replied, a twinkle in his eyes.

"Or at least, not kill him," countered Helios. "That would be a waste."

"Not kill him *yet*," clarified Zeus. "There will be time for my revenge later."

Helios clapped him on the back and they walked back to the village and Hera.

Hera stood next to Zeus in the Megara.

"This is Zeus, my husband. By right of marriage, I submit to him and the powers of the Goddess which flow through me flow into him and he rules. But, by the words of the Priest of the Sun, Helios, today marks the start of a New Year and is the day of challenge. Any who do not accept Zeus as my husband may challenge him for the power. If any overcome him, I will give myself to him and the power of the Goddess will flow from me to him, and he will be Zeus.

"All those who feel that Zeus is no longer the man to lead us should go home, arm and prepare to challenge Zeus in a duel to the death. Only through death can the threads of power be diverted. Challengers should present themselves here to fight Zeus when the Sun reaches her zenith."

Zeus stood stock still, impressive in his war gear with his brightly polished sword tucked in his belt and his bright, new tunic. It would, indeed, take a brave man to think it worthwhile to challenge him, no matter what the rewards might be in the year ahead.

In the end, there were two.

As the villagers gathered around the edge of the Megara, the two men stood forward; like Zeus, they had clean, fresh tunics, brightly polished belts and swords. By challenging Zeus for power, they guaranteed that either by the end of the day, they would be Zeus, dead, or banished. The three men would never fight together again.

"Laumachos, step forward," challenged Zeus to the man to his left. The better man, in Zeus' opinion, and one of his senior officers. Yes, if any man of the village could defeat Zeus, it would be him. And, maybe in a couple of years that might have come to pass. Zeus counted himself fortunate that the man had chosen this year to make his challenge, before Zeus inevitably started to decline. Then, of course, it was only right that a younger, stronger man challenge him as leader: such was the way of the world.

Laumachos moved into the centre of the Megara as the other man retreated into the crowd for now. As second challenger, he knew he had an advantage: Zeus would be worn down by the first bout and would have less strength to fight off a second challenger.

Laumachos drew his sword in a fluid motion, keeping both eyes on Zeus and started to circle. They had often sparred in training and he knew the measure of the man he challenged: his better, it was true, but he himself was getting older and in years to come younger men would be able to challenge either Zeus or himself - whoever was leader. It was this year or never. Probably never, he acknowledged.

Suddenly Zeus drew his sword and charged at him, throwing down a heavy overhanded blow in a single motion that flowed from the draw. Laumachos had his sword up and in perfect form for the parry. The clanging of the bronze swords echoed deafeningly around the Megara. Laumachos pushed up and backed away. Zeus pulled his sword back and swung a wicked backhanded swipe at Laumachos' head. Laumachos again parried in perfect form, then spun around behind Zeus, who followed the spin, engaging swords. A step to the left, and Laumachos disengaged. The watching crowd drew in a collective gasp as Zeus swung again. Three blows, all perfectly parried.

Laumachos jumped backwards, then turned defence into attack. A quick combination of blows had Zeus on the defensive. But then Zeus stepped to his right, slammed his sword down on Laumachos', and then used his shoulder to bash the challenger to the floor. Stepping forward, he placed his foot on Laumachos' sword and then pointed his own at the man's throat. Laumachos dropped his sword and said the ritual phrase, "I acknowledge the power of Zeus."

Zeus stepped back and climbed onto the dais with Hera. Straightening his tunic, he tucked his sword into his belt while Laumachos stood up and retreated into the crowd of villagers. Meanwhile, the Marshal came forward and collected his sword. As a failed challenger, Laumachos could no longer have a sword, but it was too valuable to just leave lying around. The Marshal would make sure that it was properly accounted for.

Hera looked at the other challenger: "Oh, Kamiades, do you still wish to challenge the Mighty Zeus, my husband, to be ruler over the village?"

Kamiades stepped forward from the crowd, his bronze sword shining as he drew it. "Indeed I do, Queen Hera. I challenge Zeus for your hand and to lead this great people in the worship of the Goddess."

Zeus stepped back down from the dais with his hand on his sword and approached Kamiades. Without waiting for Zeus to draw, Kamiades stepped forward and snapped off an overhead blow. Faster than the eye could track, Zeus had drawn his sword and parried the blow. Stepping inside the blow to his left, he counter-attacked with a series of chops, left and right, pulling many of them before they had even been parried. Quickly, what should be a duel became almost a dance as the two men offered blows only to pull them, each trying to induce the other into a mistake.

Kamiades drew first blood, drawing a thin line across Zeus' left wrist. As the crowd sucked in a collective breath, Zeus took advantage of his opponent's surprise to launch a furious attack in combination, ultimately breaking the challenger's sword. He drew back for what would have been a slash to take the man's head off, but, staring into the man's eyes, held the blow. For several heartbeats, the two of them stared into each other's eyes.

Then Kamiades dropped to his knees and released the hilt of his sword. Zeus lowered his sword until it rested on the back of the man's head.

"I acknowledge the power of Zeus," Kamiades conceded. Zeus removed his sword and tucked it back into his belt. Stretching out his hand, he raised Kamiades to his feet.

"You fought well, old friend, but you know the law. Those who challenge Zeus must either succeed or fail. To fail is to be banished. You will have your one cow, a goat, any of your own possessions, and any villagers who choose may go with you. Your life will not be easy as a scapegoat, but for the history we have together, I wish you well."

Kamiades bowed his head, "I thank my Lord Zeus. I did not challenge you because I doubted you, but because the Goddess wished it. I am pleased that she found no fault in you, O Lord.' Thus saying, he turned and left.

Zeus called Laumachos forward. "Well done, old friend. Of the challengers, none could beat me, but you challenged well and fought well and shall have your reward."

Turning to the villagers he raised his hands above his head. "Now, O villagers, attend, for in acknowledgment of my friend Laumachos' achievement today, I pronounce him King and Zeus." Snapping his fingers to an attendant, the man brought forward a tray. From it, he removed a circlet of laurel leaves. "With this crown, I anoint you, Laumachos." He reached and removed two goblets from the tray. Passing one to Laumachos, he said, "An offering from Dionysus to bless your union with Hera. Here, drink with me to share our good fortune."

Linking arms, they drank the goblets dry and then threw the clay vessels across the Megara to smash against the wall. Drawing him forward, Zeus presented Laumachos to Hera.

"Hera, this man is now your husband. This I command, that you take him and marry him and celebrate the New Year with him."

Laumachos let go of Zeus and walked over to Hera. Taking her in his arms, he kissed her, then raised her shift over her head. She, in turn, removed his belt and tunic. Then sinking down onto the floor of the dais, she pulled him on top of her, then, stroking his penis until it became fully erect, she pulled him inside her, then laid back and let herself go to the ecstasy of this man who was now her husband as the villagers looked on, calling encouragement to the man who had entered the room as Laumachos, but now, having entered Hera, was called Zeus.

The man who had entered the room called Zeus watched for a while as the new Zeus used his wife, bringing her to orgastic pleasure, then turned and left the village, denied his title, his name, his kingdom.

The fire burned at dusk to welcome the New Year as it always had.

The women of the village who had dedicated their lives to the Goddess danced around the fire, as they always had. As ever, they were led in their worship by Athena, dedicated priestess of the Goddess. And, as ever, they were joined by Hera, through whom the Goddess presented herself to the world.

The drummers played the beat, joined by the flute players and accompanied on the lyre by Apollo. The dancers performed the well-rehearsed steps of the ritual in time with the beat, steadily increasing in tempo.

From time to time, men would stand up from their places surrounding the fire and, finding their way into the rhythm of the music, would join the dance, forming an outer circle, facing in towards the women and the fire. Dancing in opposite directions around the fire, each of the men would pass all of the women, and, more importantly, each of the men would be on display before the women for when the time of selection came.

From his place in the front row, the man who had been Zeus since his challenge at noon rose up and joined the dance, performing the ritual steps in time to the music and in perfect alignment with all those around him. Seamlessly, he entered the circle of men and rotated with them, looking at each of the women he passed and smiling at them. In his former life as an army hero, he had had most of these women, knew them intimitately and had worshipped the Goddess with them. But tonight, they knew he was not the man for them, however much he smiled at them, no matter how many times he passed them. No, as Zeus, he was reserved for Hera, his wife.

The fire crackled and spat gouts of flame. Its roar competed with the noise of the drums and the music, but even so all the dancers heard it when the music suddenly changed: the tempo dropped and the drums became less intense. This was now the time of the selection, although now the ritual dictated that Hera could only make one selection: Zeus.

The circles stopped with Hera and Zeus facing each other. The music stopped too. Hera pointed at Zeus and called above the noise of the flames:

"Zeus, I call you. Come to me to demonstrate the fertility of the land. Let us show the grain how to rise. Let it be Spring again, then Summer! Let us cast off the garments of death, and celebrate the act of life!" And with that, she reached out her hands in offering.

Zeus stepped forward, taking her hands in his, then pulling her closer. As they acted the ritual of magic, he came closer to her and lifted her high against his body. The music started again, and to its rhythm their bodies swirled around her as, for the second time that day, he entered her and showed the Goddess that they understood the act of procreation, and through their efforts would encourage the grain to rise.

Around them, the other couples in the dance followed suit, all determined to ensure their acts led to a healthy grain crop this year, without which the village might starve. Slowly the bodies sank to the ground in various positions, pumping away, celebrating the life that was returning after the death of winter.

Zeus lifted himself up off Hera as he finished, flushed and pleased with himself. "Oh, it is great to be Zeus," he declared.

Suddenly a man bounded out from the edge of the circle, barely seen in the flickering firelight. The light shone and dazzled from something in his hand - a bronze sword. Leaping forward, he swung the sword through Zeus' neck, severing it in a single blow a causing a gush of blood to fountain from his arteries, spreading over Hera, the ground, and other dancers nearby.

The man picked up the head by its hair and turned to face the villagers. "The old year is dead," he declaimed. "Zeus is dead. The old Zeus is dead." And then he lifted the head up high. The man who had been Zeus, then not been Zeus, was Zeus again. Carelessly, he tossed the head of his rival into the fire.

"Long live Zeus! Long live Zeus!" chanted the villagers.

Behind living Zeus, his wife hacked the body of the dead Zeus to pieces, again in accordance with time-honoured ritual. And threw most of him into the fire. The little she kept - shrunk after its earlier exertion - was dedicated to the Goddess. As it ever had been.

2. In the Fields

Zeus knew it was his job, but that didn't mean he had to like it.

What he wanted to be doing was drilling with his soldiers, preparing for the inevitable combats the year would bring. Since becoming Zeus eight summers ago, the village had never been successfully attacked, but he had managed to lead several successful campaings against neighbouring villages. In truth, he admitted to himself, he didn't really want to be *drilling* with the soldiers, he wanted to be leading them in a raid.

There were now four nearby villages that were paying them an annual "tribute" to not attack them again. In exchange for a stipulated amount of foodstuffs, pottery, cloth, wine and other goods, Zeus had agreed not to attack them and, indeed, to join them in defending themselves against - and exacting retribution on - any other village that should attack them.

Instead, he was here in the Megara, sorting out which work details - which groups of men - would be allocated to each of the women who wanted help in their fields.

This was, of course, the season of preparation. When the harvest came, the headaches would be less - all the villagers would pull together, harvesting from one end of the village to the other until all the grain had been brought in and threshed. But now, the decisions to be made were tricky. Which was more important - making sure some bindweed in Xanthe's field was cleared before it spread, or watering all the grain on the high ground in Canippe's field that might die if it didn't rain in the next couple of days? There were always more jobs to do than men available to do them, but most of them were not *really* necessary. If the bindweed didn't spread, then the small amount of it there today would do little harm. Likewise, if it rained today or tomorrow - and his bones told him it would rain overnight - then all the backbreaking effort of lugging amphorae of water up from the river to water the fields would have been wasted. Time that men could have spent drilling for the army.

On the other hand...

He consulted briefly with Hera and made his dispositions. He ended with those most vexating women: "Xanthe, you can have Apollo's crew for the morning; when they have finished, they can go down and help Rosia with her raking and hoeing. Canippe, I believe the Goddess will answer your request directly and send rain for us all tonight; if I have understood her wrong, I will send you Herakles' crew tomorrow. That's the kind of back-breaking work he was made for. You never know, he might just choose to divert the river rather than shuttle those amphorae!" He chuckled at his own joke: strong as he was, Herakles' reputation was mainly for laziness and a bad temper.

Which is what I will have if I don't get out of here soon, thought Zeus.

In the end, it was nearly noon by the time he was actually out in the fields, but even so, he was not free to go and join Ares and the soldiers in the drills. Instead, he had to go on a round of the fields, checking on the work ethic of his various gangs, and handing out on-the-spot punishments as needed.

As he expected, Herakles was lazing off, sunning himself in Doris' field. Doris, of course, was no match for the brute Herakles. To be fair, Zeus himself was no match for the brute Herakles, but at least he could defend himself against the massive blows of an outraged Herakles.

He was supposed, as ordained by Zeus and Hera earlier in the month, to be building a stone wall between Doris' field and the adjoining one. When the harvest had been brought in, Doris wanted to fold some goats on her land, and didn't want them straying. Come to that, almost none of the women who owned the adjoining fields would want Doris' goats wandering onto their land, eating whatever second-season crops they had planted.

His crew were working, but an incredibly strong man, Herakles could lift heavier stones more frequently and more easily. By slacking off, he was depriving the team of the work of two other men.

Zeus walked over to a pile of stones that had been collected in the morning, ready for assembling into a wall this afternoon. Choosing the ideal stone, he hefted it and carried it over to where Herakles was lying, and let go.

Herakles awoke with a howl and sat up, casting the stone to one side.

"I'm sorry," said Zeus genially. "I thought maybe you were just having a quick rest while you waited for someone to bring you your next stone."

Herakles blinked the sun out of his eyes and growled. Impressively agile for such a bulky man, he jumped up, picked up the stone and tossed it effortlessly onto the wall being built.

"Happy now?" he challenged Zeus.

Zeus smiled as sweetly as he could manage: "Always happy to see the jobs I've allocated being done, thank you, Herakles. I'll move on now, assured in the knowledge that you are giving Doris your all. I certainly wouldn't want to hear otherwise tomorrow or I might have to find something worse for you to do."

Zeus dropped in on the craft sheds.

Many of the crafts - pottery and linen, for example - were entirely in the hands of women. Zeus left it to Hera to supervise those. He was, of course, most interested in Hephastos' work in the armaments shed, although it was always hot in here, even in the winter months. Today, with Spring in the air and the Sun shining down, it was truly stifling. At the end of the hut, a large stone furnace was continually stoked with wood and charcoal - whatever that was; Hephastos claimed it was something of his own invention that would burn even hotter than wood.

But the details were of no interest to Zeus. It was what Hephastos made in here that interested him: weapons. Everything from bronze swords and axes to bronze-tipped ash spears. Zeus was a particular fan of the missile weapons: bows and arrows lovingly crafted from local woods and then again tipped with bronze points. Zeus picked up a finished arrow. Delicately made, the shaft was a thin sliver of ash, as thin as it could be made but still hold up under the tension of a fully drawn bow, with three flights of feathers at the tail arranged in a perfect triangle. On the end was a delicate point of bronze, beautifully forged. The business end of the missile, this was what did the damage, burying itself deep into a man's head, chest or limbs. Ideally, it would penetrate deeply into the tissue, breaking apart blood vessels and doing untold damage to the muscles or organs beneath. Arrows rarely killed a man immediately, but they might incapacitate him for the duration of the battle, or cause him to die slowly if his injuries were not treated sufficiently rapidly.

The problem, Zeus reflected, was always the sheer *number* of them that you needed. A soldier could go on campaign with just one sword; although two might be better since bronze was inherently brittle and swords could often snap. A man with a spear would generally want two or three to throw at an enemy before closing to go toe to toe with him using a sword. But a man with a bow? He would get to the battle site, fire fifteen or twenty arrows while the armies closed and then say "I've run out of arrows". And they were so complicated to make: just an ash shaft took a man almost a day to cut, shape and whittle. The bronze heads Hephastos could cast at a rate of twenty or so a day; but the feathers for the flights took *forever* to gather: they had to kill the birds, pluck the feathers, straighten them, sew them together laboriously, then attach them to the shaft and make sure everything was aligned perfectly.

And then some idiot would fire it during practice and make a mess of the flights, and back it would come to be repaired or replaced. He really needed more men on the job of making the flights, but could he spare them from other jobs in the village? He didn't see how.

Zeus put the arrow back down and picked up an unstrung bow. It always amazed him how, unstrung, the bow bent the opposite way to how it did "in real life". And how very tough it was to attach the string to the bow, and yet how very supple the bow was that it did not break. Zeus had asked Hephastos to explain the magic of the wood to him many times, but he could not understand the spells. Hephastos had learned them from his father, of course. He had been shaping bows since he was a child in the craft sheds working alongside his father.

"That one's coming along," he said to Zeus now. "It should be ready for you by the end of the quarter-month, I'd say. It needs some more bending and some more lacquer. It seems strong enough, but you never can tell until you come to use it. And then, if it snaps, it snaps and all my work is gone to naught. Still..."

"Good man," said Zeus. "You are doing fantastic work here. How many arrows can I expect to have by the time I take my men out on campaign?"

Hephastos sucked a breath in between his teeth and thought for a moment: "How many bowmen are you thinking of taking with you?"

"Probably twenty or so. They'll have spears and swords as well, of course; no point taking them all that way and not being able to fight when they arrive."

"Twenty men, twenty bows. So, let's see ..." Zeus could see the other man's brain whirring as he tried to visualise the number of arrows he would make. "Let's say they can have twenty each. Providing, of course, that they don't destroy too many in training."

Zeus nodded sagely; that was always an unknown. But he liked the idea of twenty archers putting twenty arrows into the enemy as they approached. He would have to talk to Apollo about that.

Ares was drilling the soldiers when he started climbing the hill.

"And slash," he shouted. "That's it. And you, defenders, be sure to get your swords fully up and take the weight on those wrists. This is not like pruning bushes, you louts! Push back on that weight or you'll find a real sword coming through your guard and into your body."

They went through the drill again, half the men swinging their wooden swords horizontally into the space between them and their opponents. The other half of the men brought their swords up and in line, the flats turned perfectly to catch the edge of the attacking sword. The swords came together with a loud "clack" that always sounded wrong to Zeus - it should be the lovely chime that came from bronze swords coming together. But that was a small price to pay for not damaging the swords - or the soldiers - in training.

Zeus came to stand beside Ares. "How are they doing, today?" he asked. "It doesn't look very promising. We want to be taking them out raiding soon, not having them practising on this hill all spring."

Ares didn't take his eyes off the drilling soldiers for a moment as he responded, "they are doing better today. But we don't want to take them raiding before we're ready. Apart from the men we might lose, think about how it would affect our standing if we were to challenge someone and then come away the losers."

Zeus shuddered in spite of himself. That was not a pleasant thought. Either home or away, he could not afford to develop a reputation as a leader who could not follow through on a threat. Before long, he would find himself being challenged on a regular basis, and then the villages he had subjugated would rise up - before he knew it, he would no longer be King of Kings, but an also-ran. A prospect that did not bear thinking about.

"That goes without saying. But we need to bear in mind that we are also committed to defending our allies. If we can't do that, then they'll defect anyway. We had messages from Maia's village a few weeks back that she thought she might be attacked soon. A good defensive action along with her would be a good start to the season, especially if we could then use that as a launching pad to retaliate and maybe add another village to our clients."

"Providing it's not during the harvest season," said Ares.

"Nobody would be that stupid," said Zeus. "If it's the harvest here, it will be there, too. Everybody knows that the Goddess would look with disfavour on anyone who interfered with the harvest. It would be a disaster for everybody."

"Unless they had their harvest in first," countered Ares.

Zeus gave him a lopsided grin. The idea was madness.

3. Pharmakos

The harvest had begun, and the first day's reaping had been gathered in the Megara.

Now, the women gathered to prepare the offerings to the Goddess. As usual, the men were excluded from this most important of annual rituals: recognizing that the bounty they had received - and would continue to receive as the harvest continued - was a gift of the Goddess and that only with her help and support would the village continue to survive. To acknowledge their debt, and express their gratitude, they now prepared to offer the fruits of the first day's harvest *back* to the Goddess and her agents on earth, the snakes.

At the same time, they had engaged to purify the village by sending forth those scapegoats whom the Goddess had chosen. Four men walked among them still, marked by the Goddess, but unknown to the villagers, who in the morning would be revealed to Zeus as the four who must accompany the sacrifice - and thus be sacrificed themselves.

The women stood in a circle around the harvested corn. Led by Hera and Athene, they incanted the prayer to the Goddess,

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Goddess who art above us,
Watch over us now;
Listen as we prepare Thy feast;
To pay back a part of Your bounty.
We work here in the Night;
In the morning we will greet Your Face;
Always we think of You;
Always we worship You.
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Then the women applied themselves to work with a will. As always at harvest time, the nights were getting shorter as the Goddess rose again from her sojourn in the underworld and sprouted forth everywhere they looked: seeds were becoming plants; animals were having young; the Sun rose earlier and earlier; meadow flowers bloomed and showed their faces, hidden over the course of winter. Truly the Goddess was back amongst them. But on the downside, as the days grew longer and the nights shorter, the women had less time at night to prepare the offerings.

Each woman made cakes from the corn they had harvested, mixed together with blood from the bulls held back from the boars of the Thesmophoria the previous winter. This tied together the bounty of this spring with the remnants of the previous autumn, and reminded the Goddess that they had been faithful then, and over the intervening winter, and they were still faithful now.

They had also gathered other fruits: almonds, and figs just coming into season. Everything that they could find from the bounty of the Goddess they collected and arranged on brand new pottery platters crafted especially for this occasion. Everything they prepared was part of the offering, and everything had to be perfect: the plate, the corn offerings, the other fruits, the arrangement. If anything were to be less than perfect, it would send a message to the Goddess that they despised her love and care, and that they did not value her enough to make a perfect offering. In the past, such mistakes had cost the village dear: the Goddess had withheld the life-giving rain; or had given too much rain at once, destroying the crops as they grew; or had sent pestilence to kill the young, or the animals; or had caused the village to catch fire.

At length, all the platters were ready, the offerings arranged beautifully on them; their work here done, they went outside to greet the face of the Sun as she rose in the eastern sky on the morning of the Thargelia and Pharmakos.

The leaders among the men joined them there. As men, they were cut off from the festivals that revolved around incubation and birth: men knew of insemination and strength, but knew nothing of nourishment and growth; such activities were strictly for the women and their Goddess. Men still worshipped the Gods of the mountains and Fire, but recognized that here, in this village, it was the Goddess that controlled their destiny. But both men and women recognized the Sun as a deity. For women, She remained the most visible face of the Goddess; a face that shone down on them day after day; a face that gave life to the crops and warmth to the village. For men, the Sun was a symbol of power, strength and domination, reminding them of their ancestral Gods in the mountains: Gods of fire, spouting from the tops of the mountains, pouring down the sides of the mountains, destroying everything in their path. Although no man in the village had ever seen such a sight, the stories had been passed down from father to son throughout the generations. And the Sun offered the only visible cosmic link to these stories: a ball of fire in the sky, which was released every morning from a mountain on the horizon they could not see.

On the other hand, the Goddess the women worshipped was around them everywhere. Although excluded from her most holy rites, whenever it was allowed the men expressed their devotion and gratitude to Her: She who governed every aspect of their lives on a daily basis.

Slowly, the Sun rose on the horizon, flaming into view and trailing sparks across the sky. All of the leaders of the people - Zeus, Hera, Ares, Athene - stretched forth their arms and chanted the invocation to the risen Sun.

Today was the Thesmophoria. And the Pharmakos.

After the Sun had risen, the villagers returned to their huts.

The men then gathered in the Megara for the choosing. Zeus and Ares were responsible for identifying the four men that the Goddess had marked. How they did this - how the Goddess spoke to them - was never known to any of the other villagers, but the two men walked through the ranks of men lined up for their inspection. And four times, Zeus reached out and tapped a man on the shoulder. As he was touched, the man knew his fate, and knew the importance of not showing that he knew his fate. Straight and stiff-backed, he walked from the assembly up onto the dais in the Megara. Here, they stood in a line, each knowing that today they would be beaten and sent forth from the village. In some sense, they did not know why they had been chosen; but in another sense, they all knew exactly why: the Goddess had found them out. For which exact crimes, they did not know; but the Goddess was all-knowing and would know what they had done even if they did not themselves. And, after all, who could claim to be innocent of all wrong-doing? Thoughts and minor offences flashed through their mind's eye, but these four men knew that the only thing they truly had in common was that they were unmarried men, and the Goddess had chosen them to accompany her offerings of the firstfruits and to be sent forth from the village, taking the offences of the village with them, that they not stain the village further.

When the four men had been chosen, Zeus called out to the remaining men, "Now go home to your huts and prepare yourselves. Evil is hiding amongst us, in this village and in our huts and in our hearts. The women are already cleaning out the huts and cleaning out the evil they can find. Now you must go and help them. All the evil must be cleaned out and put on the heads of these Pharmakoi. Ares and I will lead them."

The men left, dispersing to their individual homes. Meanwhile, Zeus and Ares went to stand with the four men who remained on the dais.

"Remember, men, that you have been chosen not because you are weak, but because you are strong. You must bear all the crimes and wickedness of the whole village. They will clean it from their hearts and from their houses and they will beat it into you. You must stand strong and hold that suffering, and cleanse it from the village. If you stand strong, the Goddess will reward you for your sacrifice. How she will intervene in your life, I cannot say, for none who leave as Pharamakoi are allowed to return. Once you leave, you will be outside the law; it is true that any who see you can kill you with impunity since no man will exact revenge. But remember, too, that the Goddess is all-seeing and all-powerful. If she chooses to intervene on your behalf, no man can withstand her power. With her help, it is possible you will find a new life far from here, in another village or community where men of strength and dedication to the Goddess are recognized and rewarded. Having carried out the sins of this village, you can yet be purified through your trials and struggles; if you are, you can carry on living whereever there are men who will have you, loyal servants of the Goddess.

"Now, prepare yourselves."

Each of the men took off his regular tunic, and placed over his head the newly fashioned garments of the Pharmakoi. The pristine white robes were fashioned to resist all manner of evil and to give their wearers strength in the time of trial. None of these men were wearing sandals, but if they had, they would have taken them off. Only a man truly at one with his mother, Earth, could carry away with the sins of the village. To have worn sandals at this time would have been to despise his mother and reject her care. Such a man could never succeed in his task.

Within moments, all four men were ready. Zeus indicated that two of them were to follow him, while Ares led the other two. They started to make their way through the village, each procession slowly building with one Pharmakos in each procession for the women and one for the men.

As they passed each hut, the family inside came out, screaming and hissing and violenty set upon the two men. The males of the family would beat the man on the right; the females the man on the left. Once the vicious beatings were complete, the family would wait as the procession moved on and then join it at the rear.

Hopefully they had beaten all of the evil out of themselves and their hut and into the offerings.

At the western edge of the village, Hera and Athene waited with the other women and the platters of offering.

Zeus and Ares led the processions out to meet them, the four Pharmakoi looking beaten and battered, limping slightly, but still showing the courage and forbearance expected of the Goddess' anointed. When they arrived where the women were waiting, Zeus and Ares stepped aside from the processions and allowed the men to continue and bow to the women waiting for them.

Hera spoke for the women, addressing the Goddess rather than the Pharmakoi: "Oh, Goddess, you who sees everything, know that we have obeyed all your commands and this day we send forth these four men, carrying with them all the slights and offences against you that we have unwittingly committed over the past year. As the new year begins, remember us without fault, for we are your loving and obedient children."

She bowed her head in silence for a few minutes. When she lifted her head up, the majority of the villagers turned back to the village. With a quick gesture, she dismissed the pharmakoi: having taken on board the sins of the village, they were no longer villagers but loners of the wilderness. They wandered off: by strict form, they now went in different directions, abandoning each other to their individual fates.

When they were gone, Hera signalled to the women waiting with her and they went westwards towards the cisterns in the wilderness. When there, they laid out their gifts for the Goddess with all due respect. Then Hera invoked the ritual phrases of giving and the women retreated to observe how the Goddess would respond.

4. Wedding

Doris looked up from milking her goat to see her daughter.

"What are you doing here, Iphi?"

Iphigenia looked at her shyly. She had not known what to do when the bleeding had suddenly started in the fields, but she had felt weak and Xanthe had said that she "needed to go and find her mother" in such a determined voice that she really felt that she had no choice at all. But the closer she had come to her mother, the less she knew what to say to her. She knew how her mother felt about her slacking off.

She burst into tears.

Doris abandoned her goat, who seemed a bit miffed at the neglect, but Doris sensed something was badly wrong with her daughter and that took priority.

"What is it, sweetheart? Has something happened? Are you all right?"

Iphi blubbered for a bit, lost for words. Finally she managed to put things into some kind of coherent order for her mother. "I was working in Xanthe's field. We were pulling up some of the stones and turning the soil over and then ... and then there was all this warmth on my legs and I looked and there was blood everywhere and I felt faint again and Xanthe said I needed to find you and so I left and ... came here," she ended lamely. She lifted up the hem of her tunic to show her mother the blood running down her legs.

"Oh, wonderful!" exclaimed Doris, then looked at her daughter who was clearly lost. "Welcome to the world of women, my dear. You will always be my daughter, but you are no longer a girl: you are a woman."

With a sudden clarity, everything came into focus for Iphigenia. That which made a woman a *woman* had happened to her at last. She had seen her friends go through this transition but had somehow failed to make the connection when it happened to her.

And then, as suddenly as it had arrived, her sense of wholeness and clarity fled. "What do I do now?" she blubbered.

"Well, first, you need to stop that crying," said Doris in a calming tone Iphigenia was unused to. "And then your father and I need to go and present you to Hera and Athene for acceptance into the ranks of the women of the village."

Her father, Xerxes, was as delighted as her mother. Possibly more so, for while she was still a girl, she was his responsibility and a burden. Once she became a woman he could "offload" her, as he had put it more than once, to some other man who would be responsible for feeding and clothing her for the rest of her life.

"I must go to Zeus at once," he said. "He was telling me the other day that he was looking for a girl ready to be married. I think he has a special officer in mind."

"An officer?" said Iphigenia, going all blubbery and discombobulated again. "I'm not sure I'm worthy of that."

"Oh, rubbish, girl," responded her mother. "The man wasn't born - officer or no - who is worthy of any woman, let alone my beautiful daughter!"

"Your mother is right, Iphi," agreed her father. "I will have to talk to Zeus and make sure that we find somebody who is worthy of you. Fear not." And he left them to go and find Zeus, while the women went to find Hera and Athene to perform the rituals of womanhood.

They met in the hut of the priestess, in sight of the Goddess herself.

As Iphi walked in, the snake slithered over to her, hissing with its tongue and taking in the scent of her. After a little while, it retreated back into its hut.

Hera and Athene looked at each other, then Athene confirmed: "the Goddess has not selected this one; she is not intended for the service of the Goddess."

Hera picked up the thread: "so ladies, prepare for a wedding. I imagine that your father is going to talk to Zeus about a potential husband for you." Looking Iphigenia straight in the eyes, she added, "whoever he is will be very fortunate to have a wife like you. Many healthy children do I see in your future."

Iphi felt she had done a good job of holding herself together during the course of the interview, especially when the snake - the Goddess herself - had been rattling around her, but now she regressed to being the child she had been in the morning and broke down crying.

Hera moved over to her and held her in her arms. "There, there, girl," she soothed. "We all have a path in life and we can trust in the Goddess to choose wisely. Weep not for the girl you are leaving behind today, but press forward in the full confidence that the Goddess will always be there to help and to guide you. And from the new moon onwards, you will have a husband to stand by your side as well. Remember, girl, always trust the Goddess, for She is wise and all-seeing."

And with that, Hera escorted them from the Priestess' hut, leaving Athene with a look of confusion on her face.

Xerxes found Zeus in the first place he looked for him.

"Swing harder," Zeus shouted. "You'll never strike his head off like that, even if you used a sharp, bronze sword."

The man he rebuked looked down and backed away from his combatant. The two of them shuffled around and then took up their positions. It was clear to Xerxes that neither of these men wanted to be here, swinging practice swords at each other. In fact, he knew both of them quite well, and part of the bond the three of them shared was a general sense that ploughing fields was both more valuable work - and more rewarding - than hitting other men with long poles - whether blunt or sharp made no difference.

Zeus saw him now and saw an opportunity to stir things up. "Come, come, Xerxes," he cried. "Here, have my sword and show these two lubbers how it's done."

"I'm not sure," began Xerxes demurely, "that I necessarily have the skills you are looking for here. I would probably just fall on your sword and hurt myself."

"Rubbish, rubbish, Xerxes. Yes, yes, I know you are not a soldier for the ages, but you can at least come here and show these two what it means to put some effort in and swing hard."

If nothing else, Xerxes could see that his friends had enjoyed the short break while Zeus had hectored him. He decided that playing along would gain them some time, if nothing else. He approached Zeus and took his sword. Briefly, he experimented with it, testing its weight and balance. Then he turned to the two men: "which of you would like to go first?"

Timo stepped back, while Isocrates turned to face him. Both Xerxes and Isocrates went into the ready position while Timo took a few steps further back. Xerxes stepped in and swung his sword in a brutal overhand fashion. Isocrates quickly raised his sword in a block, but the weight of the blow pushed Isocrates' sword down close to his head. The pair traded a few dozen blows until Isocrates found himself unable to field a parry and received a solid *thunk* to the side of his chest. He dropped his sword in shock and then fell to the ground. Xerxes stepped forward and helped his friend to his feet and hugged him. "Sorry, friend," he whispered in his ear.

Zeus slapped his thigh. "Oh, well done, well done, Xerxes. I've been trying to explain this to them for the last palm of the sun and they will not listen. Yes, that's how it's done. Commit to the blow. All of your weight, all of your strength behind the blow. That's what it takes."

Timo stepped forward timidly to take his turn sparring with Xerxes while Isocrates gingerly got back to his feet. Xerxes used the few moments' grace to address Zeus directly.

"Noble Zeus," he began, "while it is always a pleasant opportunity to spar with your soldiers, I am here on a mission of a different kind altogether. My daughter - Iphigenia - has just passed the threshold of womanhood. She has gone to see Hera and Athene and we feel that she is in need of a good husband. Just the other day you said that you had some officer in need of a good wife, I believe? If that is so, my Iphigenia would be just the woman for him!"

"Capital, Xerxes, capital! We must certainly celebrate this. Indeed, I have just the fellow in mind. Young Hector was promoted just last moon to the rank of officer in charge of two hands, and he is in need of a bride to cement his place in the community. What dowry does your daughter bring with her?"

Xerxes and Doris had talked about this on and off for a season or two now. They had three daughters in total, and they had to divide their own property between them. Two of their four living sons had already made good marriages, but in any case they could continue to benefit from the use of the lands they gave to their daughters for the rest of their natural lifetimes.

"She comes with two fields, sire. I would be happy to walk you or Hector around them, show you the bounds and the quality of the soil we have been nourishing for all these years, if it please you, my lord. The best of our lands; our other two girls will not be deprived but I don't imagine they will be able to make such good matches as our Iphi."

"Splendid, splendid. Well, you two, you might as well go, nothing very much you're going to learn today. Come on, Xerxes, let's go and find Hector. If he approves the girl and her land, we've got a wedding to prepare for tomorrow!

"I'll tell you something, Xerxes: it's good that the harvest is out of the way. You know how it is for these young people who want to get married during the harvest season. You can't take a whole day off getting the crops in just for a wedding!"

Xerxes always found Zeus' bluff heartiness a little wearing. But it was a small price to pay for the privilege of his daughter being married to an up-and-coming officer like Hector. And he knew Hector would be enamoured of his daughter and enchanted by the land she brought with her.

Most of the village had gathered in the Megara by noon. Weddings were communal events in which all the villagers wanted to participate.

Hector had dressed in his finest tunic, freshly cleaned for the occasion, with his sparkling officer's belt around his waist. In accordance with tradition, on this day of peace he did not carry a sword with him, although all knew of his prowess with the weapon.

In accordance with tradition, everybody stood waiting for the bride to come in, accompanied by her parents.

From the back of the crowd, cheering started, and then a gap appeared amongst the villagers and three figures walked through. Xerxes was on the right, and Doris on the left. Between them shuffled a diminuitive figure shrouded in a blanket.

By tradition, the groom would not see his bride until after they were married.

By tradition, Athene - priestess of a Goddess who did not countenance the rite of marriage - was not present. In her place, Hera - the Queen whose marriage ennobled Zeus - officiated at the ceremony that tied together the two aspects - male and female - of the Goddess' creation. As the bride's family came to stand in front of her, and opposite Hector, she intoned the ceremonial words of greeting.

"Today, we celebrate in this village the binding of this woman to this man. In doing so, she passes from the province of the Goddess and her priestesses and passes unto this man, Hector, to be her keeper and protector. From now, he shall be her only man and she will not perform the act of life with any other, and she is excluded from the rituals of the Goddess. He promises to look after her and to work for her benefit and to nurture the land that she brings with her.

"May they have long lives and many children and bring joy and prosperity to this village.

"You may uncover the bride."

Hector walked up to her and took folds of the blanket in both hands. Lifting it up gently, he looked underneath at the woman who was now his wife. What he saw pleased him, and, with a strong flick of his wrists, sent the blanket flying, revealing her to all the villagers.

"You are now man and wife for all eternity."

5. Haloa

"To the river, ye mystics!"

As she spoke those words, Athene led the villagers down to the river for the ritual of purification. Without being pure, they could not truly express their gratitude for all the blessings they had received. And all too well did they know the importance of purity and gratitude: why, without gratitude, would the Goddess continue to bless them with all the bounty they knew every harvest?

The walk to the river was solemn, not joyous: the rite of purification was not a joyous rite, but one in which each individual needed to recognize their own part in the life of the community, for both good and bad. Each man and woman walking down to the river had the opportunity to consider, in private and in detail, every action they had taken over the past year.

Year to year, season to season, life repeated itself: the planting, the waiting, the growth, the harvest, the plenty, the joys of autumn and then back to the time of burial and planting: the new life waiting to spring up as the seasons turned once more.

And their own lives were no different: feasts followed by famines; sex followed by pregnancy followed by birth; the interleaving of peace and war; parents rearing children who in turn became parents rearing yet more children.

And in the same way, the festivals observed the cycle of pollution and purification. Everyday activities led to pollution: from the simple act of dirtying one's hands in the soil to the extreme acts of taking life, life so carefully nurtured by the Goddess. And, of course, there was the metaphorical pollution as well: acts of cruelty and unkindness to fellow villagers. Only through the frequent acts of purification could anyone - male or female - expect to continue in the cycle of life with the Goddess.

Which is why the men of the village accompanied the women down to the river. Ritually prohibited from entering into congress with the Goddess herself, and thus from the full celebration of the Haloa, they were nevertheless included in the ritual of purification which preceded it.

They walked en masse; there was no sense of order or procession to the progress to the river. In some sense, Athene led the way, but it wasn't like there was a single villager who didn't *know* the way to the river, but it was up to each individual to *find* their own way: that was part of the ritual of purification. Finding your own way to the river was a metaphor for finding your own way to the Goddess: each individual was unique, yet formed part of a community. Each life was unique, just like each year was unique, but the pattern remained the same, year upon year, generation upon generation.

Even families did not travel together. As ever, the village collaborated effortlessly to make sure the little ones did not get lost or come to grief, but there was no sense today any more than any other day that a mother or father should be responsible for their children, or that this was a ritual of *family* purification. Each adult sought out their own purification and the children wandered along with the crowd of villagers, thinking less about purification and more about playing on a lovely day out.

And it was a lovely day today. The midsummer heat was starting to fade as they set out with the sun little more than a span above the western horizon. The long summer days brought joy and, now that the harvest had all been gathered in, the hardest of the work was behind them too. This was truly the best time of the year. Anyone who struggled to praise the Goddess on a day like today had real issues.

Athene stripped off at the riverside and walked in to the water.

It simply wasn't possible to purify their clothing and nobody would want those impurities dragging them down as they tried to purify themselves for the Goddess. Athene - as the chosen of the Goddess, leading the women in her worship - would remain naked for the rest of the festival. Others would follow her example - the junior priestesses, devoted to the worship of the Goddess, of course - while any married women who wished could dress again if they chose - in new or freshly cleaned garments, of course. The men, excluded from the ceremony, would generally don a clean loincloth for the walk back to the megara.

Athene immersed herself in the waters, covering herself in the gift of the Goddess, purifying every inch of her body. On the inside, she focused entirely on the bounty of the Goddess and the joy that came from being her representative on earth. As she felt the waters wash over and through her, she felt the release from all the pollution that had accreted to her over the past year.

Hera followed Athene into the water. Although married to Zeus, she would also remain naked for the evening's festivities. Only naked did she ever feel truly close to the Goddess, in the same way that only naked did she ever feel truly close to Zeus. She often wondered what it would be like to be Athene, bound not to a man of this earth, with a man's thoughts and desires, but bound rather to the Goddess, ethereal and remote. But now she sank down into the river, choosing to immerse herself in the shallower waters, rather than walking out into the deep waters of midriver.

Slowly, all the villagers followed the two women in. A mixture of men and women, all of them stripped off on the riverbank, metaphorically stripping off their impurities and then stepping into the river of life. Some walked into the middle of the river until the waters covered them; some sank down in the shallow waters; and others swam into the river and dived down to the bottom. What *you* did mattered little; the important thing was to partake in the purification that came from the Goddess, offered by the river.

As they felt themselves washed free of pollution, the villagers came back out of the river and stood, dripping but drying in what was left of the evening sun. There were no rules as to how long you had to stay in the water: each stayed according to their own sense of the ongoing purification. Athene stayed a long while in the middle of the river, floating up to breathe and then allowing herself to sink back down, once more to commune with the Goddess who ruled her life. But even she eventually moved back to the bank and walked out.

As the sun finally set in the west, all of the villagers turned to face the orange disc and say the ritual prayer of purification:

Thank you for our lives
Thank you for our year
Thank you for the bounty you give us
Thank you for the peace you bring

Now we are cleansed
Now we are pure
Now we can give thanks
As the year turns over

And as the sun sank below the horizon, the villagers turned the other way, to face east, and to see the silver disc of the moon rising behind them.

We give thanks for your constancy
We give thanks for your mercy
We give thanks for your care
We give thanks for your bounty

And then, as one, they turned and walked back to the village.

The return trip had more the feel of a procession.

The women led the way; the inferiors - men and children both - followed behind, since they were excluded from what would follow. Athene and Hera led from the front, and the women tended to bunch up in groups behind them - the priestesses together, staying close to Athene; family groups together closer to Hera. And they walked with more determination now: this was not a wandering to the river weighed down by pollution, but a march to an appointment with the Goddess, cleansed and pure.

As they arrived at the Megara, Athene stood poised, with her arms outstretched, communing with the Goddess. The others arrived in turn and formed up behind her. Then she turned and face the villagers.

"All have now been through the ritual of purification. Those who feel themselves pure may now enter in the hall of offering. Those others may now leave."

None of the women left; the men and the children moved away to go and camp for the night in the fields, away from the luxuries and pollution of the village, and to be as close to the Goddess as their poor forms could manage.

Athene turned again and led the women into the Megara.

The tables had been laid out earlier in the day, before the ritual of purification. All of the first fruits were here: cereals and fruits: figs, grapes and nuts. Across all the tables was a lavish spread.

Athene spread her arms and gave obeisance to the Goddess

Oh, Goddess, we share with you
All that you have first given us
Knowing that we are pure and ready
And that you have our ever gratitude

And with that, the women laid into the feast, a feast that would last all night.

6. Titans

A week later, as the moon shrank to a half, Zeus led the men out to hunt.

As the sun set, they gathered in the fields west of the village to honour the Sun as it fell. Then they turned to the east, watching the stars turn overhead as they waited for the moon to rise. As it rose, they stood, then fell on their knees in reverence.

> *Oh, moon, we see your face!*
> *Oh, moon, we hear your voice!*
> *Oh, moon, grant us good hunting!*
> *Oh, moon, watch over us!*

And then, with the pale silver light of the half moon, Zeus led his band of warriors northwards into the forests.

Here was the traditional power of men. Here, away from the village and the power of the Goddess, men could find themselves and know that they, too, had a place in the world. The Goddess had corrupted the natural order of things: this planting of seeds, the management of fields, the watering and nurturing of plants, all this Zeus and his men knew to be unnatural. In the natural order of things there were men and beasts: there were the weak and the strong. The strong took what they wanted - and the weak died. Zeus knew in his very bones that this was the case.

But in the village, all the men felt weak. And they did not want to be weak.

So, not in secret but also not in the open, they carried on their communion with the Titans. Not a secret society, but an inner cadre of the chosen, they crept out of the village at night, always at the final quarter of the moon, to hunt and to celebrate the rites of the Titans.

Who were the Titans? Zeus did not know. He knew what his father had told him, which *his* father had told him, which *he* had had from some of his ancestors, men all: that once, they had lived in the mountains, far to the north, and life had been different there. In the north, it was cold, and Goddess did not like the cold, so she did not go there. In the north, man needed fire to keep warm, and there were Titans who managed the fire. Some of them had mountains that were alive in fire, and they forged bronze under their mountains and made weapons and armour like nothing else that had been seen in the world. And they shared their fire and food and weapons with any man who would acknowledge their strength and power and share with them.

So even here, in the south, where the Goddess reigned supreme and without equal, Zeus and his fellow hunters and warriors still kept up the rituals of communion with the Titans. Who were they? Zeus did not know, but he knew they had power and they loved men - not women. And that was enough for Zeus - and all his companions - needed to know in order to leave their homes for the night and go hunting and feasting.

Apollo was the first to see the boar.

It had finished eating and drinking - probably hours before - and had nestled into a thicket a bowshot away from the lake where it had no doubt been drinking the evening before. An obvious hiding place, and they had followed its tracks away from the lake.

A few glimmers of moonlight shone down here and there through the forest, but their eyes had all long since adapted to the gloom. Zeus had to admit that Apollo had very sharp eyesight in order to be able to spot the boar in the middle of those bushes - a black animal hidden in a dark place with almost no light to see by.

The crouched down while the others gathered around, looking for the boar; most of them not seeing it, but knowing that it must be there, in front of them, where Zeus and Apollo were looking so intently.

They had done this together many times before; they worked and trained together in the army; they had planned and discussed this on the march up here; in short, they knew what they were doing. When they were all squatting in a small group behind Zeus and Apollo, Zeus turned and tapped each on the shoulder and indicated what he wanted them to do. Quickly, effortlessly and most importantly silently, the hunters spread out around the thicket.

Time passed.

The angle of the moonlight slowly shifted as they waited, knowing that it was critical for everyone to be in place before anything started to happen. Suddenly the stillness of the night was broken by the distinctive call of a grebe. Zeus smiled. The boar might just think it was a bird on the lake, but he knew the intonation that told him that Deiophobos was responsible for the bird call. He was ready, and since he had gone the furthest, everyone else should be ready. If nobody made an answering bird call, Deiophobos would charge the boar in a few dozen heartbeats.

The time dragged. Zeus and Apollo were alert and ready, their spears facing forward, expecting the boar to break free of the thicket and charge in their direction - away from the attack. Remaining alert - listening for every little sound in the almost pitch black - for an extended period was wearing, but their adrenaline was fired up and they were ready.

Suddenly, there was a clattering on the far side of the thicket as Deiophobos launched into action. Shortly after him, two or three of the others followed suit and came charging towards the thicket, intentionally making all the noise they could manage. The time for silence and stealth had gone for them and their only thought was to stampeded the bull into flight - ideally away from them and towards the silent part of the forest - where Zeus and Apollo waited with spears planted.

From the thicket they heard a grunting, then the noise of the boar starting to move. It stood, listening and sniffing the air. It was too wise and experienced to just charge off mindlessly - it wanted to know what was out there first. But Deiophobos kept the pressure on, coming from upwind and making as much noise as he could. When we was close enough, he threw his spear into the thicket, striking the boar a glancing blow.

Anyone who trained with the army knew that a thrown spear was almost never going to cause a serious injury. If you wanted to hurt someone with a spear - even one with a very sharp bronze point - you had to move up close and personal, plant your feet and thrust with all of your strength - or theirs. But thrown spears had one key benefit - in battle or in the hunt: it takes a great deal of discipline to be on the receiving end and know that you can almost always just "bat away" a spear. Everybody else - and all animals - will sense they are under attack and flee.

The boar abandoned caution, turned and fled out of the thicket, away from the noise, the stench of *human* and the violence of a thrown spear. It charged out into the relatively open forest and through patches of moonlight. As it did so, it saw something glinting ahead: it did not know what it saw, but one thing went through its animal brain: *danger*.

Zeus and Apollo were ready, waiting to take the onrushing boar on their spears, planted in the ground to give maximum resistance and to allow the boar to simply kill itself rushing onto them. This was the "pure" kill, the one that showed that the Titans favoured this hunt; that they themselves wanted to partake of its flesh.

At the last moment, it turned. While it did not know what the spears *were*, it knew that danger lay that way and turned sharply right, just in time. As it did so, one of its hind legs flicked out, kicking at Apollo's spear and cutting itself on the flank. Now irritated beyond measure, it found its feet and charged forwards, across the line of waiting spearmen - the worst possible outcome for the hunters.

Zeus and Apollo responded immediately. Grasping their spears, they pulled them out of the ground and turned and charged after the boar. Zeus was on it in a flash and drove his spear with all his strength into its rump. On the other side, Apollo thrust his spear into the boar's flank. Neither blow was mortal; moreover the boar was no longer charging directly at any of the other men. A chase was now inevitable.

Memnon reacted too slowly. Further down the line, he had the time to prepare: move his spear and replant it in the line of the boar. But he was caught in indecision: should he try and kill the boar or should he flee and then chase? By the time he had decided, the boar was on him, kicking his spear away and trampling over Memnon without a thought. Flung on his back, the boar's left hind leg caught him full in the chest, planting its whole weight on him as it pushed off, crushing his chest. His life flowed out of him as he gasped for breath, the blood flowing onto the ground.

It was nearly dawn by the time they had dragged the dead boar out of the forest onto the plain.

Once the boar had been caught and killed, they had divided into two groups: a smaller group had set to with axes, chopping and collecting firewood. The larger group had gathered around the boar, dragging it and at times carrying it out of the forest. By the time they arrived at the prepared site, the fire was already roaring. Quickly some of the men went to work, cutting and dressing the boar. The choicest cuts, along with the heart and blood, were dedicated to the Titans. Set to one side, they would be the first offerings when the sun rose from his slumbers and showed his face. In this southern land, the Sun was almost the only reminder of the fire they held in their ancestral memories.

As the sky to the east became light, everything was finally ready. The men drew up in a half circle behind their fire, facing east. With the hunting moon directly overhead, the Sun boiled up over the horizon and they greeted it warmly. It was time for the feast to begin!

To you, O Sun, ball of fire!
To you, Titans of Sky and Air!
To you, Titans of Fire!
To you, Titans who Rule the Sky!

We welcome you to our Feast!
We welcome you in our Hearts!
Eat, Drink and be Merry!
Join us for our Revels!

"Dionysus! Give the Titans a drink!" Dionysus came forward with an amphora filled with that nectar of the Gods - wine - and poured it into the flames. The flames drank it up with an audible relish.

"Apollo! Feed the Titans!" Apollo stepped forward and cast the heart and the entrails of the boar into the fire and watched them be consumed.

"Give the Strength of this boar to the Titans," Zeus shouted the third time, and then stepped forward, picking up the cup containing the boar's blood. With reverence, he poured it onto the fire.

Bowing before the fire, with the Sun illuminating it from behind, Zeus spread his hands wide in homage.

"We have given you drink, O Titans! We have given you meat, O Titans! We have given you the strength of a boar, O Titans! Now come down and join us in this feast."

The men set up the spit over the fire and began to roast the carcass of the boar. As they did so, Dionysus went around, giving each man a cup of wine to drink.

It was good to hunt, thought Zeus, feeling the spirit of the Titans waft through him. This was what it meant to be a *man*.

7. Battle

Zeus was grateful for the opportunity to rest.

Since the messenger had arrived in the middle of the night, Zeus and his soldiers had had to gather their equipment together and then run the length of more than thirty furrows - mainly in the dark - in the hope of being here before the attack started, which Zeus had assumed would be at dawn. The sun was now two palms high in the sky but he had not seen any attackers. His scouts were out in the direction the messenger had indicated, but he had not heard any of their bird calls either.

Had the messenger been wrong?

Or worse, had the messenger been a deliberate plant, causing Zeus and his finest warriors to rush over to defend this village while an enemy - a cunning, clever enemy at that - circled around behind them and attacked their own village? If that was what had happened - and he ever found out who was responsible - heads would roll. Hopefully, if his own village were under attack, the villagers who he'd left behind would be able to resist them while a messenger came and found him here. They'd have to run all the way back in the heat of the day, of course, but hopefully they would be able to attack the enemy from behind.

He looked around, trying to make an enemy army appear out of the rocky landscape. Still nothing. Although it was very unlikely he would be able to see anything if none of his scouts had called out yet. But he knew the importance of being alert. If you didn't stay alert, there was a risk that you would fall asleep, particularly if you had been up all night as they had.

The downside of having other villages under his control, he reflected. When you said, "pay us tribute and we'll defend you" you did, in fact, have to turn up when they said "we are under attack". Even if, as in this instance, there appeared to be no attack in progress. Had the attackers decided better of it? Did they find out that a messenger had been sent to fetch him and run away in fear?

The time kept ticking, the sun climbed higher in the sky and the day became hot when an egret hooted mournfully. Zeus waited and then heard it again, slightly further to the west. He turned his gaze that way but still saw nothing. Not even an egret. Because, of course, there wasn't one out there. Not that far from water. One of his scouts had obviously spotted something. Already alert, Zeus tensed, reaching for his spear. Around him he could hear his two hands gathering themselves. As yet, they knew nothing of what was out there, but they believed that it was coming.

Zeus told himself to relax and settle in to wait.

The sun had risen another three fingers before Zeus finally spotted the dust that indicated the path of the advancing forces. Even further west than he had thought. Once the original signal had been given, the scouts were not supposed to give further signals unless "something happened". The enemy circling the village rather than coming straight in would not be enough for that strict rule to be overruled.

He watched as the dust plume moved to his right, still circling the village. Not a bad tactic, he presumed, trying to catch them off balance, but it really did require them to either do it more quickly with a little dust or do it at this speed with no dust. He had run all the way from his own village in the amount of time they had spent deploying this morning. Again, he asked himself if he was missing something.

Suddenly, the morning calm was broken as screaming and shrieking broke out from where the dust cloud was and three or four hands of men came charging at the village, following a route that went west and north of him. Did they know he was here? Was this all their force, or did they have more men in reserve? Or possibly about to attack somewhere else? All the possibilities and all the wrong choices flashed through his mind, along with his own dispositions. Apollo's two hands were much closer to these foreigners, but would be outnumbered. Should he go in support, or should he wait to see what developed? The other squads were scattered around the village: how would they react?

None of his other scouts had reported any sightings, but surely nobody would be so foolish as to attack a village with such small numbers. Decide, Zeus, decide! The whole outcome of this battle depends on what you decide now.

From his left he heard the repeated honking of a goose. Well, several geese in fact. Turning his attention that way, he saw another plume of dust coming towards him. Apollo would have to make do, or find one of the other squads to help him out. This group was coming almost straight at him, just slightly to his left. They would pass within an easy bowshot, maybe even a good spearcast. He watched a moment more and then turned to his men.

In total silence, he indicated to them what he wanted done: the bowmen were to wait at the rear, stand and start pumping their arrows into the enemy on his signal. They were not to leave the culvert where they were hiding until they had fired all their arrows. The others were to follow him out when he charged, bringing spears and swords to the party.

As the enemy came closer, he saw two of his scouts jump up and start chasing after them. So they had not spotted his scouts then. Unsurprising: they didn't seem to have any scouts or outrunners of their own. Now that they were closer, he could count them, after a fashion. He would need more than his own two hands to count all of them, but he wouldn't think there were more than four. So about two men for each one of his. But he had the element of surprise. Assuming they didn't see them down here before they drew close.

Zeus felt himself tensing again, but this time he knew that it was time. He was ready to give the bowmen their signal - a jerking of his spear - and then as the first couple of volleys struck home, to lead the charge amongst the confusion as they tried to turn, rally and understand the situation. Hopefully they could bring two or three of them down before they even knew they were fighting.

Another few heartbeats ... just a couple more ... yes! He jerked his spear forward, and *felt* the bowmen behind him jump up and start firing their arrows. As they launched the second volley, he heard the *thunk* as the first arrows hit. That was his signal: they knew something was up now, so it was time to charge.

Jumping up, he ran forward without even checking whether his men were obeying orders. He didn't need to: he knew they would be. They would follow him out of habit and instinct. He crossed the twenty or thirty strides in a few heartbeats, but felt that slowing of time that always came on him when the battles began. In slow motion he saw the men in front of him, sorting out the dangerous from the weak, saw who was paying attention and who was not. The man in front of him suddenly had an arrow in his leg - one of the arrows from the third volley had struck him. Momentarily distracted, he looked at his leg rather than Zeus: all the encouragement Zeus needed. He leant all of the weight of his charge into his spear and thrust it through the man's neck. Blood spurted everywhere and the man fell backwards, taking Zeus' spear with him.

Pulling his sword from his belt, he swivelled to the right, facing a man who was still running; hadn't understood yet that they were under attack. *A weakling*, thought Zeus, using the man's own momentum to drive him onto his sword. The man fell and died without even drawing his sword. Zeus stood on the body and pulled his sword back.

There were no more easy victims. The men still standing around them were aware they were under attack and defending themselves. Zeus felt he was still outnumbered, but the bowmen might be making up for that. *As long as they didn't hit their own men*, he reflected.

The next man he faced crossed swords with him. Left, right, step, twirl. This man was good, thought Zeus, embracing the mystery of the duel, the hypersensation that went with battle, the peripheral awareness that another man was striking at him from the side that enabled him to jump aside and defend himself from that sudden attack. He drove that man back, snapping his sword, before turning back to his original opponent. He laughed out loud at the joy of it all. If these turned out to be his last minutes on earth, at least he would enjoy them.

And then, suddenly it was over. The man opposite him threw down his sword, and fell to his knees, admitting defeat. Looking around, Zeus saw that the other men had too. Only a hand and a half remained fit, while Zeus had only lost one man. Surprise had won out over the numbers.

The fight might be over, but the battle was not. Leaving three men to deal with this fight, he took the others off to help Apollo.

As if Apollo needed help. By the time they were halfway there, they found Apollo and a hand of his men running towards them - to help *them*. Zeus stopped and bent double with laughter. This had been too easy. Was it all a feint for another attack? Zeus didn't think so. But even if it were, they had so thoroughly blunted this one that they could deter another attack just by threatening to kill the men they had captured.

Once they had cleared up the battlefield, they sat the men they had captured down on the ground. As honoured guests.

Apollo had sent to the village for one of their "domesticated" pigs. A victory like this required a celebration, and the only meaningful celebration was to make a meat offering to the Titans of Victory and to share what was left with the survivors. Only in this way could the victors truly display their greatness - by sharing the fruits of sacrifice with their defeated enemies.

The fire was soon crackling, and Apollo was given the task of killing and eviscerating the pig. The ritual required the execution to be done with one of the swords captured from the enemy. He examined the swords lying in the trophy pile and found one that pleased him. Picking it up and taking a few exploratory swings, he found the right balance point and approached the pig. Walking up to it, he put his arm around its neck and pulled it close. As he held it with his left arm, he used his right to plunge the sword into and through its neck. As he started dragging the blade back, the pig flinched and let out a squeal; a squeal that was quickly drowned in the gush of blood erupting from its throat and mouth. Its whole body jerked and shook as the life drained from the pig as its blood pumped out. Nevertheless, Apollo held it tight as it thrashed and did not let it escape or run around. Once it had settled, he turned it over and began dressing it for the fire. Applause broke out: it was the mark of a skilled warrior how well they could slaughter a pig or boar like this.

Once he had finished carving up the pig, Zeus came forward and picked up a cup he had filled with wine. He poured the wine into the flames, causing a whoosh as the alcohol ignited. "O Titans, we thank you for our victory. Know that our foes were brave and valiant."

Apollo approached the fire, still holding the bloody sword. Reaching forward, he placed it among the flames: "O Titans, in proof of their bravery, we give unto you their swords." Several among the soldiers came forward, took swords from the trophy and placed them in the fire. By doing so, they were giving away vast wealth - a bronze sword, even if damaged, was a valuable item: hours of effort would have gone into mining and preparing the bronze, let alone turning the raw bronze into a weapon suitable for combat. If nothing else, it would make sense to take this bronze back for Haepheastus to turn into new weapons.

But it made no sense to cheat the Titans of their spoils.

As the pig continued to roast, each man, led by Zeus, came forward to take portions of the entrails or blood and place it on the fire. No man might eat blood; the life-force of the animal belonged to the Goddess, and she only accepted blood through the intervention of the Titans. Even the defeated soldiers offered to the Titans, even though they might have had reason to feel the Titans had not helped them this day.

Although as they looked around, they knew the Titans had been there for them this day: many of their comrades had died this day, their blood spilt on the ground as the pig's had been by Apollo. Theirs might have been there too, draining into the dry soil tonight before their bodies where burned on the trophy at dawn. Instead, they would feast with their conquerors tonight, and then face the choice in the morning.

As they meat sizzled, ready to eat, Zeus and Apollo handed around cups of wine. "Let us drink to the Titans and to those who died today," said Zeus. Each of them drank a third of the cup of wine. "Let us drink to those who lived today," said Apollo. Each of them drank another third. "And let us also drink to those who could not be here today," said Zeus, remembering those of the army and village who could not participate. They drained their cups.

"And now, let us eat, drink and celebrate our life," shouted Zeus. "Let no man want for wine or meat!" And with that, the men by the fire starting hacking at the pig with their swords.

By dawn, all of the dead had been piled high on the trophy of swords.

From time to time during the night, a survivor of the attacking army had taken one of Zeus' men with him, found a comrade who had died in the assault, and asked help carrying it to the trophy, and dressing and arranging the body for his final journey - to meet, and hopefully to join, the Titans. Every warrior hoped to be worthy of that ultimate accolade when he died, and now, as they placed the bodies reverently on the trophy, they spoke the words that they believed would earn them that right - reciting their valiant acts and ending with the *epitaph* - the ultimate summary of their greatness.

With only three dead on their side, Zeus and Apollo carried all three. Not between them of course - that would not have done them honour - but with chosen members of valour from among the attacking army.

The living were now separated from the dead: the dead in a pile, the men in a line facing the horizon where the sun would soon rise. The fire had been fed during the night, but now had largely died down. Two long branches had been placed in the fire to start burning, and kindling had been placed in the trophy to make it easy to burn.

As the sun rose above the horizon, all the men watched, then bowed. Zeus walked to the fire and pulled out one of the long branches and placed in on the trophy, lighting the kindling. The leader of the attackers took the other branch and did the same thing.

As they stood between the flaming sun and the burning trophy, they stood in the "land between" - the land between the life of the sun and the death of the Titans. And now it was time for the living to choose.

"You know the ritual," said Zeus to the men left alive from the attacking army. "There are two doors to follow. You may go east, to the rising sun, and return to the lives that you led before. If you choose to do that, you must go, knowing that you were defeated in battle by men who were greater, and you will be diminished in the eyes of the Titans. But you know that you have life, and that those of you who have wives and children can be returned to them in the way that the dead cannot.

"Or you can choose death. By choosing the path of death, you say that you know that, having been beaten in battle by greater men, the path of honour is to join those greater men, and live what life you will have in their service, denying your former life because you died here. But you will be enhanced in the eyes of the Titans, as you will have sworn to forgo all other ties in the pursuit of greatness and heroism.

"This is not a choice I or anyone else can force on you: it is up to each man to decide whether he is a Hero or a Family Man. There is no disgrace in either choice. Here you will not have a family; there you will never be able to be sure if you should still be alive. Here you will have the opportunity to display your bravery and heroism; there you will be able to show your love and dedication.

"Now Choose!"

He stepped towards the rising sun, joining one of his soldiers in holding a spear at waist height. To choose life and return home, a man had to walk towards the sun and pass underneath the spear of life.

Apollo moved the other way, holding a branch of an olive tree shoulder high with another soldier. Any wishing to choose death and begin a new life in this village as a dependent warrior of the village, allowed to fight but denied women and family, had to walk towards the burning trophy of the men who died while they lived and accept that there lay their ultimate fate.

It was for each man to choose his own destiny. And, at that moment of choosing, every man knew whether he was a warrior or not: did he wish he had died with those others or, when the chips were down, would he rather live in a village without sword or spear, but with his wife and children?

As Zeus said, there were not right or wrong choices, *per se*: but each individual knew his own character.

8. Oschophoria

"The vines have brought in their bounty, now, Wife. It is more than a moon since the firstfruits. It is high time we celebrated the Oschophoria."

Hera looked at him sullenly. "Of all the festivals, that is my least favourite," she replied. "I do not feel that it sufficiently honours the Goddess."

"So, woman?" snapped Zeus. "You have your festivals to honour the Goddess."

"And you have your hunts and sacrifices to the Titans," she retorted. "Don't pretend you don't. Do you need another festival of drinking and eating?"

"You know as well as I do that the Oschophoria celebrates the harvest of the vine," he responded slowly. "There is no eating. Well, except grapes."

"Which just makes all of you more drunk," sighed Hera. "But I suppose if we must, we must. We must express our gratitude for the vine harvest. Just don't make me come."

"But you and Athene have to be there - you must cut and bear the vine branches!"

"Are there any still heavy with grapes?"

"A few, but *only* a few: that is why I say it is *high time* we celebrated the Oschophoria. And you and Athene must be there to bear the vines from the Goddess to Dionysius. And Athene must be there to award the prizes."

"To *be* the prize, I rather think you mean. At least I know you can't win."

He smirked at her: "Any time you want, any time at all. Just say the word."

The procession began in the vineyard.

Athene acknowledged the gifts of the Goddess, and that she was taking more than the fruit here - she was taking two whole branches of the vine. Even though they would be pruning the vines soon, that was not the same: that was done *for* the vine, which could not prune itself, ordained by the Goddess and shown in the healthiness of the vine in years to come. On the contrary, this was simple theft - taking what was growing, and thus belonged to the Goddess, away from her and giving it to Dionysius on the grounds that he represented some legend that his ancestors had brought the vine from somewhere to the north.

A likely story, thought Athene, once again. All that the men had brought from the north was violence and destruction into what had once been a peaceful and loving land. Even as she communed with the Goddess, she knew her power was waning. Once she had reigned supreme and mere men had had no say in her counsels. Now, that was changing and she often thought Zeus had more power in the village than Hera. It was the tribute that did it, of course: by having other villages in submission to them - to *him*, in all truth - the power of Hera, Athene and the Goddess, drawn just from this one villaged, diminished. She could sense the power in the man and knew her Goddess did too.

The violence she was about to commit against her own Goddess spoke of the imbalance of power in the village.

She took the ritual sickle in her left hand and grasped a branch near the base of the bush in her right. The ritual of destruction against a worthy vine required her to use her left hand: if she wielded the sickle with her right hand, she would declare the vine unworthy or diseased: a crime against nature. She could not do that.

With three sharp strokes, the branch came away in her hand. She turned and, bowing, passed it to Hera. Hera carefully accepted it, and placed it over her shoulder gently, ensuring she didn't damage any of the grapes or lesser branches.

Athene turned back to the vine and selected another branch. Again grasping it with her right hand, she slashed the sickle twice and the branch came away. Turning to her acolyte, she passed the sickle, then carefully lifted the branch onto her left shoulder.

Turning, Hera and Athene left the vineyard, the poor, abused vine weeping for its lost branches. Truly, the practices of these men who had conquered them were barbaric. But none could deny they had the power.

Dionysius was waiting for them outside the Megara.

Inside, everything had been set up for the drinking and the games. Two tables had been prepared in the centre of the dais for the branches. Hera went to the right and laid hers there; Athene laid hers on the table on the left. Then the two of them knelt in front of their respective tables. In one sense, the vines now "belonged" to Dionysius; but no man could take any grapes from them for himself. They had to wait for Athene's approval: then take them from her hand.

Meanwhile, Zeus did what Zeus did best: organized the men.

The first event was sword combat to first blood. Sometimes things went wrong and men could be injured - even killed - although it was hard enough to kill a man when you were trying, and in these games *trying* to kill your opponent was more likely to end up with Zeus thrusting his sword through *your* back.

The first duel was between Hector and Achilles. If he won here, Hector would probably be an officer by the end of the year. Face facts, Zeus told himself, he would probably be an officer within a year whatever happened. Achilles, now, thought Zeus.

Bravery had its place in the army. You couldn't go into battle without courage, but at the same time, there were so many other attributes you needed. Strength, discipline, coordination, height, speed. Yes, Achilles had all of those as well, in vast quantities, thought Zeus. But you also needed obedience and respect as well as a sense of teamwork. And Achilles had none of those: he was one who must be obeyed. And that, thought Zeus, could cause *him* a problem soon: come the New Year, Achilles could easily be challenging him for the leadership of the village, especially if he won here. And if he could beat Hector, he could quite possibly beat Zeus. Still, the will of the Goddess and all that. Zeus settled in to watch the bout with care. Both men knew the other well, and often drilled together. They were well-matched, if very different in style.

Zeus indicated the horn should be blown. When it blew again, both combatants had to stop fighting *at once*. Carrying on, even just one last blow, could be lethal.

The moment the horn sounded, Achilles leapt forward from his starting position and jumped to the attack. Zeus had expected this, and so had Hector who moved forward and slightly to the left to give himself some space and position himself for the onslaught. Achilles attacked with a three-blow combination which Hector easily deflected. His parries were true and in time and was then able to snap off a chanced blow at Achilles' shoulder which was easily parried in turn.

Achilles did not let up. He launched another combination, trying to force Hector backwards and find a way through his elegant parries. Hector continued moving left, eventually managing to get his back to the open space in the centre of the Megara. He allowed Achilles to rain blows on him, slowly working his way backwards, always forcing Achilles to reach further to land his next blow.

Suddenly he moved forward and lunged inside Achilles' reach. A desperate turn and downswing effected a parry without injury, but Achilles knew the move had outfoxed him and he jumped backwards. Hector now launched an attack of his own, a flurry of blows forcing Achilles back.

Hector swung a backhand blow straight into Achilles' parry. As the swords came together, Hector's sword shattered and pieces flew everywhere. As Hector raised his hands in defeat, Achilles flicked his sword out to lay a cut across Hector's chest. And then laughed at him.

Zeus was outraged. This was a desecration of the noble fight. But what could he do?

"I declare Achilles the winner and Hector's bronze sword the loser," he quickly declared. "A good fight, well fought. Now hold hands and congratulate each other."

As they bowed their heads, Athene placed a crown of laurel on Achilles' head, and handed him a bunch of grapes.

Nobody noticed as Hector slipped out shortly afterwards. Inside he was fuming. He would have his revenge on Achilles, he swore. But how?

The wine continued to flow.

By now, most of the men were incapacitated by drink, but fortuately the trials with weapons were long over. The feats of strength - lifting and wrestling - had now ended too, and only the trials of speed were left. Only the final trial remained: considered the ultimate - for no reason Zeus could fathom. Pairs of cadets had been running the length of the Megara as fast as they could. As each contest concluded, one of the cadets was handed a bunch of grapes in consolation and went to sit down. The winners proceeded to the next round. Now only two cadets remained. Polyxius and Heradenus lined up on the start line. For some reason, this seemed to matter more than the previous rounds - maybe because the ultimate prize was within touching distance. Literally.

The horn sounded on Zeus' signal and both men set off across the Megara. Each had already won three contests and they were closely matched. As they sprinted across the floor, it was hard to tell who was winning. At the finish line, painted white on the Megara floor, Apollo was sitting, given the difficult task of adjudicating. When he signalled, it was to indicate that Polyxius had won by a hair.

Both of them walked up to the dais and bowed low before Athene. Taking the last bunch of grapes from the vine, she offered them to Heradenus. Taking them, he went and sat down with the other cadets. Now we entered the time-honoured ritual which represented the pinnacle of the evening.

"I have no more grapes to offer you," intoned Athene.

"Does the vine have no more?" asked Polyxius.

"No," responded Athene. "There will be no more until the Goddess grants next year."

"Can you be sure of her bounty?" asked Polyxius, the ritual words dripping from him. "Can we be sure the vine will remember to flower and give us fruit?"

"I have faith in the Goddess," responded Athene, "but I am sure that she would approve us showing nature that we understand the workings of bounty."

And she unfastened the shoulder straps of her dress and let it fall to the ground. Reaching forward, she removed Polyxius' loincloth to find him already hard beneath.

"The Goddess truly is good," she murmured into his ear as she pushed him backwards and straddled him, honouring the Goddess in the traditional manner.

9. Rape

Iphigenia was tending to her fields.

The harvest had all come in, the subble had all been burnt, and now it was the time of year to prepare the fields for planting. Since her marriage, Doris had granted her two of her lesser fields, and she looked after them as her own. She had ceased having her monthly moons three moons ago, and now was sure that along with her crops in the spring, she would be harvesting a baby.

And that made her think of Nestor.

The nights that they spent together, her in his arms as he first held her, then massaged her, then aroused her, then entered her. She felt herself going weak at the thought of it as she tried to focus on the task at hand: hoeing through the soil, breaking up what roots remained from the summer crop and turn all the goodness over. The ritual of planting was one whose mantras she had learnt as a child, and now she applied to grow her own crops on her own land.

Each field attached to the village had to be turned over; Zeus and Hera allocated workers from the general pool to assist those who, like Doris and Iphigenia, owned the land in the village. Men, of course, could not own land although married men often worked their wives' land, and then there were many women who owned nothing. Athene - along with her priestesses - were still the largest owners of land, and they all worked exclusively on their own land. All in all, it was a mess, Iphi thought. Surely there was an easier way of organizing everything. No wonder Zeus always seemed irritated with the responsibility.

Today, Iphigenia had been assigned Achilles' crew of eight men, and of course her husband was here as well. The men, being men, were lazy. Iphi knew the importance of breaking up the soil and knew that the prosperity of her field depended as much on how well they did their work here as it did on anything else. But the men? They were here today, and then off doing something else tomorrow. All they were really interested in was fighting and the festivals where they could have sex with the priestesses.

She tugged hard on the hoe, pulling at something deep under the soil. Eventually it came loose, and a stone came to the surface. She picked it up with her left hand and tossed it onto a pile off to her left. It seemed that the ground grew stones in the same way that the baby was growing in her belly. But it made no sense - stones were not alive.

She put her hoe back in the ground and pulled, hard.

They ate the midday meal under the shade of an olive tree.

They had the usual midday fare: some olives and grapes, a few corncakes and some nuts. They had a little wine mixed with water to drink. This was not a banquet or a feast; it was just enough to give them some nourishment while they rested during the heat of the day.

"And it's just as well it's not a banquet, right, Hector?" taunted Achilles. "I mean, if it were a feast, we'd probably have games afterwards, and I'd thrash your skinny hide. Again."

Hector looked dismissively at him. He was here to work and prepare his wife's fields for the next planting. It was no real loss to Achilles if they spent all afternoon fighting or messing around - it wouldn't be his wife and child that would lose out. Better to avoid the subject and focus on the tasks in hand.

"It is pleasant to rest a while," he replied diplomatically. "But we will need all our strength to finish this field this afternoon."

"You might," replied Achilles. "But I could thrash you, finish this field and then service your wife with energy left to spare."

An insult like that was hard to bear, but Achilles could be like that. Hector decided he only had two options: he could challenge Achilles or he could move on. He felt that while he had lost to Achilles in the sword fight before, he could easily best him in a fair fight - particularly if there was a grudge attached to it. But Achilles had the backing of his gang here, and that meant a fair fight was unlucky. Better to go back to work and deal with Achilles another way - perhaps during training.

He stood up, picked up his hoe and went back to work. The others, grudgingly, followed.

Iphigenia was relieved. She might need Achilles' gang to prepare her field, but she didn't like - or trust - him at all.

"You don't seem to be working today, Hector," said Achilles.

Hector turned to face him. He was going with Iphi to help her mother with the final preparations before planting began with the new moon tomorrow night. It might seem to Achilles that that was not working, but he still had most of a day's work ahead of him.

"I'm going to Doris' fields to prepare them," he responded as politely as he could manage. "You're welcome to come and help if you aren't on a work detail."

"I have more important things to do," Achilles replied. A pause hung in the air, expectant. "Like settling a score with a coward."

"I am not a coward, Achilles, and we have no cause to fight."

"Well, in that case, let me have a go with your wife, Hector."

Hector was shocked. Even for Achilles, such brashness and coarseness was unexpected. To belittle any woman like that was abomination, but to say so *to her husband*?

"Are you drunk, Achilles?"

"No, I don't need to be drunk to face you, Hector. Fight me or be known as craven. I don't even have my friends with me today, if that's what you're scared of. Just me and you: fight for your wife. Or don't. But I intend to have her before this day is through."

That was too much for Hector. In spite of his best intentions, he threw a punch at Achilles. In short order, they were wrestling on the ground. Both men were big and strong, although dwarfed by giants like Hercules.

"Stop! Stop! Stop!" screamed Iphi. What had got into these men? Did Hector not know there was work to be done? Surely they could practise being soldiers when they were on duty?

Achilles picked up Hector's head and bumped it to the ground. It smacked into the flat of a stone and Hector passed out and lay there, motionless.

"You've killed him! You've killed him!" shrieked Iphi.

"No, he's still breathing," said Achilles. "But you are still mine. Come here." And he reached out with his left hand and pulled her towards him, standing up at the same time. Unsurprisingly, her dress tore and came away in his hand, leaving her standing there, naked. "Very nice," said Achilles, taking hold of her again.

Doris and Hercules came running when they heard the screams.

Hercules took in the scene with a single glance. Knowing the man as he did, he quickly - and correctly - figured out what must have transpired here. With a single hand, he lifted Achilles off Iphigenia and held him upright as other men might hold a small animal.

"What were you thinking?" he bellowed, using his free hand to slap Achilles around the face. "Last time I checked, Iphigenia was not your wife. I think," he said, peering around ostentatiously, "that if anyone should have his dick inside her at this time of day, it would be that man there, not you. And then I think she might be screaming in pleasure, not fear, don't *you*, Achilles?"

Saying that, he let go. Cat-quick, Achilles balanced himself on his feet and came up in a fighter's crouch.

Hercules laughed. "Oh, come off it, Achilles. Do you want to die? Are you seriously challenging me?"

"No, he's not," said a new voice. "He is challenging the Goddess. And the Goddess says that she will judge his case. Take him to the Megara. Zeus will join you there."

"Yes, priestess," acknowledged Hercules. "Let the will of the Goddess be done."

Zeus could not believe his ears.

Like Hercules, he knew that Achilles could be erratic. That he liked fighting far too much and that he lacked discipline. More than once he had had to talk to him about it. And he knew that sooner or later, Achilles would challenge him for the title of Zeus. Well, assuming he lived that long.

But now he had insulted the Goddess.

To touch any woman - let alone violate her - without her consent was to trample on the prerogatives of the Goddess. She was jealous of her rights, and no man could be considered the equal of any woman. And while Iphigenia was not yet at the rank of *mother*, she was a landowner and Hera had said that she had confirmed that she had proved fertile.

On top of that, the rules of the village said that once a woman was married, her husband was her *exclusive* sexual partner. Even if she *had* consented, what had happened today was an offence against marriage. And Zeus and Hera were there to enforce those rules.

Any way you looked at it, Achilles had violated the laws of the Goddess and the rules of the village. There was only one possible atonement: *blood*.

The only question Zeus had not yet resolved was *how* Achilles blood should be spilt. Should he acknowledge the rights of the Goddess and offer him the escape route of trial by combat, allowing the Goddess herself to judge who was the stronger? If Achilles won, he could go free, assuming he never came back to the village.

Or should he stand on his own prerogatives as leader of this community, and punish Achilles as a lawbreaker and a renegade soldier? If he chose that path, it was much simpler: he just ordered the man to die and a simple sword thrust through his heart would finish it. Nobody would question his judgment, either way.

Achilles walked into the Megara with his head up high, escorted by four other men, but not restrained or dragged. Achilles knew the punishment for his actions, and was not cowed. His fate was written in his face: it would not do to simply execute him. The villagers - and particularly the men - needed to *see* the power of the Goddess. They needed to see that *right* was right, not might. Just because Achilles - or Hector, or anyone else, could physically manhandle another man or woman did not make him supreme in this village. The Goddess would always be supreme, and her will would be demonstrated through her Queen, her King and her Priestess.

Zeus looked him squarely in the eye. Achilles looked back, full of contempt. For a moment Zeus was tempted to just order his death, see him hacked to pieces in front of him: but that would be what Achilles would do. Zeus had the maturity and wisdom to know that the long-term consequences outweighed the short-term satisfaction.

"I will not bother inquiring into the facts or ask for your version of events or explanations, Achilles," Zeus began. "You were caught red-handed in the commission of an act which offends both the Goddess and the Village. You must be punished and die."

There was silence in the Megara. Achilles looked at him without fear; or indeed any reaction. There could be no question that he had been expecting this, but even so, Zeus was impressed at his calm. *If only you had learnt some discipline*, he thought. *Where did I go wrong in your training?*

"The Goddess has decreed that you shall die by combat. As her champion on earth, I will exercise her will. If you should best me and survive, you may go free and leave the village, but to return or ever to interact with any villagers again will cost you your life. Do you understand?"

Achilles inclined his head, then reached out a hand to signal that he was ready for Zeus to approach. Zeus stood and climbed down from the dais onto the floor of the Megara. As he neared Achilles, he reached out and swung his right hand at him. Reflexively, Achilles raised his arm to block, and Zeus kicked him in the kneecap. Where most men would fall, Achilles stayed upright and stepped back, trying to pull Zeus with him. Zeus went with the pull - and his momentum - and pushed into Achilles, knocking him backwards onto the floor.

As they fell, Zeus raised his fist and, with one mighty blow, smashed his opponent's face.

Probably that would have been enough, but this man was a rapist, and Zeus had a point to prove. Kneeling, he pummelled the man's face ferociously until it was unrecognizable. Then he stood and walked away from the lifeless body. Turning to Athene, he intoned, "what is left of this creature is in the province of the Goddess in her role as Death".

Athene stepped forward, the ritual bone sickle in her hand. Removing Achilles' loincloth, she removed the offending member underneath and held it up for all to see. "As you have all seen, the Goddess will not tolerate this behaviour. This man who was a man is a man no more. Not only is he dead, but he is less than a man." Turning to one of her acolytes, she passed the offending member.

"Dispose of this garbage," ordered Zeus.

The men knew what to do. Criminals were fed to the Goddess' snakes out in the cisterns. They would take him there and throw him in. The Goddess would clean up after him and then it would be as if he never existed.

10. Challenge

Zeus did not recognize the man as he stepped forward.

"Identify yourself, challenger," he ordered.

"I am Nestor from Oschia," the man responded. "I am the son of the King and Queen there, and born to rule. Even so, in Oschia I may not marry my sister. And even should she die untimely, then I still would not be able to marry my niece."

The Megara fell still. A princely challenger. Such things were heard of - princes born to rule, raised to fight, but who had no place in the succession which went to their sisters - while the power increasingly went to their sister's *husbands*. The only place in the world for such a one was to find a village where they respected the challenge-right on New Year's Day. And thus, here he was.

Four challengers had lined up this New Year's Day. It would have been five, Zeus reflected, if Achilles had lived. Could he have beaten all five, and one of them Achilles? He doubted it. Could he beat four? Each bout took a good deal out of him, and he was no longer in his prime.

But, he had to face it, he did not know this man. Was it possible that he had been sent by the Goddess to take over from him? To marry Hera and continue their work together? Was he strong *and* intelligent? It was possible, but Zeus had no way of knowing. But then, of course, he was only a mortal. And, more than that, a mere *man*. The Goddess would decide. He merely had to have faith.

Zeus decided to play for time.

"Tell me your story," he said. "What is your training? Why did you come *here*? What battles have you fought - and won?"

"I was born in Oschia; my mother was the Queen there. My father was King as you are, in the antique fashion, and when I was but a babe, he was killed and another took his place. When I had lived ten summers, my mother died and my sister became the Queen. I trained with sword and spear and shield, and became a captain of the front rank. I led our armies for five summers and we won many victories. Oschia now has three other villages paying us tribute, and we defend them well against all comers. When I had twenty-two summers, I challenged my sister's husband at the challenge because although he was strong with a sword, he was a fool and angered our allies and enemies both. I killed him, but could not marry my sister. I became outcast, but another man, wise and just, married my sister in my stead. I know not whether he can defend his title this New Year, but that is no longer my concern. As I travelled, I heard talk of the mighty Zeus and the lovely Hera, so I wandered here. You may be mighty, and you may be wise, but I know that I have no fear in challenging you for the hand of the lovely Hera. Should I lose, I will die or be once more outcast. But what is that to me, one of the lost?"

"True it is," said Zeus, "that should you lose, you will either die in the attempt or be cast out again. Have you considered that a man such as yourself would be welcome here, if not as Consort to the fair Hera, at least as a Captain of the First Rank? You could serve here, and should you find yourself unhappy with my rule, you could challenge me then?"

"A fair offer, mighty Zeus. Well do they call you wise, both among your allies and enemies. A lesser man might accept such an offer, removing all risk from the future. But, I ask you, what is life without risk? And I remind you: *I was born to rule*. There is safety in hiding behind a woman's skirts, but there is no honour as a *man*. I may never be able to be a woman, or to have or hold land in my own right, but I *will* be as great as I can be - or fail in the attempt. No, Zeus, it is you or I: Hera can only have one consort, and it must be whichever of us demonstrates our prowess to the Goddess.

"Fair enough," conceded Zeus. "All of the combatants go and prepare yourselves. At noon, we will return here for the challenges."

Zeus faced Nestor down the length of his sword.

The first three challengers had been tough, but Zeus had dealt with them. Old sparring partners, they had known each others styles and strategies. In the end, Zeus had been mighty enough to overcome them, and all three would be outcast before the New Year celebrations started at dusk.

Nestor was an unknown, but had the advantage of having seen Zeus fight three bouts. And, of course, the advantage of being fully rested for this bout. For once, Zeus was uncertain - and it showed. He could see Nestor sizing him up, sneering at him. But he had long ago learnt the virtue of patience. If he saw any weakness in this younger man, it was arrogance. Let him play to that.

"You have challenged *me*, stripling," he said. "If you want Hera, you need to defeat me. If I am undefeated by dusk, I remain Zeus, Hera's handfast. I am happy to stand here all day."

Nestor continued to look at him for a while, then suddenly charged towards him, bronze sword flashing in the early afternoon sun. Zeus parried in form, then turned away, trying to get behind him. But oh, Nestor was quick. Three times they came together, exchanging a flurry of blows, before Nestor backed off, hesitant. He had judged Zeus and old man, and past it. He had seen him beat three challengers before him, but dismissed them as also-rans. Now he understood the speed and strength in Zeus' sword arm and began to regret his challenge. Maybe he should have taken Zeus' offer.

Zeus saw him reflecting and hoped for a moment's inattention. He moved to his left and snapped his sword out to the right, but Nestor was fully awake and ready for the challenge. In moments, they were exchanging blows again but now Zeus was on the attack and Nestor retreating across the Megara. Zeus fainted left and, as Nestor went to cover, Zeus hooked his left foot around Nestor's right and pulled. Unready for the move, Nestor lost balance. As he tried to recover, Zeus jumped inside his guard, batted his sword away and held his sword at Nestor's throat.

Nestor dropped his sword, then fell to his knees.

"I concede," he said. "I shall never be King."

"On the contrary," said Zeus. "I see everything you told me about yourself was true. While I beat you, I accept that I did so through a trick. You have proved yourself a fine fighter and a worthy foe. Come, this is Hera: she will be your wife and I will be outcast. Here," he said, giving him his sword, "have my sword."

"Zeus is cast down," cried the villagers. "Let Zeus rise up."

And Zeus, who had been Zeus so many times, and then not been Zeus, only to be Zeus again, left the Megara, and left the village.

Meanwhile, the villagers married Nestor to Hera, and acclaimed him Zeus.

The ritual of the New Year never grew old, thought Hera.

It symbolizes everything we believe in. The power of the Goddess; the sense of renewal; the returning of life after death; the act of procreation; and the fertilization of the ground. Only Athene truly understood the ways and mysteries of the Goddess, but Hera had experienced the ritual for so many years that it was part of her lifeblood.

As ever, she danced in the circle of women around the fire, infused by the rhythm of the drums, guiding the movement of her feet. To her right was Athene. All the other women were the ritual priestesses of the Goddess, who would choose the men with whom they would demonstrate the act of procreation. She, of course, was reserved for him who was Zeus.

She picked him out in the crowd and called him forward. Young and virile, his body was tanned and hard, much like the man she had called Zeus when the day had dawned. A waste, she thought, I could grow to love this man, but the Goddess knows the ritual.

He joined in the dance with her and the drums continued, became more insistent. Slowly, the outer circle filled as the priestesses called more men to join them and they circled around the fire in opposite directions. In spite of his repeated exertions this afternoon after the wedding - and they *had* been repeated - she could see that Zeus was erect already and just waiting for her. She was ready too, but could feel the tension flooding through her as she waited, the expectation building as she used her power of decision to make him wait.

Finally, as he came around again, she knew the moment was right. Reaching out with her right hand, she grasped that member that was now so large and bulbous. She pulled him towards her, then put her left hand around him, holding her against her breasts. Consumed in the moment, she was barely aware of others doing the same up and down the circle. She pushed him to the ground, straddled him and went to work with a will. Twice she came, then a third, before she finally brought him to release. Around the fire, most of the other couples were already spent, and the villagers watched, expectant.

At the moment he was at his weakest, still pumping his life-affirming seed into her, possibly implanting him with his child, a flash of firelight on bronze shone to her right. Suddenly, she was pushed off her husband as another man - a stranger and yet so familiar - appeared in the firelight. The bronze dagger plunged into Zeus' throat and the blood gushed forth.

"Zeus is dead!" called all the villagers around the fire. "Zeus is dead."

And then, as Hera stood, holding the stranger's hand and lifting it above their heads, they cry changed.

"Long live Zeus!"

And Zeus, who had begun the day as Zeus, spent an afternoon as an outcast while the Goddess turned her face away from Zeus, became Zeus again.

And Athene went to work on the dead body which had been Zeus for half a day, and whose only legacy in the village would be a child.

11. Apotheosis

25 years later

Somehow merely burning him did not seem enough for so great a man.

Somehow he seemed more a part of the Godhead that he seemed a mere hero. But *could* a man be at one with the Goddess, *she* who was all-in-all?

The whole village was gathered around the pyre this autumn evening. There was a cool breeze coming from the north that seemed to speak to all of them of the loss they had suffered. Some shivered from the cold, some from the uncertainty. Nobody there could remember a time before Zeus - *this* Zeus - had not been King. To burn him as they did all the heroes did not seem enough.

Agamemnon - the King's oldest son - stepped forward and put the torch to the pyre. Slowly the wood caught and the flames raced around the pyre, crackling and glistening as the sun set behind the hills to the west. The fire raced up in counterpoint to the disappearing sun, evoking tribal memories of the volcanoes they had left behind in the north so many generations ago.

The sun had gone around the earth thirty-three times since Zeus had first become King. Every year he had been challenged and had survived the challenge although, of late, the challenges had been more ritualistic than genuine. Many of the army leaders could have beaten Zeus if they had challenged him, but none of them really thought they would make a better King, so they refrained from challenging him. Those who did knew they would lose but could not resist the temptation of being "King for a Day". And having one day with the luscious Hera.

And in his thirty-three years he had gone from being ruler over one village, to ruler over four, to ruler over more than twenty villages. Nothing was as it was as it had been thirty-three years ago when he had successfully challenged for the hand of Hera in marriage - a marriage that had brought him a share in the leadership of the village.

Even Hera was not the same Hera. Hera the Queen who had married Zeus all those years ago had died twelve summers before Zeus and been cast to the snakes in the way traditional for the women and villagers. Only Heroes were entitled to be burnt on a pyre. After Hera's death, Zeus married one of her daughters - aged fifteen summers - and she became the new Hera.

Over the course of all those years, something else changed: Zeus went from being "the king" in the sense of being the current wife of Queen Hera, to being The King, whose wife was the (younger) Queen Hera. By successfully defending his kingship every time it was challenged, he stopped being the king by virtue of being married to the Queen, and instead became the King in his own right.

And nobody expected that to change.

A funeral pyre just like the other Heroes was not enough for the first man ever to be The King.

Apollo recused himself from competing to be the new King in Zeus' place.

"I have been Zeus' faithful servant for many years now," he said, "and I am old and grey. I look around at the yound men here - many of them sons of our great Zeus and his wife Hera - and I know that I do not have the strength to win a contest at arms.

"No matter that many of you think that I would be the man most able to rule and guide this village, I would only do so for a few years. Better then, that we choose a young, vigorous, virile man to take over and marry Hera. Let him be King, and - whoever the Goddess chooses, hopefully with the help of our dearly departed Zeus - I will be his faithful assistant as I was to the mighty Zeus.

"But, as my final official act as the right hand of Zeus, I will oversee this combat, for combat there must be to decide who shall take on the name and title and role of Zeus. Only combat serves in the eyes of the Goddess to find the one who is worthy to lead us in these trying times.

"And I swear before her, that I will oversee this combat fairly, without fear or favour, and will support whichever of these young men she chooses.

"Now, let all those who would present themselves to her to compete to be the next King step forward."

Twelve men stepped forward to present themselves. Four of them were Zeus' sons, now grown to be men of more than twenty summers. In their prime, and yet still hoping to have another decade or more in which to rule and sire sons of their own with the luscious Hera.

Apollo eyed them all up, then sent them home to arm and prepare for the combat to come.

As the sun rose high overhead, Apollo greeted the twelve in the sight of all the people of the village. Who would not be here for the first choosing of a King any of them had ever known?

Apollo had already decided how to divide them up, pairing stronger men against the weaker, so that after the first round, he expected six stronger men to make it through to the next round while the six weakest would lie dead in the dust to be carried away by the slaves. Each bout went as he expected, with most of them settled in just a few blows.

To bring six down to four, he arranged two melees between three claimants. As before, he made sure that each had one weak candidate and two who were more evenly matched. Within a few fingers of the sun, only two men remained: the only two, Apollo knew, who should have even stepped forward: Agamemnon and Achilles. One or the other would be dead by sunset; the other would be King. But which?

For once, Apollo did not know. He would find out with everyone else.

The two men circled each other again, looking for an opportunity to strike. Each had landed - and suffered - a handful of blows, and each was growing weak. Achilles was worried that his bronze sword was weakening - always a danger with this brittle material - and was considering changing it for another. He knew that Apollo would allow a pause in the fight if he asked for it, but at the same time, he felt Agamemnon was weakening. Stepping forward, he chanced a quick snap at Agamemnon's head. Agamemnon stepped to one side and dodged the blow.

Achilles took two steps back and then ran at Agamemnon, bringing his sword down in a crushing overhand blow. Agamemnon raised his sword out of instinct - and just in time - and Achilles' sword shattered into pieces from the force of the blow.

Before either man could consciously react, Agamemnon put all his force into carrying the parry through into a follow-through that slashed Achilles across the neck. As his blood started spurting out over the earth floor, Achilles fell to his knees.

Brave to the last, he threw his arms open wide and invited the final, killing blow.

Mercifully, Agamemnon supplied it.

King Agamemnon addressed the crowd.

"Today is truly a great day," he began. "But we should never let anything remove from us the memory of the man we lost and burnt yesterday. A man who was more than a hero. A man we can only call a *King*. A man who knew what his people needed and led them through the wilderness to get there. A man of fire and steel. Truly a man among men.

"And my first act as King is to make sure that we do not forget. Yesterday, west of here, towards the setting of the sun, we burnt the Great Man. As my first act, I will go there, along with any man who will come with me, and I will build out of living stones a monument to the only man I will ever call *King*. The greatest man that has ever lived. And in doing so, I recognize his spirit now as one with the Godhead, and as we recognize the Goddess as She who Reigns over all, I will recognize Zeus as the *God* in the Heavens who looks after all His children."

Although the word had never been used before, there could only be one possible meaning for the word God - it was the same as the word Goddess, but with a masculine ending rather than the feminine ending. A male Goddess was a novelty, but Agamemnon could see he had them. It was a novelty that was going to stick. They would call Zeus a God, and the would make offerings at his stone monument. Offerings that would reflect the fact that Zeus was a God of Warriors, not a Goddess of Life.

Yes, this would stick. For all time.

In Mykenai, the Goddess lived on for now - as Queen Hera lived on - but both were now subservient to their male masters.

Rome, Italy

1130 BCE

1. Aeneas

Troy was no more, Aeneas reflected as the ship bore into land, and the story was spreading across the sea.

It was no fun being the leader of a band of mercenaries whose most famous achievement was to have seen their city destroyed. Didi of Carthage - a trivial colony really, set on a fertile strip by the desert - had basically laughed in his face when he proposed marriage. And then he hadn't even managed to beat her current husband in single combat.

No, they needed to find somewhere where "the Trojans" were not a laughingstock. Somewhere beyond the reach of the Greek colonies. Sicilia was out, because they had been rebuffed there and his father Anchises had been killed in a battle on the beach. North, then, north above Sicilia. Not as far as Massilia; and certainly not one of the other islands: they all had Greek colonies and would have heard the story Agamemnon had spread far and wide. How mighty Troy had fallen. Agamemnon never mentioned the treachery that had sold the city out - that had betrayed Priam and Hector, Anchises and Aeneas. No, he told a story of glory and honour. And heroes.

And that was the story that would stick.

Aeneas looked around his ship at the men rowing. They looked a motley bunch, hard and desperate. Forged in war - a war to defend their homeland. A band of men who had learned the hard way that you can only get what you take in life. A group of homeless exiles desperate for a new start.

Desperate. Yes, that was the word to describe all of them. They were desperate.

There were times when Aeneas almost found himself hoping that Poseidon would send a mighty wave and crush their fleet, sending all of them to the bottom of the sea.

What Agamemnon had known of course was that Troy held to the old way, the old beliefs and that once Hecuba was dead, the city was dead. Rape and kill the "old woman" and there would be nothing left. In his telling, of course, the rape and murder happened *after* the city fell, when there were a thousand heroes running through the streets.

He nearly barked with laughter. Not so!

And that magic touch: that Paris, prince of Troy, had abducted Helen, from some random kingdom in Greece. Not that the Greeks had tried to abduct the heiress of Troy, and been killed in the process, starting the inevitable rounds of retribution.

After Dido, he had decided he would abandon the old ways. No more kowtowing to women, the ways of women, the gods of women. What Aeneas had learnt from the sorry saga of the last decade was that might is right, that power is the only thing that lasts, and that men win wars; women lose them. He was going to go somewhere, anywhere, on the coast here and take land. If it came with women, good; if not, he would forge his own society, find women from somewhere, kidnap and enslave them. Whatever it took.

He was going to be a King in the Greek style.

"Beach ho," called the lookout.

A good place, thought Aeneas. He was fairly sure there were no Greek colonies here. The beach was rocky and covered in pebbles, but sloped up slowly to the land, densely forested, with a stream coming down from the higher ground. They still had some casks of water on board the ships, but fresh water was a requirement if they were going to stop here and build a kingdom.

He climbed higher in the rigging of the single mast and looked out to see what else he could see. There were no obvious signs of habitation, but if they had a lookout, he would be hidden in the woods anyway. They were hardly likely to keep their entire army on the beach at all times.

He signalled to the other two ships in his flotilla. He had started off with five ships when they left Troy. They had been split up from time to time, but these three had come back together. One had been lost in the battle in Sicily that cost his father's life. The other had become separated from them during a storm as they had crossed back across the sea a few weeks back. He still hoped to catch sight of it every day, but he had to accept that even if Poseidon hadn't claimed their lives, they were probably irretrievably lost to him. The odds of meeting up at a random point on this deserted coastline were basically zero.

The three ships headed into the coastline in a triangle, his in the lead, with the other two covering his beams. The rowers took them in as quickly as they could until he signalled for them to reverse stroke. In seconds, the speed had sloughed off and the ship gently ran aground, then twisted to port as it wedged. Aeneas leapt over the side into the gentle surf and ran up the beach. The off watch followed him.

The others stowed their oars and dropped the drag anchors over the side. Then, leaving the small anchor watch of five men with their trumpets behind, they followed him into the surf as well.

Discipline first and foremost. Taking the marker sticks, Aeneas marked out a square, twenty paces to a side above the waterline, but near where the stream came through. As soon as he had done so, the others filled in, quickly assembling a rudimentary, fortified camp behind which they would be safe if they were attacked.

The locals arrived early the following morning.

Aeneas estimated there probably weren't more than twenty of them, always allowing for the possibility that this was a vanguard and the main force was following behind or were lying in ambush in case they became overconfident.

"OK, men, up you get. Form arms!"

Quickly the men who had not been on sentry duty gathered their arms and armour and, as soon as they were all ready, opened the gate in the rear fence and marched out. In what seemed no time, three ranks of thirty men were lined up in front of the camp, spears to the ready.

The locals waited on the edge of the woods, apparently uncertain what to do.

Aeneas had his doubts too, but when faced with an impossible situation, there was only one choice: attack, but with safety in mind. Leaving his remaining men to hold the fortified camp, he gave the order for a slow advance. No point rushing up the gentle slope to arrive downslope of the enemy; there was plenty of time in the day. But he wasn't going to wait to give battle: these men had homes to go to; he needed to defeat them in order to ever have a home again. Troy was lost to him forever.As they came near to the enemy line, the locals charged downhill.

"Level spears!", shouted Aeneas.

As one, the men lowered their spears to face forward. As the enemy rushed headlong, they crashed into the spears; his men responded by thrusting them forward and impaling them. The screams of the enemy mingled with the shouts of his men, determined to win here.

"Forward step!", called Aeneas from his position in the middle of the front rank.

Every man took a step forward, and thrust again. By now, half of the attackers were down, and most of the others had some wounds. Those still standing took a step or two back, unsure how to deal with this new, organized enemy.

"Forward step!", shouted Aeneas again.

Once again, the men stepped forward and thrust their spears at the men who were still standing there. At this, they all turned and ran.

"Beware an ambush!", shouted Aeneas. "Losing ten men is nothing to get a good ambush! Dead detail party, now!"

While the others waited, three men rushed forward and, daggers drawn, rushed to the fallen, dealing each of them a swift blow to the throat, ensuring they could not rise and fight again. With that done, the formation started to move forward again slowly, one step at a time. Now more than ever, there was no incentive to rush.

They reached the treeline without opposition. From here, they could see where the enemy had staged and Aeneas presumed that there would be a clear trail back to wherever they had come from. Any ambush would be one side or the other of that trail.

"Tracker forward! Marching column! Ambush ready! Eyes open!"

Swiftly, the men reorganized themselves. These were good troops, thought Aeneas, whatever the Greek world might have said about them. Organized and disciplined. He and Hector had won every engagement they had fought in front of the walls of Troy, although he had no doubt that *that* was also in the process of being airbrushed out of history. History was written by the winners. Greek men.

"Tracker, proceed!"

The tracker led the way. In truth, the passage beaten through the woods by twenty men would not have been hard to follow even if it had not been the way the townsfolk would travel to the beach on a day basis. For their skilled tracker, it was almost as easy as walking down to the harbour from the Skean gate. Despite everyone being on the alert, there was no sign of an ambush anywhere in the forest.

Abruptly, the forest ended; Aeneas called a halt. Looking out, they saw a large clearing; nothing like the size of the Trojan plain, but large enough for a sizable village, or possibly even a town.

A few buildings were clustered together, probably four hundred paces or so away.

The tracker came closer and offered his opinions. "Given what I can see, I would have thought this village would maybe support one hundred or two hundred souls. They have the land for that, and there are probably enough huts. So I would think they would have at least 70 men they could throw against us. And we have seen what? 20?"

Aeneas nodded, thoughtfully. He knew as well as anyone else: just because there was enough land here to support 200 villagers didn't mean that there were that many here. They could have died, recently or long ago. There could have been a plague, or they might already have been attacked. They could still be out there waiting, or they could have run away.

But he knew one thing beyond any doubt: once he was out on those fields, he couldn't be ambushed the way he could be in the forest. If the worst came to the worst, he could burn the huts to the ground with any potential ambushers inside.

"Five torches, now! Prepare to burn huts! Keep in the defensive column and keep your eyes open!"

He looked around to make sure his orders were being followed.

"Now! Advance!"

Slowly but steadily, the column moved forward. They walked across the open field without challenge. The silence was almost eerie. Finally, they reached the perimeter of the village.

"Halt! Defensive columns, now! Keep those eyes open! We may be attacked at any time. Prepare to burn huts!"

The men rearranged themselves effortlessly and thrust their spears out on all four sides of the square.

"With me," he said to the tracker and the nearest torchbearer, and together they walked forward. They walked to the nearest hut and looked in. It was deserted. They walked around it and found the hut at the centre of the village.

"Be ready for anything," he counselled quietly. "If it even feels like we are about to be attacked, set fire to it and then let's get back to the men."

They walked into the hut to be greeted by a gaggle of women. Not a man among them.

"Where are your men?" Aeneas asked in Trojan, not even expecting to be understood.

In the middle of the hut, a woman sat on a carved, backless chair placed on a low dais. She raised her eyes to him and said something unintelligible.

"Do you speak Greek?" Aeneas asked, switching to that language.

She motioned to another woman to the left of the dais. Looking at her, Aeneas noticed facial features reminiscent of Greek women he had met in the past. The woman looked up from her kneeling position and quietly said, "I am from Mykenai".

Aeneas felt his rage rise inside. He had to curb his tongue to avoid ordering the whole building being burnt down around him. The Gods *damn* Agamemnon! Even here, miles from civilization, a woman from *Mykenai* was here before him. How was this possible?

He turned to her nonetheless. If they were going to get out of this without destroying the entire village, they would need to negotiate. Although the villagers had very little to negotiate with. They could give him the village and all that was in it, or he could burn it down around them.

"Where are your men?" Aeneas asked her, this time in Greek.

"You killed what was left of them", she replied.

"Not so," Aeneas countered. "We killed about half of those who came against us, but the others ran away."

"Cowards," she answered. "But those were all the men left to the village. Men are expendable pawns anyway; one is always enough and I'm sure you are more than capable of placating the Goddess in the way she demands, trampling on our blood moons." She looked at him expectantly.

It could be true. If there were only ten men left, they would be better served running away than staying and fighting. But had they run away or run for help? He needed to decide, and quickly.

But the truth was, the decision had already made itself. This was where he was, and he needed to hold it against those men or any others who tried to evict him. He was sure they would.

"In that case, I am now the King here," declared Aeneas. "This village and everything in it is now my property."

"No," the woman dared to correct him. "Lavinia remains the Queen here. You may gain throne-right by marrying her, but until that you are just a visitor."

"I will come back for your 'Queen' later," Aeneas assured her. "You can use whatever form of words you like, but I am in charge here." He waved her spear at her. "You may say I obtain the right by putting *my spear* in your Queen, but I assure you that *this spear* is the one that will command your respect and obedience." He paused. "Or you can all die."

The three of them walked back to the others.

"They claim there are no men left here, but we can be sure some will come from somewhere to contest with us. Build a stockade. Pull this empty building down. When that's done and secure, four of you go back to the beach - keep those eyes peeled for an ambush! - and get all the others and everything you can manage up here. Torch the ships. We don't need them anymore. This is our new home. The New Troy!"

As it happened, they had two weeks to prepare for the inevitable attack.

Not that the locals measured time in days or weeks; they still held to the old summer-moon calendar. They counted the nine months from the rising of the Pleiades as the "year" and then respected the "time of death" until the seven (now six) sisters rose again. Archaic.

No more archaic, of course, than the idea that women ruled the world. Lavinia held to this misguided belief, as did her people, and that had made for some troublesome times over the past two weeks, but Aeneas would not be gainsaid. Lavinia and her people could believe that his *right* to rule depended on him sleeping with her; but the truth remained that it was his seven foot, metal spear - and those of his men - that enabled him to rule here.

He had learned some of the history of the village over those two weeks as well, and some of the local language, called *Latin*. Unsurprisingly, the area of the world where he found himself was called *Latinum* by the locals. They had been attacked by some people from further north, called *Etruscans* since time immemorial - here that probably meant anything over two generations - and the men who had fought had generally managed to do enough to hold the village but the process of attrition meant that when Aeneas had landed on the beach, Turnus - Lavinia's spouse-cum-warleader - had only had the twenty men he had brought with him at his disposal. In fleeing, he would have been reduced to a mere ten fighting men. The only hope he had was to find allies. Let him.

The preparations for the inevitable battle had proceeded apace and Aeneas had not just built a central fort - the *citadel* as he thought of it - but had worked to build an outer wall around the central encampment. There was nothing he could do to protect the fields of course - standing crops were always the first thing to be destroyed in a war like this - and he would not give up his strong, defensible position in order to protect anything.

In reality, there wasn't any real need to protect the village or the women in it. If you believed that the right to rule and the right to wealth ran through the female line, then obviously you wanted to claim the women *alive*. They might be forcibly raped after the battle, but it was probably no worse than what they endured on most nights with their "legitimate" husbands. Certainly Lavinia had accepted him willingly enough: no force required there!

No, while he wouldn't admit it to them, the reason he wanted to keep the women inside the wall was to *hold onto them*. If Turnus were to return and claim Lavinia, in the eyes of all the locals he would be king, even if he couldn't manage to hold that title in battle with other claimants. It was an antique way of thinking, but Aeneas relished the advantage that came from being the man who knew the truth. A pleasant change after Troy, when he had laboured under the disadvantage of being on the more old-fashioned side. Of course, ten years of war had hardened their forces, and by the final weeks, he and Hector had led the finest forces on the battlefield. They would have won and sent the Greek forces packing if they had not been betrayed ...

He cut off that endless, circular thought. Troy had been betrayed and the traitors were dead and the Greeks had won and he was here in Latinum preparing to defend a pathetic little fort in the middle of nowhere against some local bumpkins. Still, better than the alternative of being in a watery grave somewhere out there at sea.

He was reviewing his defences from the outside when the shout came.

"Soldiers to the north!"

He immediately turned and looked in that direction. He had plenty of time to get back inside the fort before they arrived and from here he was closer to the enemy. In addition to the trees they had hacked down for logs to build his fortlet, they had burnt through significant parts of the forest to clear sight lines and travel lanes. It was now possible to see well over 800 paces to the north without there being anywhere for soldiers to hide. Not that this lot seemed to understand the value of hiding. Maybe they thought that they would just overrun them, and take Lavinia and the village for themselves with no difficulty. Clearly, they had not been at the siege of Troy. Not a Nestor, Agamemnon or Odysseus among them. Time would tell if they had a soldier with the strength and courage of Achilles, Ajax or Ajax.

His initial impression was that they were coming in strength. He could see forty or fifty soldiers emerging from the trees, and they were coming in a way that suggested there were more behind. He turned and looked at his fortlet again. A solid defensive position gave the defenders an enormous advantage - everyone knew that. And yet, in this backwater, there had not been a single defensive structure to stop him: no wall, no citadel, not even a ditch. The biggest obstacle was the river and that was only an obstacle if you were attacking from the north. And given the size of it, only really if you were a child.

It would do, he told himself. It wasn't perfect; but even the strongest structures were only as strong as the men (and women) holding them. He had given all his men clear orders: he would rather kill all the women in the village than run the risk they would betray him to Turnus and his allies. Any - he repeated *any* - woman who was acting suspiciously or came out of the hut they were assigned to was to be killed. Instantly. No questions. He was not going to be betrayed again.

He walked back around to the south of the fort and walked in through the gate. It was closed and barred behind him. Four reliable men were assigned there at all times. Their job was simple: the gate stayed closed unless he personally ordered it open. Anyone who had a different opinion was to die. Or else they would.

Once again he considered the value of the river as a defensive position. Rivers were hard to cross, and this lot probably didn't know about things like covering fire. But it wasn't as secure as the fortlet, and he would probably lose any men he used to defend it. It would be worth it if ten men could kill forty as they came out of the river, but he really didn't think that would be the case here. This mob would probably stretch the length of the river and cross willy-nilly. His men would probably be quickly surrounded and killed. There was no obvious way to bottle them up: this river didn't need a ford to be crossed.

It was nearly noon by the time the enemy horde had made their way from the forest, crossed the river, and gathered on the south bank opposite him. Already Aeneas despised this foe. They had just sat down where they were when they arrived, a mass of humanity resting and sunning themselves. Their baggage had been dumped wherever they finished up, and there was no order to anything.

Pothides came up to him. "Do you think," he asked, "that we could sally out and drive them back into the river before they could even pick up their weapons?"

Aeneas looked over the troops before him. He had been wondering something similar. A simultaneous attack from east and west, using the river behind them as an anvil - it would be a strategy. But he was drastically outnumbered. Given he would have to leave at least twenty men behind to secure the fort, could seventy get the job done? Was it worth it?

"Three ranks of twelve each side? Could we?" he asked Pothides. "It just defies all credibility." He glanced around again, counting groups of men as he did so. "At least 300, I'd say. If they attack us, the wall helps us out, but if we go out there, we could easily be flanked, surrounded and eliminated. That's one for the poets my friend. If you want to die a hero's death, that's one way to do it."

"We did stupider things in front of Troy," Pothides countered.

"Did we, in truth?" asked Aeneas. "Never with such small numbers. My company never had less than 200; and Hector generally wanted 1,000 men with him. And we had a strongly held city behind us. This is not the same. Even 90 men could not hold this fort against Agamemnon. 20 would be impossible, even against this rabble. No, I think we have to stay here." Wistful for the strategy that could have been with just another fifty men, he looked out over the field, wondering just how primitive and stupid these men were.

"And thrust!" he shouted as the enemy came again.

When they had come, it had been predictably disorganized. They had come as individuals and groups, and thrown themselves against the wall, trying to climb it and get inside. Did they even *have* missile weapons? Did they not appreciate how difficult it was with the height advantage he had built into the wall by digging a ditch on the outside and piling the earth up inside? This was the dumbest thing he had ever seen. The men on the wall had an easy time of it: pick a target, thrust your spear, and wait for the scream. From the roof of the Megaron, he and Pothides could see the battle playing out in front of them. There was no plan to the attack, just men rushing forward to the slaughter.

"Thrust again!" he called. Not that the men needed his encouragement: difficult as it would be to get over the wall, any man who managed it would bring death to those men around him even with the short, stabbing swords that they carried.

Aeneas looked over to where the 20-man reserve unit stood behind them. He nodded at them and leaned over to Pothides: "Time to take them in the rear?"

Pothides looked out and saw what Aeneas meant. The enemy were two or three deep trying to navigate the ditch, the dead bodies, the wall and the spears. Those that came too close were dying, the others were milling about. A disciplined charge now would break them - physically and mentally. It was a risk, Pothides knew, and knew that Aeneas knew. The reserve was a *reserve*. They didn't have enough men for a sally company. But it was a question of risk and reward. They *might* need the reserve later, but only if the battle went on later. Break them now and there would be no need for fighting later.

And they had only lost two men so far; other than that, they were holding their own.

"Yes," he agreed. "Now would be the time."

"What are you waiting for?" he asked and turning, shouted to the men guarding the gate. "Open for sally out!" he shouted. "Then as you were."

Pothides jumped off the roof and ran to the reserve company. "On me!" he shouted, and ran with them to the gate which opened just before they arrived and closed after the last man passed through. He led them on a tangent away from the village, to the river and then back behind the men still attacking the wall. Forming up, he called "Charge!" and ran into the backs of the men waiting there, a glittering wall of steel spears leading the way. Within two charges, the enemy were breaking and running for the river.

"Discipline!" called Pothides. "About face! Charge!" A rout was always difficult to manage. Men threw their weapons and armour away, believing that their only hope of salvation lay in their speed. But any man that held on to his dagger or sword knew better: just kill the man nearest you and you know he won't kill you. Among these sheep fleeing for their lives would be a few wolves. You always had to be on the look out for the wolves.

"Beware wolves! Beware daggers! Look out for swords! And charge!" he shouted.

The river was soon running red with blood.

Aeneas lost four men in total that day. The handful of enemy survivors were drafted in to replace them.

This is the life for me, thought Aeneas as he lay in bed with Lavinia that night. Let her think she is important if she wants to, but nobody is going to stop me being King in my lifetime. There's nobody here that can manage it. Even these Etruscans don't scare me.

2. Alba Longa

"Lavi says so, that's who," retorted Ascanius angrily.

"Well, she doesn't know everything," answered Aeneas. "If I say you will be King after me, you will be King after me, whatever Lavi and her husband want. The days of women ruling because of birthright are gone, and people need to realize that."

"Well, tell that to one of your other sons," countered Ascanius, somewhat mollified, but still angry. "Apart from anything else, I don't see **the point**. I mean, yes, I could rule here, but I could easily go elsewhere, conquer a town, marry the queen, show them the true way of Jupiter Indiges and exercise power forever. And, yes, if my son wants to wait and take over, he can. But, I ask you, father, *why would I wait*?"

Aeneas had no answer to this brutal logic. He was basically forced with a choice: he could kill himself to make way for his son, fight his son and have one of them kill the other, or let him go.

It seemed among his other talents Ascanius was a mind reader: "I could kill you father, or ask you to kill yourself, or otherwise die honourably in order that I can take over. You have worked hard for what you have, you have struggled for more years than I can imagine. You deserve to enjoy what you have.

"And I'm not really sure that I could cope with just being given all that on a plate. Lavi's husband Cornus is a good man; he will wait, and he will rule after you, and the people will be happy with that. It will be easy and undisputed and you can go to the pyre knowing that what you have built will be left behind you."

Aeneas raised his hands, accepting what he could not beat. This son was too much like him: he was a soldier born and an adventurer. He would find his place in the world, and that was not administering a few villages which were at peace.

"I see greatness in you, my son. I know not what the future holds for you, but I know that you will do great and glorious things, worthy of your ancestry. Go with my blessing, son, but know that as long as I live you have my support. Now, how many men do you plan to take?"

"How many don't you need? They may be mouths to feed, but give me enough and I won't have that much problem convincing people to feed us."

"Two squads, say 40? It may not seem like many, but remember that when I first came here, I took this village *and* held it against the Etruscans with less than a century."

Ascanius had hoped for more, but at least it wouldn't be hard to choose the 40: his father had shown his wisdom again, for they both knew he would take the 40 men who already looked on him as their personal commander. And, in times of peace, the 40 men who would be least wanted here. Men who *wanted* to fight; not men who trained simply in order to defend their families.

Aeneas finished up the planning: "Go and spread the word. You go next new moon. And, Ascanius: no women go with you. You can find them anywhere. We need all the women we can lay our hands on here. Any man that is so foolishly attached to a woman that he can't go without her can't go. Tell them that. It will soon straighten them out."

Inland, this country - Latinum - was hilly or even mountainous.

Ascanius had come inland before, scouting out what he could, and raiding for cattle and slaves from time to time. He might not recognize it, but he had acute wanderlust and often went much further afield than was really necessary. Maybe he hoped to replicate the travels of his father's youth, but if he did, he had no idea how far Carthage was from here, let alone Troy. From time to time, he had considered taking up with some of the merchants who sailed up and down the coast of Latinum, but always the thought of war and glory in battle drew him back. He had heard his father's stories often enough: of the fierce warriors of the Greek colonies; and of the People of the Sea with their swords made of a material stronger than bronze. He had never seen one of these "iron" swords, but had heard tales, both from his father and from merchants who came through the area. Out of Latinum, he was a minnow.

But how to grow strong? He had three thoughts. The first was to move inland: further from the coast, it would be harder for roving bands of warriors to find him and subdue him; moreover, he would have more warning than he would on the coast. Secondly, he understood war instinctively: he wanted high ground; a hill or a mountain top. He could build a ditch, a wall, a fence: inside that, he would be secure. Thirdly, he could watch and wait: sooner or later, a band of soldiers would turn up that he could ambush and discover what was going on in the outside world.

It was not a quick plan, and would probably not come to fruition in his lifetime. But it would be *his* plan, and he would pass it on to his sons, and to their sons. And in three or four generations, when he was forgotten, a mighty empire would arise in these hills that would trace its origins to Aeneas and Ascanius. To their powerful new idea: that the world belonged to *men prepared and strong enough to fight and kill for it*.

The men gathered around him in the pre-dawn light at the base of the hill. A hill that Ascanius insisted on calling a "Mount". Trying to make it sound more imposing.

The villagers here had not tried particularly hard to take advantage of its obvious defensive possibilities. There was no ditch or wall at the top. As far as Ascanius could tell, short of killing or intimidating the fifty or so men on top of the hill, he was as good as King here.

He looked around at the men one last time. "Ready?" he asked. "Remember, every man we kill is one less man to work the fields and to recruit into our army. If we can bluster and intimidate, let's do that. But don't get sloppy. I'd rather kill ten of them than lose one of us. Let's go!"

He turned, picked up his two spears, one for throwing and one for jabbing, and led the way up the hill. Forty men really wasn't enough to take a village, even one as unprotected as this - even with the advantage of surprise. But he certainly wasn't going to wear his men out running up this hill like an amateur.

"Hey! Who are you?"

Ascanius had made it a lot closer to the central plaza and huts than he had expected. Even without a wall, a fence or a citadel, he had expected to be spotted and challenged as soon as he crossed the outer boundary of the village's lands. As it happened, they had managed to take advantage of the cover provided by an olive grove to be within a bowshot of the huts. Not that he had any bowmen, of course. When you only had forty men to your name, you really couldn't afford the luxury of having men standing around at the back popping arrows in the air on the off-chance that one of them did some damage.

Now he looked at where the challenger stood, no more than twenty paces away. He flicked his left wrist at Corridus.

"Kill him."

Yes, he had made a point of how he didn't want any *unnecessary* killing, but he did want to intimidate, bluster, bully and generally convince these villagers that they were *all* going to die. And he didn't know any better way of doing that than to kill the first few who challenged him. Their blood and their heads were significant currency when it came to trying to "persuade" the others they did not want to fight.

Corridus took five paces forward, then, spear in both hands, he thrust it up and into the man's throat, piercing it and killing him instantly. As he twisted the spear out, another man came up with an axe and hacked his head off.

As quietly as they could, they carried on through the olive grove.

It really shouldn't be this easy, Ascanius told himself as he entered the plaza, unchallenged.

But it had been. Apart from the one sloppy guard whom they had killed, nobody had challenged them at all. And now they were here in the very heart of the village and, ahead, he could see the leading women of the village in a hut together.

"Eyes sharp!" he called softly to the men around him. Realistically, if this was a trap, it wasn't a good one. Yes, they might all be trapped and all die, but they would take these women with them.

"Well met, ladies," he opened in Latin as his men spread out around him. He had learnt his father's tongue, of course, but he had also grown up speaking his mother's language and knew that the villagers here in Alba would too. "It seems your menfolk have neglected to look after their most precious possessions."

The Queen looked up at him disdainfully. "I am nobody's possession," she informed him primly and calmly. "I am the Queen and the right hand of the Goddess Venus."

"Indeed," countered Ascanius, a smirk crossing his lips. "I have a spear here which claims otherwise. Would your goddess care to put in an appearance and dispute with me?"

"You heretic! Disdain the goddess as you do, and you will not live long."

"Longer than you will unless you submit to me. If you have any notion where your husband is, I will happily fight him for possession of you."

"I have no husband, whelp," she retorted dismissively. "Here in Alba we keep to the old ways and I celebrate with the Goddess' chosen. No man is worthy to be called my equal."

"Once again, we find ourselves at odds, my dear. But then if you don't even have a husband, you can marry me without restraint. And nobody even needs to die. Excellent."

"I am not marrying you or anyone else."

"A shame," he countered. "We were so close to getting out of here without anyone dying. Never mind, I'll marry your daughter instead."

"Over my dead body!"

"Sadly prophetic," he lamented, and, lashing out with his spear, killed her instantly. "Now," he continued, as if nothing had happened, "would one of you good ladies go and find the queen and prepare her for marriage? Corridus will come with you in case the young lady needs persuading.

"Of course, if she cannot be persuaded, Corridus will no doubt solve the problem and line up another volunteer, if you take my meaning. Meanwhile, my spear can become impatient and may end up accidentally killing one or two more of these ladies while I'm waiting."

Corridus left with a squad of guards and two of the women.

Ascanius was married by nightfall. Not something his young bride had ever expected, given that marriage was unheard of here.

Not a bad trade, Ascanius considered. The old queen had been, how to put it, *old*. Whereas this queen was young and delectable, the youngest of the old queen's daughters.

The vanquished men had had no objections to any of this. If anything, they felt their standing had gone up in the world. They were no longer mere men in a village entirely run by women. They were second class men in a village run by men.

Men who took no nonsense from women.

3. Romulus

"You are not thugs," thundered Numitor, "you are my sons!"

"And what good does that do us?" countered Remus. "We are your sons, but not your heir. That goes to whoever you allow to marry Julia. Which, given that she is our sister, is not us. So what are we left with?"

"You have a good life; you are captains in the army; you have wives and property. Really, what more do you want?"

"You say we are captains in the army," said Remus. "But you don't like us fighting," finished Romulus.

"You say we must train and prepare for war," continued Remus. "And then call us thugs for fighting our enemies," added Romulus.

"*Your* enemies," said Numitor. "Precisely. *Not* the enemies of Alba Longa. Those are the people I expect you to fight."

"And who," asked Remus. "Decides that?" finished Romulus.

It had been a habit of theirs since they had first started talking, on the same day. Twins were often close, but everybody remarked on *just* how close - and how similar these two were. Sometimes it seemed like they were just one person, but taking it in turns to act the part.

"The point being," expostulated Remus, "that we want to decide." "And to do that," explained Romulus, "we need to be, as it were, in charge." "In short," summarized Remus, "we want to be Kings in our own right."

"The eternal curse of young royal men. Trained to power but with no outlet for it. Well, that's it as far as I'm concerned. You and your gang of thugs are no longer welcome here. Get out of my city. And don't come back. Any of you."

They left the Megaron and went outside into the bright afternoon sunshine.

"That went well," said Remus.

"We're free," said Romulus.

"Where shall we go?" asked Remus. "There's adventure out in those hills."

"Look," exclaimed Romulus, pointing to the sky. "Eagles!"

Remus watched them fly north, up and over the river. They looked at each other. "North!" they exclaimed together. "Jupiter has spoken," concluded Romulus. "Time to get the 'gang' together for an expedition," said Remus. "We need supplies and weapons as well," concurred Romulus. "Let's get going!"

It confused both of them when they disagreed.

It happened so rarely, in truth, that they had never needed to develop a strategy for dealing with such conflicts. But one faced them now.

Having scouted the area thoroughly, they had found that two of the summits had small towns on them. Of the others, Remus liked one in particular. "It's a good place to found a town. There is a river close at hand. There is nothing to stop us building there, and then we can trade and deal with the locals."

"Or we could just take this town Palatium. It's already there, it's occupied, there is a queen and well, you know how it goes. Kill a few men including her husband, and then, there you are: king of Palatium, a town that already exists."

"Except we're *already* married, Romulus. Just because you didn't bring your wife with you doesn't mean you're not."

That was a continuing bone of contention between them. Romulus' wife had not felt inclined to leave a life of luxury in Alba to take to the dubious life of the campaign trail; Remus' had not wanted to be left behind. Romulus felt that in the absence of his wife, he was at most a widower and was free to marry again. Remus felt the gods would turn their faces away from them if he were to do anything so impious.

"A compromise?" asked Catalus, coming up to them. "We need to build a camp. Yon hill would be a good site. As you say, Remus, it's easily defensible and has good access to water. We could build a camp on that hill. Then we can see what the neighbours are like and, well, you know ..."

"If they were to attack us ..." pondered Romulus. "Then we could defend ourselves and take Palatium," finished Remus.

"Bright boys," said Catalus, easily ten summers their senior. "And that's all but inevitable, isn't it? I mean, if there were an armed camp within five stades of you, and they kept stealing your sheep from that valley, I mean, who wouldn't try and defend what was rightfully theirs?"

Romulus and Remus broke out laughing. "Too right," said Romulus. "Let's get going," said Remus.

They took all their building materials and their gear up the Aventine and started to build a camp.

Evander came up the hill with his sword drawn but reversed.

Behind him were two hundred or so warriors - certainly more than the hundred or so Romulus and Remus had at their disposal.

"They wouldn't be able to break in," commented Romulus, "but they could beat us in a straight fight."

"Then I suggest not getting into a straight fight," counselled Remus.

"But I do want to get into *a* fight with them," said Romulus. "They have something I want."

"Palatium," said Remus.

"True, but also the heiress of Carmenta."

"It's the same thing."

Romulus looked at his twin thoughtfully. "I suppose it is," he said, "but now that I've met her, I want her for herself."

"Except you're already married," Remus reminded him.

"My wife is dead to me," Romulus prevaricated. "He's getting close, let's go."

"You know, if you want the Queen, then that's the man you need to kill," said Catalus as they went out through the gate. "If he were to attack you under the gods' truce, I mean, in sight of all his men, just come at you..."

Romulus looked at him quizzically: "do you really think he's likely to do that?"

"Oh no," smirked Catalus, "I'm sure he would only do that if he were provoked beyond reason. And, I mean, you are not so stupid as to offend him by telling him about the affair you're having with his wife behind his back."

"I'm *not*," shouted Romulus, offended.

"Yeah, I know that," said Catalus. "But he doesn't. So just don't mention it and everything will be fine."

Realization dawned on Romulus as he started walking again. Damn, but Catalus was clever. Like a modern day Ulysses.

They met about a bowshot from the wall. Evander was neither so trusting or so stupid as to come closer.

They met as individuals on the hillside. Their respective armies waited just out of earshot: Evander's 200 further down the hill and Romulus' 100 just outside the wall at its summit.

"When is it going to stop?" demanded Evander, angrily.

"What?" asked Romulus, innocently. "It seems to me that this stand-off can finish whenever you decide to turn around and march your men back through the valley and up that hill and inside those gates."

"I'm not talking about this 'stand-off', you idiot. I am here to demand restitution for the actions of your men."

"My men? What have they been doing then?"

"You know as well as I do that they have been taking sheep from my shepherds down in the valley," Evander answered, gesturing vaguely behind him. "They have taken twenty sheep already this moon. It cannot go on," he insisted.

"Can it not?" enquired Romulus, deliberately raising the tension. "In that case, by all means, I suggest you stop it. I am unaware of my men taking anything that does not belong to them, although I can certainly ask around..." He waved his hand airily as if to suggest that nothing would come of such enquiries. "But I would suggest that if you find sheep are going missing that you look closer to home. I mean, surely if there were thieves abroad in the night, your very competent-looking guards could surely deal with them?" And again, he waved his hand, this time in the general direction of the men waiting down the hill.

"What do you mean, closer to home? Do you deny stealing my sheep?" thundered Evander, loud enough for both armies to hear what he had to say.

"Of course I deny it, my dear chap," said Romulus reasonably. "As I say, I can make a few enquiries, but I don't see how my men could even get out of our fort, let alone near your sheep. Quite frankly, the whole idea is preposterous. It seems much more likely that one of your men is involved in, shall we say, extra-curricular activities. And not always with your wife."

"What? What about my wife?" retorted Evander, spitting and starting to wave his sword around.

"Well, you know, even over here, we hear certain things, and your wife does have a bit of a, shall we say, reputation? I imagine that diverting a few sheep would be a good way of raising the funds to impress her..."

"Who? Who are you accusing?" yelled Evander, now threatening Romulus with the sword.

Romulus took a couple of steps backwards and started to raise his hands, the right still holding the spear.

At which point, Evander completely lost it.

The leading men of both armies gathered around Romulus and a seriously wounded Evander.

"I have no idea," Romulus answered Servius, Evander's second in command. "He accused us of stealing sheep, and I denied it. As far as I know, none of my men has been out at night wandering the hillside, never mind stealing sheep. And I don't see how they could have managed to dispose of a sheep without the smell of roasting flesh coming to my attention.

"I made those points to him, but he seemed disinclined to believe me. But it was when I mentioned the possible perfidy within your own ranks that he lost it and attacked me. I don't really know why, but he seemed to take the suggestion personally. *Have* you had those kinds of discipline issues?"

Servius looked at the man closely. He had no doubt that Romulus, scum that he was, was lying to him. Evander's temper was well known in Palatium; it wouldn't surprise him if this man knew that too and had devised a plausible plan to exploit it. But none of that would help him here. It was undeniable that Evander *had* attacked Romulus, even though he should have known better.

"No, of course not," he responded at length. "We all respected and admired Evander," he said, exaggerating slightly, knowing what was almost inevitable now. "But, *whatever* the provocation," he added, clearly indicating that he believed something more had been said, "I accept that he should not have attacked you. But his death expiates that offence against the gods. We will now retreat to our city to choose a new king."

"No," contradicted Romulus.

Servius and the others froze. What did he mean? Servius looked at him.

"His death expiates the sin of attacking me, but does not expiate his crime of accusing me. For that, I demand restitution."

"What do you demand?"

"A place in the funeral games."

Servius' expression froze in shock. Any doubts he had about whether all of this had been planned dissipated in a moment. Of course it had. Yes, Romulus might not be the brightest pea in the pod, but he could probably beat any of the other contenders likely to take part in the funeral games. He looked around and his eyes fixed on Catalus, a gentle smirk on his face and laughter rolling around his eyes. Yes, that was the one. The brains of the operation. Just not quite smart enough to be able to conceal it. He *wanted* you to know how clever he was. A serious flaw if you actually want to be that cunning. But Servius could not deny it: he was trapped. As the Queen's son, he obviously could not participate in the games. But he would rather it went to one of his friends than this man, boor that he was.

That he might end up marrying his mother didn't bear thinking about.

In the end, four men came forward to claim the throne.

In the eyes of the gods, it was all done to honour the man who had died. These men risked life and limb in combat to honour a man who had risked - and lost - all.

The sword fights were to first blood, of course. Each victor then drew a lot in the next round until only one man was left standing. With only four combatants, there were two rounds.

And Romulus, accomplished thug that he was, won both his matches easily. And claimed the prize.

Before the games began, the pyre had been prepared and Evander's body placed on it. At noon, the games had begun and a short while later, Romulus was declared victor. His first task was to light the pyre.

He took the torch that had been prepared and followed the priestess to the hearth of the constant flame. In these modern days, starting a fire was not so hard: a variety of techniques were available; most men now carried a flint, an iron striker and some tinder with them everywhere they went. But there had been a temple that held the constant flame in villages up and down the peninsula since time immemorial. And it was always there that the flame was found to light the torch for the pyre.

He knelt down and plunged the dry kindling into the heart of the fire. As it caught, he twisted it back and forth until not just the outer kindling, but the pitch-infused pine was alight. Then he removed it from the fire and, holding it stretched out before him, walked back to the pyre. As he approached, the priestesses chanted the words of power to ensure that Evander's soul would separate from his body and go wherever it was that souls went when they were freed from this mortal coil.

As the chanting reached its peak, Romulus stretched out his arm and buried the flame in the pyre.

As he watched it burn, his mind turned to the rest of his prize: Carmenta. She was very pretty. But, more than that, she was the key to absolute power. He now had two villages.

4. The Senate

"Don't think you can do it all by yourself, Romulus."

"And what, I should hamstring myself with some talking shop of fools?"

"Fools, is it? Hmm. It didn't seem that way when I told you how to kill Evander in plain sight of everyone and still get away with it. If I remember correctly, the word Ulysses passed your lips."

Romulus waved the comment away. "The thing is," he said, "only one man can be King. And that's me. Don't try and tell me otherwise. It just won't work."

"Not so," countered Catalus, as ever with an example to hand. "It's common in a lot of the Greek communities to have two kings. One to lead the armies, and one to rule at home when the army is on campaign."

"But that is not what you are suggesting, is it?" argued Romulus. "You are suggesting something along the lines of letting every adult male in on the job of governing. We would be overrun before everyone had even managed to get their long-winded speeches out. We are young; we are small. You know as well as I do that we are under threat from all sides - Sabines, Etruscans - hell, even some of my own people are conspiring against me!"

"And can you blame them?" asked Catalus reasonably. "You promised them the earth, and a share in ruling it. And now you have what you came for, what do *we* have? We're living in some little stockade that can't hold to candle to Alba; we don't even have any women - except the few who came with their men - and we hardly ever see you: the man who is supposed to be our king. Mutiny is about the least of your problems if you don't address it."

"So, what do you want me to do about it?" asked Romulus, irritably.

"I've told you what you need to do: you need to appoint a consultative body to discuss issues and make suggestions. You need to listen to them and answer their concerns. And you can take advantage of it by delegating a lot of the boring - and undesirable - tasks to them: either as a body or as individuals. You could view them as a body that does a lot of the thinking for you and then you just make decisions. You could even appoint a couple of them - probably on a rotating basis - to keep your informed of their thinking; advanced knowledge as it were."

"Of mutiny, you mean?"

"Well, that would be an extreme case. Let's face it, they are going to be going out scouting. They will hear things. They can get together and discuss things. Then the - shall we call them *praetors*? - can come to you and brief you on what's happening. You wouldn't need to spend hours in long discussions, but everybody would feel more involved in the process."

Romulus nodded. All that made sense.

"Make it so."

"Oh no, my friend. You need to make it so. Stop humping your pretty wife for a day or two and come over to the Aventine. We'll sort it all out then."

The men gathered under a clear blue sky in the centre of the camp they had established on the Aventine.

The moment he arrived, Romulus could feel the tension. He understood what it was that Catalus had sensed - that the mood was ugly and ready for mutiny. As yet, he did not understand why. He hoped that Catalus' solution worked, although he had serious doubts about that.

He looked around him, noting faces here and there. Yes, some of these men were ready to overthrow him, possibly even murder him. Maybe they thought of themselves in his place, but could they really? Did they have the blood? Still, if you believed that all it took to be King was to be married to the Queen, then anyone had the blood.

"My friends, we grew up in Alba together; we have travelled here together; we have fought together on many occasions; and together we conquered Palatium without bloodshed. Now we are rulers here."

"You are," someone heckled.

Romulus pondered. Which was true? "No," he enunciated clearly and slowly, dragging out the thought. "*We* are the rulers here."

Someone near the front spoke up: a Brutus, but Romulus could not keep them all straight. "Yet, you rule from a soft bed with a soft woman underneath you. We live here," he swept his arm around in a circle indicating the extent of the village, "with not even captive women to use. How are we rulers? What do we rule? Ourselves?"

"It is true," he said slowly, "that not all of our plans have come to fruition as yet. It is true that you do not have the wealth, riches or women that you have been promised. But all these things will come. I have been busy, it is true, and yes, I have a woman to use. But I assure you she has been taking up very little of my time.

"I have been dealing with many difficult and trying issues. Being King is less fun than I had imagined. So many issues crop up on a daily basis. Issues of farming, and fields, rotas and crops ..." he paused theatrically. "It is, to say the least, overwhelming. Maybe I should have stuck to the life of a brigand. And I have nobody I can trust to help me with this work."

"You have us," yelled a third man. Romulus knew him: Gaius Vatius. Well, well, well. Was he on the verge of mutiny too, or was he a plant by Catalus to nudge the conversation in the right direction?

"You? You men are soldiers. I could not demean you by asking you to deal with daily trivia!"

"And yet you demean yourself."

Romulus pondered this, giving the men time to see that he was considering it in all its aspects.

"True, but that is what I must do. I am the King."

"We would help you in this as much as we would risk our lives fighting for this town or any other."

A ragged roar of assent went up from the assembled men.

Romulus was prepared to act surprised, but even so, the genuine surprise of the moment overcame him. "Really?" he gasped. "It would never have occurred ..."

The tension had drained out of the meeting. Almost at once, the body of men who had been disgruntled and mutinous were back on side. They were supporting him, helping him as they always had.

"Well, I suppose if that's what you want, I suppose ... how would this work?"

Before the sun had set, he had conscripted a hundred men to run things, discuss things, rule things and basically take all the hassle out of his life. And they had volunteered to do all of that in exchange for a few baubles: the right to be called "fathers of the country", to be collectively his "senate", and to appoint two praetors annually to oversee the kingdom.

Oh, and one big giveaway: they also had the right to sit in judgment upon him. Should they vote unanimously, they could strip him of his title of King and execute him.

Not going to happen, thought Romulus.

5. Rape of the Sabines

"Why," Romulus asked tentatively, "do I have the very strong feeling that I am not going to like what you are about to suggest?"

"Because you are afraid of my brilliance. And because you are under the thumb of the lovely Carmenta and her daughters."

Romulus rolled his eyes. He had to admit that, while he would have been *a* King without Catulus, he would certainly not have wielded the same level of power without the man.

"You have two, if not three, interleaved problems," expostulated Catalus. "First and foremost, you have anointed a hundred fearsome warriors to be 'Conscript Fathers' and yet they have no women on whom to father children. Secondly, you have the selfsame warriors - and a few hundred lesser warriors - who want to fight an enemy, and yet have no enemy to fight."

"And thirdly, since you mentioned a third?"

"Well, given those two problems, you have a group of about a hundred fearsome warriors, whom you agreed could depose you if you did not meet their needs, who are not at all happy with the job that you are doing as King and might, if pushed too far, decided that deposing you was in their best interests."

"And replace me with whom? You?"

"I imagine they would follow the same protocol that we used to at Alba, and appoint an *interrex* to govern while they sat and chose a new King. Who would then be forced - not that much persuasion would probably be needed - to marry the lovely Carmenta or one of her daughters. Any serious rival candidates for queen would then be sent off to worship Vesta - or beheaded, at their choice.

"But, yes, I would imagine a number of votes would swing my way, if only because when the *interrex* asked, I would put forward my very clear case: that I would *immediately* carry out the plan I am suggesting to you now. So, in a way, the plan is in charge and *will* happen. It's really just a question of whether you get the credit or it goes to me. Assuming it works, of course."

"Assuming," agreed Romulus, wearily. He was now totally convinced he would hate this plan, but once again had been completely outfoxed by Catulus. *Was* the man just that much more clever than him? Or was he just able to play with his mind and run rings around him? He could never tell. But, once again, he had to admit the self-evident: the man's plans generally worked.

The lull in conversation lasted a little while. Catulus was clearly unwilling to speak further until Romulus had assented to the plan; or at least assented to hearing the plan.

"Go on then," Romulus finally forced out.

"Well, it's really simple," said Catulus, smiling. "The men want women, but you don't have any. You need to get some from somewhere. The men want to fight, but there is an uneasy peace at the moment in this region. The two go together: we either start a war to get women, or else in getting some women, we will start a war."

"That is the nub of the problem," complained Romulus. "There is, as you say, a truce of sorts in place. Nobody trusts us enough to give us their daughters in marriage, but we can't take them from our defeated enemies. This is neither simple nor brilliant."

"You are trapped," countered Catalus, "in your pretty wife's apron strings. *She* wants peace, and so you are hamstrung looking for a peaceful solution. Whereas the solution lies in *provoking* a war."

"We have one hundred fierce warriors. And, as you say, a couple of hundred others. That isn't anything like enough to assault any of the towns of the Sabines or the Etruscans. The men may want to fight, but they don't want to die."

"But, you agree, they would be willing to defend our towns? And that such a defensive action, behind these walls, would almost undoubtedly be victorious?"

"Yes," said Romulus, guardedly, "but why would they?"

"The cunning part of the plan is to *provoke* them into attacking us. And to do it while solving our other problem."

"Our other problem?"

"Yes, suppose, for a minute, that we were to advertise far and wide that we were going to hold a special festival for Neptune. Suppose, for a minute, that we were to advertise free food, and entertainment. Suppose we were, in particular to make it attractive to all the young women in the neighbourhood."

"Yes..."

"And then, suppose, when they were all happily in their cups at the end of the evening, we were to ambush them, beat the men and evict them from the town, while keeping the women behind - say, around about a hundred young, nubile women."

"The men would not be armed, so they would need to go home and arm themselves..."

"And we would know they were coming and be ready to defend ourselves ... possibly even ambush them on the way."

Romulus thought long and hard.

"You're right," he conceded at last. "I don't like this plan. And what I don't like about it more than anything else is how right you are that it is the only reasonable way forward. And you are definitely right that I don't want to have to explain it to Carmenta or the girls.

"I think the only thing to do is for you to take full responsibility, Catalus. You're in charge: plan a wonderful feast. I will of course attend. Delegate the thuggery to Thalassius. He will know what to do. On the day, expect a significant portion of the population - including *our* women - to attend. I'll leave a garrison here to make sure that 'we are not tricked' or something. Just make sure none of our women get raped. And make that very clear to Thalassius. Conscript Father or not, anyone found raping a Roman woman will have his balls cut off."

"Yes, O King," murmured Catalus. "It shall all be as you wish."

In the end, probably four hundred men and women walked up the Palatine to attend the *Consualia*.

Catalus had done his job well: not only had he advertised the event far and wide, and made it live up to the billing with the free food, drink and entertainment, but he had come up with a whole *faux* history of the *Consualia* which meant that no man was allowed to come armed; no man was allowed to come unless accompanied by at least one, preferably more, women; and that part of the ceremony was to award prizes to the most beautiful women in attendance.

The more Romulus thought about it, the more he was sure *someone* would smell a rat. But the fact that his own wife and daughters had gone with the messengers to some of the various towns passing on the word and inviting friends and correspondents, all in total ignorance of what was really being planned, meant that their honest, genuine excitement rubbed off on all their acquaintances. By the day of the festival, there was no other topic of conversation in Rome, or indeed any of the neighbouring towns.

As the day wound down, everybody started to gather in the forum, ready for the entertainment to begin. First up, while people were gathering, there were jugglers and circus tricks. Then, when most of the guests were there, the mimes started. Funny, unscripted plays with almost no dialogue and predictable plots, usually involving a man's wife cheating on him, only to be discovered (usually in the act) and mock fights breaking out.

And finally, the main event. Twenty pairs of gladiators came onto the stage, ready to do combat to first blood. The same ritual as would happen at a dead man's funeral to decide who would inherit. As they paired off, Catalus shouted "strike" and they began to fight to first blood. As each man was tagged, they walked off the stage into the milling crowd, who were still being plied with free beer and wine.

The ten winners took a moment to catch their breath and were announced by Catalus. "Here we have Brutus, and Fabius, my own son Catalus, and of course we have Thalassius." At the mention of his name, Thalassius threw up his arms and yelled "Strike!". Chaos erupted.

All through the crowd, the men of Rome, denied the right to marry neighbouring women by the custom that women here were free and were the owners of everything, rose up and snatched the young women from the crowd. They set upon the visiting men with cudgels and beat them towards the nearest gate. It didn't take much effort: before long, the men were in headlong flight for the exits, taking what women they could with them. The rest were kidnapped and taken back across to the Aventine, to become wives for the first time in their life.

The repercussions were surprisingly long in coming.

Romulus had expected an attack to come within a month or two; but as Sextilis became September, then October, he realised that no attack was going to come this year. And over the course of that time, the women settled down to their lot. It obviously wasn't the same as it had been growing up in a women-dominated society, but once they had accepted their loss of station, they came to the understanding that this was forever and their daily lot was little changed. The everyday tasks of growing and preparing food; being pregnant and having children; and looking after the community were all much the same. The only thing that really felt different was being limited to one sexual partner - and the changes in the community that came from not celebrating the festivals in the traditional manner. Sexual flamboyance was out, and everything military was in.

In the end, more than a year had gone by before there were any reprisals. And even that was so slow in being organised that Romulus had over a week's warning from his spies.

"They're starting to marshal in Caenina," one reported early in November the following year. "They've brought all the harvest in, and they're starting to arm and train for combat."

"Whatever took them so long?" asked Romulus, who had been waiting for this moment for so long.

"I think it was politics as much as anything. While the women are in charge there, and have lost their daughters, the men are the ones who'll have to do the fighting, and they didn't really lose anything. And I think they recognise that beating us is not going to be easy - particularly if we have the advantage of defending the Aventine."

"Hmmm," acknowledged Romulus.

The pause grew extended for some time. Then Romulus jumped up and said, "Send for Catalus at once. We need to start planning."

"Why only one of them?" demanded Catalus when he had been given all the information. "We must have offended all of our neighbours, and yet just one of these cities has the courage to attack us, and even that after more than a year! What gives?"

"We think they tried to organise a co-ordinated response, and spent some time trying to get Titius, the warleader of the Sabine confederacy, to attack us, but he felt that we had basically done them a good turn, so wasn't going to try and punish us."

"What? How did we do them a good turn?" exclaimed Catalus.

"He thinks they had too many women in their villages, and that they needed to do something about it. We helped out by taking some of them away without actually killing them."

"Then why would they not sell them to us when we asked?"

"Because that was a *political* decision that was in the hands of the women leaders. Who, understandably, did not want to sell their daughters into what they considered to be a life of slavery. But Titius is a man, making a man's decision after the fact, which is that even if they stood a chance of beating us in battle, they would not stand very much of a chance of recovering the women. And, in reality, would probably cost the *actual lives* of more men dying in battle than the number of women who had been abducted.

"Then why Caenina, on their own? Why now?" asked Romulus. "If this Titius didn't think they could win with all the Sabine tribes, then what prospect does just one of them have, by themselves?"

"I imagine that one of the women you abducted was related to their Queen," answered Catalus. "As to why now, possibly they have elected a new Queen. Or possibly this year's Sacred King wants to go out with a bang rather than just being executed at the New Year's festival, which will be in March or April, I would think. Maybe you abducted his favourite lay."

Romulus shook his head. On such things turned the fates of whole communities. The warleader missed his favourite piece of tail. As if there wasn't plenty more where that came from in Caenina.

"Well, at least they took the bait," commented Romulus. "Now we just need to take advantage. Stay or go, do you think?"

"Oh, definitely go," said Catalus. "If we were up against the might of all the Sabines, I think we'd need the walls to even up the advantage, but against just Caenina? They'll be lucky to put a full century out in the field. And we have, what, four centuries now?"

"Easily," responded Romulus. "You know, at the rate the local wastrels have been coming in, we're going to need more women soon. But we've been able to keep up with arming them all, and training is a compulsory condition of asylum here."

The hundred men weren't even really in a column.

Each of them was acting as if they were out on a countryside walk, except with weapons. If they had any scouts out, they were simultaneously very good at hiding and very bad at scouting, Romulus thought as he watched the "column" go by. This, he thought, is going to be easy.

He had occupied a couple of hills either side of the obvious route between Caenina and Rome. Two centuries were hidden there on each side of the road. The century coming from Caenina seemed - and probably were - oblivious. Romulus turned to look at Catalus, his eyes silently asking, "can they really be this dumb?". And the small nod of the head from Catalus confirmed that he really believed that this was the way things were done around here - archaic.

When the last stragglers were in the narrow defile, he simply stood up, and without so much as looking around him, charged down the hill. This was going to be easier that stealing a rattle off a baby.

The two Roman forces met in the middle of the defile, with the hundred men of Caenina trapped between them. In moments, half the Caeninae were dead, and the other half surrendered. Not so much throwing away their weapons as never having got around to drawing them. The battle was largely over before it had started.

"Right then," said Romulus. "Who is in charge here?"

"Appius was," replied one of the men, pointing at a corpse. "But you just killed him."

"Right, well, then, what's your name?"

"Cornelius."

"Very good. Does anyone have any objection to Cornelius being in charge of you rabble? No? Good. You're now in charge, Cornelius, and that will last for as long as you do what I say. Understand?"

"Yes, lord."

"Very good. You are going to turn around now, and go back to Caenina. You are going to walk up to the gates, and get whoever is left there to open them. And then you are going to hold them open until we arrive. Is that all clear?"

"What is to stop us walking in, then closing the gates and holding the town against you."

Romulus pretended to think for a bit, and the pointed at Catalus. "You explain, Catalus."

"That's easy," he said. "You like being alive, don't you?"

The moment that the gates were opened, Romulus led his 400 out of the forest and charged the gate. Before anyone inside Caenina could react, Romulus and his men were inside, waving their swords and spears around and threatening death and destruction to anyone who opposed them.

He set his men to emptying out the huts and herding the people to the central square. When they were all gathered there, he leapt up onto a makeshift platform and addressed them.

"Look, it's really very simple. We needed women to have as wives for our families. You refused to let us marry your young women, so we were forced to take them for ourselves. They are happy now. They are contented wives and mothers.

"But you couldn't let go. You couldn't let us have wives and children. The penalty for that has been death for half the warriors of this town. And the further penalty I am going to impose is the destruction of Caenina. Before we leave tomorrow, we will burn down the whole town. And you have a choice.

"You can burn with the town, if it means that much to you. Or you can wander from here, without possessions or land. Or you can come with us and swell the burgeoning population of Rome. No, you won't have any possessions or land, except what you can carry with you; no, you won't be entitled to rule; no, you cannot be free but will have to marry the men that I designate to be your husbands. But you will be alive, you will have a place in the community, and you will be reunited with your daughters.

"You have until we leave tomorrow to decide."

He was unsurprised by how many of the villagers - both men and women - decided to make the ten mile trek to Rome in his baggage train carrying what they could while Thalassius led half a century of Roman soldiers from hut to hut burning everything that remained.

6. Arx of the Capitol

Rome now covered three hills, and had meeting points in the "forums" in the valleys between.

In addition to the Palatine and the Aventine, Romulus had fortified the Capitoline hill, distributing the men he had captured from his foreign wars over the three years that had elapsed since the kidnap of the Sabine women. First Caenina, then Antemnae, then Crustumium had attacked Rome and fallen. Finally, having seen three of his more powerful communities destroyed, Titius recognised that he had to act.

"There is no point in just charging in without a plan, however," he asserted to the gathered council. "We have seen how that has worked out for Caenina and the rest. Rome is a power to be reckoned with now, and we would be foolish to ignore its strength.

"They have built defences on all three of the hills that they have occupied; attacking any of those uphill is asking for trouble. Instead, we need to take one of those and hold it against *them*."

"How do you propose to do *that*?" demanded Mettius Curtius, a longtime rival for the job of Sabine warleader. "If we could occupy one of those hills, why not all three and call the job done?"

"Because, my dear friend, we need help to get inside, and that help is not easily forthcoming. Why do you think I have taken so long to act? But I finally have the person I need on the inside."

"You do? Who?"

"That would be telling, and I am not interested in revealing my sources at this time. The chance of casual treachery is just too high. Suffice it to say that I have a way into the Capitoline Citadel - the Arx as the Romans call it - for tomorrow night. All that remains is to muster our forces and attack."

The night was almost pitch black, just a sliver of moon, as the soldiers crept up the north face of the Capitoline hill away from the river.

"We wait here," whispered Titius as they reached a spring a hundred paces or less from the fortified fence. "Everybody keep absolutely quiet and still until our guide comes."

Time dragged on, marked only by the motion of the stars overhead in a largely cloudless sky, until they heard the chinking of a bucket chain coming down the hill. Out of the darkness appeared a young girl. She put her bucket down next to the spring and started to fill it.

"Well met, Tarpeia," said Titius, his voice above a whisper but pitched not to carry to the guards on the wall above. "We have come as we promised."

The girl turned in shock. "You!" she said. "Where are my gifts? You promised me an armring."

"Here," said Titius, pulling a silver ring from his arm and giving it to her. "Now, quietly, without talking, pick up your bucket and walk back up the hill."

She did as he instructed and led the force of eight centuries up the path to the top of the hill. When she arrived, she called out the password to the guard on the gate: "Jove Magnus Est". Slowly, the gate creaked open and the girl was admitted. Before the guards could close the gate, Titius drew his sword and, slamming his shield into the gate, barged through, stabbing the guard in the chest as he did so. Curtius came through behind, shoving his shield at the first person to stand in his way, and snapping off a sword thrust as he did so.

Quickly, the men deployed and killed as many of the Romans as they could. Before long, the noise had roused the Romans and they fled as quickly as possible. By daybreak, Titius held undisputed control of the Capitoline Arx. When they came to clean up the bodies, they found Tarpeia, still clutching the armring, crushed under a pile of bodies by the gate. Titius calmly picked up the armring and put it back on his arm.

He would never have been able to trust her.

Romulus seethed.

Obviously he had been betrayed on the Capitol. He didn't know how, but there was no other way that the Capitol could have fallen in the way that he was being told it had. And, from what he was learning, the enemy had taken it with something like eight centuries of men and killed or evicted all of the inhabitants - not just his soldiers, but the womenfolk too. Which meant that the prospects of convincing somebody inside the fort to betray it back to him were limited, to say the least.

He wanted to scream; to rant and rave; to wave his arms about; to hack somebody to death for this reverse. But he knew none of those things would do any good. No, it was time to be calm and think. What could they do?

Eventually he asked the question out loud: "what can we do?"

"I don't think we have any choice," replied Catalus. "Unless we want these interlopers in our midst for forever, we need to evict them. And there's only one way we're going to do that: a frontal assault."

"Can that work?" demanded Romulus. "Surely, with eight centuries in that fort they could hold it against two or three times the number we could possibly bring to bear."

"Yes, except..." countered Catalus.

"Except what?"

"Except that they will not be satisfied with taking one of the forts - and the least desirable at that. They will want to take the other two as well."

"So we could just wait here for them; is that what you're saying?"

"Probably not. If we don't move, they probably won't move. They'll just sit there until we come out, and then they'll sally forth and attack us if they think they have the numbers. Don't forget that we stored enough grain in there to last our garrison for a couple of years. It will probably last them much the same, even if they can't smuggle more in. Which we can't stop them doing without completely investing the place."

"So..."

"So, if we attack the Arx, then when they repel us, there's a good chance that they follow us out, attempting to finish the job as it were. If we retreat back to the Palatine, we may even be able to get them to follow us up that hill. And then ..."

"And then we can turn the tables on them and attack back down the hill," concluded Romulus. "Yes, I can see how that could work. What about the women?"

"Which women?"

"The ones who were evicted from the Arx last night."

"What about them?"

"Where are they now?"

"Safely inside the Aventine fort."

"Very good. Keep them there. And keep a century in there as well to guard it and keep them under watchful eye. I know somebody betrayed the Arx, and I can't help feeling that it was a woman. The same here on the Palatine. Let's leave a century here and keep the women under observation."

"That doesn't leave us many men for a full frontal assault on the Arx. Which, I don't need to remind you, was built specifically for defending against a full frontal assault."

"True enough, but if they have bribed a woman in one of the citadels to betray us, how can you be sure that they haven't bribed one in all three?"

The attack on the walls stalled, as they all knew it would.

Romulus shouted "retreat!" and the men fell away from the walls.

While they were regrouping, the gate opened and, with a loud bellow, Mettius Curtius led his century out of the Arx and charged down the hill into the middle of Romulus' army. First to react was Hostius Hostilius, who led his century at the charge to meet Curtius. Not a fair fight; the Sabines had the advantages of both the hill and the momentum. Hostilius organised his men as quickly as he could, and built a shield wall three men deep with swords at the front and spears reaching over from the back; but it was all he could do to hold it together as Curtius muscled in from above.

Meanwhile, Romulus was able to stop his men from fleeing everywhere and gathered them together just on the Palatine side of the forum. Invoking Jupiter Stator, he promised to dedicate a temple at that very spot if his men were victorious.

Hostilius was retreating steadilly, but holding his line firm. All he needed to do was to slowly back down to the forum and then he could retreat through or around Romulus' line.

"Back step! Open shields! Thrust!" he called, over and over again. With each motion, his line of men would take a step back, then move their left arm to one side, exposing themselves very briefly while thrusting out with their swords. Meanwhile, the men in the back row were thrusting, thrusting, thrusting their seven foot spears over the heads of the front two ranks into their opponents faces. The men in the middle row were mainly just shoving on the men in front of them, pressing them into the attacking Sabines.

"Aargh!" Suddenly, Hostilius was down, bleeding from a spear thrust to his neck. The man behind him quickly took his place in the front rank, driving hard with his spear. Meanwhile two men in the back row reached down and picked up his body, quickly carrying it away to Romulus.

But the damage was done. Not so much to the structure of the line as to the morale. Hostilius had been the kingpin which had held the century together. Without that, the structure fell apart. First the spearmen turned and ran, then the second line, and finally the front rank turned tail and ran as quickly as they could for the safety of the forum and Romulus' men.

Not always quickly enough, though. One of the problems with running away, rather than the steady falling back that Hostilius had been attempting is that you expose your back to the enemy's swords. And in that heartbeat between stopping attacking and getting away, you are at great risk. Twelve of the front rank were hacked down as they tried to retreat.

Curtius let out a bellow and a boast: "these men may be up to abducting Sabine women, but they cannot take on an army of Sabine men! Let's get them boys!" And he charged down the hill, losing the structure of his unit as he ran.

That might have been fine, had Romulus been waiting for him still on the downslope; or, had he not had time to discipline and organise his men. But as Curtius ran headlong across the forum, he started to climb the Palatine hill. Straight into the arms of Romulus' six centuries. Romulus cast his javelin, hitting Mettius Curtius straight in the mouth.

"And charge!" commanded Romulus as the enemy commander fell to the ground. "Keep a tight formation, though!"

The men charged forward as they had trained - oh, *so often* - slamming into the Sabine shield wall in a perfect line, the second rank literally driving the first rank into the enemy, shields first; the third rank reaching over and stabbing, stabbing down with their spears. The Sabines could not help but retreat, possibly even regroup.

From the corner of his eye, Romulus saw movement coming from the Palatine hill. He didn't really have time to study it, but he couldn't ignore it either. Some group of people were coming down the hill at a run, off to his right hand side.

"Prepare to defend right flank! Reserves to the right!"

Suddenly the pressure eased on the line as the Sabines retreated. Romulus took the opportunity to issue more commands:

"Hold fast! Step back! Wrap right flank!"

Having done that, he took the opportunity to look more closely at the party coming down the hill.

It was women.

"What is going on, here?" he demanded.

A group of women came up the small gap between the opposing forces. Now it would be impossible to start fighting again without killing all these women - daughters on the one hand; wives on the other.

"Stop! Stop! Stop!" yelled the leader. "What are you doing? Yes, fathers, we understand that you have come to rescue us, but you have taken too long! Had you come within days of our capture and rape, we would have welcomed the bloodshed and rescue. But now we are beloved wives, parents of young children; we cannot return to you as we were without denying the parentage of our children.

"And you, husbands, we understand that you feel the need to protect what you have stolen from our parents, but consider this: they are still our parents, and we grew up with them. Why should they die at your hands?

"Surely we can all be reasonable people here?"

Romulus could still feel the killing spirit coursing through his veins. He wanted to lash out with his sword, kill these interlopers. But slowly, so slowly, he came back to his senses, to find Catalus talking.

"You are quite right, we have no need to fight. But we do need to have the Arx back. We cannot countenance anyone - even your putative blood relatives - holding onto a key part of our defences."

"Surely we can do better than that," she responded. "Can we not accept that some of them will want to come and live here? Some of our mothers, who we actually know, could come too. And some of us, those of us who want to, could go and live in the towns and cities of the Sabines?"

"Why would any man want to go and live in a place where he would be a second-class citizen?" asked Romulus. "A place where he cannot own land or cattle? Why would a man give up knowing who his children are, and just share in the collective sense of the population of the village?"

"I do not know," she responded. "But I do know that I miss my mother dearly, and I would like to return to her. I would be happy to forego my normal privileges of rank, and to take my husband and children with me. I do not know if he would agree to go with me, but given that he is of no rank here, he would not lose anything really, would he?"

Romulus thought about this for a while, then looked back and Titius across from him. Part of him still wanted to impale him on his sword, but the calmer part of him knew that many men would die here today unless ...

Catalus responded for him, "Yes, that would be acceptable to us if it is acceptable to Warleader Titius. We would want control of the Arx back, but any who wanted to stay would be welcome. And any families that wanted to leave and go to towns and villages of the Sabines would be welcome to do so.

"But no woman may leave without her husband."

7. Death of Romulus

Romulus called the Senate together.

"It has come to my attention that some among you are discontented with my rule. I would have this out with you now. I have indicated that I wish my son Titus to rule after me, and it seems that many of you are not content with this. I will have a division. All those who wish Titus to rule after me pass to my right, all those who do not, pass to my left."

"Not so fast, Romulus," countered Fabius. "We need to discuss this first. I, for one, do not feel that your son Titus has what it takes to rule this community. He is selfish and thinks only of himself. He does not care about the greater good of the community, and he does not care about our relationships with our neighbours. In short, I do not think Titus would be interested in serving anybody except himself. And, I for one, would find that intolerable and demand the right of combat to contest it."

"Furthermore," expounded Hostilius, "this is not the way in which we have ordered ourselves in the past. Yes, I know that the Greeks did it, but we are not in Greece. Even the Etruscans do not blindly follow father with son. We need to follow our own traditions, and the tradition that we follow is that *after* the death of the king, all those who would be king present themselves in the forum and fight to first blood. That is our way."

"Although," interjected Catalus, "it is not necessarily the best way. We are a group of one hundred men here. The best men, may I say, in Rome. Why can we not look through our ranks and choose the best man for the job?"

"Or indeed, outside our ranks," remarked Horatius. "I, for one, would much rather have King Titius than King Titus. There is a man who understands both men and the needs of a community. Why not ask him to move from Cures to Rome and become our King?"

"Because he's too old," mumbled Fabius under his breath. No point replacing one old geezer with another one more likely to pop his clogs first."

There was a smattering of laughter around Fabius, those that could hear him.

Lucius Forfatius rose to his feet. "I feel that it is my burden to remind the King that when he appointed us - or our fathers - to this body, he agreed to be bound by its decisions and, most important of all, he agreed to be bound by the unanimous verdict of this body that he should be deposed.

"*I* move that all those who feel that Romulus has outstayed his welcome pass to the right. If unanimous, I declare that Romulus be deposed immediately."

The house flew into uproar. *Surely* that was treason? But enough men there had been alive when Romulus had formed the Senate to nod sagely: yes, it was true. Others had heard it from their fathers. The hubbub grew louder as senators argued backwards and forwards.

"In conclusion, there is one point above all that I want to make, esteemed fathers," enunciated Gaius Julius Proculus carefully at the end of a long and meandering speech during which much of the house had simmered down, "which is that heaven knows that the only valid grounds for kingship is to be married to the familiar of Carmenta - who in this generation is the youngest daughter of Romulus, that is the fourth Romula.

"This young lady, as can be imagined, since she is still but eleven summers old, is still unmarried and indeed a virgin. But the genuine right to rule here can only be held by him who marries her and makes her fruitful. Given her current virgin state, it matters little to the discussion at hand - we can still find a man to our taste and marry him to her. But, of course, the man we find may not already have a wife."

Marriage in Rome was for life (or at least until death); divorce was at that time unheard of. Nor could any man marry more than one woman. In short, any man who wanted to be king had to be single. That reduced the field dramatically, and made it much more likely that a man from outside the community would be chosen.

But, more than that, if Proculus' view were to be accepted, it positively ruled the king's son out of the running. Among other things that were strictly forbidden by the Romans was an incestuous marriage - as one between the king's son and daughter could not help but be.

"No, no, no, a thousand times no," screamed Romulus. "You are not getting away with that, Gaius Julius. That is the old way, the way we have rejected. In Rome, men rule as *men*, not as mere adjuncts of women. My daughter has no special powers or privileges; those go to my son."

"I did not say your daughter, O King," responded Proculus, remaining calm under the weight of this diatribe. "I said the daughter of your wife. Specifically the youngest daughter of your wife. That is how the territory of Rome has always been ruled, and how you obtained your mandate to rule."

"I gained my right to rule by conquest," objected Romulus. "And I will defend my right to rule by the sword and the spear. Do you challenge me, Gaius Julius?"

"Not I," replied Proculus. "I am now too old and infirm. I will give you counsel, and I will point out the truth. But challenge you I cannot."

"But I will!" exclaimed Fabius, moving into the centre of the meeting room. "I challenge you to a duel to the death, for I will not lay down under this tyranny. It is my right to contest for the right to rule here, and I challenge you to deny that. Come down off that throne and fight me!" And he drew his sword.

Romulus stood, ponderously, and stepped down off the dais, drawing his sword as he did so. Two steps later, he swung hard at Fabius' head. Fabius snapped off a quick parry, and then a riposte. Romulus was experienced and quick, but he was old and no match for the vigour of the younger man. Within a few blows Romulus was down on the ground.

"Finish it!" he demanded. "It is the only way I will give in." And started to rise.

Fabius finished it.

8. Interrex

They decided to call the time between the kings an "interregnum". Practical people, Romans.

And, in lieu of a king, they appointed an *interrex* - a king between the kings. They chose Gaius Julius Proculus as *interrex* on account of his age - he had basically already rejected the top job.

"But," he warned them, "I will only do the job for a few days while we sort out how we are going to choose a new king. And to cover up the murder of Romulus."

"He was not murdered!" countered Fabius. "I killed him in a duel, fair and square."

"Indeed so," said Proculus calmly. "I saw you do it with my own eyes. But spare a thought, if you will, for the couple of thousand men and women of Rome who did *not* see it happen. One hundred exclusive men go into a room with Romulus, and he does not come out alive. What do you think happened?"

And he went out to call the people together into the Forum.

"And a great storm came down, and a great wind, and we were separated from Romulus, much though we tried to stay near him, and then we heard the voice of Jupiter calling from the sky, calling Romulus to him, and then we were blinded by the lightning of the storm, and deafened by the noise of the wind, and then we saw him no more.

"When the storm had passed, we searched everywhere for him, but nowhere could we find him. We know that Jupiter must have called him home, not willing that his burial place should become desecrated over the years."

Nobody in the crowd believed this. Any of it.

But also, nobody in the crowd could challenge it, because they did not know what had happened. And was it not sacrilegious to suggest either that Jupiter could not have summoned up a storm and taken Romulus with him? Or, on the other hand, to claim that Romulus was not worthy to be taken.

"So, is he with the Gods, now, then?" shouted someone in the crowd.

"Indeed he is; he must be, since his body is not anywhere on earth," lied Proculus calmly, knowing exactly what his fellow senators had done with the all-too-physical body of Romulus. "And more than that, I say unto you that he is with the Gods *as* a God, the God Romulus, who will ever after look after the interests of Rome."

Three days later, Proculus called the Senate back into session.

"I warned you that I would only be interrex for a few days. I have sent out invitations to all the villages round about inviting their finest men to come to the Forum in Rome within ten days. There, they may fight to first blood to determine their right to marry Romula and become King of Rome.

"Needless to say, anybody *in* Rome is also welcome to contest this trial. Whether a member of this body or not, you are welcome to try your strength in repeated single combat. Yes, that includes you, Fabius.

"But be warned: physical strength will not be enough. You must then convince this body of your suitability to the role. Failure to do so will lead to expulsion or death. Physical prowess alone is not enough to govern Rome.

"And I will resign as *interrex* before the contest. Catalus, will you take over as *interrex* for the contest to determine the next King of Rome?"

Catalus rose from his stool. "Yes, I will," he intoned.

In the end, over thirty men presented themselves for the challenge.

Among the contestants was one Numa, who had been born in Cures to one of the queen's daughters, Pompilia, who had been kidnapped at the Consualia; after the war of the capitol, her husband had moved back with her to Cures to be near her mother; twenty years later, she had inherited the throne and developed a close relationship with Rome.

Over the years, the culture of Cures had become more male-centric akin to Rome: Pompilia accepted her marriage to her husband as binding and sexually exclusive. As such, she was no longer able to take part in the New Year's Day fertility rites, which devolved instead on the high priestess. But even so, there was no place for male inheritance of power. Without question, the throne would pass to one of her daughters.

Which left Numa in a place familiar to many men throughout the history of those times: brought up in the royal family, he had education and experience in ruling, but nothing to rule. Which left him two options: stay in Cures as a military man; or go off in search of another queendom looking for a sacred king.

The election in Rome seemed a perfect opportunity: not only was his father a Roman, who had inculcated him with an understanding of the culture and traditions of Rome; but he was uniquely qualified as a monarch-in-waiting. Although he despised war and fighting, thought them unnecessarily inefficient ways of resolving issues, he had been thoroughly trained in all aspects of war, from fighting with shield and spear, to commanding both small units and large forces.

He easily won his first two bouts, drawing blood on his third stroke, and quickly became a favourite to win the physical contest of the duels. His third - and final - bout was against Fabius. Altogether a trickier proposition than the first two. Fabius was an experienced duellist, who had practised all his life, had killed Romulus in a duel, and believed very strongly that might was right and that he had earned the right to rule Rome by the simple fact of having killed Romulus.

Fabius started the duel on the attack: a series of quick blows to head and body, combined with deft shield work pushed Numa back towards the rope marking out the gladiatorial ring. But Numa was possessed of infinite patience and dedication. He knew that while a duel could be lost in the first few blows, it could not easily be *won* in the first few. He kept his shield up and his spear poised, ready to counter any blows that made it past his shield. Pressing forward with his shield, he used the opportunity to turn Fabius and move closer to the centre of the ring. Fabius turned and sent down another flurry of blows with his spear. Again, Numa blocked them all with his shield, waiting for Fabius to give away his pattern. Everyone had one, he knew.

After a few more combinations, Numa decided to try and upset Fabius' rhythm. As Fabius started to attack, he pushed his shield forward and darted his spear out at Fabius' head. Fabius ducked behind his shield and pressed hard into it, trying to knock Numa off balance. Expecting that, Numa retreated a step, trying to encourage Fabius to fall. Fabius was wise to that trick and backed off. The two men stood for a moment, breathing heavily.

As Fabius moved to close the gap again, Numa leapt forward and to his right, bashing his shield into Fabius' and chancing a blow around the outside, trying to get behind Fabius' shield. It didn't work, but it certainly gave the older man something to think about. Then, suddenly, both of them were thrusting with their spears, parrying blows on their shields and dancing around the ring. Spontaneous applause broke out from the audience: surely one of these two was the man they were looking for?

The fight could not last at that tempo. As the shields came together, Numa twisted his as he backed away. Fabius, expecting a push, stumbled momentarily. But it was enough; pressing hard on his shield, Numa forced Fabius to the ground, then drove his spear through the gap into this thigh, then retreated from the ring, throwing his arms - and weapons - up and shouting "first blood".

The applause was universal.

In the end, four men were chosen to be interviewed in front of the whole Senate.

There was only really one question: "what would you propose doing if you were elected King of Rome?"

Fabius had a simple, direct answer.

"I would work for the greater glory of Rome. I would enlarge the size of the standing army, making it three centuries. I would increase the training amongst the other men of Rome to ensure that when we went on campaign we could always call on at least twenty centuries. I would make war on all those lands that do not accept our hegemony; and I would force all those lands to accept the *paterfamilias* - the concept that men, and men only, decide how cities are governed. Men are stronger, and strength wins."

Numa had a more nuanced view.

"War cannot give life; it can only take it away. Every time we go off to fight, less men come back than left. Yes, it is glorious to fight and to win battles; yes, sacking cities brings booty and wealth from other places to Rome. But, I ask you, does it actually create wealth? No, it just transfers it from elsewhere to here.

"And often it doesn't even do that. How much money do we spend on fighting wars? How much could we do with the time and materials involved in making shields, and spears? How much time do we waste in training men to fight? Can we not do better?

"I see the need for a standing army; and I see the need to have other men ready to defend the city against attack. But can we not gain more through investments in agriculture; in metalwork; in trade? After all, most cities will not trade with you if they are afraid that you are only scoping out their wealth prior to attacking them.

"But I would rather see us work towards growing our own community: improving farming, improving metalworking, carpentry; improving the salt trade; building ships and barges to improve trade between us and Ostia, and Ostia and the rest of the world around the sea."

In the end, Numa was chosen by an almost unanimous vote of the Senate.

The following week, on a day that was held to be auspicious by all the priests and augurs, Numa married Romula. And settled down to be a King who negotiated before he fought. He dedicated a number of temples, including to Janus, the two-faced god: a god of opening and closing; of war and peace. And he closed the gates of the temple, indicating that Rome was at peace with all her neighbours.

And he invested in improving the way everything was done at Rome. Farming improved returns dramatically; although he built no roads, he levelled and improved the communications along the Tiber from the salt mines down to Ostia. And he built a fleet of barges to transport wealth up and down the Tiber from Ostia.

9. Vestal Virgins

"And what stops their husbands fighting for the throne when I die?"

Numa looked at Romula: this was not an idle or rhetorical question. They now had five living daughters as well as their four (largely irrelevant) sons. While tradition held that the spirit of Carmenta travelled in the youngest daughter, that would not stop an enterprising husband of one of the older daughters from claiming otherwise (or even, if unscrupulous enough, eliminating the younger ones).

"You could always not marry them."

"How would I justify that? They are the most eligible maidens in the country. Men will come from near and far to marry them."

"And that is precisely your problem. Unscrupulous men. Men who will fight for power."

"So the question remains: how would I justify keeping our daughters virgins their entire lives?"

"You don't need to keep them virgins their entire lives: just long enough for Egeria to be married, and for her husband to solidify his claim to power once you have gone."

"Yes, yes, but how: tell me that, how?"

"Something religious, I would think. You have done enough there already. And so much of it has been suppressing the promiscuous sexual rituals that setting up your own daughters as virgins would be in line with that."

Numa pondered. He knew she was right. And she was certainly right about his suppression of the archaic female-dominated sexual orgies that had constituted the old religion. Well, in some ways, he'd had to. The only way in which he could be sure that *his* children inherited was to stop Romula from having sex with anyone other than him. And any number of other men felt the same way. From there it had been a small step to appointing a high priest - the Pontifex Maximus - when the old high priestess had died. Without a priestess to lead the orgies, they had died away, replaced by a bloodless religion based on animal sacrifice, rather than human.

"I am going to create a college of six virgins dedicated to Vesta, the Goddess of the Hearth."

He had called the Senate into session to promulgate his plan.

"As you know, Vesta is the Goddess of fire and flame, and is our only guarantor of fire in our hearths. But do we do enough to worship her? Last winter, in that dreadful storm, most of the fires throughout the city died. Only through the intervention of the Goddess herself did Jove agree to send a thunderbolt to set fire to that house in the forum. I now propose to build a temple to Vesta on that spot, and will dedicate four of my daughters to be her priestesses. They will be responsible for ensuring that there is always fire in one of the six hearths in the temple: one for each of the priestesses."

"Who will be the other two priestesses?"

"I am open to suggestions, Proculus. If you have a virgin daughter, you are welcome to put her name forward. As is anyone in this august body. There are only three conditions for consideration: firstly, the girl must be at least ten years old; secondly, she must be a virgin, unmarried and not even betrothed; and thirdly, she must be noble, and endowed with sufficient funds to provide for her needs for twenty years.

"For that is the time that we will expect our virgins to serve Vesta: twenty years. At the end of that time, they will be free to marry or not as they see fit."

10. Tullus Hostilius

A few years later, Egeria turned 16, and became eligible for marriage.

Against his better judgment, Numa invited all the young noblemen from all the cities around about - together with those of his Senate - who wanted to compete for the chance to become his son-in-law and, by extension, his heir.

Of the twenty-two men who presented themselves, there could only be one winner: Tullus Hostilius, grandson of the legendary fighter Hositilius who had first supported, then opposed Romulus. He had inherited his father's seat in the Senate (who had, in turn, inherited it from his father) and had both supported and opposed Numa by turns - but always intelligently and with cogent reasons. Inasmuch as Numa would have preferred somebody else, he would have preferred a more peaceful man. Over the years, they had argued more than anything about the merits of war and peace. Numa could only hope that Tullus would calm down as he matured, and as he faced the actual choices and consequences of those choices. But Numa knew, too, that part of the problem was of his own making: having pursued a policy of peace for thirty years now, none of the young men of the city had ever experienced war at first hand - the occasional skirmish or conflict perhaps, but not the all out footslog of a major infantry engagement where your friends died in the front lines.

By the end of March, Tullus and Egeria were married, and Tullus became heir apparent to the throne. For better or worse. Now aged 30, he pushed for a more pro-active foreign policy, interpreting even trivial slights as a major affront to the dignity of Rome.

And Rome was now very dignified. Having been at peace for over 30 years, and having a stable family structure, the people had grown rich. Any number of temples and other public buildings had sprung up in and around the forum, and there were men to spare from farming for other trades, even as merchants. As the population grew, so did the number of houses and even the new *insulae*: a version of a house with two or three stories, allowing multiple individuals or families to share the same ground area. In fact, Rome had grown so rich that it could no longer feed itself: it had to import grain and olives from the neighbouring towns. A problem if it ever decided to go to war with those towns again.

"It is the Etruscans we need to be wary of, my son," intoned Numa to Tullus.

"But the Albans are attacking us on an almost daily basis," retorted Tullus. "It is an affront to the dignity of Rome."

"And our men are raiding their cattle too," sighed Numa wearily. "It comes from having too many cattle and too many men and not enough land. Both Alba and we are at peace and are prospering mightily. That is what is attracting the Etruscans to our neighborhood. They are old and weak; we are young and vigorous. We need to work together with the Albans to evict the Etruscans."

So the argument raged between the two: patient father, headstrong son. It went on for almost ten years - the ten years that Tullus was learning his trade from his father-in-law. It took place in private, at dinners, in the Senate, and in the public forum at Rome. And all the while Tullus led his small bands of raiders out to attack the Albans; cattle were carted off and farmers killed. All the time Tullus railed against the fact that he could not declare war on the Albans without his father-in-law's say-so.

Until Numa died.

This time there were no challengers.

Tullus had cemented his authority as the heir apparent and it only needed one interrex to have both the Senate and People vote through their approval. Tullus went into the Forum and addressed the People:

"Today I become King of Rome. While I understand what my father-in-law did, and why he dawdled and tried to negotiate with our enemies, I say that I will not put up with it a moment longer. These cattle raids must stop, and they must stop NOW! It is intolerable to the dignity of Rome that we should put up with it any longer.

"But, in light of the delicacy of relations between states, I will this day send two ambassadors to Alba Longa with our final demand: either they apologise and make full restitution for the damage they have caused to our farmers, or we will visit war on them such as they have never seen before.

"For, my fellow citizens, we are ready to fight. While we have been at peace for these last decades, we have still prepared for war. We have grouped our people into centuries, and they have drilled with spear, javelin, sword and shield. Our centuries are ready to fight and to storm Alba Longa, should they refuse us requital!

"Now, come here, and let us choose two messengers from among us, that they may be sent unto the King of Alba Longa."

Horatius and Fabius were shown into the court of King Cluilius.

"Sir, with all good deference and judgment, we require requital of the indemnity against which we have previously informed you forthwith. Our lord the King informs us than in the absence of an admission on your part as to the forthcoming nature of this indemnity, we will be left no choice but to declare war on Alba Longa, and to raze it to the ground and deport all its goods and populace."

Cluilius tried to keep his stunned reaction off his face. First off, the amount that they had demanded in compensation was out of all proportion to the damage done in a few cattle raids - even if they hadn't been mutual; he had sent his own delegates to the court of the new King Tullus to try and sort it out.

"My friends, surely you cannot be serious. I accept that there have been cattle raids; and I accept that there has been fault on both sides. In fact, I have sent a delegation to your new king to try and resolve these very issues."

"That can be of no concern to us," interjected Horatius. "We have very strict instructions from our King: either pay the indemnity, or feel the weight of Heaven fall on your heads. We have lost patience. You have thirty days."

Meanwhile, Alba's representatives, Curiatius and Fuffetius, were meeting with King Tullus.

"Please, my friends," Tullus implored, "you must be tired from your long journey. Take your ease, take a day or two to rest and refresh yourselves, and then let us meet again in a couple of days."

Taking Tullus at face value, and thinking that he wanted them to be in a good frame of mind to enter into discussions, they did as he bid, and took a couple of days to rest and recover their strength. And to indulge in the food and drink that he plied them with. So that, by the time they finally settled down to negotiate with the King, Horatius and Fabius had already returned with King Cluilius' refusal to pay the ridiculous indemnity that they had demanded.

"So," Tullus began, "how may I be of assistance to Alba."

"We have been instructed by the King to see if we can put a stop to these annoying cattle raids," replied Curiatius.

"Indeed," Tullus responded, "has your King had a re-think?"

"It was never our King's policy to support the cattle raids," replied Fuffetius. "They have been individual farmers, generally acting in retaliation against your farmers' aggression. The King would like to see an end to them and harmonious relations with Rome."

"That is not what my delegates told me," he said, snapping his fingers at Horatius. "Tell us what the King said, Horatius."

"He said that he refused to pay any indemnity and that if we wanted anything from him, we would need to take it by force."

Curiatius and Fuffetius looked at each other. Something, they knew, was wrong here, but they could not outright call the King of Rome and his accredited ambassador liars to their faces.

"Is that so, indeed?" temporized Curiatius. "That is not something of which I was aware. We were sent with instructions to see on what terms we could agree peace, and how we could enforce that peace. Is there no room for discussion on those points?"

"Apparently not," lamented King Tullus. "It would seem your own King has sold you out. We will see you on the battlefield, gentlemen."

The battle was arranged for three weeks later.

The heralds had agreed the location, and where the armies should stage, along with the date and time that the battle would start.

Horatius was commanding the Roman right wing, while Fabius had the left. Naturally, the king had taken the centre for himself.

Opposing them, Cluilius had the centre, and Curiatius the right, opposite Fabius. Fuffetius marshalled the left, opposing Horatius.

At the appointed time, the heralds blew their trumpets, and the two armies advanced on each other. The Romans were in a slightly disadvantageous position, marching uphill into the morning sun. But, as Tullus had observed, it can often be an advantage to appear to be at a disadvantage.

As they came closer, the Romans threw their javelins and charged, running the last twenty paces up the gentle slope into a force that was dodging missiles. Using their locked shields as a ram, they battered into the Albans and kept running. The Albans, unprepared for the violence of this assault took a step back and lost the battle then and there.

It took another hour of hard slog for the Romans to convert that initial impetus into a full-scale rout, but the discipline of the line held. Press forward; open shield; stab with the short *gladius* sword; close the shield; repeat. The continual pressure was what did for the Albans: they were more used to individual combat and swirling longswords; in this confined space, the longsword could neither stab through the gap in the shields, or strike a blow over the top.

It was Horatius on the right who finally crushed the resistance, pushing Fuffetius back and back, bending his line from where it met the centre until it broke. Horatius, fighting in the front line, was one of the first through the gap, from where he could start stabbing the Alban defenders from behind. As they turned to face him, more gaps opened up in the Alban lines, and more Roman soldiers poured through the gaps. Until, finally, the whole of the Alban lines crumbled and they turned and fled.

At which point, it was Fabius and his men on the left who had the most energy remaining. They charged after the fleeing Alban soldiers, killing them indiscriminately in their hundreds.

Finally, they reached the walls of Alba Longa, which kept its gates open to allow the fleeing soldiers back in.

And the pursuing Romans.

The sack of a city is never pleasant.

The sack of Alba Longa was particularly brutal, since it began with the end of the battlefield massacre. Naturally, men ran to their own houses, hoping to defend individually what they had failed to defend as a collective. It didn't work, of course, as the Roman army followed not as individuals but as groups of anywhere from a decury to a century. Against one or two men, the results were a foregone conclusion, as were the knock-on consequences for the women and children left defenceless.

And then there was the fire.

Inevitably, even had some Roman soldiers not used fire as a weapon of terror, fires would have spread from fire spilled from hearths. But many of the soldiers, frustrated by women who tried to resist rape, or tried to keep their children safe, picked up brands from the fires and deliberately set fire to the women or to the houses. Soon the whole settlement was burning and everybody - Roman and Alban alike; soldiers and civilians alike - was fleeing out of the gates into the hills around.

Tullus ordered such soldiers as he still had control of to round them all up and organize them for the march back to Rome.

At Rome, Tullus changed his attitude. Instead of consigning all of the captives to slavery, he honoured them as citizens of Rome. The men he enrolled according to their status and wealth at Alba, even though much of that wealth had (literally) gone up in smoke; he expected that they would make more.

And so came to Rome some of the names that would redound to glory in the years to come: Julius Caesar, Claudius, Marcellus.

11. Ancus Marcius

Tullus was now old. And vulnerable.

He had had a good run, all things considered, and had managed to grow the population of Rome considerably, mainly through conquest.

But his crushing and destruction of Alba remained a weakness and a point of resentment amongst the people. Ten years after the destruction, he had been forced by Gaius Julius Caesar and Appius Claudius to institute a festival - the festival of the Alban Mount - to "propitiate the gods who had been desecrated through the destruction". Caesar - a member of the descendants of the female line at Alba Longa, and thus one who considered himself worthy to be a king - arranged for himself to be appointed supervisory priest of the festival; a position he had held for the rest of his life.

And, as part of the festival, Tullus had to consent to being challenged for the right to his throne. Only trueborn heirs of the queens of Alba Longa were entitled to challenge, and given that the female line had been stamped out in the destruction of Alba Longa, they were a dying breed. On three previous occasions, Tullus had been challenged, and each time he had emerged the victor. Three dead from combat; many others - such as Caesar - had died of old age, having lived a good life without feeling the need to challenge Tullus for the kingship of Rome. His children, of course, did not "inherit" membership of the royal family of Alba - that could only be passed down directly from the mother; and there were no mothers left.

Which meant that now, some 45 years after the destruction of Alba, there were three men left who were capable of challenging Tullus. Two of them - a Junius and a Claudius - were too old and infirm themselves to challenge Tullus; but Ancus Marcius, born in the year of the destruction of Alba, was 46 and in the prime of life. This, he felt, was his time. All he had to do was challenge Tullus; kill him in a duel; marry his youngest daughter, the very pretty Hostilia, currently a vestal virgin but that could be sorted out; and become the new King of Rome.

The herald blew his horn to announce the start of Day 3 of the Festival of the Alban Mount: challenge day.

"Do any here among you, claiming direct descent from the goddess of Alba Longa, wish to challenge our noble King Tullus Hostilius for the title of King of Rome?"

Silence greeted this enquiry. Tullus, sitting on his throne, looked around him, then turned to the herald and nodded. The herald, noticing this gesture, lifted his spear, ready to thump it down to close off the challenge window, when a voice spoke up, clearly, distinctly, but not shouting.

"I do."

Gasps came from many of the onlookers who had not been expecting a challenge. Slowly Ancus Marcius walked out in front of the crowd and faced the king.

"I, Ancus Marcius, do hereby challenge you, Tullus Hostilius. Firstly, for the simple opportunity to become king in your stead: a place to which I feel entitled by right of birth. Secondly, to atone for your cruel murder of my mother and father in the destruction of Alba Longa, lo, these 45 years ago."

Nobody said anything; the silence stretched for many heartbeats. Then Tullus stood and drew his sword - the usually ceremonial longsword; the sword of the challenge. Marcius threw off his cloak and drew his sword - likewise a long sword, ill-equipped for the day to day fighting in the front line, but ideally suited to single combat. And then took two steps forward and struck.

The iron swords came together with a belling clang. Tullus was quick to disengage and then to strike back. Marcius was ready with his parry. Tullus was stronger than he had realized, but Marcius knew that he was now an old man and would not have the stamina of a man two-thirds of his age. All he had to do was keep striking, parrying, turning, circling and wear the old man down.

When it came, it came suddenly. Marcius raised his sword and swung down in a large overhead blow. Tullus was late on the parry, and couldn't hold it. Without even trying, the strength of Marcius' blow went on, down through the parry, and struck Tullus in the head - an almost fatal blow. Immediately Tullus collapsed. Marcius went in for the killing blow, but when he saw Tullus lying there - his body sprawled out, his sword off to one side, blood streaming from the wound to his head, he found he couldn't deliver it. And turned away.

"Somebody minister unto the King," he yelled.

Quickly, a couple of senators rushed forward and began the process of binding him up. They carried him off to his tent, and there the doctors tried their best to help him. But to no avail. In the dark reaches of the night, word came to Marcius that the King was dead. He was still standing there, on the challenge ground, unable to believe that this was how it felt. He had assumed he would feel elated - giddy, even. He had killed many men before, so it wasn't strictly the killing that worried him; it was killing a god on earth.

"Your majesty," Cladius greeted him.

He looked up, unfamiliar with the honorific.

"Yes, the King is dead," Claudius confirmed. "And I don't think we need an interrex to tell us who the next king is going to be."

"No," responded King Ancus Marcius. "But we do need one until I can confirm my kingship by a marriage to Hostilia."

Ancus and Hostilia were happily married for twenty years.

They had four children: two boys and two girls. Both of the girls were called Marcia, of course, but the younger one had the nickname Tanaquil (or "gift of God") because her birth had been difficult, but she (and her mother) had nevertheless survived.

She was a strange child. Some described her as "not altogether there", while others saw in her the kind of prophetic abilities attributed to Kassandra of old: seeing the truth, but not being able to convince anyone else of it. At age 12, when playing a game of "I Spy" with one of her governesses in the forum, she pointed to a man and said, "I see my husband". Her governess was flummoxed by this remark, since obviously the girl was too young to be married and, moreover, as the hieress to the throne was not even engaged yet.

"What?" she mumbled. But the girl was already away, striding up to the man and plucking a flower from her hair.

"Hello, sir," she greeted the man. "I see you are not from around here, but I see that one day you will be King. Come with me and let me introduce you to your predecessor."

Lucumo looked at her startled. Not because he thought her mad, but because it seemed she had divined his innermost secret; for indeed, he had come to Rome with the express intent of winning some kind of power. Maybe not as King, but at least as a general. And here he was, barely an hour into his time here, and already this woman was offering to introduce him to the king. Was this possible? Was it destiny?

He opened his mouth to respond, when a woman intervened, gabbling an explanation in fast latin that he did not really understand. He turned to her and asked who she was.

"I am Fabia, and this is Marcia, who we call Tanaquil, the daughter of the King of Rome, Ancus Marcius."

"So she can, in fact, take me to meet the King."

The governess looked at both of them, wondering what was happening here. Then Tanaquil spoke again, "Of course I can, Lucumo. I said I would, and I will."

"How ... how did you know my name?" asked Lucomo.

"Why would I not know everything about my future husband?" asked Tanaquil, laughing softly. "Of course I know you are called Lucumo Tarquinius, and you are an adventurer recently arrived from Caere. You will not return thither, but will stay here, marry me and have a daughter. It is her son who will make the trip back to Caere that you cannot. But not, obviously, until our granddaughter has died."

Lucumo stood with his mouth open. This was more than he could process. But how could he doubt her, when she knew his innermost thoughts?

"She says strange things at times," interjected the governess. "We do not always know what she means by them. But at other times, she can be quite rational."

"Things only seem strange when you have no context for them," responded Lucumo gently. "The fact that we do not understand what she says merely means that we cannot see what she can see.

"Please, take me to meet your revered father. I would greet him and offer him my services, such as they are."

"And you are?"

"I am Lucumo Tarquinius, sire, from the Etruscan city of Caere."

"Which explains your strong accent, no doubt."

"Sire, I am son of the King there, and was taught Latin from an early age. I apologise if my accent offends you."

"It doesn't offend me, young man, I just notice it, that's all."

"And what are you doing here?"

"As I said, I am son of the King in Caere, which means, as I'm sure you are aware, that I have been trained to be a king, and a leader of men, but I am automatically disallowed from being the King in Caere, since that title goes to the husband of my youngest sister. So I set out to try my luck somewhere else, where a man of wit may gain advantage."

"And you decided to take advantage of my daughter?"

"No, father," interjected Tanaquil, "that was down to me. I saw Lucumo coming through the gate and recognised him as my future husband. I went and greeted him with a kiss and a flower, as I am sure you would have expected the lady my mother to greet you on your return from travelling."

"And yet this man has not returned from travelling, but is simply arriving from another town - and another country!"

"He is my husband, for all that, as you will see once he has defeated the citizens of Politorium."

"Politorium, ha! That city has twice defied my attempts to reduce it. And yet you say that this pup will manage that."

"Yes, father, he will do this deed in the coming campaigning season. He must, otherwise you will never let him be my husband, you see."

Used as he was to his daughter's tangled logic, even this was too much for him. But if he was destined to reduce Politorium, then he was indeed a gifted general. A small price to pay.

"So be it! You have until the end of the year to bring me the gods of Poltorium. If you succeed, you will marry my daughter as she says. If you fail, you will suffer the fate of all fraudsters and cheats in this city and your head will be separated from your shoulders.

"Do I make myself plain?"

"Indeed, sire."

All too plain. And he didn't even know where Politorium was. Let alone how he was going to take it.

Not something that Tanaquil had any sympathy for.

"What could be easier?" she asked, ingenuously. "You simply follow the path up the hill, wait by the spring, and then when they open the gate, you march in.

"I'd do it at night, if I were you, because otherwise they might see you coming. And make sure to muffle all your weapons and armour, otherwise they might hear you."

"What are you talking about?" said Lucumo, wearily. If she had "seen" this as clearly as she had seen their future together - down to the fate of their grandchildren - then she would be right. It was just a question of getting the story out of her straight.

"The gate to the spring is barred and locked, obviously," she carried on, oblivious to his tone. "But the servants come out to collect water day and night. All you need to do is to walk up there in the dark, when they can't see you, making sure they can't hear you, and wait for them to unbar the gate and let some servants out to collect water. Although you can't see the spring from down below, if you follow the watercourse up, you'll reach it.

"Nothing could be easier."

Politorium fell, Lucumo looted the city and brought Ancus Marcius the figures of the Gods.

In the New Year, he and Tanaquil married and Lucumo became heir apparent. Six years later, Ancus Marcius died in what might, in another world, have been considered "suspicious" circumstances.

12. Servius Tullius

Servius Tullius was seven years old when his father died in a fire.

Servius fled the house and, although burned, managed to find a puddle big enough to extinguish the fire. He rolled around in it until all the flames were out, and he was quite muddy.

His father had been adlected into the senate as a grandson of Tullus Hostilius; and it had been expected that Servius would follow in his father's footsteps and become a senator in his turn. But that now seemed in doubt.

"Obviously we must adopt the poor boy," began Tanaquil, with that faraway expression on her face that Lucumo had come to know so well. But even he was taken aback by what came next.

"Otherwise how will he now receive the education and wisdom he will need to marry our daughter?"

It was on the tip of Lucumo's tongue to point out that they didn't actually *have* a daughter yet, but then he stopped. If she could see far enough into the future to know that this poor orphan was going to marry their daughter, she presumably knew just when said child was going to be born.

"Our second daughter," she clarified, cementing his opinion. "Not the one that I'm carrying at the moment."

He gaped at her. She was pregnant? How long had she known? How far along was she?

"I'm a couple of weeks late," she said. "I've been suspicious for a few days now, but I went to see the priestess this morning and she confirmed it."

"And it will be a daughter?" he asked.

"Indeed so," she responded. "A beautiful little thing. But of no consequence, since in a couple of years, we will have another. And Carmenta travels through the youngest daughter, always."

Her gift still left him bemused. How could she know so much of what was to come? Still, she did, and he certainly found it useful. What she said next, though, left him cold.

"Beware the farmers making a ruckus."

Servius grew into a wise and introspective young man.

At the age of thirty, he married Lucumo's younger daughter, Tarquinia the younger, just after her eighteenth birthday. From that moment on, Lucumo knew he was living on borrowed time. The thing was, he didn't just not know that he could trust his wife; he knew that he could not trust her. In fact, she had told him explicitly that when Tarquinia became pregnant, "your life will be measured in days, rather than weeks, and Servius will take your place."

When he had countered that one way to stop that would be to kill the young whippersnapper first, she had laughed and advised him "against trying it": "If you try to fool the gods, you merely show yourself up as the fool."

Lucumo never met that grandchild. In fact, he never even found out that his younger daughter was pregnant.

One day, when he was hearing cases in his throne room, two farmers came in, arguing about a border fence. They wanted him to rule on their case. The dispute had been going on for some years, it seemed, dating back to their parents' time.

"My father was scared of his father," one explained. "Rather than call him out, or go to the magistrate, he just let him take more and more of our land, until it was obvious to everyone around that he had moved the stones."

"Not so," countered the other. "His father was a gambler, and when he could not pay his debts, he ceded us land in lieu of payment."

"And do you have evidence of this? Did he formally hand over the land in a notarised document?" asked Lucumo.

"No, of course not," responded the farmer. "He knew what he was doing, and so did his family. Note that it's only after he's dead that they are trying it on."

"And you, young man," said Lucumo, turning to the other farmer. "Do you have proof of title to the land you claim? Notarised by a presiding magistrate?"

"Indeed so," he responded. "Along with the survey indicating the original positions of the boundary stones. I have it here," he added, patting a scroll.

Lucumo motioned to a clerk. "Pending review of these documents, I am forced to find for the plaintiff. Case dismissed."

"Outrage!" yelled the loser. "How can you ignore the truth of what I have to say! I swear it before all the Lares!" And he struck the other farmer across the face.

While Lucumo and his guards were distracted, Servius reached behind him, picked up an axe, and wielded it firmly, burying it in Lucumo's head.

The gasps around the room told the whole story. Even the fracas between and around the two farmers ceased.

"I am now the King," intoned Servius.

"All hail the King!" shouted everyone in the room in unison.

Servius was as good a king as it had seemed he might be.

Some kings revel in the power; some in the glory; some just want to make war; others want to be adored. But a few, a very small minority, are actually interested in the *work* of ruling: the act of making the city run more smoothly. Numa had been such a one; and Servius Tullius was another.

Once he had power, he knew what he was going to do with it. Yes, he carried on fighting battles, but only when he was attacked. But his main goal was to transform the city. It took him all the forty-odd years of his reign, but he succeeded.

First and foremost, he made the city more defensible by encircling it with one, complete wall. Up until now, each of the various hills of Rome had had their own walls, leaving the valleys - the forum, the Circus Maximus, and so on - exposed to enemy predations. His wall encircled all of the city, including the seven hills and all the valleys in between. Where he could, he built the wall slightly up the hills to add defensive strength to them; where he could not, he built the walls higher to compensate. He built the walls of tufa stone: a volcanic rock, it was easy to mine, shape and transport. When fitted together, the stones had a natural sponginess that resisted attack by battering ram or artillery. It was his life's work: over thirty years spent in the construction of walls which, he was sure, were the most impressive a city had had since Troy.

But the walls by themselves were not enough to guarantee the city could be defended. For that, he needed an army. So he conducted a thorough census of the people, grouping them into classes based on their wealth and ability to equip themselves for war. Their wealth, of course, told him how much they had to defend - and thus their incentive to defend it; their ability to equip themselves for war told him how they could defend themselves.

The richest he put to work as cavalry: only the richest in a city like Rome could afford to keep a warhorse, let alone two. The next richest he enrolled as heavy infantry, requiring them to equip themselves with javelins, sword, shield, helmet and body armour. Below that, he appointed others to be pikemen, called upon in emergencies to defend the walls, but only needing a simple pike with which to defend their stretch of wall. Below them, he had slingers and artillery operators. And finally, in the fifth class, he had the non-combatant support staff, responsible for all the day-to-day logistics of supporting an army: carters, bakers, artificers and so on. And everybody knew their job, and what was expected of them.

Although Servius himself was unimpressed by war, he knew the importance of discipline in preparing for war, and the value of preparation when it came to war. And so, he required all the men in the city to carry out their appropriate drills at least twice per month. Servius organised the rotas by which they were drilled, and made sure that in addition to each century drilling together, they trained multiple units together: cavalry and infantry together; heavy infantry with the slingers; and so on. Servius turned what had been a very effective armed state into a war machine.

But a state is only worth defending if it is worth living in. And, Servius had concluded early in his reign, Rome could be a shithole - literally. As the city had grown, so had the distance that bodily excretions needed to be carried to dispose of them sensibly - to wit, on the fields where they would help the crops to grow. A problem that Servius recognised would only get worse as he enclosed the city in a big wall.

The solution came to him one day as he was standing, looking at the Tiber, effortlessly flowing and carrying away all manner of detritus: branches, leaves, even a dead cow. He turned to his colleague, Claudius, and asked him how it worked.

"How does what work, Servius?" responded Claudius, perplexed.

"Look at all that muck just *moving*," he responded. "Nobody is carrying it; nobody is loading it into carts; it is just flowing. How does that work?"

"The river carries it as it flows out to the sea. Just like if you were trying to swim across it."

"So could we not do the same with our bodily wastes? Wash them away in a river?"

"We could, but it would be a long way to come to the river every time a man wanted a piss," pointed out Claudius. "Some men might only just make it back home by the time they needed another."

"But, what if we built our own river," contended Servius, trying to see through the fog of his own thoughts. "We could build a channel through the forum down to the river."

After a number of experiments, they realised that what they needed to do was to tunnel *under* the ground, at a level which caused the effluent to flow naturally, without being forced, but without coming out in a rush. They built a number of interconnecting tunnels, all flowing into the Tiber. Any farmer who wanted to avail himself of this fertilizer just needed to come to the outflow and collect as much as he wanted. Any that was left over would flow out into the Tiber and down to the sea.

One day, a number of representatives of the Sabine cities came to see him.

"It is many years ago now that we last had disputations with you, O King of Rome," they intoned. "And in the years that have since gone by, we have become much more one people. And now, the threats from the Etruscans seem to grow, possibly drawn on by your increasing assertiveness. That you see this too cannot be denied - look at the walls that are going up around your city."

"All this is true," remarked Servius. "While we do not fear the Etruscans, we recognize that we have made them jealous of us and our power. All the more so since my father-in-law was Etruscan. I think they felt that he should perhaps have done more to turn the balance of power in their favour."

"And yet, we hear that you are considering marrying your daughter to Lucumo's grandson, Not so?"

"I don't think I have any choice. Lucius is my finest general, and he is popular among both the Senate and People. Does this worry you?"

"Not overtly. But marrying your youngest daughter, that will make him king one day, will it not? And we fear that. We fear that he will be what the Greeks call a *tyrannos*: a king in love with the power, not the duty. And we fear that your daughter will not have it in her to resist his urges and impulses. That he will become even more proud, even more arrogant, and that he will dictate more than he will consult.

"In short, we would much rather have your other son-in-law, Spurius Lucretius, to be our king. But we know that that is not how the inheritance works."

"Short of killing or locking my daughter Servia Tertia up as a Vestal Virgin for the rest of her life, no, it cannot work that way. As you say, the goddess Carmenta inhabits the soul of the youngest living daughter. You know, since the tradition is more yours than ours, that older daughters only come into the inheritance once the younger daughters are dead, possibly even going back generations. Although Carmenta only knows what happens when there are no daughters left to be found anywhere."

"The line dies out; there can be no kings; and usually the city dies."

"Then let us make that the fate of Veii instead of Rome."

The battle for Veii was not over in a season.

In fact, Veii did not fall to either Servius Tullius or Lucius Tarquinius in their lifetimes. In fact, it was to remain a thorn in the flesh of the Romans for over a hundred years.

The battle to be King of Rome was a lot shorter. Lucius Tarquinius married Servia Tertia before the campaign started; by the end of the year, he was challenging Servius openly.

"I say that the campaign against Veii failed because of the lack of leadership shown by the King. I challenge you for the right to be King," he challenged in the Senate House. "Fight me or admit that you are craven."

"Why would I fight you, my son-in-law?" countered Servius. "All know that you will be King after me; wait, be patient, use the time to build support amongst your fellow Senators; to hone your skills on the battlefield. And then, when my race is run, I will depart gracefully and leave you to be King."

"What will be left of my inheritance, then? You will have frittered it away by fighting losing battles against Veii and other Etruscans. Rome will be but a shell of what it is now."

There was an audible intake of breath around the Senate House. Many of the Senators had themselves been at Veii, and had seen the tactics employed - and who had been in charge of deciding them. And it was not Servius. For Lucius to accuse him of betrayal - and in public - was horrifying. And yet, did anybody dare say anything? Almost whatever happened, this was going to be their next king.

Servius thought and considered. If he accepted the challenge now, he would be as strong as he would ever be. If he won the challenge, he would be secure from another challenge. On the other hand, if he lost ...

He looked around the Senate House and saw what was on every face. They would lose respect for him if he refused the challenge. And more: they feared the man who would replace him. Only one thing to do then, accept the challenge and win, ideally killing his own daughter's husband ...

"I accept this challenge. Tomorrow at dawn in the forum."

Dawn came late in those cold, dark days of December.

The people still called them the days of death, even though the Numa had systemized the calendar centuries ago, filling in the months November, December, January and February, along with the occasionally necessary Mercedonius, when February ended before the Pleiades rose in the sky.

It was also cold and frosty; unusually so. As Servius looked around, it considered it an omen. And not a good one. Hades was cold as well, they said, and it seemed like this was going to be his introduction to Hades. He marched into the forum, openly unafraid but inside the doubt was gnawing at him. Could he best his son-in-law? Could he bring himself to kill him? How could he have been so blind, even after the clear warnings from the Sabine ambassadors?

Tarquin was waiting for him; and now, in this moment, Servius saw him as he really was. Maybe it was one of those premonitions that they say come just before death, but Servius saw the *tyrannos* arrayed before him. The cruelty was etched on Tarquin's face. This man before Servius wanted to kill him; had, for many years been building up to just this moment.

Servius relaxed. Now he saw what was in the mind of his younger rival, he had no qualms or doubts: it was a simple matter of kill or be killed, just like it often had been in the front lines of battle. There were no more moral issues to consider.

Spurius Lucretius stepped up to officiate.

"This is a bout to first blood for the right to be King of Rome. The challenge weapon is the sword. No missile weapons, shields or armour are permitted. Go with Jupiter."

Servius drew his sword and watched as Tarquin did the same. And then waited. And waited.

"You challenged *me*, remember?" Servius taunted. "Having second thoughts?"

"Not at all," replied Tarquin, and launched into a quick, vicious, lunging attack.

Servius had not fought in the front lines for thirty years without having learnt to defend himself. Of course, battle in the front lines was different to single combat: you had armour, a shield, and comrades on either side of you to protect you. But a sword was still a key part of your defensive posture.

The battle - for that was what it was - raged for five minutes or more, relentless and exhausting, until both men were breathing hard. Tarquin suddenly backed up, and launched an attack on Servius' exposed left side. As he turned to meet the challenge, Servius slipped on a patch of frost. Tarquin's blow went through Servius' guard and clipped him, drawing blood. Technically, this was a win, but before anyone could react, Tarquin altered the direction of his thrust and drove his sword through his opponent's neck.

There was a muffled cheer, then a shout of "Long Live the King". But none of it was enthusiastic.

13. Tarquin

The relationship between Tarquin and the Senate rapidly entered into a vicious circle.

The politest interpretation that could be put on it was that Tarquin was a natural "military man". Although the grandson of a king, he had come up through the ranks until he had become a general. And now he was used to everybody following his orders. The Senate, filled with generals, couch generals and ambassadors, was not used to - or indeed, willing to - obeying orders. It wanted, if not control, at least to be consulted on all matters. And considered Tarquin's approach to be high-handed at best.

The general opinion of most of Rome expressed behind closed doors was that Tarquin was a spoiled brat. That he had been born grandson of a king, and a proud king at that, and had been brought up with the expectation that one day he would be king, and that all of that would one day fall into his lap as long as he did the minimum to marry the king's daughter. And yes, he had fought in the ranks and "worked his way up" to general, but that was just a sham to cover for the fact that he had been pre-ordained for it. He had not been born a peasant and won his way to general the way that others had - through sheer merit.

Senators, it is true, began to murmur about Tarquin. Some, in private, gave him the *cognomen Superbus*, meaning "the proud" or "the arrogant". But none seriously planned any action: what action, after all, could they actually take?

Meanwhile, Tarquin felt simultaneously threatened and empowered. Starting with some of the leading Senators, he trumped up charges against them, hauled them into court, dismissed the jury and acted as judge himself. Naturally, he found them all guilty, fined them their entire fortune and sentenced them to death.

As the years went on, he found more and more reasons to dispose of more and more Senators. This one was incompetent in a battle; this one had been a coward; this one was plotting treason. All were found guilty, executed and had their fortunes seized.

In total, Tarquin had five children who survived to maturity.

His only daughter, Tarquinia, he married to one of the leading men of Tusculum, Gaius Octavius Mamilius. His four sons he brought up to follow after him in war, knowing that the kingship he had given to Octavius. A man he was very careful to stay away from any time he was in Rome.

As part of their training for war, Tarquin sent his sons off to be legates or generals in the various theatres of war which he was pursuing at any given time. And they were generally succesful in these endeavours.

When he entered into a dispute with the Rutulians, he desired that his army should capture and sack the town of Ardea. He consequently sent his most senior general, Volesus, to take charge of this army and sent all of his sons to be legates, along with Gaius Octavius and his relation Collatinus Tarquinius. To entertain them as the butt of their humour, he also sent his nephew Lucius Junius, noble enough of birth (being his sister's son) but recognised everywhere as a fool - so much so that he was given the nickname "Brutus".

Upon arrival in front of Ardea, Volesus thought it would be easy enough to storm the city. Dividing up his army into the appropriate units and placing Sextus and TItus in charge of one part each, he ordered them to attack the walls. They did so at once, and battle was swiftly joined. But the walls were too high to be scaled, and too thick to be knocked down, and the gates were too solid and too buttressed to be broken through. In short, there was no way into the city. Both Sextus and Titus found themselves repelled from the walls and Volesus sounded the retreat.

"Right, men," he said when he had gathered his commanders in his tent when the battle was over. "We tried to do it the easy way, and that wasn't as easy as we'd hoped. So now we need to do it the hard way. We are going to starve them out. I want the whole city circumvallated in three days, or I'll decimate your legions. Don't bother waiting for the morning, or the men to be rested. Get half of them building three camps, one at each of the corners, and get the other half digging out the fortifications. Then they can take it in turns to carry on building the fortifications, rest and be on sentry duty. I'm not expecting anyone to come to the aid of Ardea, but we need to be ready to deal with them if they do. Any questions? No. Good."

The young men went off to do as they were told, and within just over two days, the fortifications were built, with the three camps providing secure accomodation for the men, and the walls having watchtowers from where they could see both into the town and for miles around. They were safe, well supplied from Rome, and the town of Ardea was cut off. They didn't know how much food they had with them in the town, but they knew there was a spring providing water.

Now, it was just a question of sitting back and waiting.

Waiting did not come naturally to Tarquins.

They were men of action. They sat around at night, drinking, and telling each other that "with just one more attack" they would have made it within the city. That they would have won the battle, had it not been for Volesus sounding the retreat to early.

They did not get along well with their co-legates, at least, whenever they saw them. Gaius Octavius was always keeping busy dealing with the myriad problems of command: from keeping his troops supplied, to keeping them occupied, to breaking up fights and establishing discipline. Meanwhile, Collatinus was frequently busy doing many of the same tasks, as well as leading raids on the city, trying to figure out where a weak spot might be. His heroism and discipline upset the Tarquin brothers, who felt that they should be doing something equally dramatic, but quietly Volesus had overlooked them - they just weren't up to the task.

So they sat around, and drank, and made fun of their cousin Lucius Junius. "Come here, Brutus," they would say, "and fill up my beaker of wine." "Brutus, go and empty the chamberpot." Not content with teasing him, they gave him all the most demeaning jobs - the jobs properly to be carried out by a slave.

One evening, when they were drinking, but were still sober, Octavius and Collatinus came into their command tent.

"Oh, oh, oh," exclaimed Arruns, "to what to we owe this unexpected pleasure?"

Snapping his fingers, Gaius addressed Lucius Junius. "Brutus, quick, get our guests beakers of wine. And be quick about it. None of your usual sluggishness."

"You really shouldn't treat him so," urged Collatinus. "He is not a slave; he is near as well born as you. He cannot help it if he is not altogether there."

"He may not be able to help it," retorted Titus, "but that doesn't mean we should give him ideas above his station. Would you make him King?"

"You know he cannot be King," chided Collatinus. "He is the daughter of the King's sister. It would be improper for him to marry any of the children of the Goddess."

"Unlike you, eh?" commented Sextus. "You are married to the King's cousin, are you not?"

"Indeed," replied Collatinus, "but she will not inherit the power, because Lucretia is not the youngest of the youngest. You know that as well as I do. That falls to your sister Tarquinia."

"Who is married to our esteemed legate Octavius. Who decided that you would be our next King?" asked Sextus sourly. "What fool decided that? Brutus?"

"I think you will find the fool in question was your father and hers, King Tarquin," replied Octavius levelly.

"Are you calling my father a fool?" challenged Gaius, misinterpreting the conversation.

"Not at all," responded Octavius. "I was just answering your brother's question as well as I could."

At that moment, Brutus came back with beakers of wine for the two men, and they sat down on the camp stools. And started to drink, albeit more slowly than the king's sons.

The messenger was breathless as he hurried in.

"Sirs, I have the gravest news."

Immediately, he had the attention of all seven men in the room, even, had the others noticed it, Lucius Junius.

Kneeling before Gaius Octavius, he murmured the formal words, "it pains me to express the passing of the lady Tarquinia".

Octavius looked at him blankly, in complete shock. "How... Why... When...?" he mumbled.

"Can this really be true?" asked Collatinus. "What happened, man? Speak."

"Yes, it is true," replied the messenger. "It is, as you know, the time for the fevers in Rome. The Lady Tarquinia had caught a fever, but laughed it off and said it was not worth distracting her husband from his duties. But she steadily grew worse until this morning, she died. Your father-in-law immediately summoned me and gave me this sad duty."

"Yes," murmured Octavius. "That sounds like her. Prioritizing our duty over her own comfort. And it is true that there is nothing I could have done. I assume she had the best doctors?"

"Yes," replied the messenger. "All of the best Greeks were called, but there was nothing they could do."

14. Lucretia

"You realize what this means of course," Arruns said to Sextus a couple of days later.

"No, what?"

"Octavius will not be King."

"Because our sister died."

"Yes, the fact that he was married to her will matter for nothing now she is dead. In fact, I've heard it said that in some of the towns of Latinum, a king is deposed once his wife dies, and sometimes the king is even put to death."

"Barbaric. At least that doesn't happen here."

"Otherwise our father would no longer be the King of Rome. And Octavius would have had his opportunity to inherit."

"So who does become King?"

"You mean, who becomes Queen? Because the answer to who becomes King is 'the husband of the Queen'."

"And that is?"

"As far as I am aware, there is only one candidate, which would be Lucretia."

"And that means that our oh-so-pious friend Collatinus will be King? Really? Him?"

"Who, indeed, could have guessed? She seemed so far removed from the throne at the time, and even just a few days ago ... it was bound to be Octavius."

"Except, as you said, it's not that Collatinus will be King, it's that Lucretia will be Queen."

And with that, he left it hanging.

"How goes the military operation?" Sextus asked Collatinus that evening over a beaker of wine.

"Apart from the fact that our forces are bored from having nothing to do, it's fine."

"I'm bored, too," commented Arruns.

"Aren't we all?" asked Gaius.

"Well, you could come and help with the work that we supposed to be doing," retorted Collatinus angrily. "It didn't used to be too bad, you four skiving off when you were supposed to be working, but now that Octavius doesn't care about anything anymore, it's too much work just for me."

"Poor boy," mocked Titus. "Maybe you should get the Brutus to help you out. I'm sure he'd be a barrel of laughs."

"Oh, get lost," responded Collatinus wearily.

"I need a wife," said Sextus suddenly. "I need to get married and settle down. I need to have children to follow me. Who knows anything about wives?"

"Do you have anyone in mind?" asked Arruns.

"No, not really. I'm not even sure of what I want in a wife. Your wife, for instance, Gaius, always seems up for a laugh. And yours, Arruns, seems somewhat quieter, but is great to look at. And I assume she's good in bed. I think that would be important to me. What do you think, Collatinus?"

"I don't know what would please you," he replied. "I know that my wife pleases me - in bed and out of it. She is everything a Roman matron should be - quiet, speaks only when spoken to; efficent, keeps the household running smoothly; peaceable; elegant. Yes, she is truly a queen among women," he continued without realising what he had said or how it would inflame Sextus' jealousy.

"A real paragon of virtue. I assume she spins wool, as well," Sextus mocked.

"Of course. I am sure that if we were to drop in unannounced, right now, that we would find her with her distaff in her hand, spinning. She is not one of these modern types to find drinking and gossiping more productive than spinning wool."

Arruns laughed. "How easily you are deceived, good Collatinus. Surely you cannot believe that your wife is home alone, spinning. Spinning you tales, perhaps. She is probably at home 'entertaining' one of your slaves."

In his corner, Brutus sat up, shocked by the accusation. He knew Lucretia personally, and knew that she was just as virtuous as Collatinus believed her to be. He would swear to it in court - for all the good the word of a madman would do. And then he relaxed again, remembering his part: he was a fool.

"Well, I suggest we put it to the test. It is too late this evening, but if we set off for Rome at mid-afternoon tomorrow, we can be there around this time, if we use the post horses. We can drop in on your wives, Arruns, Gaius and Titus, and see what they are doing. Then we can go over to my house and see what *my* wife is doing. And then you can admit that I have the most virtuous wife in the world."

"Let us do that!" cackled Sextus. "I do not think it is virtue that I value most in a wife, but let us first see this virtuous woman and then maybe I will be convinced."

It was easier than they thought to visit the three brothers' wives.

When they arrived at Arruns' house, the steward told them that his wife was out. When he enquired where, he was told at Gaius' house. So they went there. When they arrived, the steward admitted them into the atrium, where all three wives were gathered, drinking wine and chatting about the latest rumours and scandals in the city.

"Well, Gaius," drawled his wife, "how very good of you to drop by. And bringing such handsome companions too. Did you miss me so much that you had to abandon your siege of wherever-it-was to come and see me?"

"Arruns," said that son's wife, getting up to greet him with a hug and a kiss. "What an unexpected pleasure. We received no word. Has Ardea fallen?"

"Titus," greeted his wife. "Have you come to make a baby brother for little Titus?"

"No," replied all three, suprisingly close to in unison.

"I have decided to get married," explained Sextus. "And so I am looking for a wife."

"Well, there's no point looking here," exclaimed Gaius' wife. "We're all already taken, and by your brothers, at that! Imagine the scandal if you were to marry one of us. They'd still be talking about it in a hundred years!"

"Indeed not," said Sextus. "But I am trying to decide what I want in a wife. And somehow, I don't think it's what you three have to offer."

Failing to realise that he had mortally offended the three women, he turned to his companions and said, "right, lads, let's go and see what Collatinus' wife has to offer."

They set off, and within less than an hour, arrived at Collatinus' modest house. They knocked, and the door was promptly opened by the steward, who greeted Collatinus formally. He introduced his companions, and then led them into the atrium, which was deserted.

"Where is your wife, Collatinus?"

"She will be where I said she would be," he replied. "In her room, working on her spinning."

They walked through the atrium to the residential part of the house. There, in the second cubicle on the left, was a woman, sat upright in a chair, distaff in her hand, spinning wool. Just as Collatinus had said she would be.

And it was clearly not a set-up: the whole room reflected this personality, as did the speed and efficiency with which she was working. She did not rise to greet them.

"Lucretia, these men are the King's sons: Sextus, Arruns, Titus and Gaius."

Now she rose and, putting her distaff to one side, bowed before them. "Your graces, I am sorry that you have found me working. Did the steward not take account of your needs? What can I do to make your comfortable? I apologise for not being ready to greet you, but I received no word."

"That," replied Sextus, "is because we sent no word. Deliberately. We wished to surprise you and find out in what manner you occupied yourself in the evenings. I am desirous of finding myself a wife, and was amazed when Collatinus told me what a paragon of virtue he had married. I refused to believe it until I had seen it for myself."

"How ungallant of you, sir," she replied formally. "I am sure that there is nothing exceptional about my behaviour, and if you were to drop in on any other woman in Rome this evening you would likewise find her occupied as I have been."

"Sadly, we have dropped in on three other women this evening - my brothers' wives, to be precise," answered Sextus, waving his arm around to indicate the three men to whom he referred, "and they were not so occupied. But rather, they were occupied in drinking wine and gossipping. It seems to me," he added darkly, "that that is not the kind of wife I want."

Turning to Collatinus, he added, "you are right, Collatinus. You have the most virtuous wife in Rome. I doubt I could find a better if I tried."

Two more weeks went by.

Two more boring weeks with nothing for Sextus to do but sit and drink and think about things. Collatinus didn't even seem to appreciate that he was now next in line for the throne. He just kept on doing his duties as the tribune that he was. It would be so easy for him to die when the time finally came to storm Ardea. And then Lucretia would be free for him to marry. Marriage between cousins wasn't *exactly* the done thing, but it was pretty much how all the royals had managed it for generations. Grandsons marrying granddaughters. It wasn't technically incest, just ... a little close.

Brutus came in to see if he needed anything. He waved him away. Of course, sometimes you ended up with idiots like Brutus from too much inbreeding. But what did that matter to him? He would be king; it didn't really matter what happened to his children. Although, maybe, if he didn't have any daughters ... this stupid tradition of the woman inheriting the right to the throne would die out and one of his sons could just inherit the throne with the power.

And over and over came the thought ... all he had to do was convince Lucretia to marry him in the event that Collatinus were to die, and then arrange for Collatinus to die. It was all so simple.

Arruns came in the room.

"I have been thinking," he began. "It is time I was married. And I have picked out a wife."

"You have?" said Arruns, amazed. "I didn't realise you had been away from the front."

"I have not. But I am going to go tonight and propose."

"To whom?" asked Arruns, incredulous. "Who is this paragon of virtue? Do I know her?"

"You do indeed," replied Sextus. "You met her when I did two weeks past. I have chosen Lucretia."

Arruns burst out laughing. "A good one, my brother. The only problem is that, as you observed, she is virtuous and, uh, already married."

"I do not see that as an obstacle," countered Sextus. "Her husband will only live as long as we are sat here doing nothing. The moment that we storm Ardea, he will die. On my sword if not someone else's."

Arruns looked at him in shock. Surely his brother could not be serious? But he seemed perfectly serious. He was going to kill a fellow officer? And the heir to the throne at that?

"I beg you, brother, give up this plan. It is sacrilege to kill the anointed of the gods. You will be damned for all eternity. This plan will not prosper."

Sextus looked at his brother, shocked. Could Arruns really not see the beauty of this plan? Had he spoken out of turn to the wrong man? Would he need to kill this brother to silence him as well?

"You are right, Arruns. It was just a passing fancy. Get our brothers and let us drink wine! Brutus!"

Brutus came immediately from where he had been waiting for a summons.

"Fetch wine, Brutus! We need to drink!"

Another week had gone by.

In spite of his brother's objections, Sextus still could not see any real flaws in his plan. He was sure he could arrange for Collatinus to die in the assault on Ardea, when it finally came. He was less sure what to do about Arruns, but if the wedding was a fait accompli, he would probably not say anything. He really just needed to go and see Lucretia and tell her what he had planned. It wasn't a long ride to Rome.

He left off thinking and took up acting. "Brutus! My riding cape, I'm going to Rome!"

Brutus brought the cape within minutes and Sextus was up and out of the tent, heading to the line of post horses near the camp entrance.

"Come on, man! I haven't got all day to stand here waiting for a horse!" he yelled at the postmaster.

This was the final stop before Rome, and they seemed to have run out of horses or something. It was so frustrating, he was so close. He knew that his plan was going to work, and that he would be charming Lucretia in no time at all.

Finally the man produced a horse. Sextus mounted it, and went on his way to Rome.

The steward opened the door.

"Greetings, Sextus Tarquinius," he intoned, respectfully. "How may I be of assistance to you, this evening?"

"I am here to see the lady of the house," replied Sextus, brusquely. "Is she in?"

The steward looked at him blankly. "Yes, she is in, why would she not be?"

"Then I would like to see her."

"I'm afraid that isn't possible, sir, without the master's permission. And he has not sent word."

"I *am* his word. Do you think I would have come without his consent?"

"I do not know, good sir. But I do know that he gave explicit instructions before he left for the war that nobody was to be permitted to enter the house without his instructions. I understand you came before, but you came with him; so that is his granting you permission. But I have not had word that you would be returning."

"Well, I have. Now go and fetch the Lady Lucretia before I kill you," he added threateningly, one had on his sword, ostentatiously displayed on his belt.

"Yes, sir," he said, summoning another slave to his side and instructing him silently to fetch the lady to the atrium.

Sextus moved into the atrium himself and looked around. As before, the house was kept in immaculate trim: yes, this was the woman for him.

And then she appeared.

In spite of the late time of day, and the fact that clearly nobody was expected, she was beautifully presented. Her hair and gown were perfect, and she had the perfect expression on her face: gently welcoming, submissive, yet quietly confident.

"How can I help you sir? Are you well? Is my husband well?"

And the perfect greeting! His heart soared. What a catch this woman was. But what to say about her husband.

"It was actually about your husband that I wished to speak to you, madam. Yes, he is well, but I am concerned that he will not be for much longer."

A flash of distress appeared on her face. "Why is that, good sir?"

"I believe he has formed a death wish. I think he feels guilt about the amount of time it has taken us to capture Ardea, and that his only option to assauge that guilt is to die during the storming of it."

She took this in, processing it. "And what would you have me do, sir?"

"Marry me."

She looked at him in total shock and disbelief. It was all she could do to stammer out a response. "I do not understand you, sir. You know that I am already married."

"Yes, to a complete loser who does not deserve to be called your husband, let alone King of Rome! He is an unwortthy pile of dung that doesn't understand what he has lucked into by marrying you. He is not worthy!"

"You appear to be somewhat overwrought, sir. May I suggest you leave before you say or do something you might come to regret?"

"Leaving would be the one thing I might come to regret, Lucretia. I have come to claim you for my wife, and my wife you will be."

"No, sir, that cannot be. I am married to Collatinus, and until he is dead, I am not free to marry another. Indeed, even if he were to die this evening, I would not be free to marry for another nine months to prove that I am not carrying his postumous child. Surely you know the law?"

Sextus lost his cool.

"Woman, you will be carrying my child by the time you see him next!"

Stepping forward, he pulled her elegant gown off her, and proceeded to rape her, right there in the atrium. She never stood a chance of resisting.

Brutus arrived at the house of Spurius Lucretius first.

"Good sir, I know you think of me as everyone else does - a mental defective - but that is just a part I have had to play to preserve my life from those 'royals' who would have threatened it. As, I believe, they are about to threaten the chastity of your daughter."

"What are you saying? Who would threaten my daughter when her husband is away?"

"Sextus Tarquinius. Possibly him alone. I heard him discussing it with his brother Arruns a few days ago, and I told Collatinus, but he laughed it off. Told me that it was just a joke at my expense. I considered that, and considered it was not worth breaking my disguise to contradict him. But this evening, he ordered me to find his riding cape, and then set off for Rome. I set off as soon after as I could, leaving a message for Collatinus to follow when he returned. I would expect him shortly."

At that moment, the messenger from Lucretia's house burst in.

"Your lords, I have grave news. Sextus Tarquinius just turned up at the lady's house and threatened the steward with death if he did not admit him. Considering it the lesser of two evils, he admitted him but sent me here with this message: ready yourselves and come at once to her rescue."

The two men exchanged glances. Would the two of them be enough? Where could they find more men to back them up at this time?

"Valerius, the son of my commander, Volesus, is at his home nearby," said Brutus. "We could call on him."

"And I will leave a message for Collatinus. If, indeed, he comes here, he will know the score. But I imagine he will ride straight for his own house."

"In that case, we had better hurry. We would not want him to encounter Sextus before we arrive to back him up."

In the end, they all arrived at around the same time.

Brutus was surprised to see that Arruns had arrived with Collatinus. But not as surprised as Arruns was to see the change that had come over Brutus. Where the fool had been, there was now a cool, competent commander. Collatinus, while not expecting the shift, was less surprised. He had never treated Brutus as a butt, and had felt sorry for the young man.

The steward admitted them to the house. And immediately kneeled on the floor in front of Collatinus.

"I am sorry, sir, that I could not keep the man from the house. I should, nevertheless have tried, even at the cost of my own life. I beg you, sir, once you have questioned me, put me to death for dereliction of duty."

"Get up, man!" said Collatinus, gently. "If I had realised that Sextus would come here with a sword, I would have retained some soldiers to protect you all. But it never occurred to me. Nor should it have occurred to you. But I am grateful that you lived. You were able to send a message to Spurius, here. And you are more use to me alive than dead. Tell me, where is the foul traitor?"

"He left, sir. When he had had his pleasure, he took his things and left."

"And where is my wife?"

"She is in her room, sir."

"Bring her here."

Lucretia came, eyes downcast. When she saw her husband and father in the atrium, she gave a little start, and then dropped to her knees and buried her face in her hands.

"Forgive me, lord, for my body has betrayed me - and I have betrayed you. Sextus Tarquinius came here last night, and against my will, enjoyed my body. And when he had taken his pleasure, he left. He said that he wanted to marry me, but such as he will never marry me.

"I swear to the truth of all this, and call upon the god Mors to be my witness."

So saying, she withdrew a dagger from the fold of her gown and plunged it into her heart.

"No!" cried Collatinus, darting forward to hold her. "You do not need to do this. I believe you!"

"If you believe me, then hunt this tyrant down. And his father who made him so. Let none other be tyrant over Rome so long as Rome shall live."

As he looked into her eyes, the light slowly went out of them. And with Lucretia, the goddess of the KIngs of Rome, died too.

The goddess Carmenta was dead.

15. Epilogue

True to his word, Collatinus went and hunted down Sextus, then Tarquin Superbus himself.

In order to do that, he had to lift the siege of Ardea, but the troops there were happy enough about that; the siege had been boring for them too.

Once the Tarquins were dead, the Senate needed to decide on a new form of government. Should they just appoint a King without the legitimacy of a marriage to the Queen Carmenta? Or should they just appoint one interrex after another?

It was Brutus who provided the solution.

"No and no, but also yes and yes," he opined in the Senate. "It would offend the Gods for us to appoint a man on our own authority to be King, but it would also be wasteful to appoint a man every five days.

"Let us rather, then, choose two men, for the period of one year - the amount of time which, we are told, kings used to serve before Romulus decided to make himself *rex perpetuus*. We choose two men so that we do not have one tyrant over us, but rather two men who will balance each other out. In the same way that we understand that there were, at one time, two kings in a year, one to kill the other and to balance out the seasons.

"But we do not need to kill our representatives when they have served their year. They know, going in, that they are magistrates appointed by this body, in their prime of life. And that, once finished with their term, they can return to this body with their reputations enhanced.

"What say you?"

After some debate, the Senate decided to go with this plan. And the first two men elected as *praetors* for the city of Rome? Unsurprisingly, Brutus and Collatinus.

The plan largely worked well for four hundred years, until first Gaius Marius, then Lucius Cornelius Sulla, then Gaius Julius Caesar figured out how to circumvent the checks and balances in the system.

A. Additional Notes

B. Author's Note

There are quite a few notes at the end of this book. But my book, my rules.

First off, this book is a lot longer - or possibly just much broader in scope - than I had originally intended. The book took life from Robert Graves' assertion in *King Jesus* that the Roman Kings followed a practice of matrilineal inheritance and that, despite the obfuscations he had tried to put in, it was clear to anybody who read Livy what was going on. I read Livy again, and decided that, for all the obfuscations, he must be right. And I thought it would be cool to go back and "unpack" that, and try and tell the story in a way that removed those obfuscations.

That was twenty years ago.

As I did research, now and again, I came up with more and more evidence that not only was this true, but it was true across Europe - and probably across the world - for one very simple reason: until very, very recently, every woman knew who her children were, but not a single man could actually be **sure**. And, when you think about wealth and inheritance, you realize how very important it is to know who your children are if you want them to inherit from you (which appears to be a basic animal instinct).

And the longer this went on, the more I realized that telling the story I wanted to tell - basically what amounts to Volume 4 here - depended on so much history that I needed to provide at least an extensive prologue. Which itself needed a prologue. You get the picture.

As I reached the end of planning and starting writing, I wondered if I actually needed another volume, describing the Trojan War. You see, as you look at it, there is no reason not to believe that we are talking about a war between male-dominated kingdoms in Greece and a *still matrilineal* society in Troy. Maybe, maybe not. It's very tempting to say again that Homer glossed over that, but given that all our accounts of the Trojan War only took written form hundreds of years after the event - and were composed by the victors - it wouldn't surprise me if all those details went missing in the interim. I may still go back and write that; the biggest obstacle is that it is a legend that has been covered so well and so often that it almost feels impossible to "retell" it now - especially when the devil is all in the details.

Of course, having decided to do that, the fourth volume here is a lot shorter than it would otherwise have been, and lots of detail has been left out. If your favourite Livy story didn't make it, I'm sorry. Hopefully the world of Hyancinth and Sprig made up for it.

C. Narrative Style

In general, when writing I prefer to use a first-person perspective. In this book, that has not been possible for any number of reasons. At no point was there a character that I felt could tell enough of the story in their own voice.

However, as much as possible, I have followed the style I refer to as "third-person cheating", which is to say, I have tried to tell the story in the third person, but in every chapter there is a "lead" character that the story follows closely, showing much more of the *inside* of that character than any of the others. So, in Section 1, the girl Sprig, who becomes the woman Clematis, is at the centre of the story and much of what is told is told through her eyes. In the first place, I made this choice because, as a girl becoming a woman, she was perfectly positioned to tell the story to people who likewise had never seen this society at work before.

In all cases, I have tried to avoid giving any descriptions or accounts of natural phenomena or human experience or other matters such as time, space or geography which would have been outside the experience or understanding of those present. While I recognise that this may be confusing to some readers, I am trying to stay as close to the experience and worldview of my protagonists as possible given the constraints.

So, for example, I have refrained from using any kind of modern units, including, but not limited to, weeks, seconds, hours, preferring instead to relate concepts associated with the motion of the moon or sun to describe the passage of time and "heartbeats" where short units of time are concerned. If you are a relatively healthy adult, a complete heartbeat should not be that much shorter than a second. If it's longer, you are probably very healthy.

In the same way, I have tried to avoid using modern conveniences such as counting and writing. It's my belief that all of the societies mentioned in this book would have had access to both, although in both cases, I would think that it would be at a primitive level. Even up until the middle of the first millennium BC, the Persian army counted their casualties by having each soldier going to war deposit an arrow in a storehouse. Those that came back alive picked up an arrow from the pile and put it elsewhere. A very simple visualisation of the number of casualties was created by the simple expedient of comparing the two piles: the first pile was the count of those who did not return; the second pile was the survivors.

This novel may not flow like a complete story: jumping as it does across four epochs and two locations, it is not possible to create a single narrative. Inasmuch as there is a single character for this story, it is the titular *Goddess* who is slowly but surely crushed out of the story until she is "killed" in the person of Carmenta in Rome by the jealousy of the Tarquins and the founding of the Republic. But even under the kings in Rome, her worship - like women generally - was ruthlessly suppressed. The rape and suicide of Lucretia may have been the end point of this story but by the time it happened, it was largely irrelevant.

I have tried to tell this vast, sweeping story through a series of *vignettes*: each mini story illuminating some aspect of the society that existed and the relationships between Goddess, women, men, ritual, wealth and power. Wealth and power are inextricably linked, and men only truly started to gain power once they were able to gain and hold wealth by identifying their own progeny and being able to pass on their accumulated wealth to *their* children. Before DNA testing, it was only by insisting on marriage and the sanctity of marriage that any man could truly know if a child was his. And once men started going down that path, the complete suppression of women - in ancient Rome or modern Afghanistan - was inevitable.

The names of the characters have evolved as I have told the story. In Section 4, I have mainly used the characters in Livy, and thus their names. Auxiliary characters have been given other, typical, Roman names current in the era. In Section 3, as Zeus takes control, I have used a lot of names of Greek gods, and other names from myth and legend. Section 2 sees some of the names of earlier gods, such as Cronos, who were "phased out" by Zeus. The society of Section 1 has been so thorougly suppressed from our history that, short of decoding Linear A texts (which I believe to have been from this period, in a language of this period which pre-dates all Indo-European languages), I have no idea what names would be used. I chose to use flower names for the women, with more flowery names for the leaders, and names that we might use for pets for the men, representing their much lower status. Obviously I have no actual evidence for this whatsoever, but I do feel that in this primitive society men were probably viewed much like pets or beasts of burden - they were good for three things: heavy labour, fighting and sex. And their status and thus names reflected this.

I have tried to show how complete the reversal was by the end of the book, in which women in Rome not only had simpler names that those of the men, but all the daughters of one family had *the same name*: the *gens* of the family; to distinguish them numbers or nicknames were used.

D. Unhistorical Note

At this point in books like this, it is usual to add a "Historical Note" explaining how what I have writtern deviates from what I have read in the history books.

But what is history? I think at the very least, it depends on us having some kind of written record of the events of the time and at least the names of those who were involved.

For the first three sections of this book, we don't have that. Any of it. For the fourth, we have very, very late Latin sources (such as Livy), writing about a time so remote from them they can barely understand it. For comparison, consider writing a story set in Italy 500-700 years ago without reference to written sources (or, if you prefer, consider writing a story set in the Americas before the arrival of Columbus). Without a comprehensive understanding of the feudal system, it would be impossible to explain the actions of most of the players, or even what was happening at a large scale: how, where and when were wars fought; what happened during the reformation, or the renaissance?

We obviously don't know what records Livy had available to him, but they were unlikely to have been as rich as the information we have about the middle ages; more like what we know about the dark ages. So, is his account really history? Most historians don't think so, and don't accept it as such. Livy's accounts seem to project a great deal of the thoughts and morals and laws of the late constitutional period back onto the time of the Kings, to which they clearly do not apply.

And everything is just too neat. Romulus sets up the state and organises a fantastic army. Numa comes along and institutes religion. Tullius comes along and gives good governance. No, these things did not happen like that.

But how did they happen? Almost undoubtedly from two factors: evolution and conquest.

So let's go back to the beginning. I said we don't have any written records. I'm not actually sure that's true, but what is true is that we don't have any written records that *we can read*. We do have a lot of texts in Linear A, but nobody has been able to decipher them. It has been shown that Linear B is consistent with being an early form of the Greek language written in some other script - a script which is remarkably similar to Linear A.

We do know - or at least strongly believe - that the Greek language, and the Hellenic people, came to Greece from somewhere else; we call these people "Indo-European": not because that is where they came *from*, but because those are the places where they went and spread their language, culture, morals and values. By extension, they could not have been native to Greece. So a consistent story would be one in which a native population could speak a language distinct from Greek - and all other Indo-European languages - and write it down, and then be conquered by another population which spoke Greek but could not write. The merger of these two peoples could leave some group of them writing Greek in the existing (native) script. For the record, this is what I imagine happening at the end of Section 2, when Zeus overruns the empire of Cronos.

The other thing we have is a set of random stories much like the legends that Livy repurposed in describing the early history of Rome. And, as we read between the lines of those stories, a different narrative emerges from the one that they appear to tell.

In telling the story I have told in these pages, I was by no means starting from scratch. My personal starting point came in the early 1990s when I read Merlin Stone's "When God was a Woman" and Robert Graves' "The Greek Myths". Both told a story of how, back at the beginning of civilization, men and women worshipped not a God or Gods, but a Goddess. And did so for a spectacularly good reason - women had all the power, and all the utility - so surely the divine was just like that?

The key to this story is understanding that in primitive times - and primitive societies to this day - what seems to us the fundamentally obvious fact that children are produced by the sexual activities of women *with* men, was simply not recognised as such at all. People believed that seeds were carried through the wind, through rivers or through the consumption of seeds in a woman's diet. If men were not involved in the process, men did not have children. Women clearly did have children and thus had the ability to pass on wealth that they had accumulated in their lifetimes.

And when agriculture was discovered (or invented), probably by women, for the first time in human history it made sense to stay put, to stop being nomadic, and then suddenly there was wealth to inherit - fields, buildings, pottery, jewels. And so, for probably 5000 years (estimates vary wildly, and I am no expert), women across southern Europe and north Africa held titles to lands and goods that men shared in but, you cannot help but feel, as very much second-class citizens. In Section 1, I have given all my male characters names associated with pet dogs to make this point: men were useful, often loved, but were viewed in the same way that we today view our pets. I have no justification for this: I am using what Robert Graves describes as the analeptic method: I have immersed myself in the period, looked around and seen what *must* have been. Although I accept I could be wrong. I would love to know.

But things changed. At some point, somewhere, probably somewhere remote, men discovered that women who went for a long enough time without having sex with a man *never* became pregnant, no matter how many rivers they bathed in, windy fields they stood in or nuts they ate. And at some point, men determined the causal connection between sex and pregnancy. And then, somewhere, probably more than once, a man realised that if he was the *only* man to have sex with a given woman, then any children *she* had were by extension his children.

That probably happened somewhere far away from the Greek setting of my story. But Cronos in Section 1, and Zeus in Section 2 have acquired this knowledge and come from male-dominated, nomadic, pastoral tribes. Here, I feel I am on much more solid ground in treating of the traditions. Every major western tradition looks back and sees in its past its patriarchs, and sees the same people. Abraham, Isaac and Jacob in the Bible were all of this type: tribal leaders who understood the importance of only one man impregnating any single woman (although it was fine for him to impregnate any number of women) with hideous penalties for women who defied this rule.

But also in the Bible (and elsewhere), we pick up echoes of something else: a time when all was pleasant and happy before man dominated women (in the Garden of Eden; is the true "tree of knowledge" the knowledge that sexual intercourse is key to pregnancy?). And the stories of the Kingdoms of Israel and Judah redound with stories of "the Queen of Heaven" - Ashtoreth, Astarte - and her servants, the priestesses, all of whose crimes appear to be freedom-related: free to own wealth, free to worship in their own way, free to have sex with those they want to. There is no doubt that this is a story of a cover-up: the men have taken control, and want to airbrush the women out of history. Except that they always do it very badly, leaving evidence all over the place as to what they did. Reconstructing the actual truth is beyond us; identifying and stripping back the lies, and thus looking behind the curtain give us a glimpse into what the truth might have been. And then, as Robert Graves says, you use the analeptic method to reconstruct the history that might have been. It undoubtedly was not as I have written it, but I hope that I am not a thousand miles off.

In that case, what do I claim is "probably" true, or at least, "truth-adjacent"? In other words, stripping away the narrative, what do I claim are the facts that underlie the story of my first two sections? (Section 3 should be recognizable to those who have read Greek legends: the Iliad and the Odyssey, for example, and Section 4 is based entirely on looking behind what Livy wrote).

For me, the story starts with Dr JG Frazer's "The Golden Bough", which apparently caused a sensation when it was first published over a century ago, but, surprisingly, I had never heard of this bestseller before I started researching this topic. I suspect it became a bestseller by the simple fact of taking a lot of detailed scientific research and summarising it for a broader audience. Based on this, and giving it significant credit for her conclusions, Jane Ellen Harrison wrote "A Prologomena on the History of Greek Religion", which looks at the written evidence for Greek religion in the classical period and then, much like a patient furniture restorer, peels off layer after layer of misinterpretation, redirection and gloss in order to reveal the most likely origins of the various Greek festivals. Notably, she identifies four as being "for women only" and as having some very unusual rituals. Furthermore, much of the "technology" of these rituals seems stuck far back in time, being unaware of wine or the keeping of animals. Moreover, she correlates this with similar *Roman* festivals, such as the Bona Dea, which have similar characteristics.

This is backed up by archaeological evidence in the area. Maria Gimbutas spent much of her career finding and examining prehistoric evidence from caves and other locations across middle Europe. In doing so, she found a surprising level of consistency between artifacts at all the different sites she visited. And all of the artwork dwelt on symbols and imagery drawn from the cycle of life and from women as the givers of life. The contrast to the later European emp[hasis on the male-dominated pursuits of war and contests of strength could not be more clear.

Against that backdrop, and given the fundamental assumption of Robert Graves' analysis: that the Greek myths are there to account for the difference between the earlier iconography and ritual and the beliefs of the days in which the myths were told - probably long before they were written as we have them today - the explanations the he gives for the meanings of the myths, and the details of the societies they set out to obscure, become apparent and acceptable on face value.

Having said that, the myths cover many parts of Greece, and many different local rituals and interpretations, and across at least two seismic changes in power structures (I have condensed that in this book to represent two major changes between Sections 1 and 2 and between Sections 2 and 3). The myths are often repetitive, showing the same transition happening in different parts of Greece. At other times, they show similar transitions happening, but with different original customs leading to different rituals. For example, in my "Cronos" phase (Section 2), we see Kings being murdered by their "sons" - generally a reference to the man who became King after him - or we see them dying in chariot crashes, or we see them going mad and killing themselves.

At the same time, we often see the sons of the Queen leaving the place of their birth and going wandering. Quite simply, these are men who might see themselves as being "royal" by accident of birth (and to a lesser extent upbringing) but simply cannot have a place in a power structure in which men can only gain positions of power by marrying a Queen - initially their mother, later their sister or their niece. In other places - most notably Egypt - brothers and sisters frequently, if not always, married for the same reason - the title to the throne came through the female line, while the males of the family wanted to retain power by marrying into that female line. Only marriages that we - and the Greeks - would consider incestuous can achieve that goal.

In his novel *King Jesus*, Robert Graves alludes to the same principle in discussing both the succession of the Roman Kings and the reason for their ultimate demise. The right to rule Rome descended, he argued, from the Goddess Carmenta, considered incarnate in the female line of Queens of the Sabines. As I have indicated above, Livy's account of all this is garbled and, at the very least, fudged, to fit with his preconceived notions of what would naturally happen in a patriarchy. And, in consequence, he has his characters frequently acting with surprise at the events that unfold around them.

Taking a different initial stance, and trying to remove the varnish that Livy has put on his story, I came up with the sequence of events that unfolds in Section 4 - I won't repeat that here, except to say that it seems to me that the most likely story is that Rome was already a "city" (or at least a large town) when Romulus arrived with a small army from Alba Longa or somewhere else to the south. The members of that army were almost undoubtedly the men who formed the senate and, if it does not reflect just a normal story of annual kings, I suspect that Remus had been such an annual king whom Romulus murdered when conquering Rome. The so-called "Rape of the Sabines" was not so much a cunning plan as quite simply the outcome of a conquest - a story Livy cannot tell since he has Romulus build the town from scratch.

Originally, I wanted to focus in on the exact steps by which the women lost power and the men gained it. At each step, it seemed to me, the men must use their superior strengths - in particular, literal strength - in order to take power from women and wield it themselves. But I ran into two problems: one was the treacle-like speed with which these changes took place, and the other was I could not understand the nature of the compromises that seemed to be reached.

The closest parallel I could really see was with the Roman Empire and its frontier with the barbarian tribes in the fifth century. The barbarians were *stronger*, in the literal sense of having the numbers and the level of strength and violence to overcome the Roman soldiers, but they had been held at bay, literally for centuries, by the fact that the Romans had society, civilization, coordination and the ability to move their (lesser) numbers from one place to another as the tactical situation required it. But nevertheless, everywhere that the barbarians conquered, although a period of chaos inevitably followed, some version of proto-Roman civilzation - the rule of law, cities and towns, military organisation, ranks and titles, not to mention Christianity - eventually came to predominate. Why?

In this case, I believe it was that the structures were there and their roots went deep. The barbarians came, and they defeated the Roman *armies*, and sacked and pillaged the Roman *cities*, and broke up the Roman empire into smaller, disconnected territories. But at ground level, the citizens and civilians of Europe carried on much as they had for centuries past, in their villages and towns, growing crops, working in industries and paying their taxes - albeit to different overlords. Meanwhile the Church operated to reconnect disconnected territories, even sending missionaries to re-convert parts of the world that had returned to (a different) paganism after the barbarian invasions.

I have tried to work on the theory that the two waves of invaders - roughly corresponding to the Ionian and Doric conquests of Greece - have followed this same pattern. I have shown first Cronos, then Zeus, coming down across the mountains from the Eurasian Steppes, bringing with them knowledge (such as the role of men in producing children), technology (the raising of animals) and their own religion (in particular, the belief in Gods rather than Goddesses, but also a more linear rather than cyclic life). I have shown the point of impact with a given village, which had no previous experience of these beliefs. In reality, of course, any such wave of invaders would be both more general and more diffuse. It is also much more likely to have been encountered somewhere much further north (say Delphi), and assuredly not on the Peloponnese. If I were a historian, these things might bother me; as an author, they worry me not at all.

Both times, I have then skipped forward a couple of hundred years, allowing the impact of the "conquest" to settle down, the froth to disappear and see how much has remained unchanged. No matter the spin I may have put on this as an author, there is no question that the reality was something like this. A thousand years later, during classical times, classical authors reported festivals and rituals that were still practised *only by women* (see Harrison). Other rituals retained the characteristics that seem out of keeping with the Indo European traditions and thus, presumably, were part of the indigineous rituals which the conquerors were either unable or unwilling to eliminate. Given the ebb and flow of human history, and in particular, the history of dark age Europe I am using as an analogy, I can only assume that this process was incredibly detailed, sporadic and spread over decades if not centuries, and probably involved interaction between villages and tribes as wars continued over the time. The only real evidence that I have is drawn from the sources I have quoted: people looking back over time and accounting for why things are the way they are now through myths, and the modern science of archaeology which constrains how things could have been at various points in history.

Thus, in each case, although the previous section ended with the conquest of the female-run village by an external, patriarchal society, the patriarchal society does not win. In fact, as I read the history I am referencing, the patriarchy *only* wins at the very end of this book: with the death of the Goddess Carmenta. At that point, the leading men of Rome - the descendants of the violent gang of Romulans - are left in charge of the field and have no constraints on how they shackled and treated their womenfolk. The men would reign supreme in Europe for the next 2,500 years.